THE GILDED DOOR

A NOVEL OF ROME

Rome, AD 112–113

ANONYMOUS

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MMXXVI

This is a work of fiction. The historical persons, places and events portrayed here are used imaginatively. All other characters are inventions, and any resemblance to the living or the dead is accidental.

Mature content. This novel contains depictions of slavery, sexual coercion, physical violence and torture. It is intended for adult readers.

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"Quid Romae faciam? mentiri nescio."

"What should I do at Rome? I do not know how to lie."

JUVENAL · SATIRES III

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PART ONE

THE GILDED DOOR

CHAPTER I

THE HOUSE ON THE CLIVUS

Rome, March, AD 112

The gilt on the door was renewed every spring, and every spring it fooled somebody. From the Clivus Suburanus it looked like the entrance to a magistrate's house: two leaves of oak, a row of iron studs, a bronze knocker worn smooth by hands that had no business being gentle. You had to stand close to see that the oak had been patched at the bottom, where a generation of the Subura had kicked it, and that the studs were iron painted to look like bronze.

Cerdon stood in the doorway with his club and his good cloak, and told the litter-bearers where to put the litter, and the litter-bearers told him where to put his club, and the matter was settled the way such matters were settled in that lane: with insults, and a coin, and everybody going where they had intended to go.

Behind the door the mosaic said what the door did not. A threshold shows a visitor what the house thinks of him. The house of Antonia Cassia showed a door within a door, worked in black and white tesserae, and beyond it a wreath, and beyond the wreath nothing at all.

The first guests came at the ninth hour, when the light on the Esquiline turns the color of old honey and the tanners down by the river begin to make their presence known.

Lucius Iunius Gallus arrived on foot, as he always did, with two clients trailing him and the air of a man who had once been consul

and had not yet stopped mentioning it. He was fifty-eight and looked sixty, and he had the manners of a man who had been taught that manners were the only thing a gentleman truly owned. He kissed Antonia's cheek, which he had been doing for eleven years, and said, "I hear you have a turbot."

"I have two turbots," Antonia said. "One for you, and one for the man you will tell about it."

"Then I shall tell only one man."

"Then one turbot would have sufficed."

His son came behind him, and did not kiss her. Decimus Iunius Gallus was nineteen and had spent the winter in the company of people who told him he was remarkable. He had his father's nose and his mother's money and no occupation beyond the spending of both. He looked around the atrium as though he were pricing it.

"Decimus," Antonia said.

"Domina."

That was all. He had called her that since he was fourteen. It was the correct word from a young senator to a freedwoman, and he used it the way a man uses a knife at table: correctly, and to make a point.

Gaius Calpurnius Daphnus came next, off a boat that morning, still smelling faintly of the Tiber and strongly of money. He was fifty, a freedman like herself, with a shipper's hands and a banker's eyes, and he had brought a jar of wine from Crete which he presented with the gravity of a man handing over a treaty.

"From the estate of a man who died owing me four hundred thousand," he said. "I thought you might like to drink his cellar."

"I might like to drink his whole estate."

"Give me time."

Lucius Valerius Crescens came in his uniform because he had come from the station and had not had time to change, and because he knew that the uniform did something to the room. He was a

tribune of the seventh cohort of the vigiles, thirty-four years old, and he had the particular tiredness of a man who spent his nights being shouted at by people whose houses were on fire. He was also in debt to three money-lenders, a fact known to Antonia and to no one else in the room.

"You are late," she said.

"I am on duty."

"You are on duty in a dining room."

"Somebody has to watch the wine."

Then Manius Cassius Verus the Younger came in, alone, twenty years old and already carrying his father's name like a coat that did not fit him. He had been back from the Danube six months, and he had not yet found anything in Rome worth doing. He drank too much, and he was clever, and those two things together had made him the sort of young man who is invited everywhere and trusted nowhere.

"Verianus," Antonia said.

"Antonia." He used her name, and only her name, and he did it with a small defiance that she had long since decided to find useful rather than rude.

The last guest was Oppius Nepos, and he was late on purpose.

He came in with two slaves behind him carrying a covered basket, and he made his apologies to the room rather than to his hostess, which was the sort of thing he did. He was forty-three, an equestrian, and he had the smooth, well-fed look of a man who had never carried anything heavier than a document. He had made his money in the last years of Domitian, when a man could make money by remembering what other men had said, and he had kept it in the better years by remembering what other men had said about the men who had remembered.

"Domina," he said. "A small thing. Thrushes from Baiae. Fattened on figs."

"Your generosity is famous."

"Only my generosity?"

"Among other things."

He smiled. He had a good smile. That was the trouble with him.

They went through into the dining room, and the dining room did what it was built to do. It was twelve feet by twenty, painted on three walls with the story of Danaë, who was shut in a tower by a father who had been told that her son would kill him, and who was visited by a god in the form of a shower of gold. The painter had been paid well, and had made the gold look like coins, and the coins look like rain.

"Your Danaë has been busy," Gallus said, settling onto the couch. "The tower looks well. The god looks like a tax collector."

"The god is a tax collector," Antonia said. "That is the joke."

"Your painter has a coarse mind."

"My painter has six children and a bad hip. He paints what he is paid for."

The first course came: oysters from Britain, eggs, thrushes, and a dish of mushrooms that Beryllos had been fretting over since noon. The wine was Caecuban, which was almost gone from the world and which Antonia served to men who would notice.

"Tell me about the forum," Daphnus said to Gallus. "They say the basilica is bigger than the Circus."

"Nothing is bigger than the Circus."

"The emperor's architects disagree."

"The emperor's architects are paid to disagree."

"The emperor," Nepos said, "is building a forum that will last a thousand years. I should like to build something that lasts a thousand years."

"You have built a reputation," Antonia said. "That lasts longer."

Nepos inclined his head, accepting it as a compliment, which it was not.

Verianus was drinking his wine too quickly and looking at the painted Danaë as though he had never seen her before. "My father says the column will be finished in the summer," he said. "He says the spiral will show the whole war. Every cohort, every bridge, every Dacian village. He says you will be able to read it like a book."

"Can you read?" Decimus asked.

"I can read well enough to know what my father says."

There was a small pause, the kind that costs a young man a dinner invitation. Gallus filled it by talking about the Dacian treasure, and how much of it had gone into the forum, and how much of it had gone into the soldiers' purses, and how much of it, in his opinion, had gone into the pockets of the men who arranged the contracts.

"Which is to say," he said, "the usual."

"The usual is what makes Rome," Daphnus said. "If the emperor built a bridge and nobody stole from it, we should have to invent a second river."

They laughed, and the wine went round, and Gallus began to talk about the east. There had been a letter from the governor of Cappadocia, he said, or a letter about a letter; the king of Armenia had done something, or had failed to do something, and the Parthians had done something in reply, and the emperor had been seen in conversation with the men who drew maps. Nothing had been decided. Everything had been prepared.

"War?" Daphnus said. "In his sixtieth year?"

"Alexander was dead at thirty-three," Gallus said. "The emperor is not Alexander. He is patient. He will go east, and he will take his architects with him, and when he has finished with the Parthians he will build a road where their capital used to be."

"And the cost?"

"The cost is always the same. The soldiers pay it first, and the provinces pay it second, and we pay it third, in the price of grain and the price of marble and the price of a good mason."

"And who profits?"

"Ah," Gallus said. "That is a different question, and the answer is always a man with a contract."

Nepos turned his cup slowly by the stem. "You speak as though the war were a misfortune. It is an opportunity. The east is full of men who have something to sell and no one to sell it to. A man with a ship, or a friend in the commissary, or a cousin who knows the roads —"

"A man with a cousin," Antonia said. "Rome is governed by cousins."

"Rome is governed by cousins and freedmen," Nepos said, "and the cousins need the freedmen to count."

"Then the freedmen should ask a better price."

Nepos smiled at her over the cup. "That is what I have always admired about you."

"Admiration is a cold room to keep a woman in."

The second course came: a boar, a turbot, a dish of peacock's tongues which were, Antonia knew, not peacock's tongues at all, because Beryllos had told her so and had threatened to leave if she told anyone else.

Kallisto sang after the second course. She came in with her lyre and stood where the light would find her, and she sang a song in Greek about a woman waiting at a door. She had sung it before, twice, and both times Antonia had told her not to sing it again. Tonight she had been permitted, and she knew why, and she sang it to the room as though the room were one man and she had a use for him.

When she had finished, Gallus wiped his eyes and said, "You have a treasure there, Antonia."

"I have a singer."

"You have a treasure."

"Treasures are kept in strongboxes. Singers are kept in houses."

"Some treasures are kept in houses," Nepos said. "Some houses are kept for treasure."

Antonia looked at him. "You are becoming philosophical, Oppius Nepos."

"Only after the second course."

There was a scrape of a stool. Decimus had turned on his couch to face Verianus, with the bright, unkind look of a young man who has found something to say.

"Speaking of treasures," he said. "Verianus was telling me about his father's house. The old man keeps a girl there. A slave. She sings like a nightingale, and she has the old man's eyes."

"Decimus," his father said.

"She does. He won't sell her, either. My sister says —"

"That is enough."

"She is said to have the old man's eyes," Decimus said, to the room now, "and if she has his eyes, I hope for her sake she does not have his nose."

The laughter came, and went, and left something behind. Verianus had gone the color of the linen. His cup was halfway to his mouth and had stopped there, and he was looking at Decimus with an expression that Antonia had seen before, on men in courtrooms, in the moment before they were told the verdict.

Antonia said, "Decimus, tell me about your mother's estate. Is it true that the olive trees are dying?"

The boy turned to her, pleased to be asked. He talked about the estate for a quarter of an hour, and the moment passed, and the room went back to being a room.

But Antonia had heard it. A girl in the Cassian house. A singing girl, with the old man's eyes.

She had heard such things before. Rome was full of men with bastards, and full of bastards with their father's eyes, and it meant nothing. It meant nothing at all. She reached for her cup and found that her hand had gone cold.

At the end of the evening, when the guests were collecting their cloaks, Nepos found her by the door.

"The Palatine has been slow with your little matter," he said.

"It is not a little matter."

"All matters are little to the men who decide them. That is why they take so long." He adjusted his cloak. "I know a man in the petitions office. A discreet man. He has done such things before."

"And what would he want?"

"A friend," Nepos said. "He is a man who likes to have friends. As I am."

"You have a great many friends."

"I have a great many friends," he agreed, "and very few of them know it."

He went out. Antonia stood in the doorway for a moment, and the cold came in off the lane, and Cerdon closed the door against it.

❦

The house after a banquet was a different house. The lamps burned low; the slaves moved through the rooms with cloths and buckets; the smell of wine and perfume gave way to the smell of vinegar and wet wool. Beryllos could be heard in the kitchen, telling someone exactly what he thought of the turbot.

In the passage outside the dining room, Kallisto was waiting, wrapped in a bed-cloak with her hair down. She had taken the pins out and had not put them back, which meant she wanted to be seen being tired.

"You sang well," Antonia said.

"I sang what you told me not to sing."

"I noticed."

"Three times I have asked you for the papers." Kallisto fell into step beside her. "You said after the games. The games were in October."

"The games were in October. The papers are not."

"I have been in this house nine years. I have paid for the roof twice and the bath once and the Greek teacher for the little one, and I have kept my mouth shut about the governor of Baetica and the wife of the praetor and the thing with the incense. I am not asking for a gift. I am asking for an accounting."

Antonia stopped at the door of the small room. "You want a house of your own on the Aventine, with a garden and a cook and a door that locks from the inside. That is four hundred thousand, and you have sixty, and if you leave this house with sixty you will be back in a room above a fountain by the winter."

"I might do better than you think."

"You might. You are clever, and you are beautiful, and you have a voice that makes old men remember their fathers. None of those things keeps a house. A house is kept by a woman who can say no to a man with money, and you have never once said no to a man with money."

Kallisto's mouth tightened. "You taught me not to."

"I taught you to make him pay for the yes. That is not the same thing." Antonia put her hand on the door. "Stay until the summer. I will give you a share of the season, a real share, written down, and in the summer we will talk about the papers again."

"A written share."

"Written and sealed."

"Sealed by whom? You have no seal of your own. You have a ring with a leaf on it that you never use."

Antonia looked at her. "Go to bed, Kallisto."

The singer went, and her bare feet made no sound on the mosaic, and Antonia stood in the passage for a moment with the lamp in her hand.

Antonia went to the small room behind the tablinum, where she kept the strongbox and the book. Tullia was already there, with the tablets and the lamp, and a face that had been waiting to say something for three hours.

"How much?" Antonia said.

"Two hundred and forty for the dinner. Sixty for the wine from Daphnus, which was a gift and which he will want paid for in April. The aedile's clerk wants fifty, and he wants it in silver, and he wants it before the Ides."

"He will have it before the Ides."

"And the man from the petitions office wants three thousand."

Antonia sat down. "Three thousand."

"He says the rescript has to be copied, and the copy has to be carried, and the carrier has to be a man of consequence, and men of consequence are expensive."

"They are also common. Offer him two."

"He will refuse."

"Then offer him two and a half, and let him think he has beaten you."

Tullia wrote it down. She was forty-seven, a freedwoman of the household, and she had been keeping Antonia's accounts for nine years. She had a face like a closed door and a memory like a warehouse, and she was the only person in Rome who could tell Antonia the truth without being asked for it.

"There is something else," Tullia said.

"Of course there is."

"A man came on Tuesday. Not to the door. To the gate at the back, where the wine comes in. He asked Meroe about a child."

Antonia did not move.

"A girl," Tullia said. "Sold out of the house of Cominius Asiaticus eighteen years ago. He said he was buying, and that he paid well for information, and that he had been told this was a house that knew things."

"What did Meroe tell him?"

"That she had come to Rome from Capua in the year of the fire and knew nothing about any child."

"Good."

"She told me afterward that he had a mark on his hand. A burn, she said. Like a brand."

Antonia looked at the lamp. It was a good lamp, bronze, with a small bronze door on the handle. She had bought it in the year she stopped being poor.

"Find out who he is," she said. "Do not ask at the station. Do not ask Crescens. Use the boy who runs for the fullers."

"He will want money."

"Give him money."

Tullia made a note. Then she said, "The girl Dessa did not eat again."

"Which girl?"

"You know which girl."

"I know eleven girls."

"Dessa. The Dacian. She has not eaten since the Nones, and she has been sitting in the garden at night with her shoes off, which Meroe says is a sign."

"A sign of what?"

"Of a girl who is thinking about the road."

Antonia rubbed her eyes. "Have Eutychus look at her. If she is sick, she is sick. If she is thinking about the road, have Hilarus sleep across her door."

"And if she runs?"

"Then she runs," Antonia said. "And we find her before she gets to the gate, and we do not beat her in the street, and we do not make a spectacle of a girl with a good hand for figures. She costs me twelve thousand sesterces and she can add a column of numbers faster than you."

"She can add a column faster than me because I taught her."

"Then you should be proud, and not let her get to the gate."

Tullia gathered the tablets. At the door she stopped.

"You have not asked me about the other thing."

"What other thing?"

"The Cassian girl," Tullia said. "The one the boy talked about."

Antonia looked up. The lamp threw her shadow onto the wall, and the shadow was larger than she was.

"Go to bed, Tullia."

"Good night, domina."

When she had gone, Antonia opened the strongbox. Inside were the ledgers, wrapped in oiled cloth, and a smaller box of cedar, and in the cedar box a lead token the size of a thumbnail, struck with the image of a door. It had been broken across the middle. She had the half with the door.

She turned it over twice, the way she had turned it over a thousand times, and put it back, and locked the box, and sat for a while with her hand on the lid.

❦

The knock came at the fourth hour, when the city was at its quietest and the only people awake were bakers and thieves and women who could not sleep.

Cerdon came to the door of the small room with his club in his hand and his cloak over his night-shirt. "Domina. The back gate."

"Who?"

"A woman. Well dressed. A slave with her, a girl. She says she will not go away."

"Does she have a name?"

"She says her name is Publia."

Antonia was quiet for a moment. Then she put on her mantle and went out through the garden, where the roses were still six weeks from flowering and the fountain made its small, patient noise, and stood at the back gate with the lamp in her hand.

The woman was veiled. The veil was good wool, the sort that costs more than it looks, and the cloak beneath it was the color of a dove's throat. Behind her, holding a second lamp, stood a girl of about eighteen in a plain tunic, with a slave's collar at her throat and a lead token on a cord beside it.

"Lift your veil," Antonia said.

The woman lifted it. She was sixteen, with a long face and her father's brows and a mouth that had been trained not to move. She looked at Antonia as though she had rehearsed the look.

"You are Publia Cassia," Antonia said.

"Yes."

"Your father is a consular. Your mother is dead. You are betrothed to Titus Caesennius Rufus, and the wedding is in September, and you have come to my back gate at the fourth hour with one slave and no escort, which means that either you are foolish, or you are desperate, or you are both."

"Both," Publia said.

"Then come in," Antonia said, "before the whole Subura sees you."

She led them through the garden and into the small room, and shut the door, and set the lamp on the table. The slave girl stood by the wall with her eyes down. She was a pretty thing, dark-haired, with a mark like a crescent on the inside of her wrist, and she held the second lamp as though it were a baby.

"Sit," Antonia said.

Publia sat. She did not look at the ledgers or the strongbox or the bronze lamp. She looked at Antonia, and her hands were steady, and her voice, when it came, was steady too.

"I want you to break my marriage," she said.

Antonia sat down opposite her. "Why?"

"Because I have seen him."

"Caesennius?"

"He came to dinner in January. He has a house on the Caelian and a wife in Baetica, or perhaps she is dead, no one is sure. He talked about his brickfields for an hour. He has a way of looking at a girl as though he were estimating her." Publia's mouth did not move. "He is fifty-four."

"And your father wants the match."

"My father wants the proconsulship of Asia. Caesennius has a cousin on the emperor's council, and a fortune, and no children of his own, and he has offered a settlement that would pay my father's debts and leave enough over for a campaign." She said it flatly, as though she were reading a list of prices. "I heard them discussing it. I was in the passage behind the curtain, and they did not know I was there, and my father said that a daughter is a door, and that a man must open it at the right time."

Antonia said nothing. The fountain made its noise in the garden. Somewhere in the house a door closed.

"And your stepmother?" Antonia said.

"Marcella says I should be grateful." Publia's voice did not change. "She says that when she married my father she was twenty-one and he was forty, and that she has never regretted it, and that gratitude is a better foundation for a marriage than love, because gratitude lasts."

"Marcella is a sensible woman."

"Marcella is a wall," Publia said. "You cannot get through her, and you cannot get round her, and if you stand close enough you can hear her thinking."

Antonia almost smiled. "What do you want me to do?"

"I don't know. You are said to know how to do things."

"Things."

"Men," Publia said. "You are said to know how to make men do what you want, and how to make them sorry if they don't."

"Who says that?"

"My father."

Antonia leaned back. "What does your father say?"

"He says you are the most dangerous woman in Rome."

"He is right."

"Then help me."

Antonia looked at her for a long moment. She was a child, and she was not a fool, and she had come to the one door in Rome that a girl of her name should never have approached. That took a kind of courage. It also took a kind of ignorance that could get them all killed.

"Listen to me," Antonia said. "If you are seen coming here, your father will not beat you. He will do something worse. He will be reasonable. He will take you to the country and find a widow to keep you, and he will move the wedding to June, and you will spend the rest of your life in a house in Baetica with a man who estimates you. And I will lose my house, and my girls will be sold, and the man who buys them will not be as kind as I am. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Do you?"

"Yes."

"Then go home," Antonia said, "and do not come here again."

Publia did not move. "There is a girl in my father's house," she said. "Her name is Myrtale. She is my maid. She has been with me

since I was eight years old, and she is the only person in that house who has ever been kind to me without wanting something."

Antonia's hand was flat on the table. She did not move it.

"And my father will not sell her," Publia said. "He will not free her. He will not let her marry. He keeps her the way a man keeps a thing he does not want anyone else to have. I have asked him. He says she is provided for."

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because I have nothing else to give you," Publia said. "I have a dowry, and a name, and a father who would sell me to a brickmaker for a consulship. If I offered you money you would laugh at me, and if I offered you my friendship you would not believe me. So I am offering you what I know."

"And what do you want in return?"

"To not be married to that man."

"That is not a thing I can give you. That is a thing you will have to do yourself." Antonia leaned forward. "If I help you, you will owe me. Not now. Later, when I ask. Do you understand what it means to owe a woman like me?"

Publia's steady hands were not quite steady. "I have heard."

"You have heard stories. You have not heard the half of it." Antonia sat back. "Go home. Think about what you are asking. If you still want it in a week, send me a message by the woman who sells flowers at the Porta Esquilina, and do not sign it, and do not come here again."

"And the girl? Myrtale?"

"What about her?"

"She will be sold when I marry. Or given away. Caesennius will not have another man's bastard in his house, and my father will not pay to keep her, and Marcella has been waiting eight years for an excuse." Publia's voice had gone thin. "She is the only person in that

house who has ever been kind to me without wanting something. If you can do nothing else —"

"I have said I will think," Antonia said.

"Because you knew him," Publia said. "Before. I don't know how. But when he speaks of you, his voice changes, and my stepmother leaves the room. And because I think that if anyone in Rome can make him open a door, it is you."

Antonia looked past her, at the slave girl by the wall. The girl was standing very still, holding the lamp, and the light was on her face, and she was looking at Antonia with an attention that was not the attention of a servant.

"What is your name?" Antonia said.

The girl glanced at her mistress, then back. "Myrtale, domina."

"Who gave you that name?"

"The master's house. I was called it when I came."

"When you came from where?"

"I don't remember, domina. I was small."

Antonia looked at the token at her throat. It was lead, thumb-sized, on a leather cord, and it had been worn smooth by years against the girl's skin. There was a wreath on it. There was nothing else on it at all.

The room was very quiet. Antonia heard her own breathing, and the fountain, and the small dry sound of the lamp.

"Go home," she said, and her voice was steady, because her voice had been trained for thirty-nine years to be steady. "Both of you. Go out through the garden and turn left at the fuller's, and keep your veil down until you reach the Vicus Patricius."

Publia stood. At the door she turned. "Will you help me?"

"I will think about it," Antonia said.

When they had gone, she sat without moving for a long time. Then she opened the cedar box, and took out the half-token, and held it in her palm. The door on it had been struck by a die that had

made ten thousand others. It was worth nothing. It was worth everything she had.

She turned it over. On the back, where the break was, there was the smallest trace of a leaf: the edge of a wreath, cut off when the token was snapped in two.

Antonia closed her hand around it and sat in the dark until the first carts began to move on the Clivus, and the city woke up, and the day came in through the shutters like a creditor.

CHAPTER II

A DAUGHTER OF THE CASSII

Rome, March, AD 112

Morning in the house came in stages. First the water-carriers, whose wheels had a particular squeal on the cobbles of the Clivus; then the bakers, who opened their shutters and let out the smell of hot bread and burnt flour; then the fullers, whose tubs gave the whole lane a smell like a nailed-up dog. By the time the sun reached the top of the garden wall, the household had been awake for two hours and the day was already behind.

Antonia went out to the peristyle with her cup and stood looking at the roses. They were tight and green and would be nothing for weeks. In the corner the fountain ran into its basin with the sound of a small, patient argument. Dessa was sitting on the edge of the basin with her shoes off and her feet in the water.

"You will get a chill," Antonia said.

"It is warm, domina."

"It is March."

"In Dacia it is warm in March," Dessa said, and then looked as if she had said something she had been told not to say.

"In Dacia it is snow in March."

"Sometimes." Dessa drew her feet out of the water and put them under her, and her face closed the way a door closes when the person inside has decided not to answer.

She was twenty and looked seventeen, with the flat cheekbones of the north country and hair that went red in the sun. She had been

taken at fourteen, from a village whose name Antonia had heard once and never again. She had come through three owners before this house. The first had taught her to carry water. The second had taught her to be quiet. The third, who was a money-lender with a taste for arithmetic, had discovered that she could count, and had used her for four years, and had sold her in the autumn for more than he paid.

"Tullia says you have not been eating," Antonia said.

"I eat."

"Tullia says you have been sitting in the garden at night."

"It is cooler."

"It is March." Antonia sat down on the edge of the basin, which put her at the girl's level, and Dessa looked away, at the roses, at the wall, at anything. "I am not going to ask you what you are thinking. You would lie, and then you would be ashamed of lying, and it would be worse for both of us. I am going to ask you one thing. If you were to run, where would you go?"

Dessa's jaw moved. "I don't know what you mean."

"You know exactly what I mean. Where would you go?"

"Home," Dessa said, and the word came out of her like something pulled.

"Your village is five hundred miles from here, on the other side of two provinces and a river, and there is no village there anymore. There is a fort, and a road, and a tax collector. The men who took you are dead or rich. The men who would take you now would take you to a different kind of house, and the house would not have a garden."

"I know what kind of house."

"Do you?"

"I know what I am worth," Dessa said. "Twelve thousand sesterces. Tullia told me, when I asked. She said a girl who can count is worth twelve thousand, and a girl who can sing is worth thirty, and

a girl who can do both is worth a great deal more than her master thinks."

Antonia almost laughed. "Tullia should learn to be less helpful."

"She said you would not beat me for asking."

"She is right. I will not beat you for asking. I will beat you for running, because if you run, Cerdon has to chase you, and if Cerdon chases you, the watch sees it, and if the watch sees it, some clerk writes your name in a book, and the book says I keep slaves who run. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Then stay out of the water in March."

Antonia stood up and went inside. At the door of the tablinum she stopped. "Dessa."

"Domina?"

"Come to me after the midday meal. I have four hundred entries in the grain accounts and I have not the patience for them."

The girl's face did something complicated. "Yes, domina."

❦

Tullia was in the tablinum with the tablets laid out in rows, and Meroe standing by the door with her hands folded, and the look of a woman who has been rehearsing her story and has decided to tell it badly.

"Tell me about the man," Antonia said.

"He came to the back gate on Tuesday, in the afternoon, when the wine comes. He was well dressed. Not fine — well. A good cloak, no fringe, boots that had been mended. He had the look of a man who works for someone else and is paid not to say so."

"Age?"

"Forty, perhaps. He had a burn on the back of his right hand, here, between the thumb and the finger, and it was old. He said he was looking for a girl child sold out of the house of Cominius Asi-

aticus in the year of the fire. He said he paid for information. He showed me a coin."

"A gold coin?"

"A silver one. He said there would be more."

"And you told him?"

"That I had come from Capua in the year of the fire and knew nothing of any child. And he said, 'A pity,' and he said, 'If you remember, ask for me at the shop of the sandal-maker in the Via Nova, and say the name Felix,' and he went away up the lane."

Meroe's family had come from Capua; the year of the fire was the year Vespasian's temple burned, though which fire a person meant depended on where they had been standing. Antonia had used Meroe's Capuan childhood as a screen for eleven years. It was a good screen because it was true.

"You did well," Antonia said. "If he comes again, tell him the same, and send the boy to me at once. Do not go to the station. Do not send to the aediles. If anyone else asks at this door about a child, they are to be told to come back in the evening, and then Cerdon is to shut the door in their face."

"How many people are going to ask?" Meroe said.

"That is what I mean to find out."

When Meroe had gone, Tullia put her hand flat on the tablets. "There is more."

"Of course there is."

"The flower-seller at the Esquiline sent a message at dawn. A girl came to her before light, veiled, and gave her two words. She said: the fourteenth."

"The fourteenth of what?"

"Just the fourteenth. The girl said the lady would understand."

Antonia turned the date over. The fourteenth was the eve of the Ides. On the Ides of March, in the year before the emperor was born, a man had been killed in the senate house for wanting to be a

king, and Rome had been telling the story ever since, mostly to warn itself.

"She means the eve of the Ides," Antonia said. "At the fifth hour. Tell the flower-seller to send her to the fuller's yard behind the house, not to the door. And Tullia — the money. Three thousand for the petitions office was robbery. Send the man two hundred and tell him I have heard that the rescript is being held by the office of the ab epistulis, and that a man who charges three thousand for a copy is a man who has something to hide."

"That is a lie."

"It is a suspicion. It will do until I have a lie."

Tullia wrote it down.

"Now," Antonia said. "The Cassii."

Tullia sat back. This was her subject. She had been a slave in a great house before she was freed, and she had kept, from that life, a memory like a tax roll and the ability to be told a secret and remember the shape of it without remembering the words.

"The Cassii have been dining above their means for thirty years," she said. "Manius Cassius Verus's father had two consulships and a bad steward. When the old man died, the estate came with a debt of nearly two million. The son spent four years paying interest and none of the principal. Then he married Acilia Marcella, whose father was a banker at Puteoli, and she brought him a dowry of one and a half million and a way of looking at a bill that has saved the family twice over."

"And the second wife does not like her stepson."

"The second wife is pleasant to the stepson in public and has not been alone in a room with him in seven years. The stepson is the old wife's boy. The son has been in Dacia. The daughter —"

"The daughter is for sale."

"They are asking one million two hundred thousand for her, which is a great deal even for a girl with two consuls in the family,

and Caesennius Rufus is offering eight hundred thousand, and there is a cousin on the emperor's council who wants a son-in-law with a future."

"And Verus's own debts?"

"Six hundred thousand to the fiscus, in three installments, and the first is due in June. Another three or four hundred thousand to men who do not write things down."

Antonia looked at the window. A fly was walking on the sill, from the light into the shade and back.

"So the marriage buys the proconsulship."

"The marriage buys the first installment, and the proconsulship buys the rest. A governor of Asia can make two million in a year without touching his own money. Everyone knows it. Nobody says it."

"And the girl in the house? The one the boy talked about at dinner?"

Tullia's mouth did something small. "There is a story. It came from the kitchen of the Cassian house by way of a woman who sells them fish. The child was bought as an infant, eighteen years ago, from a dealer. She was given to a nurse in the country until she was five or six, and then brought into the house, and she has been in the house ever since, and she is maid to the daughter."

"Bought from which dealer?"

"The fish-woman did not know. She knew the nurse. The nurse is dead."

"Everyone is dead," Antonia said. "That is what makes Rome so restful."

"There is another thing." Tullia turned a tablet over. "The wet-nurse's sister is still alive. She lives at Ficulea, on the road to Nomentum, and she is a midwife, and her name is Iusta. She is said to have attended a birth in the Subura in the year before the child was

bought, a birth in a house of women, and she is said to remember it."

Antonia sat very still. "Who told you that?"

"The fish-woman. She did not know she was telling me anything. She was complaining about her sister, who is a midwife, and who will not lend her money, and who is always talking about a baby she delivered in the Subura that had a token tied to its wrist."

"A token."

"A lead token. The midwife thought it was a charm." Tullia looked up. "Domina, you have gone white."

"It is the lamp," Antonia said. "It is too close."

"The emperor knows it."

"The emperor has been in Dacia, and then in the forum, and then on the Danube, and now he is looking east. The emperor knows what his freedmen tell him. His freedmen are told by men like —" Tullia stopped.

"Men like Oppius Nepos," Antonia said.

"I was going to say men like me."

"Men like you tell me the truth. Men like Nepos tell the emperor a story." Antonia stood up. "I am going to the forum. Have Hilarus bring the litter, and have him bring the plain one, and tell him if he jogs on the Sacred Way I will have him sold to a teacher of rhetoric."

The Basilica Ulpia had been open four years and still smelled of new stone. It was the largest thing of its kind in the world, and it was not, strictly, needed: Rome had basilicas enough. That was the point. A man had wanted to build something that said what could be built, and the something said it, and the merchants had moved in under the arches with their scales and their tablets and their arguments, and now the most beautiful building in the city was a marketplace.

Daphnus had a corner between the second and third column, where the drafts were bad, because drafts were cheap. He sat on a folding stool with a board on his knees, and two clerks on either side of him wrote in a script so small that a reader needed good eyes and no conscience.

"You are early," he said.

"I am punctual. It is a different vice." Antonia sat on the bench opposite him. "The grain."

"The grain is good. The grain is very good. We have three ships of Egyptian wheat coming into Portus before the Kalends, and the price in Ostia is down two sesterces on the modius, and the annona is buying, which means the price will be up six by the summer."

"And our little venture?"

"Your little venture is twelve thousand modii in a warehouse that floods, and my cousin is watching it. If you want to be rich, buy the warehouse. If you want to be comfortable, lend to the men who own the ships."

"I want to be neither."

"Then you want to be interesting, and there is no money in it." Daphnus made a mark on his tablet. "You are not here about grain."

"I am here about a man. Not a name. A description. He wears a good cloak, he carries a silver coin in his pocket, and he has an old burn on the back of his hand, between the thumb and the first finger. He has been asking questions in the Subura about a child sold eighteen years ago. He told a woman to ask for him at the sandal-maker's in the Via Nova and to say the name Felix."

Daphnus stopped writing. "Felix is a common name."

"Yes."

"There is a Felix who works for the urban prefect's office. A freedman. He does the things the prefect does not want to sign."

"How do you know?"

"Because I have paid him," Daphnus said. "Twice. Once for a ship's manifest, once for a man's tax record. He is expensive and he is careful and he has never once asked me a question about why I wanted to know. If he is asking questions himself, someone above him has told him to."

"And who is above him?"

"Not the prefect," Daphnus said. "The prefect does not care about children. The prefect cares about order, and the grain, and the emperor's temper, and whether the vigiles can put out a fire in the fourteenth region before it reaches the Palatine. Children are not order." He looked at her. "Who is asking you about children?"

"Nobody, yet."

"Antonia."

"Nobody, yet," she said. "When somebody does, I will tell you."

She left him at his board and went out into the forum, where the light was so bright on the new marble that it hurt to look at the steps. There were men everywhere: senators in their litters going up the Clivus Argentarius, clerks with bundles of tablets, a group of Jews arguing near the arch, a boy selling water from a jar, two soldiers of the Guard standing at the corner, watching nothing with tremendous attention.

And there, at the foot of the steps, with four clients around him and a secretary at his elbow, was Manius Cassius Verus.

He was in a toga, which he wore the way other men wore a helmet: as a thing designed to be looked at. He was forty-five, tall, thin at the jaw and thick at the neck, with grey at the temples and the particular uprightness of a man who has been told all his life that he carries a family. He was listening to one of his clients, and his face had the patient attention of a man who is being told something he already knows and expects to be told again.

Antonia did not stop. She went down the steps on the far side, past the equestrian statue of the emperor on the horse, and she was almost at the bottom when the secretary looked up.

She saw the moment of recognition cross his face, and then she saw him lean and speak, and she saw Verus turn his head.

He looked at her the way a man looks at a door that has been left open in a house he thought was locked. It lasted less than a breath. Then one of his clients said something, and he turned back, and the secretary wrote, and the line of men closed around him like water.

She walked out through the arch of the forum and along the Argiletum to the Clivus, and her heart was going like a hammer, and she was furious that it was.

"Domina."

He had come out of the booksellers' row on the left, where the men who sold second-hand copies of the poets stood with their scrolls in baskets and their prices written on their fingers. He was in a pale cloak with a narrow border, and he had a roll of papyrus under his arm, and he was smiling.

"You are following me," Antonia said.

"I am walking in the same direction."

"To the Subura?"

"To the shop of a man who sells purple dye. I have a house to furnish." Nepos fell in beside her, and she did not stop, and he matched her pace as though they had agreed it. "You were at the basilica."

"I was."

"Daphnus is a good man. Careful. He has the largest private warehouse in Portus and he still buys his cloaks at the second-hand stalls." He glanced at her. "You were at the basilica, and before that you were at the forum steps, and Manius Cassius Verus was at the forum steps, and he looked at you as though you had been a bird in a room."

"You have good eyes."

"I have good clients. They tell me things." Nepos shifted the roll under his arm. "Have you thought about the petitions office?"

"I have."

"And?"

"I have thought that a man who wants three thousand sesterces for a copy of a rescript is either a fool or a thief, and I have thought that men who are either of those things usually turn out to be both. I have sent him two hundred, with a message about the office of the ab epistulis, and we shall see what he does with it."

Nepos laughed, and it was a real laugh, which was somehow worse than a false one. "You are a great deal cleverer than most of the men I work with."

"Most of the men you work with are senators."

"Yes," said Nepos. "That is what I said."

They walked a little way in silence. A cart went by, loaded with amphorae, and the driver shouted at them to move, and Nepos moved, and Antonia did not, and the driver went round her.

"One thing," Nepos said. "The Cassii."

"What of them?"

"They are an old family and an old family is a costly thing to keep. Verus has the name, and the name has the debts, and the debts have the marriage. The daughter is to be married in September, and the bridegroom is Caesennius Rufus, and the bridegroom's cousin sits on the council. That is the whole story of Rome this year: an old name, a new fortune, and a girl in the middle who will be told she is fortunate."

"You are very well informed about a wedding."

"I am invited," Nepos said. "Are you?"

Antonia stopped walking. "No."

"Then you will not see the bride's father give her away, with the tears in his eyes and the whole city watching, and the old name

saved, and the money all in the right pockets." Nepos took a step and turned. "It is a great pity. They say Verus has been asking about a freedwoman in the Subura. Asking the prefect's office, through a clerk he knows. He is very discreet, and he is very frightened, and I have never known a frightened patrician to be discreet for long."

"Are you threatening me, Oppius Nepos?"

"I am telling you," he said pleasantly, "that a man may be a friend to a house without being invited to its wedding."

He went on down the Argiletum, unhurried, and the crowd took him, and Antonia stood in the middle of the street with the carts going round her and the dye-shops stinking of urine and murex, and her hands were cold again, and it was not the March wind.

❦

The moonlight on the fourteenth came late and thin, and the fuller's yard behind the house smelled of stale urine and lime, and Antonia stood in the corner of it with her mantle up and waited, and told herself she was a fool.

Publia came alone this time, which was worse. She came through the gap in the wall by the fuller's shed, veiled, and she was breathing as though she had run, and when Antonia took her arm she felt the girl shaking.

"You are alone."

"Myrtale is with my aunt's household tonight. The old woman is sick and my father sent her to sit up." Publia pulled the veil down. "And my father has forbidden anyone in the house to speak your name."

"Then it will be spoken a great deal."

"He said it to the household." Publia's voice was flat. "He stood in the atrium, where the whole family could hear, and he said that the woman on the Clivus is not to be received, not to be greeted, not

to be mentioned, and that any slave who speaks to her or to her people will be sold within the day. Then he went into his tablinum and shut the door and stayed there until dark."

Antonia looked at the girl's face in the thin light. "Why?"

"How should I know? He is my father." Publia wiped her eyes with the edge of her veil, and it was the gesture of a child, and it made her look about twelve. "My stepmother came to my room afterward. She said, 'Your father is not angry. He is frightened, and men who are frightened say things that cost other people very dear.' Then she said, 'Do not write to her, do not send to her, and do not go to her, and if you have already gone to her, do not tell me.'"

"And then what did she do?"

"She sat with me until I fell asleep." Publia's mouth twisted. "I do not understand her."

"Nobody understands Marcella. That is her great achievement."

They stood a moment in the smell of the fuller's yard. Somewhere a dog started up and stopped. Antonia could hear the city, all around, in its ten thousand ways of making noise.

"The girl," Antonia said. "Myrtale. You said she has a token."

"A lead token. On a cord, around her neck. She never takes it off. She says it was tied to her when she was small and she does not know who tied it."

"What is on it?"

"A wreath. Just a wreath. She showed me once." Publia hesitated. "Why does that matter?"

"It matters because I have seen such a token before." Antonia's voice was steady. "There was a dealer in Rome, eighteen years ago, a woman named Bassa, who bought children and sold them on. She had a token struck so that the women whose children she sold could be told, if they ever had money, which child was which. One half went with the child. One half stayed with the mother."

Publia's face changed, and went very still. "That is a horrible story."

"Yes."

"You are making it up."

"I am not."

"Then —" Publia stopped. Her hands had come together in front of her, and she was twisting her fingers, and Antonia saw her work through it, and saw the moment she arrived.

"Oh," she said.

"Yes."

"But she is a slave."

"She is a slave now," Antonia said. "She was not always."

Publia looked at her for a long time. "You know whose child she is."

"I suspect."

"Whose?"

"I will tell you when I am certain, and not before, because a thing like this said too early will get the girl sold into Africa and me into a cellar."

The girl's eyes had gone hard, and Antonia felt a flicker of something that was not quite respect and not quite fear. "You want something from me."

"I do."

"Name it."

"Two things. In your father's tablinum, among his papers, there will be a record of purchase for a slave girl, bought when she was an infant or a small child, about eighteen years ago. Find it. Read the date, the seller's name, the price, and the words. Do not take it — if it goes missing he will know the house is not safe and he will start burning things. Look at it, and remember it exactly, and bring me the copy."

"I have never been in my father's tablinum in my life."

"You are his daughter and he has been in this house for thirty years. There will be a day when he is at the baths. There is always such a day."

Fifteen years of hunger and an elephant, said Antonia, though not aloud. What she said was, "And the second thing?"

"You have to come to the wedding," Publia said. "In September. To my father's house. He cannot forbid a guest at a wedding without explaining why, and my stepmother will insist on a large wedding, because she is proud of the money she has spent on the house."

Antonia felt something cold move in her. "You want me to walk into that house."

"I want you to walk into that house," Publia said, "and stand in the room where they keep the shrine, and eat their dinner, and let them look at you. And I want to see my father's face when he cannot do a thing about it."

The dog started up again. The gate at the end of the yard moved a little in the wind and did not open.

"All right," Antonia said. "Both things. But you will do exactly as I say, and you will not tell the girl. Not a word. Not until I am ready."

"Why not?"

"Because she has been a slave for eighteen years and she has survived it by knowing exactly what her master wants to hear. If you tell her what I believe, she will do one of two things. She will believe it and be destroyed by it, or she will not believe it and you will have lost her. Either way she will still have to sleep in a room near his, and every servant in that house will see a change in her, and one of them will tell the master." Antonia put her hand on the girl's shoulder. "You will be kind to her, and you will not tell her, and you will find the paper. That is all. Do you understand?"

"Not telling her," Publia said, "feels like a lie."

"It is a lie. It is one of the three or four worth telling." Antonia looked past her at the gate. "Now go home, and go through the fuller's, and if you see a man with a burned hand, turn your face away and keep walking, and tell me about it in the morning."

Publia went. Antonia stood in the yard for a while after the girl had gone, with her hand on the cold brick, and thought about a house that had been shut against her for eighteen years, and about a door in a mosaic, and about a girl with a token on a cord who did not know she was her mother's.

Hilarus was waiting at the corner with the lamp shuttered. He was twenty-five and had the shoulders of a man who carried a chair up the Viminal four times a day, and he had once, in his first month, tried to run, and had been brought back by Cerdon and had expected to be sold. Antonia had made him carry her litter for a month with no supper and had then given him a knife and told him that if he ever wanted to go he should tell her first and she would give him a week's wages and a letter to a man in Ostia. He had cried, which had embarrassed them both, and had stayed three years since.

"Domina," he said. "There was a man at the corner."

"With a burned hand?"

"With a cloak. He watched the gate for an hour and then he went away up the hill."

"Did he see you?"

"I was a lamp," Hilarus said. "Nobody sees a lamp."

They went in through the garden and Antonia bolted the gate herself, and stood in the dark among the sleeping roses, and did the arithmetic she had been avoiding all evening. She had a fortune of perhaps three million sesterces, most of it in loans, warehouses and the goodwill of men who owed her. She had a house that could be closed by a single magistrate's order. She had no family name, no vote, no imperium, no father to speak for her in the senate house, and no legal standing to demand anything at all from a consular.

She had a book, and a token, and a promise made to a girl of sixteen in a fuller's yard.

It had begun, then. It would not stop until one of them was dead or free.

CHAPTER III

THE SIXTH HOUR

Rome, March, AD 112

The Baths of Trajan opened at the sixth hour and by the half-hour there were three hundred people in the outer hall, and the noise was like a market inside a drum. Antonia went in with two of her women and a slave carrying the oil and the strigils, and paid the quadrans at the door, and handed her cloak to a boy who would lose it.

Rome went to the baths to be clean. It went more to be seen, and to see, and to find out what the price of a thing was before the forum opened the next morning. A man could learn more in the tepidarium than in a week of the morning call, because a man in the tepidarium has nothing to defend himself with but a towel.

Antonia did not undress. She had a room off the women's side, which cost her four hundred sesterces a year and was worth every coin of it, and in that room she took off her mantle and her shoes and her earrings and put on a wool tunic that reached her knees and belted it, and went out into the steam with her hair bound up.

This was unusual, and noticed, and had been noticed for fifteen years. She had heard every explanation the city had invented: that she had been branded, that she had been burned in a fire, that she had a growth on her shoulder that would make a strong man faint, that she was a Jew, that she was a Christian, that she had once been a man. She let them all stand. A rumor was a wall, and a wall with four sides was better than a wall with one.

The truth was on her back and her left shoulder, and it was not a brand. It was the hand of a man with a rope in it, applied over an afternoon and a night and part of a morning in the year 93, and it had healed into a map of something that had happened to somebody, and if she raised her left arm above her shoulder the skin pulled and the arm would not go higher than her ear.

Rufina, who had been with her eleven years and was the only person alive who had seen her without the tunic, took the oil and began at her shoulders.

"Not the left."

"I know, domina."

"Not even gently."

"I know, domina."

She closed her eyes. Around her the steam billowed and the women talked: about a marriage, about a miscarriage, about the price of pepper, about the praetor's wife who had worn the same dress twice in a week. There was a girl of about nineteen sitting on the edge of the plunge with her feet in the water, and she was crying, and two older women were talking past her as though she were furniture.

"Rufina. The girl."

"One of the house of Pomponius. The father is selling her to a man in Africa."

"How do you know?"

"Because the woman with the yellow hair told the woman with the mole, and the woman with the mole told everyone else in the pool, and I have been sitting here for a quarter of an hour listening to them enjoy it."

Antonia opened her eyes. The steam was thick and the light in it was like light in milk. She watched the girl cry, and did nothing, because she had learned at twenty-five that a woman who interferes in

another woman's marriage in a public bath makes an enemy of the husband, the father, the aunt and the girl, and rescues nobody.

After a while she said, "When we leave, give her the address of the fuller on the Clivus. Not mine. The fuller's. And tell her that if she must run, run in the evening and go to Ostia, not to the north road, because the north road is watched."

"That is a great deal of advice for a stranger."

"She is not a stranger. She is what I was." Antonia stood, and the steam rolled off her, and she went out through the tepidarium into the cold room, and the shock of it made her eyes water, and she stood under the cold spout until her heart slowed, and then she went to do business.

The man she had come to see was waiting in the corner of the cold room with his hands under his arms, shivering, bald, sixty, and richer than half the senate. His name was Gaius Iulius Hermes, and he had begun life as a slave in the household of a man who had owned brickfields, and he now owned four of those brickfields and had a contract to supply tiles to the emperor's new forum, and he had a son who was a knight and a daughter who had married into a family with a consul in it.

He kissed her hand, which was more intimate than he intended and less than she allowed.

"You are late," he said.

"I am never late. You are early, because you are cold, and because you are afraid the man from the fiscus will find you here."

"The man from the fiscus will not find me here. He is at the baths of Titus, where the water is warmer and the company is worse." Hermes shuffled in his towel. "The contract."

"The contract is good. You will deliver forty thousand tiles to the site by the Kalends of June, and you will be paid in two parts, and the second part will be late."

"It is always late."

"It is always late because the fiscus is always short, and the fiscus is always short because the emperor is building a column one hundred feet high with a spiral of two thousand five hundred figures on it, and somebody has to pay for the figures." Antonia took the tablet he had brought, which was wrapped in oilcloth and was a copy of the contract. "Who signed for the fiscus?"

"Haterius."

"Haterius is a clerk."

"Haterius is a clerk who takes a fee, and the fee is one and a half per cent, and I have paid it, and I have written it down as a gift to a temple, and if the temple asks I will say it was for a new roof." Hermes looked at her. "You are not listening."

"I am listening. I am also counting." She turned the tablet. "The contract is for forty thousand tiles. The site needs sixty thousand. There will be a second contract in the summer, and it will go to whoever gives Haterius the larger gift, and Haterius will let the contract to a man whose brother-in-law is in the office of the a rationibus. That is how it works."

"Then I must give Haterius a larger gift."

"Then you will be paid less than the gift, and you will make it up on the thickness of the tiles, and one day a tile will be too thin and a roof will fall in and kill a man, and the man's widow will go to the prefect, and the prefect will look for a name, and it will not be Haterius's name."

Hermes was silent. The cold room dripped. A man came out of the hot room, red as a lobster, and threw himself into the plunge with a shriek.

"What do you advise?" Hermes said.

"Give Haterius his fee and take the second contract, and make your tiles the thickness the site requires, and keep the contract in a strongbox with a copy of the receipt. In three years, when the emperor is in the east and the accounts are being audited by men who

were not there, a receipt is the difference between a fine and a cart to the docks."

"You are a hard woman."

"I am a careful one. Hard is what people call careful when it is a woman."

She gave him back the tablet, and he put it under his arm and held out his hand, and she let him kiss it again, and he went away shivering into the steam.

❦

The women's side let out into a garden of clipped box with a portico around it, and the portico was where the real business of the city was done, the business of reputations. Antonia came out with her hair still damp and her mantle over her arm, and saw the group at the far end, and knew that she had been seen, and knew that it had been arranged.

Acilia Marcella sat on the stone bench with two other women and a slave holding a parasol, though the sun was behind a cloud. She was thirty-three and dressed like a woman of forty-five, in the old fashion, in the heavy wool and the deep colors, with her hair braided close to her head. It made her look like a portrait of somebody's grandmother, and it was a lie, because she had the sharpest eyes in any room she entered.

"Antonia Cassia," she said, and smiled. "Come and sit. We were talking about marriage."

The two other women made room. One of them was the wife of a praetor; the other was the widow of a man who had been consul twice and had died of a stroke in his own bath.

"I have nothing to say about marriage," Antonia said.

"That is what makes you so useful." Marcella gestured, and the slave with the parasol moved it, and Antonia had no choice but to sit in the small shade of it. "This is the month of weddings. My step-

daughter is to marry in September. I have spent the morning with the goldsmith."

"In that case, you have my sympathy."

"The goldsmith is a poet. He showed me a bracelet and said that it was a line from Sappho, and I said that I did not read Sappho, and he said that he could tell, and I paid him twice what the bracelet was worth because he had made me laugh." Marcella's smile was thin and real. "Tell me. If a girl must marry a man she does not know, what should her stepmother give her?"

"Time," Antonia said. "Everything else can be bought later."

"Time is what her father has least of."

"Then her father is poor in the only thing that matters."

The widow laughed, and then stopped laughing when Marcella did not. Marcella turned her cup in her hand, and the sun came out from behind the cloud, and the shadows of the box hedge lay on the paving like a grid.

"My stepdaughter has been unwell," Marcella said. "She has been going out in the evenings. She comes back with her hands cold and her eyes bright, and she will not tell me where she has been, and I have not asked her, because a girl of sixteen with a secret is a girl with a friend, and a friend is better than a fever."

Antonia said nothing.

"She is a good girl," Marcella said. "She is not clever, but she is honest, and honesty in a woman is a kind of cleverness that takes longer to show. She will make a good wife to Caesennius, who is not a bad man, though he is dull, and dullness in a husband is a mercy."

"You are convincing yourself," Antonia said. "Do not do it in front of me. I have no interest in your comfort."

The two other women became extremely interested in the view. Marcella set her cup down.

"You have a reputation," she said, "for saying the unsayable in a pleasant voice. I had heard it. I had assumed it was an exaggeration."

"It is not."

"No." Marcella stood. "Walk with me a little. The portico is long and my knees are bad."

They walked. The two women did not follow, and the slave with the parasol followed at a distance, and the long portico with its painted ceiling was empty except for a pair of old men arguing about a charioteer.

"You know a great deal about my household," Marcella said.

"I know what the city knows."

"You know more than the city knows." She stopped by a column, and put her hand on it, and looked out at the garden. "I have been married to a Cassius for nine years. In nine years I have learned that a great family is not a family. It is a company. It has assets and it has debts, and the debts are people, and the assets are people, and the difference between the two is a matter of the account books. My husband loves his name more than he loves his children, and he loves his children more than he loves me, and he loves his own idea of himself more than any of it."

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because you are going to do something," Marcella said, "and I would like to know what it is before it is done."

"I am going to open a jar of wine," Antonia said. "This evening. Would you like to come?"

Marcella looked at her for a long moment. Then she laughed, and it was a good laugh, and it made her look thirty-three and tired.

"I have a girl in my house," she said, "who is twenty and pretty and has no more idea of what she is than a cat. And I have a husband who does not look at her, and a stepson who does not look at anything but the bottom of a cup, and a stepdaughter who is being sold to a brickmaker for a consulship." She turned. "If you are going to break my husband's house, do it in the spring, before the wedding, and do it in a way that leaves the rest of us standing."

"I have not said I was going to break anything."

"You have not said anything at all. That is how I know." Marcella smiled, and it was almost kind. "You should not have worn the tunic. Everyone can see you are hiding something, and everyone can see you are not frightened of being seen. It makes them think about you for a quarter of an hour longer than they otherwise would."

She walked away, and the parasol went with her, and Antonia stood by the column with her wet hair on her neck.

❦

At the door of the women's side, the girl from the plunge was waiting with her shoes in her hand.

"Rufina said you had spoken to her about me," she said. Her eyes were red and her voice was steady, which was worse than crying. "She said you had told her to tell me about Ostia."

"Rufina talks too much."

"Is it true that the north road is watched?"

"It is watched in the spring, when the shepherds come down. It is not watched in the winter, because nobody goes north in the winter." Antonia looked at her. "You are not going to run."

The girl's chin came up. "How do you know?"

"Because you are standing here asking a strange woman for directions instead of walking out of the gate. A girl who is going to run does not ask. She goes." Antonia took her by the wrist, gently, above the bruise. "You have a father who is selling you and a man in Africa who has bought you and no money of your own. That is a bad hand. But it is not the worst hand in Rome, and I have seen the worst hand played well. Do you know what the worst hand needs?"

"What?"

"A witness," Antonia said. "Not a friend, not a lover, not a god. A witness. Someone who will say, in front of other people, that they saw what was done to you. Find one before you go anywhere. A

neighbor, a nurse, a priest of Isis with a good memory. Then, when you are gone, there will be a woman in Rome who says your name out loud, and a man who has beaten you will have to explain why."

The girl looked at her. "Did someone witness for you?"

"Yes," Antonia said. "And it took her eleven years, and she was too late, and I have been paying for it ever since. Go home. Do not go to Africa in October; the crossing is bad and the men who arrange it are worse. If you are still in Rome in the summer, send to the fuller's on the Clivus and ask for Tullia."

She walked away without looking back, because looking back would have made it a kindness, and kindnesses given in doorways were remembered by the wrong people.

❦

The office of petitions was in a wing of the imperial forum, up a stair, behind a door with a bronze plate that said nothing at all. It had been designed, Antonia thought, by a man who had been told that citizens would come here only in the last extremity, and who had decided to make the last extremity as comfortable as possible so that their patience would last.

It did not work. The room held forty people and had chairs for six. There were petitioners from the provinces in good cloaks that had been worn for a week. There was a Jew from Antioch with a bundle of letters and a Greek from Corinth with a claim about a well. There was a woman in black with a boy of about eleven, and the boy had a letter in his hand, and was holding it the way a person holds a bird.

Antonia did not sit. She stood in the corner with Tullia beside her, and she waited the way a woman waits for news, which is to say without moving, and for a great deal longer than anyone around her expected.

At the third hour of waiting, a clerk came out with a tablet and called six names, and three of them went in. At the fourth, he came out again and looked at Antonia, and came over.

"You are Antonia Cassia."

"Yes."

"The secretary will see you."

The secretary was not the man Nepos had named. He was a freedman called Haterius, about sixty, with the hands of a copyist, and he had been in this office for twenty years, and he had watched three emperors and seen the same petitions arrive year after year in the same handwriting.

"The petition," he said, "is for a grant of freeborn standing to a freedwoman of the household of Cassia Severa, manumitted in the consulship of Pompeius Collega and Priscinus, on the eleventh day before the Kalends of December."

"That is correct."

"The fee has been paid. The witness has been called and has confirmed the manumission. The office has read the petition." He put it down. "The office has no objection to the petition."

Antonia did not smile. Men in offices said the first part of a sentence in order to watch a person's face before they said the second.

"The office has no objection," Haterius said, "but the office cannot advance the petition to the council without the endorsement of a consular, and a consular is not a clerk who signs whatever is on his desk."

"I know what a consular is."

"Then you know that they are busy, and that a consular is asked for three hundred endorsements a year, and that the ones he remembers are the ones asked for by a man he owes something to, or a man who owes something to him, or a woman who has done one of them a service and is owed in her own right." He looked at her. "Do you have such a consular?"

"No."

Haterius nodded, and made a mark on the tablet. "Then the petition will wait until you find one. It need not be withdrawn. It will not be forgotten. It will wait."

"How long?"

"Some petitions have waited eleven years." He said it without unkindness. "The emperor is leaving for the east in a year, or two, or five. The office will go with him, in part. A petition that needs his hand will go to the east and come back with a seal or it will not come back at all."

Antonia said, "There is a man in the Via Nova with a burned hand, who says his name is Felix, and who says he works for the prefect's office."

Haterius looked at her. She watched him decide not to have heard it, and watched him decide that not hearing it would be worse.

"There is a Felix who works for the prefect's office," he said. "He is a freedman of the household of the praetorians. He carries messages."

"Between whom?"

"Between men who do not want their names in a letter."

"And the petition about a child?"

The old man's face did not move. "I am a clerk," he said. "I write things down and I read what is put in front of me. If there were a petition about a child, it would be in a different room of the empire, and I would not be told about it."

"Then tell me which room."

"Domina," Haterius said, and for the first time there was something in his voice that was not a clerk's voice. "Go home. Find a consular. Do not ask a clerk which room, because a clerk who tells you which room will be in the room next to you, and you will not like his company."

Tullia took her arm and drew her out. In the corridor the woman in black was still waiting, and the boy had fallen asleep with his head on her lap, and the letter was still in his hand, folded, sealed, and addressed in a fine hand to a man who was dead.

Antonia stopped. "What is your petition?"

The woman looked up. She had a broad provincial face and a bruise on her wrist the color of a plum, and she had been sitting on that bench since before dawn.

"My husband was a centurion in the second legion," she said. "He died at Sarmizegetusa, in the last year of the war. The legion wrote that his pay was owed and would be paid to his heir, and his heir is my son, and I have been to the office of the legion three times and the office has moved, and I have been to the treasury twice and the treasury says the second legion was paid, and I have been to the governor's office and the governor's office says the second legion was paid to the legion, not to the men. And my son has been to the temple of Mars and back and he is eleven and he can read and he wrote this letter and the man it is addressed to died in the year of the fire."

"Give it to me," Antonia said.

The woman hesitated. "You are not an official."

"I am not. I am worse." Antonia took the letter and opened it and read it while the woman watched her. It was a good letter. It was in a clear hand and it said what the boy had been told to say and it ended with the boy's name and the name of his father and a request for the pay of six years, and a request for the money the legion had promised for the funeral, and a request, at the end, in a smaller hand, that the emperor might remember the men of the second.

"How much is owed?"

"Nine hundred and sixty sesterces. And the funeral money, which is three hundred."

Antonia folded the letter. “Come to the house on the Clivus Suburanus on the day after tomorrow, at the ninth hour, and ask for Tullia. Bring the letter and the marriage record and your son’s birth record if you have it, and if the legion’s man asked for a bribe, bring his name and the amount.”

The woman’s mouth worked. “I have nothing to give you.”

“You have the letter,” Antonia said. “That will do.”

They went out into the forum. It was late afternoon and the light had gone long and yellow, and the great equestrian statue threw a shadow the length of the square. Tullia said, after a while, “You cannot get a legion’s pay out of the treasury in a month, and certainly not before the wedding.”

“No.”

“Then why did you tell her to come?”

“Because in nineteen years nobody has told her to come to anywhere,” Antonia said, “and because I am going to walk into a house on the Viminal in September and ask for a girl, and I will find it useful to have been the sort of woman who once asked for a soldier’s pay.”

❦

The night was the only part of the day that was hers.

Crescens came at the eighth hour, off a watch, with the smell of smoke in his cloak. He had taken off the uniform and put on a plain tunic, which was his way of saying that he came as a man and not as a tribune, and by now she knew what it meant when he did that, and she knew what it would cost her to care.

“You have eaten,” she said.

“I have eaten. The prefect’s wife sent bread and cheese down to the station, which she does once a year, and we all stood around eating it and pretending we did not notice that she had sent it because a

man died in a fire on the Caelian and the prefect did not want a complaint."

"Which man?"

"A shopkeeper. His name was the same as the shop's, and the shop was his whole family, and the family slept above it, and none of them woke up." He put his helmet on the table, and looked at it, and did not sit. "The shop was a bakery. The men ran out of the bakery and the family did not."

Antonia came and stood behind him and put her hands on his shoulders. He was thirty-four and his shoulders were hard with carrying, and he leaned back against her a little and let out his breath.

They went to bed, and it was good, and it was quiet, and afterward he lay on his back with one arm over his eyes and she lay beside him with the sheet up to her shoulder and looked at the ceiling where the lamplight moved.

"You are thinking," he said.

"I am always thinking."

"You are thinking in a particular way. You are thinking about a thing you will not tell me." He moved his arm. "I am not asking. I am telling you that I can tell. It is my one accomplishment."

"Your one accomplishment is that you can pull a man out of a burning building."

"That is other people's accomplishment. Mine is that I notice."

She turned her head. In the dark he was a shape with a glint of grey at the temple. He was eleven years younger than she was, and this had mattered to her at the beginning, and did not matter now, and would not be spoken of.

"There is a man," she said. "A freedman with a burned hand, who works for the prefect's office. His name is Felix. He has been asking about a child sold eighteen years ago from the house of Cominius Asiaticus."

Crescens was quiet for a moment. “Cominius died in the year of the fire.”

“Cominius died in his bed, with a slave beside him, and the slave was sold with the house.”

“How do you know that?”

“Because I bought her,” Antonia said. “She is sixty now. She sits by the door at night and she does not remember the man’s name but she remembers his hands.”

“You bought a witness.”

“I bought a woman who could not be sold to anyone else.” Antonia turned on her back. “Who is Felix’s master?”

“His master is the prefect. But the prefect’s office is not the prefect’s. The prefect is Petronius Celer, who is a good man and a lazy one, and the office runs on three freedmen, and one of them is a man called Anicetus, and Anicetus does not do anything unless he is told by a man with a name. I do not know which name.”

“Find out.”

“I am a tribune of the seventh cohort. I put out fires. I am not a spy.”

“You are the fire-watch,” Antonia said, “which means you are the only official in Rome who can knock on any door in the city at any hour and have a reason. You are not a spy. You are a man who notices.”

Crescens was quiet for a while. Then he said, “If I ask, and someone above me hears that I asked, I will be transferred to the docks, and there will be a fire in the docks, and I will be blamed for it, and I will be dismissed, and I will owe three money-lenders money I cannot pay, and the only house in Rome that would take me in would be this one.”

“I know.”

“You know, and you are asking anyway.”

“Yes,” Antonia said.

He turned his head. "Why?"

"Because you are the only man I know who could ask and survive the asking. Because you owe me eleven thousand sesterces and you have never once pretended you did not. Because I am nearly forty and I have spent my life making men want me, and it turns out that what I wanted all along was to be able to tell one of them the truth."

The lamp guttered. Crescens put his hand on her arm, and his hand was warm, and she did not tell him not to touch the left.

"What is the truth?" he said.

"The truth," Antonia said, "is in a house on the Viminal, and I have been invited to a wedding."

She did not say more. She lay awake after he had fallen asleep, and listened to the fountain, and to the noise the city made at night, which was never silence and never quite noise. Somewhere a door shut. Somewhere a woman laughed, or cried, or both. The house settled, and creaked, and held.

In the morning, before dawn, Cerdon came with a folded tablet sealed with a cassia leaf.

Antonia broke the seal under the lamp and read it twice. It was six words and no signature.

Come to me, and come alone.

She held the tablet over the flame until it caught, and dropped it in the bowl, and watched the cassia leaf blacken and curl.

CHAPTER IV

WHAT THE SENATOR WANTED

Rome, March, AD 112

The letter had said *come to me*, and she had not come. Three days later a second letter came, and it said nothing at all: it was a page of a poet, copied out in a careful hand, the one about the girl who waits at the door and cannot make herself knock. No signature. The cassia leaf in the wax.

Antonia read it twice and then sent Cerdon to the Viminal with a message that had taken her an hour to write and was four words long.

The door is open.

She spent the day making the house into a place where a consular could be received without either of them being able to pretend afterward that it had been an accident. The dining room was shut. The garden was swept. Beryllos was told to make nothing, and to be seen making nothing, which was a small insult delivered with great care. The girls were sent out: Kallisto to the house of a patron who had asked for her, Dessa to the market with Tullia and a list. Antonia put on a stola of dark blue, and a mantle the color of wine, and no jewelry at all, and looked at herself in the bronze for a long time.

At the ninth hour he came, on foot, with one slave and no litter, which was itself a statement: a consular who walks is a man making a point about the modesty of his fortune or the strength of his legs, and Verus had never in his life made a point about either.

While she waited, she did what she always did before a thing that frightened her: she walked the house.

The kitchen first, where Beryllos had put out a bowl of olives he had not been told to put out, in the hope of being noticed. "Take them away," Antonia said. "He is not to be fed." Then the passage, where the girls slept in three rooms with a lamp at the end and a bell on the door; then the bath, where the water had been changed and the bronze had been polished and the small crack in the mosaic by the step had been filled with white cement that did not match. Then the dining room, where the twelve couches stood empty in the last of the light and the painted Danaë held out her hands to a shower of coins.

In the year 93 this room had not existed. In the year 93 she had slept in a room above a fuller's shop with a straw mattress and a jug and a window the size of a hand, and she had woken every morning to the smell of the urine vats, and she had thought of the smell as the smell of being alive, because the alternative had been the smell of the other thing.

She stood in the doorway and made herself remember the Cassian house as it had been: the long fauces with the black threshold stone, the atrium with the masks in their cupboards, the garden with the old vine, the corridor behind the kitchen where the slaves slept, the lamp with the bronze door on its handle. She remembered the smell of the lamp oil, which was cheap and rancid, and the smell of the master's wool, which was not.

She remembered a rope. She did not let herself remember it for longer than it took to see it.

"Domina." Rufina was in the passage with the blue stola over her arm. "You are white."

"I am cold."

"It is the warmest day of the month."

"Then I am old." Antonia took the stola. "Rufina. If he raises his voice in this house, do not come. If he raises his hand, do not come. If he does anything at all that I do not answer, then come with the knife and stand between us and do not say a word."

Rufina's face did not change. She had been a slave in a house in Pompeii when the mountain went, and she had been sold four times since, and she had a scar on her forearm in the shape of a crescent, and she had never once in eleven years asked Antonia a question about her back.

"And if he does nothing?" she said.

"Then bring wine at the second hour, whether we want it or not, and say that the cook is asking about the fish."

❦

At the ninth hour he came.

Cerdon brought him through the passage into the peristyle and left him there, as he had been told. Antonia came out under the colonnade and stopped at the edge of the light.

He had aged in a way that was almost an accusation. The jaw was still good, the shoulders still straight, but the skin under his eyes had gone thin, and there was grey in his close-cut hair, and he stood with one hand behind his back as though he were at a levy.

"Manius," she said.

He flinched. It was very small. She had not expected it to be so small, or to give her so much.

"Antonia."

"You may sit. The bench is clean. I had it cleaned."

He did not sit.

"Very well," she said. "Stand."

The fountain ran. Somewhere in the house a door closed. He looked around the garden, at the roses, at the painted wall, at the little bronze Priapus by the gate with his ridiculous load, and his

face did the thing she remembered: it arranged itself. First the mouth, then the eyes, then the forehead, and by the time it had finished arranging there was a man standing there who had never been frightened of anything.

"You have done well for yourself," he said.

"I have."

"The house is —" he looked for the word, and found, as he always did, the word that cost the least — "comfortable."

"It is worth four hundred thousand. The garden is worth sixty. The girls are worth more than the garden and the house together, and the wine is worth more than the girls." She came out into the light. "You did not come here to value the property."

"No."

"Then say what you came to say."

He looked at her. Sixteen years, and something in the look had not changed, and she hated it for not changing.

"My daughter came to see you," he said.

"Yes."

"Twice."

"Yes."

"She is sixteen years old. She is betrothed to a man of equestrian family with a cousin on the council. She will be married in September, and the marriage will secure the future of my house, and her children will be Romans of two fortunes." He said it evenly. "And she came to you, at your back gate, twice, in the dark, with one slave, because you are the only person in Rome who would listen to her."

"I listened to her."

"You encouraged her."

"I told her to go home."

"You told her," Verus said, and his voice did not rise, "that her father was selling her."

"Her father is selling her."

"The word is marriage."

"The word is marriage when the woman has a choice and the man has a name. When the man is fifty-four and the woman is sixteen and the money goes to her father, the word is sale. You may call it a marriage in the senate house. In this garden we are among friends."

His jaw worked. "You have not changed."

"No. That is the tragedy of it." She sat on the bench and gestured at the other end of it. "Sit down, Manius. You are making my neck hurt."

He sat. He sat at the far end, with his hands on his knees, and for a moment they were two people on a bench in a garden in March, and the sixteen years were only weather.

"I did not come to quarrel," he said.

"You came to tell me to stay away from your house and your daughter and your wedding. Say it, and go, and we can both be finished before the wine."

"I came to ask you a question."

"Ask."

"What do you want?"

The fountain ran. Antonia looked at the roses.

"I want the rescript," she said. "I want a consular's endorsement. I want a man of your standing to carry my petition to the council and say that the woman named in it is known to him, and of good character, and deserving. That is what I want. It has been what I have wanted for eleven years, and you know it, because you know everything that happens in that office."

Verus's face did not move. "I will not do it."

"I know."

"Because you are not of good character."

"I know that also."

"Because a man who endorses the petition of a brothel-keeper —"

"There it is," Antonia said, and smiled, and the smile was a knife turned handle-out.

"— a woman who keeps a house of —" He stopped himself. He was a senator; he had been trained since boyhood to stop himself just before the word that would put him in the wrong. "A woman of your profession."

"Say it in Latin, Manius. You are a consular. You have a fine vocabulary. Say the word you have been using about me since the year 94."

He said nothing. The fountain ran.

"You cannot," she said. "That is the difference between us, and it has always been the difference. You know what I am, and you know it precisely, and you have known it in the dark. And you have spent sixteen years arranging your face so that no one could tell that you knew it." She stood. "I do not arrange my face. What I am is written on the door, and men come to the door, and they pay, and they are not the worse for it, and some of them are the better."

"You are not the worse for it," Verus said, and his voice had gone quiet. "That is what you tell yourself."

"It is what I know."

"You were not —" He stopped, and started again. "There was a girl in the house. In my mother's house. She had a room behind the kitchen, and she slept on a pallet, and she was clever, and she could read better than my sister. She used to sit with the steward's accounts and find the errors, and the steward hated her for it. She had a way of —" He looked at the fountain. "She had a way of putting her head to one side when she was thinking, like a bird. She was seventeen."

"I was nineteen."

"You were nineteen," he agreed. "And I was twenty-six, and I was going to be consul, and my father had told me since I was a child that the family was the only thing that mattered, and the family was not a thing you could see or touch. It was a name on a list. It was the order in which men stood at a sacrifice."

"It was a name on a list," Antonia said, "and I was a body on a pallet."

"Yes."

The word did something to the garden. Neither of them had expected him to say it.

"I have thought about that year," Verus said, "more than I have thought about any year of my life. I have thought about what I did and what I did not do, and I have made arguments to myself at night, and the arguments are good. They are the best arguments I have. And then I see a girl with her head to one side, and the arguments are worth nothing, and I am still the man who made them."

Antonia stood very still. She had imagined this speech for sixteen years, in perhaps forty versions, and in none of them had he said it in her garden, on a bench, with his hands on his knees, in the voice of a man reading a ledger.

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because you asked me what I wanted."

"I asked you what you wanted. Not what you regret."

"What I want," Verus said, "is for the girl in my house to go on being in my house."

The garden went cold. Antonia heard her own blood.

"She is my daughter's maid," he said. "She has a room off the passage, and she sleeps there, and she is fed, and she is not beaten, and she has work that does not ruin her hands. She is twenty. In four years I will marry her to a freedman of my household, or I will set her free, and she will have a trade and a name and a place in the

city. That is more than most women in Rome will ever have. That is more than her mother had."

Her mother.

Antonia said, "Say her name."

"I have not said the name in sixteen years."

"Say it."

"Prima," Verus said.

The word was not loud. It went through her like a nail.

"Do not," she said, "use that name in this house."

"It is your name."

"It was the name a man gave me when he bought my mother, and it means first, and I was not first, I was the fourth or fifth, and by the time I could read I knew what it meant." Her voice was steady, and she was proud of it. "I have been Antonia Cassia for eleven years. I bought the name with money. I earned it. It is in the records of the city, and if you say the other name again in my garden I will have Cerdon put you in the street, consular or not, and the whole Subura will see it."

Verus stood. For a moment he was close to her, close enough that she could smell the wool of his toga and the oil in his hair, and she did not step back, because stepping back was a thing the girl on the pallet had done.

"I know what you are doing," he said. "You are gathering a case. You have a girl who is frightened of her father, and a ledger of names, and a story about a token, and you think that one day you will stand in front of the praetor and say, that girl is free, and the praetor will look at the man who has been consul and say, oh, is she, and the whole city will fall down."

"I think no such thing."

"Then what do you think?"

"I think you have been very careful," Antonia said. "I think the purchase was made in the name of your steward, and the steward is

dead. I think the girl was put with a nurse in the country for six years and brought into the house when the nurse died, and that the household believes she was bought from a dealer in the Subura, which is true. I think there is not one document in Rome that connects her to me, except the token around her neck, and a midwife at Ficulea who remembers a birth, and a woman in this house who kept the other half of the token, and a book I have kept for eighteen years." She looked at him. "And I think you know all of that, because you have been counting it, the way I have, every night, for eighteen years."

Verus's face had gone the color of tallow.

"If I wanted to destroy you," he said, "I could do it in a week. You are a freedwoman who keeps a house of pleasure. There are a hundred men in the senate who would sign a complaint against you and thank me for the pen."

"There are a hundred men in the senate who have been in this house, and their names are in a book, and the book is not in this house."

Something moved behind his eyes then, and it was not anger. Antonia saw it, and understood it, and was afraid of it.

"You have made a copy," he said.

"I have made nothing. I have kept a book. The book has been kept for eleven years, and it says who came, and when, and what they said they wanted, and what they paid, and what they were afraid of. It is not a weapon. It is a record. A weapon is a thing you use; a record is a thing that exists. Men have killed for less, and men have paid more to know that a record exists." She stepped back. "Go home, Manius. Tell your daughter to obey you. Tell your wife to be kind to the girl. And do not send any more men with burned hands to ask questions at my back gate, because the next one will be sent back to you in a cart."

Verus went to the door. At the edge of the colonnade he turned, and the lamplight was on his face, and for one moment he looked like the man in the garden of the house on the Viminal, twenty-six years old, with his whole life in front of him and a girl on a pallet behind the kitchen.

"What do you want?" he said again.

"Everything," Antonia said. "That is what I have always wanted. It is what you have always had."

He went out. Cerdon shut the door. Antonia stood in the garden for a long time, and then she went into the small room, and opened the cedar box, and took out the half-token, and looked at it, and put it down, and put her hands flat on the table.

❦

The house of Lucius Iunius Gallus stood on the Caelian with a view of the aqueduct and a garden that had been laid out by his grandfather and had not been touched since. It had no peristyle, no bath, and one dining room, and the dining room had a leak in the corner that had been mended four times with red tiles, so that the ceiling looked like a page with corrections on it.

He was at dinner with two men and a boy of about ten, and he sent the men away when Antonia was announced, and the boy stayed because the boy was his grandson and had been allowed to stay up.

"You look like a woman who has been in an argument," Gallus said.

"I have been in a conversation."

"The difference being?"

"A conversation is what a woman calls an argument she has won." Antonia sat. "Who were the men?"

"A man from the corn office and a man who wants to be a man from the corn office. They came to ask me what I thought about the

water supply, and I told them that the water supply is a matter for the aediles, and they told me that the aediles are a matter for the consul, and I told them that the consul is a matter for the emperor, and they went away satisfied, which shows how little they wanted."

"And what do you think about the water supply?"

"I think it is a great deal better than it was, and that the men who improved it are dead, and the men who will be praised for it are not born." Gallus poured her wine with his own hand, which was a thing he did for no one. "You did not come to talk about water."

"I came to ask a favor."

"Ah." He sat back. "Say it."

"I need a consular's endorsement for my petition."

Gallus looked at her for a long moment. The boy, at the end of the table, was eating a fig with great concentration, and pretending not to listen in the way children do, which is by listening with the whole body.

"Who has refused you?" Gallus said.

"Nobody has refused me. Nobody has been asked."

"That is not true. You have asked someone. You have the face."

"I have asked no one. I have been told that the office will not advance the petition without an endorsement, and that consulars are busy men, and that the ones who sign are the ones who are owed something or who owe something."

"And so you came to me."

"And so I came to you."

Gallus turned his cup. "You know what I am. I am a man who was consul for two months in the year 96, in a year when four men were consul and one of them was murdered, and I have not held a province, and I have not been on the council, and my name in the senate house is worth a good deal less than my father's was. I am a consular the way a man who has been to sea once is a sailor."

"You are a consular the way a man who has been to sea once is the only man in the room who knows which way the wind is blowing." Antonia set her cup down. "The endorsement does not need to open the door. It needs to be on the paper. The office will do the rest, or it will not, and if it does not I will have lost nothing but the fee."

"You will have lost something," Gallus said. "A petition endorsed by a consular and refused by the council is a petition that has been looked at and found wanting. The next time, the clerk will read the first page and not the second."

"I know."

"And if the reason it is refused is not the petition?"

"Then I will know that also."

Gallus was quiet for a while. The boy finished the fig and licked his fingers, and Gallus, without looking, put out his hand and the boy came and stood by his chair, and Gallus rested his hand on the boy's head.

"The proconsulship of Asia," Gallus said. "That is what the marriage is for, whatever the wedding songs say. Verus wants the province and the province costs money, and the bridegroom's cousin sits on the council, and the council draws up the list of the men who will govern. It is not a bribe. It is worse than a bribe. It is a favor done in the open, by men who will tell you afterward that they did nothing of the kind."

"Can he be stopped?"

"By whom? The emperor is in Dacia in his mind and in the east in his plans. The prefect is a lazy man. The senate will not stop a consular from going to a rich province, because every man in the senate hopes to go to a rich province himself." Gallus turned his cup. "There is a story that the emperor intends to send a man of his own to Asia, a legate with a special commission, to look at the cities' accounts. If that is true, the proconsulship of Asia will be worth a

great deal less than Verus thinks, and the man who tells him so will not be thanked."

"Where did you hear it?"

"From a man who heard it from a clerk who heard it from a freedman of the empress." Gallus shrugged. "It may be nothing. It may be everything. In Rome, the difference between nothing and everything is how many men have heard it."

"Then I shall hear it again," Antonia said.

"Decimus has been in the company of young Verus," he said.

"I know. They were both at my table."

"The son is a fool and the father is a cold man, and I do not like the way the son looks at his father, or the way the father looks at nothing." Gallus's hand did not move on the boy's head. "There is a story in the city that the Cassii have a slave girl who is more than a slave. I have heard it twice, from two men who do not know each other. That is how a story becomes a fact in Rome: two men who do not know each other, saying it in the same week."

Antonia said nothing.

"If I sign your petition," Gallus said, "and it becomes known that I have signed it, there will be men who ask why. And the answer, whatever it is, will be attached to your name and to mine for as long as we are both alive."

"I know."

"And you are asking me anyway."

"Yes."

Gallus lifted his hand from the boy's head. "Go to bed, Gaius. Tell your mother I said so, and tell her I said it before the second cup, so that she cannot say I was drunk."

The boy went, and at the door he turned and looked at Antonia with an expression of enormous seriousness, and then he was gone.

"Bring me the petition," Gallus said. "I will read it. If it is honest and the witness is good, I will sign it and carry it myself. And if it is

refused, I will want to know why, and I will ask, in the senate house, in front of men who will have to answer."

Antonia looked at him. She had come to ask a favor and had been given something else, and she was not sure yet whether it was a gift or a rope.

"Why?" she said.

"Because when I was thirty, a man I owed everything to asked me to do a small dishonesty, and I did it, and it cost another man his life, and I have been a decent man ever since to make up for it." Gallus refilled her cup. "It does not work, by the way. The decency. It does not make up for anything. But it passes the time, and it is better than the alternative."

❦

Tullia found her there an hour later.

"The girls are back. Dessa bought the fish and got a better price than the list allowed, and she has put the difference in the house box without being asked, which is either the beginning of a very good steward or the beginning of a very careful thief."

"She is careful. She has been careful since she was fourteen. Careful is what a slave is instead of happy." Antonia looked up. "I want the Ostia accounts brought up. The grain venture, the warehouse, all of it. And I want a list of every ship's master we have paid in the last two years, and every manifest we have seen."

"You are going to Ostia."

"On Thursday."

"Thursday is the day of the wedding contract."

"The contract is in September."

"The contract is signed in April, in the house of the bridegroom, with the two families present. It is signed on Thursday."

Antonia looked at the wall for a moment. "Then I will be in Ostia on Thursday, and you will go to the signing in my place."

"Me."

"You. You are a freedwoman of this house and you are known to every steward in the city, and you will stand at the back with the slaves and the clients and you will watch Acilia Marcella's face when the dowry is named."

Tullia's mouth twitched. "And if the dowry is named at a sum that leaves the Cassii with nothing?"

"Then we will know what the wedding is worth," Antonia said, "and we will know what her father is willing to do to keep it."

Tullia went out with the tablets. Antonia sat alone in the small room with the lamp and the strongbox and the smell of the oil, and did the thing she did every night, which was to open the book and read one page of it at random and remember the man whose name was on it.

Tonight the page was from the fourth year. A praetor, two hundred thousand, for a favor about a will. A knight, thirty thousand, for an introduction. A man whose name she had written as a squiggle because he had paid in gold and asked her not to write him at all. A woman — there were eleven women in the book, and their names were written in a different hand, Tullia's hand, because Antonia had never trusted her own to write them — a woman who had come to the house at night and asked for a girl and had sat in the garden and wept for an hour and had paid nothing.

Antonia closed the book. In the passage, Cerdon was telling someone about the man with the burned hand, who had been at the corner again, and had stood in the rain for an hour, and had gone away when the watch came round.

She put the book back in the oiled cloth and locked the strongbox, and sat with her hand on the lid.

On Thursday she would go to Ostia, and she would find the man who had bought the child, or the man who had sold her, or the

paper that said which. It had been eighteen years. It could wait four days.

It could not wait four days. She knew that, and she sat in the dark and knew it, and the lamp burned down, and the house breathed around her, and somewhere beyond the wall a woman was singing a song about a sailor who did not come home.

She had a superstition about that song. She had heard it first in the year 94, in a room above a fuller's shop, sung badly by a girl in the next building who had a baby and no husband and an opinion about everything, and she had heard it again in the brothel on the Aventine, from a woman who was dying of something the physician would not name, and she had heard it in this house on the night she took the lease.

"Go to bed," she said to the house, and the house did not answer, because it was a house and it had learned, in eleven years, to keep its opinions to itself.

She went to bed.

CHAPTER V

THE HARBOUR MASTER'S LEDGER

Ostia, March, AD 112

They left before daylight, in a hired carriage with a driver who had been recommended for silence and a mule that had been recommended for nothing. The Ostian road ran south-west from the Porta Ostiensis between market gardens and rubbish heaps, and for the first hour the only things awake were the geese and the men coming into the city with vegetables on their backs.

Tullia slept. Antonia did not. She sat with her feet on a bale of wool and watched the road come out of the dark, and thought about a ledger.

At the seventh hour they came over the low ridge and saw the sea. Ostia lay below them, red roofs and white warehouses and the great brown mouth of the Tiber turning in its own mud, and beyond it, to the north, the lighthouse at Portus with its fire going out in the daylight, and the harbor full of masts so dense that from a distance it looked like a burned forest.

"There are three hundred ships in that harbor," said the driver, who had been silent for four hours and had evidently decided that the recommendation had been satisfied. "They say the grain fleet alone brings a hundred thousand tons a year."

"They say a great many things. Who is they?"

"The Greeks in the tavern."

"Then it is true. The Greeks in the tavern have no reason to lie about grain." Antonia looked at the water. "Turn left at the second

milestone and take me to the house of Gaius Calpurnius Daphnus, on the street of the rope-makers."

The house of Daphnus was a warehouse with a room in it. The room had a bed, a table, a bronze lamp in the shape of a ship, and a view of a wall. The warehouse had four thousand modii of Egyptian wheat, a rat problem, and a small shrine in the corner with a fresh garland on it, and the shrine had three gods in it: one Roman, one Greek, and one that Antonia did not recognize and did not ask about.

Daphnus was already up and in a bad temper. "You are early."

"You say that every time, and every time I am exactly on time, and you say it because it makes you feel like a busy man." Antonia put her bag on the table. "The girl."

"The girl is where I said she would be. But you will not like it." He poured wine and did not offer her any, which meant he was serious. "Bassa is dead. She died six years ago, of an ulcer, in her bed, in a house she owned on the via della Foce. Her business went to a freedman called Secundus, who was her steward and is now a dealer in his own right. He has four rooms behind the Macellum and a yard, and he sells by the head, and he keeps better records than the treasury."

"And he will sell me a girl."

"He will sell you a girl. What he will not do is sell you a girl for the price of a girl, because he knows what you are and he knows that a woman who runs your house does not come to Ostia in March to buy a maid."

"Then he thinks I want something else."

"Half of Ostia thinks you want something else." Daphnus's mouth moved. "The other half knows you are looking for a paper and are too clever to say so, and they are more dangerous, because they will sell you the paper and also sell the fact that you wanted it."

"And which half is Secundus in?"

"Secundus is in the half that sells both." Daphnus set down the cup and took his cloak. "I have known him fourteen years. He is not a monster. He is a man with a shop. That is worse, in case you were wondering. A monster can be hated, and hatred is a sort of clarity. A man with a shop will sell you a child and give you a receipt, and he will go home and eat his dinner, and he will sleep."

Before that, the morning's business. Daphnus walked her along the quay to the square where the shippers had their offices, a colonnade with a mosaic floor of ships and dolphins and the names of every port from Alexandria to Gades. The men who ran the sea sat under the arcade on stools, with their clerks behind them and their account books open, and the noise was the noise of any market: money counted, credit promised, weather argued about.

A man called Aulus Caecilius was waiting for them, and he was sixty and had a face like a dried fig, and he owned two ships and had shares in four more, and he had the particular courtesy of men who have been ruined once and recovered.

"The Egyptian ships are late," he said, without preamble. "The grain comes in and the price drops and every shipper in the port says the same thing, and then next year the price rises and they say the other thing. You are not here to buy grain."

"I am here to buy grain."

"Then you are here to buy grain at a price that will look foolish in June."

"Then I shall be foolish in June." Antonia sat down on the bench beside him. "I want three thousand modii of the Egyptian wheat, delivered to the warehouse of Daphnus before the Kalends of May, and I want it at the Ostian price and not the Roman one."

"Impossible."

"Everything is impossible before breakfast."

"The Ostian price is for the man who has a ship. You have no ship."

"I have a warehouse, which is better than a ship, because a warehouse does not sink." She let a moment pass. "I have also the goodwill of a man in the corn office, who can tell me on any given morning how many ships are expected and how many have come in, and a warehouse in the fourteenth region where the grain can sit until the price is right. What I do not have is a man with a ship. So I have brought a bargain instead of a ship. You will deliver the grain to my man at the Ostian price, and when the price rises in June, as it will, I will sell it back to you at a price we agree today, and you will make a profit on grain that never left your warehouse."

Caecilius looked at her for a while. "That is a very old trick."

"It is. It works because men forget that it is old."

"It works if the price rises."

"It will rise."

"Why?"

"Because the emperor is going east, and the east takes legions, and legions eat grain, and the grain goes out of the province to feed them, and the price of grain in Italy rises in a war year the way it has risen in every war year since Sulla." Antonia turned her cup. "You knew that. You wanted to hear me say it, so that you could tell your clerk that the woman from Rome said it and so it must be true."

Caecilius's dry face cracked into something like a grin. "In June," he said, "I will say it was my idea."

"In June you may say it was the emperor's idea. Only deliver the grain."

The bargain was made the way bargains were made in the port: with two witnesses, a written tablet in duplicate, a deposit in silver, and a small offering of wine to the goddess of the harbor, which Caecilius made with the air of a man who had not believed in her since the year of the three bad harvests.

The Macellum of Ostia was a square of shops around a courtyard with a fish market in it and a shrine of the genius of the place at the corner. Behind it, in a lane too narrow for a cart, was a door painted a deep green, and behind the door was a yard, and in the yard were eleven people.

Antonia had been in such yards before. She had been in one at the age of nineteen, though not this one, and not in this town. She had learned that the trick of it was to look at the people and not at the thing the yard was: at the man from Britain with the scars on his back, at the two sisters who held hands, at the old woman with the cough who would be dead before the summer and would be sold cheap to whoever would take her.

Secundus came out with his tablets before he looked up. He was fifty-five, fat, clean, with a barber's hands. "Gaius Calpurnius said you would come. He did not say you would come yourself."

"I am here."

"You are here." He smiled. "The house on the Clivus. I have heard of it. A fine house. My father bought a girl from your man, years ago, a Numidian, and she went to a house on the Aventine — but that is business, and not to the purpose. What are you looking for?"

"A maid. Sixteen to twenty. She must be clean, and she must be able to be taught, and she must not be stupid."

"A maid is nine hundred sesterces."

"A maid of that description is four hundred."

"A maid of that description is nine hundred, because I am the only man in Ostia who can deliver one this week and you have come to me in March when every girl on the market is nineteen and ugly."

"Show me."

Secundus showed her. There were six women of the right age, and they were brought out and made to stand in a line in the yard, and told to say their names and their trades. Most of them had been

taught to say these things before. One of them, a girl of about thirteen, was at the end of the line and had not been in the group with the two sisters; she had been sitting on a stone in the corner with her arms around her knees, and when the man with the whipcords came to fetch her she got up at once, before he touched her, which was a thing Antonia recognized and did not want to recognize.

"This one is small," Antonia said.

"She is Numidian. They do not grow tall."

"She is thirteen."

"Fourteen," Secundus said. "She has the certificate to say fourteen."

Antonia looked at the girl. The girl looked at the ground.

"What is your name?"

"Sabina," the girl said.

"Who named you that?"

"The last house."

"That is not a name. That is a list of three things that were done to somebody." Antonia turned. "How much?"

"Nine hundred."

"For a girl of thirteen who has been in three houses?"

"Nine hundred and fifty."

Daphnus, at the gate, was studying the sky. Antonia said, "Eight hundred, and I will buy the girl and the girl's certificate, and I will not tell the port officials about the yard's drainage. That is a great deal more than eight hundred."

Secundus did not look at the drainage, or at the yard. "Eight fifty."

"Eight twenty-five, and you will bring me the accounts of the woman Bassa, because I am told you keep better records than the treasury, and because a man who sells me a girl for eight twenty-five and then asks a favor of me next year is a man I can deal with. A man

who gives me a girl for a fraction of her worth is a man who is planning something else."

Secundus's eyes moved. This was the moment. Antonia had seen it in a hundred negotiations: the moment when the man on the other side of the table realized he was not the cleverest person in the room and decided, instead of becoming smaller, to become larger.

"The accounts of Bassa," he said, "are in a trunk in my tablinum, and they are the only copy of eighteen years of business, and a man who wanted to see them would have to buy something worth his trouble."

"Then sell me something worth my trouble."

Secundus rubbed his jaw. "I will tell you what I would tell my own sister. There are men in Rome who have come down to Ostia asking about the child in the last month. Not one man. Two, and they did not come together, and they did not ask the same questions."

Antonia did not move. "What did they ask?"

"The first asked about a child sold to a house beginning with C. That was a man with a burned hand, in a good cloak, and he paid for his answer with silver and he did not write anything down. The second asked whether Bassa's ledger still existed, and whether it was for sale, and he said he was acting for a household that wished to be certain that its records were correct." Secundus spat on the ground. "I have been in this business thirty years. There is no household in Rome that sends a man to be certain about its records. A household sends a man to be certain that the records are gone."

"And what did you tell him?"

"I told him that Bassa's books were burned when she died, which is a lie, and that I only kept the accounts of the last five years, which is also a lie." Secundus smiled. "I keep them all, domina. I keep everything. A man who keeps everything in this trade lives to

be sixty. A man who throws things away lives to be forty and dies of a complaint of the throat."

Antonia said, "The second man. What did he look like?"

"Tall. Greek, by his accent. Very clean. He had a ring with a horse on it and he paid in gold, which is a thing no one in this town does unless they wish it not to be remembered."

She felt the ground move a little under her, the way it does when you have been walking on a bridge and you suddenly see how high it is. Nepos. Or somebody behind Nepos. Either way, someone had been in Ostia before her, and had asked about the ledger before she had, and had been told a lie that would hold for about as long as it took to bribe the right clerk.

"Then I will pay you tonight," Antonia said, "and you will keep everything, and you will tell the next man who comes that the ledger was sold to a woman from Rome who paid in gold and gave no name."

"There is no such woman."

"There will be by the evening," said Antonia.

"What exactly are you looking for?"

"A child," Antonia said. "Bought in the year of the fire, sold out at three or four months old, and sold to a house with a name that begins with C."

Secundus looked at her for a long time. In the yard the man with the whipcords shifted his weight, and the two sisters held hands, and the old woman coughed.

"The year of the fire," Secundus said, "was a very good year for us, because there were a great many children with no one to claim them. I will need to think about the price."

"I have four hundred thousand in credit with Daphnus, and I have a boat tomorrow, and I have a great deal of patience." Antonia took the girl by the hand — the hand was small and cold and did not pull away — and put the coins in Secundus's palm, one by one,

counting them out loud. “But I do not have the patience to stand in this yard all day. My father used to say that a man’s price is written on his face, and if he will not read it out loud, someone else will take it out of his pocket, so he had better learn to speak. I never knew my father. But the man who owned my mother was a great one for saying it. So. Name a price, Secundus. Name it now.”

Secundus looked at the coins in his hand and then at her. “The trunk is in the tablinum,” he said. “Come at the sixth hour, when the market closes, and bring the girl, and I will tell you what a page is worth.”

The tablinum of Secundus smelled of ink and of the stuff they use for moths. The trunk was iron-bound, and inside it were seventy tablets and thirty bundles of papyrus tied with string, and the smell when it opened was the smell of a whole trade: dust, sealing wax, the sourness of eight hundred names.

It took an hour. Tullia read, and Antonia read, and the girl Sabina sat on the floor by the door with a piece of bread and watched them, and the lamp was lit, and outside the market closed and the town went quiet in the way Ostia went quiet, which was never entirely.

The tablets were heavy and cold, and the writing on them was in three hands: Bassa’s, large and round; her steward’s, small and slanting; and a third hand that appeared only in the margins, in ink so faint it had to be held at an angle to the lamp. Tullia read the margins out loud, because Tullia had been a slave in a house where the steward wrote in the margins, and she knew what a margin was for.

“Here. *The Syrian, paid, do not sell again.* Here. *Boy with the bad eye, keep away from the senator, he asks for boys with both eyes.* And here —“ Tullia stopped.

“Read it.”

"*Girl with the token. Do not sell to the house of Verus. The price is not to be discussed.*"

Antonia took the tablet and turned it to the light, and read the words twice, and then a third time, as though a fourth reading might change them.

"Bassa wrote that?"

"Bassa, or her steward. It is not in the same hand as the other margins. It is in the large hand."

"Then Bassa knew that the sale was wrong, and she wrote a note to herself to be careful, and she sold the child anyway, and she took the mark of the infinity for it, which is what a woman writes when the sum is too large to write down." Antonia put the tablet on the table. "How much is a woman's silence worth, Tullia?"

"Less than a man's, and more than a horse," Tullia said.

"Write that down. I may need it one day."

Bassa had kept her books the way an accountant keeps them and the way a woman keeps them: in three columns, with the date on the left, the price in the middle, and the words on the right. In the year of the fire there were eleven entries for infants, and Antonia read all eleven, and her hand was steady on the tablet.

The ninth entry was in a shorter hand than the others, as though it had been written in a hurry or with the tablet held on the knee.

Puella trimensis. Ex Iusta, obstetrix. HS □. Vendita domo C. Cassii Veri, per Chryseron, ser. — a girl of three months, from Iusta the midwife, sold for the mark of the infinity sign to the house of Gaius Cassius Verus, through Chryseros, his slave.

The room was very quiet. Antonia heard the girl chewing her bread. She heard a dog outside. She heard the sea, a long way off, and the gulls, and the sound of a shutter going up somewhere.

"Domina," Tullia said.

"Read it."

Tullia read it, twice, and then set the tablet down.

"HS □," she said. "The infinity sign."

"It means the price was not money," Antonia said. "Or the price was never paid. Or the price was so large that Bassa did not want to write it. She used the same sign four times in eighteen years. Here, for a boy sold to a man in Capua who was her patron. Here, for a pair of twins sold to a temple. And here, for a girl sold to the Cassii." She turned the tablet. "The midwife's name is Iusta."

"The midwife at Ficulea."

"The same woman, or her cousin, or a woman she trained. There is only one Iusta who attends births in that district." Antonia put the tablet down. "The slave's name is Chryseros. He was the steward of the Cassii. He died in the year 96, of a fever, in his bed, which is the way all useful men die."

"Then the paper is worth what he paid for it," Tullia said. "It is a line in a dealer's book, and the dealer is dead, and the slave is dead, and the buyer is a consular who will say the hand is not his."

"It is worth what we do with it."

"Which is what?"

Antonia looked at the lamp for a moment. Then she looked at the girl on the floor, who had finished her bread and was watching her with the flat, careful attention of a child who has learned that adults are weather.

"First," Antonia said, "we pay him for the page."

Secundus named six thousand. Antonia paid four, and the man held out his hand, and she put the tablet inside her mantle and said, "You will make a copy tonight, in the same hand, and you will keep it in the trunk, and if anyone comes to you with money for the original, you will show them the copy and say that the original was destroyed by fire."

"And if they pay more than you have?"

"Then they will have bought a copy that says what I have already read, and you will have made an enemy of a woman who knows ex-

actly how many girls were in your yard in March." Antonia smiled. "Do not go into the pouring business, Secundus. It is bad for the health."

Outside it had begun to rain. The lane ran with water the color of brick-dust, and Antonia walked in it with the tablet under her mantle and Sabina's hand in hers, and Tullia behind with the lamp, and none of them spoke until they came to the rope-maker's street.

"You are shaking," Tullia said.

"I am cold."

"You have not been cold since I met you."

"Then I am shaking," Antonia said.

Later, in the room with the ship-shaped lamp, she sat on the bed and looked at the tablet in her hands: a page of a dead woman's accounts, eleven words and a sign, and the whole of her life turned on it.

Puella trimensis. Ex Iusta, obstetrix. Vendita domo C. Cassii Veri.

They had not even given her a name in the book. She was a girl of three months, and she had been sold to a house, and the house had been the house of the father, and the man who had done it had a good name and a bad steward and a consular's chair, and in September his other daughter would be married in front of the whole city.

Antonia put the tablet down, and lay back on the bed, and cried in the way she had not cried since the year 94, which was to say almost silently, with her hand over her mouth, while the rain went on the roof and the lamp burned.

❦

In the morning the girl Sabina went to Rome in the wagon with Tullia, with a cloak and a box of combs and a letter to Rufina; and Antonia went down to the harbor mouth and stood a long time

looking at the sea, which was grey and enormous and did not care about anything, and then she went to find the ship's master who had brought the letter, and paid him to carry a message back up the river to Rome.

The message was for Gallus, and it was four lines, and it said that the petition was ready, and that she would bring it on the fifteenth day before the Kalends of April, and that she was grateful, and that she wished to tell him something that could not be written down.

Then she went to the warehouse and did the accounts, because the accounts did not stop for the past, and the wheat did not stop, and the rats did not stop, and at the sixth hour she was sitting on a bale with a tablet on her knee when a clerk came from the harbor office to say that a ship had come in with a load from Caesarea, and that among the passengers was a man who said he was a friend of Oppius Nepos.

Antonia looked up from the tablet.

"Did he ask for me?"

"He asked whether the house of Antonia Cassia had a venture in the harbor, and he asked it of the harbor office, and the harbor office told him that a woman from Rome had been in the town since Thursday."

"Then he knows I am here." She closed the tablet. "Where is he staying?"

"At the inn of the three anchors, by the theater."

"Send a boy with a jar of wine and a message that the house of Antonia Cassia does not receive friends of Oppius Nepos in warehouses, but that she will be at the baths at the ninth hour, and that if he wishes to speak to her he may speak to her there, in public, where he will have to be polite."

The clerk wrote it down and went away.

The man from Caesarea was called Menander and he was waiting at the baths when she came, and he was exactly as Secundus had

described him: tall, Greek, very clean, with a horse on his ring. He had taken a private room and he had ordered wine and figs, and he received her with the courtesy of a man who has been sent to be courteous and has been given a budget for it.

"You are not bathing," he said.

"I am not. I am conducting business in a place where a man who raises his voice is thrown out by the bathman."

"Ah. That is very wise. In Caesarea we do the same, only we do it in the temple of the emperors, which is quieter and has better statues." He pushed the figs toward her. "Oppius Nepos sends his compliments."

"Nepos sends his compliments to everyone. It is his only expense."

Menander laughed. "He said you were amusing. He also said you were the most dangerous woman in Rome, but I think he says that to all the women who will not sleep with him."

Antonia looked at him. "What does he want?"

"You know what he wants."

"I want to hear you say it."

"He wants the ledger of the house of Antonia Cassia." Menander ate a fig, and wiped his fingers, and his eyes were bright and entirely without warmth. "Not the book of the house. The book of the guests. The names, the dates, the sums, the favors. He is prepared to pay a great deal for it, and he is prepared to pay a great deal more for it if it comes with a statement about the household of Manius Cassius Verus."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then he will buy it from someone else, and he will be less generous." Menander smiled. "You are thinking that there is no one else. There is always someone else. Every house has a steward, and every steward has a price, and every price is lower than the person paying it thinks."

Antonia stood. "Tell Oppius Nepos that the book is in a place he will not find it, and that the woman who keeps it has kept it for eleven years, and that in eleven years she has been offered money for it by four men, and has refused all four, and that the fourth offer was the largest and came from a man who is now dead."

She said the last words very pleasantly, and watched them land.

Menander's smile did not change, but his hands did: they stopped moving.

"That was a long time ago," he said.

"It was. And yet here we are."

She went out into the street. It was raining again, and the lamps were being lit along the via della Foce, and the sea was invisible beyond the roofs, and she stood under the awning of a wine shop and found she was breathing as though she had run up a hill.

Antonia would take the boat alone in the morning. She sat in the warehouse with the rats and the wheat and the smell of the sea, and thought about the man from Caesarea, and what he could have been sent to buy, and what she would be willing to sell.

At the door, the watchman's boy was lighting the lamp in the little shrine, and the three gods in it looked out at the warehouse with their faces worn smooth by the thumbs of everybody who had ever worked there. Antonia watched him for a moment, then put a coin in the box and did not say which god it was for, because it was better to let them settle it among themselves.

In the morning she would go up the river with the tide, and by evening she would be in Rome, and the paper would be in the cedar box with the token, and the two halves of her life would be in the same room for the first time.

She slept that night on the bed with the ship-shaped lamp, and dreamed of a door, and woke before dawn with her heart going and the taste of salt in her mouth.

CHAPTER VI

FLORALIA

Rome, the Floralia, AD 112

The Floralia began with a goat and ended, most years, with a lawsuit. In between came six days in which the city did what it did at the end of April, which was to drink, to dance, to strip, to throw beans into the crowd, and to behave as though the gods had gone to the country and left the door unlocked.

Antonia did not like the Floralia. She liked the money it brought. In six days the house on the Clivus took more than in the whole of the preceding month, and the men who came to it came in a mood to be generous and to be seen being generous, and a generous man was a man who could be asked for things.

By the third day the lane outside was hung with garlands that had gone brown at the edges, and the doorkeeper had been offered three bribes and had taken two, and Beryllos had bought a whole tunny at the fish market and was in a state of high artistic fever, and Cela, the newest of the girls, had been sick on the mosaic and had blamed the wine.

"Take the beans out of the passage," Antonia said. "There are beans in the passage. Why are there beans in the passage?"

"Because the boys throw them," said Rufina.

"Then the boys can come in and sweep them up, and then they can be thrown out on their ears, and then they can throw their beans in somebody else's passage."

At the ninth hour a clerk came from the aedile, and Antonia received him in the tablinum with Tullia at her shoulder and a purse on the table.

"The games," the clerk said. "There will be a procession at the Circus on the last day, and the aedile has asked that the houses on the Clivus provide a canopy and a choir of six, and that the women of the houses stand in the front of the procession and throw flowers."

"How many flowers?"

"Two baskets each."

"Two baskets each is four hundred flowers, and the flowers will be thrown away in the street, and the women will be seen by every man in the Circus, and one of my girls will be recognized by her brother and there will be a knife fight." Antonia pushed the purse across the table. "There is sixty sesterces in that. The house will provide a canopy and four women and two baskets, and the four women will wear veils, and the aedile will say nothing about the veils, because the aedile's brother-in-law has been in this house three times since January."

The clerk took the purse. "The aedile's brother-in-law."

"His name is on a page. It is a good page. The aedile should be pleased that it is a page in a book and not a page in a court record."

The clerk looked at the purse, and then at her, and then put the purse in his cloak. "The aedile asked me to say that the games are for the people, and that the people love a great house."

"The people love a great house the way they love a thunderstorm," Antonia said. "They enjoy it and they hope it does not land on them."

When he had gone, Tullia came in with the day's book. "The canopy is forty sesterces. The flowers are sixty if we buy them at the Porta Esquilina before the second hour, and ninety if we buy them

after, and the veils are twelve and I have already bought them because I know what you are like."

"What am I like?"

"You are like a woman who will argue about sixty sesterces for a quarter of an hour and then give a slave-girl a cloak that cost four hundred because it was raining."

"That girl is worth twelve thousand and she catches cold in the chest."

"The cloak was four hundred," Tullia said, and wrote it down, and Antonia let her have the last word because she had been letting her have the last word for nine years and it was one of the reasons the household worked.

In the garden the girls were rehearsing the procession. Cela, who was nineteen and from Mutina, had been given the front position because she had the best walk, and she was practicing it up and down the colonnade with a basket of dry beans on her hip, and the other three were in a line behind her, and they were all laughing, and Rufina was shouting at them about their shoulders.

Antonia stood at the door and watched them. This was the part of the day she would remember afterward, when everything else had been taken: four girls in cheap wreaths practicing a walk in a garden, in the last week of April, with the whole city drunk outside the wall.

"Domina," Cela called. "Is it the left foot first or the right?"

"The left. Always the left. Every procession in Rome starts with the left foot, and every priest who tells you otherwise is selling something."

"Then I have been doing it wrong."

"Then you will be doing it right by the sixth day, and nobody will know, and if they do know they will be too drunk to care."

The portico of Octavia was crowded and the shade was a commodity



Publia sent word on the morning of the last day, by the flower-seller, and the word was a place: the portico of Octavia, at the sixth hour, in the shade, where a great many women would be, so that one more would not be noticed.

Antonia went with Rufina and Hilarus and stood among the columns where the shade was deepest, and watched the crowd go by. The portico was full of the wives of Rome, and their daughters, and their slaves, and their parasols, and the noise was like a roof coming down.

Publia came at the half-hour, in a litter, with two slaves and her maid. She was in pale yellow with her hair up in the fashion of a woman who is betrothed, and she looked like a girl dressed as her own mother.

Myrtale walked behind the litter with her eyes down.

Antonia had prepared herself for it, and it did not help. The girl came along the colonnade in the ordinary way, carrying her mistress's fan and a basket, and her hair was dark and bound up, and she had a smudge of dust on one cheek, and she looked up once, briefly, at the painted ceiling, and her mouth made the smallest shape of pleasure, and she looked down again.

She had a way of putting her head to one side when she was thinking. She had her father's brows. She had Antonia's hands.

"Domina." Publia had come up to her, and was standing there, and her face was frightened. "You said to come to the portico. You did not say you would bring the whole street."

"I brought two people and a litter-bearer. The rest of the street came by itself."

Publia looked around, and then leaned close, and spoke quickly, the way people speak when they have rehearsed something and are afraid of forgetting it.

"I was in the tablinum on the Nones. My father was at the baths with Caesennius and the contract men. The steward was in the kitchen. I went in and I found the strongbox and I could not open it, and then I found the tablets in the cupboard, in the third pigeonhole, in a bundle tied with string and marked with the year."

"And?"

"And there is a page. It is not the purchase. There is no purchase. There is a note of a debt owed to my father by a man called Chryseros, who was his slave, and the debt is written as a sum of sesterces paid on his behalf, and beside the sum there is a note in my father's own hand, and the note says, *for the child, from Bassa, and no more to be said.*" Publia's voice was shaking. "I copied it. I copied it onto a wax tablet and I copied the tablet onto a second tablet and I burned the first one. I brought the second one today. It is under my mattress at home and I will bring it to you at the wedding, and if I am searched before then I will say I was practicing my letters."

Antonia looked at her. The girl had done it. She had gone into her father's cupboard and read his hand and copied it and burned the copy, and she was sixteen.

"What was the sum?" Antonia said.

"Ninety thousand sesterces."

The crowd went by. A child was crying somewhere. A woman laughed the long, bright laugh of a woman who wants to be heard.

"Ninety thousand," Antonia said, "for a child of three months, sold to a man's own house, with the price written as a debt in the man's own book and the words *no more to be said* beside it."

"I do not understand it."

"You are not meant to. It is not a purchase. It is a bribe to himself." Antonia looked at the girl. "He could not write that he had

bought a child from a dealer, so he wrote that his slave had bought her on his behalf, and he paid the slave's debt, and he wrote a note to himself so that he would remember why. That is what men do when they cannot bear the thing they have done and cannot stop doing it."

Publia's face had gone white. "There is more."

"Say it."

"My father has found a buyer for Myrtale. He is a man in Formiae who has a farm and a wife who is ill, and he will pay twelve thousand, and she is to go after the wedding, when the house is quiet." Publia's voice cracked. "I heard him tell my stepmother. He said the girl has been in the house too long and has become a thing the house talks about, and that the wife in Formiae will not last the winter, and that the man will be kind to her."

"And what did Marcella say?"

"Marcella said, 'Then you had better sell her before the wedding, and not after, or the girl will be in the house when the bride comes and the bride will see her, and the bride will have a mother, and mothers talk.'"

Antonia stood very still. Somewhere beyond the colonnade a trumpet sounded, and the crowd turned toward it like a field turning in the wind.

"When does he mean to send her?"

"I do not know. Before September. Perhaps in the summer, when the city empties." Publia caught at her sleeve. "You said you would help me. You have done nothing. The contract is signed and the money is promised and there is a man in Formiae and I am to be married in September and she will be gone before the wedding and I will not even be able to say goodbye, because they will send her while I am at my aunt's."

"I have not done nothing."

"What have you done?"

"I have bought a page from a dead woman's ledger that says the child was sold to your father's house. I have a midwife at Ficulea who attended the birth. I have a woman in my house who held the other half of a token. And I have a consular of Rome who has read my petition and will carry it in the senate house, and in two weeks I will stand in front of the praetor with all of it, and your father will be summoned to answer a charge under the lex Fabia." Antonia took her by the shoulders. "I have not been idle. I have been building a wall, and a wall is made of stones that are carried one at a time, and if I had told you in March you would have run into your father's tablinum and taken the page, and he would have found it gone, and the girl would have been on the road to Formiae before the week was out."

Publia stared at her. "You are going to accuse my father in court."

"I am going to accuse him of holding a free woman as a slave."

"She is not a free woman. She has a collar."

"She has no collar. She has a cord with a token. And she was born free, because her mother was manumitted before the birth, and the manumission is in the records of the city, and the midwife remembers the token and the birth, and the dealer's book says the child came from Iusta the midwife and was sold to the house of Caesar —" Antonia stopped herself. "To the house of Cassius Verus."

"Her mother," Publia said slowly. "Who is her mother?"

"Not here."

"Who is her mother?"

Antonia looked past her, at the girl standing in the shade with the fan, and the words were in her mouth, and she had been carrying them for eighteen years, and they would not come out.

"Not here," she said. "Not today. When it is done, and when it is safe, I will tell you. And I will tell her."

"Domina." It was Myrtale. She had come up behind her mistress with the fan, and she was looking at Antonia with a small, careful frown. "Forgive me. The lady's fan is broken. The pin has come out of the hinge."

Antonia looked at the fan. It was ivory and gilt and the pin had indeed come out, and the girl was holding it together with her fingers.

"Give it to me," Antonia said.

She took the fan and turned it over, and took a pin from her own hair, and bent the point of it with her thumbnail, and worked it through the hinge, and gave it back. The whole thing took less than a minute. The girl watched her hands the entire time.

"You have done that before," Myrtale said.

"I have mended a great many things."

"You have the hands of a woman who mends."

"What hands does a woman who mends have?"

"Quick ones," Myrtale said. "And a mark here." She touched her own wrist, on the inside, where a crescent-shaped mark would be. "Like mine."

Antonia's own wrist was bare. She had a mark on the back of her left hand, from a splash of hot oil in her first year in the house above the fuller's, and it was not a crescent.

"Show me," Antonia said.

The girl hesitated, and glanced at her mistress, and then turned her wrist up. The mark was small and pale and shaped like a paring of moon. Antonia had seen it before, in the small room at the fourth hour, when the girl had held the lamp.

"How did you come by it?"

"I was born with it. The nurse used to say it was the moon's thumbprint, and that a child with the moon's thumbprint would travel far." Myrtale smiled, and it was a good smile, and it was

ruined by the fact that she was being kind to a stranger. “I have not traveled far. But the nurse was old.”

“Was she kind to you?”

“She was old,” Myrtale said again, as though that were an answer.

Publia’s voice was sharp. “Myrtale.”

“Yes, domina.” The girl stepped back, and put the fan in her mistress’s hand, and went to stand with the slaves and the litter, and did not look at Antonia again.

Antonia stood in the middle of the portico and heard the crowd and the water and her own blood. Somewhere in her chest was a sound she had not made in eighteen years, and she held it there, and it stayed.

“You had better tell her before the court,” Publia said.

“You had better tell her before the court,” Publia said, and her voice was not the voice of a child anymore. “Because a court is a room full of men, and the men will say the girl is a slave, and the girl will hear them, and she will believe them if no one has told her otherwise.”

❦

That night the house on the Clivus had thirty guests, which was ten more than the dining room held, and the overflow was on the terrace under an awning strung between the walls, with lamps in the branches of the fig tree and cushions on the ground. The night was warm. The Floralia was ending. Somewhere up the hill a party of young men were singing a song about a Vestal, and somewhere down the hill a woman was screaming at a man, and between them the whole Subura was alive and loud and full of the smell of grilled fish.

Decimus Iunius Gallus arrived in a garland of roses that had been made for him by a girl in the Circus, and by the second hour he

was very drunk, and by the third hour he had decided that the evening's entertainment was to be his wit.

Verianus came late, alone, in a dark tunic with his hair wet from the baths. He had been drinking since noon; Antonia could see it in the way he held his cup, which was with both hands, carefully, as though it might escape.

Nepos did not come. He sent a gift instead: a pair of silver cups with a horse on each, and a note wishing the house a good season, which was the sort of gift a man sent when he wanted it remembered that he had not come.

Kallisto sang, and the house was quiet, and then it was not quiet, and the wine went round. Dessa carried the jug with her eyes down and her mouth set, and Antonia watched her because she watched everything, and saw that the girl had not eaten and that she had been to the gate twice.

Daphnus came late and found her by the fig tree, and he had brought a jar of Falernian and the look of a man who has news.

"The ship from Caesarea," he said. "The one with the passenger."

"Menander."

"Menander has been to the harbor office three times, and the third time he came with a man from the prefect's staff, and they asked to see the manifests of every ship that came in from Egypt in the last month." Daphnus put the jar down. "They are not looking for grain."

"No."

"They are looking for grain that is not there. It is the oldest way. You find a discrepancy in a man's manifests, and then you have a reason to open his warehouse, and then you have a reason to look at his books, and then you have a reason to look at his name." He looked at her. "What is in your books, Antonia?"

"Names."

"Whose?"

"Yours," she said. "And a great many others."

Daphnus was quiet for a moment. Then he laughed, shortly, and without much joy. "I have been in business thirty years and I have never once been frightened of a ledger until tonight."

"Then you have been lucky. Ledgers are the most frightening thing in Rome. That is why the men who keep them are careful, and why the men who do not keep them are loud." Antonia took the jar from him. "Go home, Gaius. Do not come to the house for a month. If anyone asks, you have not spoken to me since March, and you do not know what I am."

"And if they ask me under oath?"

"Then tell them the truth. It will be the first time in your life and they will not believe you."

At the fourth hour the terrace was crowded and the lamps had burned down and the party had that loose, happy, dangerous feel of a good night going wrong. Antonia was at the far end with Gallus, who was talking about the water supply with the loving detail of a man who has no other subject, and she saw Decimus get up from his couch and cross the terrace to where Verianus sat alone.

She watched them the way a woman watches a pot come to the boil. Decimus said something, and laughed, and put his hand on Verianus's shoulder. Verianus said something that was not a laugh. Decimus stepped back, and said something else, louder, and there was a small circle of silence around them, and the people near them turned to look.

"— the old man's eyes," Decimus said, and his voice carried, because drunk men's voices carry. "That is what I said in March, and I will say it again in September. Your father keeps a girl with his own eyes, and when the bride comes into that house, the bride will have to look at her every morning and know what the old man —"

Verianus hit him.

It was not a drunkard's swing. It was fast and low and it caught Decimus under the jaw, and he went back over the couch and knocked a lamp off the table, and the oil caught and there was a small blue flame running across the mosaic, and two women screamed and a man laughed, and Hilarus was there with a cloth before it could reach the cushions.

Verianus stood over him. His hands were shaking.

"Say it again," he said. "Say it again in my father's house, and I will do worse."

"It is not your father's house," Decimus said from the floor, holding his jaw. "It is a brothel. Your father is too proud to come to it, so he sends his son."

The terrace had gone quiet. Thirty people were looking at Antonia.

She walked across the terrace. She did not hurry. She had learned a long time ago that a woman who hurries in her own house has lost it.

"Decimus," she said, "you have broken a lamp, and there is oil on a mosaic that cost me two thousand sesterces, and you have insulted my guest in my house, and you have done it while wearing a garland of flowers that my doorkeeper paid for. I am going to give you a choice. You may go home now, in a litter, with your garland, and in the morning you may send me the two thousand sesterces with a note of apology, and we will say that the wine was strong."

He looked up at her, and his mouth was bleeding, and his eyes were the eyes of a boy who has just discovered that the world will not let him be funny forever.

"And the other choice?"

"You may stay, and be carried out, and I will still have the two thousand sesterces, and the story will be a great deal better."

Decimus got up. For a moment Antonia thought he would be sensible. Then he looked at the thirty people, and at the girls, and at

Verianus, and he did the thing that young men do when they have been humiliated in front of an audience, which is to make the audience bigger.

"You are all very fine," he said. "You sit in this house and you drink her wine and you tell yourselves she is a businesswoman. She is a freedwoman who sells women. My father says the emperor's grandmother sold salt and her son sold grain and now the emperor sells war, and the whole empire is a market, and the only difference between the people at the top and the people at the bottom is the price. She is a stall. You are buying at a stall."

He threw the garland on the floor. Nobody stopped him. He walked out through the garden and the gate, and Cerdon shut the door behind him, and the party breathed again, and somebody laughed, and the music started, and Kallisto sang the song about the woman at the door, and it was the fourth time.

Verianus sat down. His hands were still shaking. Antonia stood by the fig tree with the lamps in it, and looked at the dark beyond the awning, and thought about the way a night could turn.

At the sixth hour she went to her own room. The house was quieting; the guests were going; the last litter went out of the lane. Rufina brought her a cup of water and took her shoes, and she lay down with her eyes open and listened to the house settle.

Then a woman screamed.

It was not a party scream. It was the other kind. It came from the garden, and it stopped in the middle, the way screams stop when the screamer has put both hands over her own mouth.

Antonia was up and through the passage before she had decided to move. The garden was dark and the fountain was running, and the lamps had been put out, and the moon was behind the wall. She came around the corner of the colonnade and saw the body in the fountain.

He was face down in eighteen inches of water, with his arms out and his palms up, and his good tunic was dark with wet, and the water around him was moving and then it was still.

Hilarus got there first. He took the shoulders and turned the body over, and the face came up into the moonlight, and it was Decimus Iunius Gallus, nineteen years old, with his mouth open and his eyes open and a small cut on his forehead where the lip of the basin had caught him.

"He is dead," Hilarus said.

"Get away from him." Antonia was kneeling. "Get away from him and do not touch anything else. Where is the girl?"

"Which girl?"

"The one who screamed."

"In the passage. It was Dessa. She came running and she was —"

"Is she hurt?"

"She is not hurt," Hilarus said. "Domina, she is not hurt, but her hands are wet."

Antonia looked at the fountain. She looked at the water, and the body, and the cut on the forehead, and the palms turned up. Then she looked at the terrace, at the little table where Verianus had been sitting at the fourth hour, and at the dark of the garden beyond the wall.

"The gate," she said. "Is the gate open?"

Cerdon came running. He was in his night-shirt with his club. "The gate is open. The bolt is drawn from the inside. Domina, the boy Verianus is not in the house."

Antonia stood up in the wet grass. Her hands were cold. In the dark, beyond the wall, the Subura was still making its noise, and the city was going on being the city, and a nineteen-year-old boy was lying in her fountain with his eyes open, and the last thing that had happened to him had happened in her house.

"Nobody leaves," she said. "Nobody comes in. Cerdon, go to the station and get Crescens. Not the aediles. Not the prefect. Crescens." She looked down at the body. "And find the girl. Find Dessa, and bring her to me, and do not let anyone else touch her before I have."

She stood in the garden in the dark and listened to the water running, and thought about Gallus, who would be told before noon, and about the two thousand sesterces, and about the garland of roses lying on the terrace where a boy had thrown it.

She thought: I am going to lie about this.

She did not know yet why. She only knew that the thought had come, whole and cold and certain, the way the truth usually came.

Crescens came within the half-hour, with two of his men and a lantern, and he came through the garden without a word to anyone, and knelt by the body, and looked at it for a long time before he touched it.

"Who found him?"

"The girl. Dessa."

"Where is she?"

"In the passage. Rufina has her."

"Keep her there. Do not let her wash her hands." He looked up. "You have guessed why."

"I have guessed that a boy came to my house, was hit in the face by another boy, and then was found in my fountain with a cut on his head. A man could make a story out of that. A man could make four."

"A man could make one," Crescens said. "The one that says he was pushed, and fell, and hit his head on the rim, and drowned in eighteen inches of water, which is a thing that happens more often than you would think, because a man who is stunned and face down in a fountain does not get up."

"Or a man could make the one that says he was held under."

"With what?" Crescens said. "There are no marks on his arms. If a man held him under, he would have fought, and there would be marks. Unless the man was very strong, or the boy was already dead, or the boy was so drunk he did not know he was drowning."

"He was drunk."

"He was very drunk. Everybody on that terrace was very drunk." Crescens stood up and wiped his hands. "The aediles will call it an accident. The aediles call everything an accident. A young man, a party, a fountain, a great house, a family that does not want a scandal three months before a wedding. It is an accident. It is the sort of accident that happens every week in this city, and the aediles will write it down and take their fee and go home."

"And you?"

"I am a tribune of the fire-watch. I put out fires." He looked at her. "But I am also the man who notices, and I have noticed that the boy Verianus left this house at the fourth hour and did not say goodbye to his hostess, and that the girl who found the body has wet hands and has not spoken a word since, and that you, domina, have already decided what you are going to say."

"I have not decided."

"You have decided. I can see it in your face." He came closer. "Whatever it is, say it to me now, before the aediles come, so that when they ask me what I saw I can be a liar in the same language."

Antonia looked at the body in the fountain, and at the cut on the forehead, and at the palms turned up, and she thought of a boy of nineteen throwing a garland on a mosaic and telling thirty people what he thought of her house. She thought of his father at dinner with a boy on his knee. She thought of a girl in the passage with wet hands, who had seen what she had seen, and who was a slave, and whose word in a Roman court was worth nothing at all unless it was given under torture.

"I am going to say," she said, "that I found him like this, and that I do not know how he came to be here, and that he was a guest in my house and I will pay for his funeral."

Crescens's face did not change. "And the girl?"

"The girl is not going to be questioned."

"That is not what I asked."

"The girl," Antonia said, "is not going to be questioned. If a man comes with a warrant, he will find that she was sold last month to a house in Africa and that the sale is registered, and he will find the registration, because I will have made it before he arrives."

Crescens looked at the fountain.

"You are protecting a witness," he said. "And in protecting her, you are making yourself the only person who knows what she knows. And that is a very dangerous place to stand."

"I know."

"Then I hope to God she is worth it."

"She is worth twelve thousand sesterces," Antonia said, "and she can add a column of figures faster than Tullia, and she has not eaten in a week because she has been thinking about the road. She is worth a great deal more than my safety, and I have only just discovered it."

PART TWO

THE BOOK OF DEBTS

CHAPTER VII

THE VIGILES

Rome, the day after the Floralia, AD 112

The station house of the seventh cohort stood at the foot of the Viminal, in a narrow street between a bakery and a yard where a man kept pigs, and it had been built in the reign of Augustus and had been repaired, badly, by every emperor since. It had a courtyard with a well, a shed for the pumps, a stable with four horses that were too old to pull anything, and a room upstairs where the tribune slept when he slept.

By the time Antonia was brought there, at the second hour, the courtyard was full. There were twelve firemen in leather aprons, three of them still black to the elbow from a chimney the night before. There was a clerk at a folding table with a wax tablet and a pen. There was a man from the aedile's office in a good cloak, standing apart, with his hands behind his back and the expression of a man who has been woken up and intends to make somebody pay for it. And there was a body on a board under a sheet, in the corner, out of the way, with a boy of about fifteen sitting beside it and waving a branch at the flies.

Antonia came in a plain mantle with Tullia and Hilarus, and she came on foot, because a litter at a station house in the morning was a statement, and she had not yet decided what statement to make.

"Antonia Cassia," the clerk said. "Of the house on the Clivus Suburanus."

"Yes."

"The aedile's office has been informed of the death of Decimus Iunius Gallus, of the house of the Iunii, son of Lucius Iunius Gallus, consular. The body was found in the fountain of the house of Antonia Cassia at the sixth hour of the morning, by a slave. Is that correct?"

"It is correct."

"You will tell the office what you know."

"I will tell the office what I saw. I did not see him fall."

The man from the aedile's office turned. He was about fifty, and he had the voice of a man who had spent thirty years saying the same sentences and had never once been contradicted by anyone with more money than the man who sent him.

"You will tell the office what you know," he said again.

"I will tell you what I saw," Antonia said. "And then you will tell me what you want."

The man's name was Vibius. He was a freedman of the aedile's household, and he had a chain of offices behind him and a chain of favors in front of him, and he had been sent out at dawn because a consular's son had drowned in a house of ill fame, and because the aedile did not want to know what had happened, he wanted to know what it would cost to make it have not happened.

"Tell me about the evening," Vibius said.

She told him. She told it well. She had spent twenty years learning how to tell a thing so that it was true in every particular and false in its whole. There had been a party. There had been thirty guests. There had been wine, and a quarrel between two young men, and one of them had struck the other, and the other had gone home. She had retired at the sixth hour. She had been woken by a scream. She had come out and found the body in the fountain and had sent for the watch at once.

"Who was the young man who struck him?"

"Manius Cassius Verus the Younger."

"And where is he now?"

"I do not know. He left the house at the fourth hour, before the body was found, and he did not speak to me."

"Did he strike him hard?"

"He struck him once, in the face, and the boy went over a couch."

"And then?"

"And then I stopped it. I gave Decimus the choice of going home or being carried, and he chose to go home, and he went home." Antonia looked at him. "That is what I saw. If he came back, I did not see it."

Vibius wrote. The clerk wrote. The firemen watched from the far side of the yard, and one of them, a big man with a broken nose, was watching her the way men watch a thing they have been told not to touch.

"The aedile will want to know," Vibius said, "whether the house was in the habit of serving wine to men of the senatorial order without limit, and whether the girls of the house were in the garden at the time, and whether any of them were —"

"Say the word," Antonia said. "You have been circling it for a quarter of an hour. Say the word and I will answer it."

Vibius looked up. Something in his face closed like a shutter.

"The aedile will want to know," he said, "whether the house is a place where such a death could be called an accident without further inquiry."

"Ah," said Antonia. "That is a different sentence. Now we understand each other." She sat down on the bench by the well, and arranged her mantle, and looked up at him. "How much?"

The clerk stopped writing. The firemen went very still. Vibius's face did not move, but his hands did, and Antonia had been reading hands for twenty years.

"That is not —"

"It is exactly that. You have come here at dawn with a clerk and a tablet and a body, and you have not sent for the coroner, and you have not sealed the house, and you have not questioned the slaves one by one, and you have not asked a single question about the fountain. You have asked me about the wine and the girls and the word accident. So: how much?"

Vibius looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "The aedile is a busy man. A young man drowned at a party. It happens. The family will want it quiet, the house will want it quiet, and the city will want it quiet in September, because there is a wedding."

"There is a wedding."

"There is a wedding," Vibius said, "and the aedile has been invited."

Antonia stood up. "Then the aedile shall have a gift. A hundred thousand sesterces to the games fund, in the name of my house, and my house will close for the month of May, and the girls will go to the country, and there will be no parties and no noise and no stories in the Subura. That is what the aedile's office may tell him."

Vibius's mouth moved. "A hundred thousand."

"Two hundred," Antonia said, "if the office writes the word accident before the sun goes down."

The clerk wrote it. Vibius took the tablet and read it, and nodded, and said that the aedile would be grateful, and that the body would be released to the family at the second hour, and that the office would make a note of the cooperation of the house.

"And the slave," Vibius said. "The one who found him."

Antonia's face did not change. "What of her?"

"The office will want to question her. A slave's evidence is taken under —"

"The slave was sold last month," Antonia said. "To a house in Africa. She went out on the ship from Puteoli on the Ides. There is a registration."

Vibius looked at her. "You told me she found the body."

"I told you a slave found the body. I did not say which slave. There are eleven in my house. The one who found him has been with me for six years and her name is Rufina, and she will tell you the same story I have told you, because it is the true one."

The man from the aedile's office looked at her for a long, long moment.

"You are a very cool woman," he said.

"I am a very expensive one," Antonia said. "Cheap women are the ones who lose their nerve."

When Vibius had gone, with the tablet under his arm and the clerk behind him, the courtyard of the seventh cohort went back to being a courtyard. The firemen rolled the pumps out to dry them. The boy with the branch went on waving it at the flies. And Crescens came down the outside stair in his uniform, with his helmet under his arm, and stood beside her at the well without saying anything for a moment.

"You lied to him," he said.

"I did."

"You lied to him in my station house, in front of my men, and now my men think that the tribune of the seventh cohort takes money from a brothel to write the word accident on a boy's death."

"Did you take money?"

"No."

"Then your men think you did, which is the same as having taken it, and you will have to live with that, or you will have to tell them the truth." Antonia looked at him. "Which will it be?"

Crescens put his helmet down on the well-head. He looked tired in a way that had nothing to do with the night.

"I have been in this cohort six years," he said. "I have pulled forty-one people out of burning buildings and I have watched eleven of them die, and I have been thanked twice. I have been in the

Subura at midnight and at noon, and I have seen what a landlord does when a wall falls down and kills a tenant, and I have seen what a father does when his daughter is taken by a man with a name. I know what the aedile's office is. I have known for six years. I did not need you to tell me."

"Then why are you angry?"

"Because I thought I was the one man in Rome who could stand in a room and say what happened, and now I am standing in a room with you and saying what you tell me to say." He picked up his helmet. "There was something on the boy's hands. Or rather, there was nothing on them, and there should have been. Did you notice?"

"I noticed."

"Then you know more than Vibius, and Vibius knows more than the aedile, and the aedile knows more than anybody will ever say out loud." Crescens looked at the door. "I am going to write in my report that the body was found face down, that the water was shallow, that there was a cut on the forehead consistent with a fall against the rim of the basin, and that there were no marks of a struggle. All of that is true. I am not going to write that the cut was on the front of the head and that a man falling forward into a fountain cuts his chin or his cheekbone and not the middle of his forehead, because if I write that, the report goes to the prefect, and the prefect's office has a man called Felix with a burned hand who has been asking questions about your house, and I do not want Felix reading my report."

Antonia looked at him. "You have been asking."

"I have been asking. Quietly. At the station, and at the baths, and once at a wine shop where the prefect's clerks drink." He put his helmet on. "Felix is not the prefect's man. He is paid by the prefect's office and he answers to a man called Anicetus, who answers to nobody in the office at all. Anicetus has a patron. I do not know the

name. The name is not written anywhere, which means the man who owns him is either very great or very careful."

"Or both."

"Or both," Crescens said. "Go home, domina. And when the funeral is over, come to me at the station at the second hour, and I will show you what a man's hands look like when he has drowned fighting, and then you will know how much of a lie you have told."

❦

She got back to the house at the fourth hour, and Gallus was already in the atrium.

He had come alone, which was worse than coming with a crowd. He was in the plain tunic of a man who has been woken in the night and has not thought about his clothes, and his face was the face of a man who has been told that his son is dead and has not yet been told anything else.

"Where is he?" he said.

"At the station house. They will bring him to your house at the second hour. I have sent word to your steward."

"He was in your fountain."

"Yes."

"You sent for the watch."

"Yes."

"You did not send for me."

Antonia stood in the middle of her own atrium and did not look away. "I sent for the watch, and then I sent for you, and you were asleep, and your steward was told, and he said he would tell you when you woke."

"He did not tell me. A boy from the station told me. A boy in a helmet, with a note in his hand, at the door, in front of my wife." Gallus's voice was very quiet. "Do you know what my wife said? She said, 'Which son?'"

Antonia did not answer.

"She has three sons," Gallus said. "Two by me and one by her first husband. She said, 'Which son?' and the boy said, 'Decimus,' and she sat down on the step. And I stood in my own doorway with the whole street looking at me, and I thought, the woman on the Clivus knew before I did."

He walked past her into the garden, and stood looking at the fountain.

The water had been drained. The basin was dry, with a dark stain on the bottom and a scattering of leaves, and someone had scrubbed the rim, and the scrub had not taken out the mark where the boy's head had struck the marble.

"Tell me," Gallus said.

She told him. She told him the same story she had told Vibius, in the same words, and she watched him listen to it, and she watched him take it in, and she watched the moment he did not believe her.

"Decimus was drunk," he said.

"Very."

"He insulted your house."

"He did."

"And Verus's son struck him."

"Once. In the face."

"And then he went home." Gallus turned. His eyes were dry, and that was the worst of it. "My son went home, and then he came back to your house, and he climbed over your wall or he came through your gate, and he went to your fountain and he fell in and he drowned. In the dark. Alone."

"That is what I know."

"You know more."

"I know what I saw."

Gallus took two steps and took her by the arm, and his grip was not violent, it was worse: it was the grip of a man holding on to something in a storm.

"He was nineteen," he said. "He was a fool, and he was vain, and he spent my money, and he made jokes about people who could not answer him, and he was my son. And I have spent the morning in my own house listening to my wife say that it was a house of women, and that he should never have gone, and that she had told me so, and she had, and she was right. And now you are standing in your garden with your hands folded and telling me that a boy fell into a fountain."

Antonia put her hand over his.

"Lucius," she said. "Let go of my arm."

He looked down. He let go.

"I will find out," she said. "Whatever there is to find, I will find it. Not for the aedile, and not for the city, and not for your wife. For you. And when I have found it, I will bring it to you and no one else, and you will decide what to do with it. That I promise you. On the house, and on the water, and on whatever I have that is worth swearing by."

Gallus looked at the fountain.

"There is a thing I have to ask you," Gallus said. "It is not about the fountain."

"Ask."

"The masks. The family masks. There are fourteen of them, and my father had them repainted in the year he was consul, and they are in the cupboard in the atrium, and on the third day they will bring them out and the actors will put them on, and the whole family will be a procession of dead men with my son at the front." Gallus's voice was steady and terrible. "And I find that I cannot bear the thought of my son's face being made into a mask and put in a cupboard and worn by an actor at somebody else's funeral in twenty

years. I find that I would rather there were no masks at all, and no procession, and no speeches, and no city looking at us."

"Then have no masks."

"My wife wants the masks. My wife's family wants the masks. The Iunii have been consuls for two hundred years and the masks are what a family has instead of money." Gallus looked at the dry basin. "I have spent my life believing that a family is a thing that continues. And now I find that what continues is the masks, and the name, and the debts, and that the boy is not continued at all. The boy is simply gone, and the masks go on without him."

"Lucius."

"I am not asking you to agree with me. I am telling you what I have discovered in the last six hours, because you are the only person I can tell it to who will not repeat it." He turned. "He was afraid of the dark," he said. "When he was small. He would not sleep without a lamp, and his mother used to say that a Roman should not be afraid of anything, and I used to leave the lamp. Every night. For eleven years." He turned and walked to the door. "Find out, then."

At the door he stopped. "The funeral is on the third day. There will be masks. There will be a procession with the whole family's death masks, and the actors will wear them, and my son will be the newest face in the cupboard, and the whole city will come to look at us."

"Lucius."

"Do not come," he said. "Not to the house, and not to the funeral. Not until you bring me what you promised."

He went out. Cerdon shut the door.

❦

Dessa was in the cellar.

It was not a prison, though it had been built as one, in the year when Antonia had bought the house and had found, under the kit-

chen, a room with a barred window and a ring in the wall. She had the ring taken out and the window enlarged, and she used the room for wine, and the smell of the wine had gone into the walls, so that the place smelled like a good year even when the year was bad.

The girl was sitting on a stool with a cup of water in her hands. She had been there since before dawn. Her hands had been washed — Rufina had washed them, without being told, which was either a kindness or a disaster — and her face was the color of the wall.

"Leave us," Antonia said.

Rufina went. Antonia sat down on the other stool and waited. She had learned, from years of dealing with frightened people, that the first thing a frightened person says is never the thing that matters, and that the second thing is usually the truth, and that the way to get to the second thing is to wait until the silence has become more uncomfortable than the lie.

The silence lasted a long time. The wine in the racks breathed. Somewhere above them, Beryllos dropped something.

"I did not push him," Dessa said.

The girl had been in the cellar for a night, and she had not slept, and she had the particular stillness of a slave who has decided that the safest thing in the world is to be small. Antonia had seen that stillness in her own hands once, in a room above a fuller's shop, and she had spent eighteen years learning to see it in other people and to hate it.

"Before that," Antonia said. "Everything before that. Start at the beginning of the day, and do not leave anything out because you think I will be angry. I have been angry at better men than you and it has never cost me a night's sleep, so you may tell me anything."

Dessa looked at the cup. "There was a man in the lane in the afternoon. He came to the gate with a message for Cerdon and Cerdon told him to come back at dark. And then at dark there was a man in the lane again, and I thought it was the same one, and I

watched him from the kitchen window, and he did not come to the gate. He stood at the corner by the fuller's and looked at the house."

"For how long?"

"Until the lamps were lit. And then he went away up the hill, and came back." Dessa's hands tightened on the cup. "He came back after the party began. He stood in the lane and he watched the terrace, and I could see him through the gap in the wall, and I thought, that man is counting the guests."

"Could you see his face?"

"The lamp was behind him."

"His cloak?"

"It was dark. It had a hood."

"His height?"

"He was tall. Taller than Cerdon." Dessa stopped. "He was standing the way the master used to stand."

"Which master?"

"The one who sold me. When he was waiting for me to be brought to him. He stood with his hands behind his back and his chin up, and he did not move, and he was not in a hurry, and that was the worst of it." She looked up. "This man stood like that."

Antonia sat very still. She knew that stance. She had seen it in a senate-house corridor and in a garden on the Viminal and in a doorway at the fourth hour, and it belonged to a particular kind of Roman who has been waited on since he was four years old.

"Go on," she said.

"I know."

"I did not touch him. I went out to the garden because I could not sleep and I heard a noise in the fountain, and I went and there was a man in the water and I put my hands in to turn him over, that is all, that is all I did, and then I screamed and then Hilarus came."

"You put your hands in the water."

"To turn him over."

"Which way?"

"What?"

"Which way did you turn him over? Toward you, or away?"

Dessa looked at her. "I — toward me. I took him by the shoulder and pulled, and he came up, and his face was —" She stopped.

"He was face down."

"Yes."

"And you turned him toward yourself, which means his head went back, and his face came up, and you saw it."

"Yes."

"And his arms were out, with the palms up."

"Yes." Dessa's voice had gone very small. "I remember the hands."

Antonia sat back. It was not proof. It was not even much of a fact. But a man who is drowning fights; a man who is drowning puts his hands down and pushes and scrapes and takes the skin off his knuckles on the marble, and there had been no scrapes on the boy's knuckles. A man who is stunned and goes into the water face down floats with his hands out and his palms up, and there had been a cut on his forehead, and a cut on a forehead needs something to cut it.

The rim of the fountain was smooth. She had felt it herself, in the dark, with her fingers, before the watch came. It was smooth as a dish.

"When you came into the garden," Antonia said, "was there anyone else there?"

Dessa did not answer at once. She looked at the cup in her hands.

"The gate was open," she said.

"Yes. You told Cerdon."

"I told Cerdon the gate was open. I did not tell him that I saw a man in the lane."

Antonia's heart moved. "What man?"

"I do not know. He was at the end of the lane by the fuller's, in the dark, and he was not walking, he was standing. And when I screamed, he went."

"Which way?"

"Down the hill."

"Was he tall?"

"I think so."

"Did he have a cloak?"

"I could not see. It was dark."

"Did he have a lamp?"

"No."

"Then he knew the lane," Antonia said. "A man in the Subura at night without a lamp either knows the lane or is drunk or is up to something. Did you see his hands?"

Dessa looked up. "His hands?"

"Did you see his hands?"

"No, domina." The girl's face changed, and something came into it that Antonia could not read. "I saw his ring."

"His ring."

"It was bright. It caught the light from the passage, when I came out with the lamp. It was on his hand, and it was bright."

"A gold ring?"

"Yes."

"With what on it?"

Dessa thought. "A leaf," she said. "It was a little leaf."

Antonia sat very still on the stool in the wine cellar, and the smell of the good year came up out of the walls, and she heard, quite distinctly, the sound of her own voice saying, sixteen years ago, in a house on the Viminal, *give me back my ring.*

That afternoon the house closed.

It was done in an hour, the way a house closes when it has closed before. The shutters went up on the street side. The garlands came down and were burned in the yard with the dry beans. Beryllos packed his knives in a cloth and sat on a chest in the kitchen and wept, briefly and without embarrassment, and then went to his sister's in the Aventine with a ham under his arm that Antonia pretended not to see.

Kallisto went to a patron's house at the fourth hour in a litter with two boxes, and at the gate she turned and said, "When it opens again, I want the papers. Not a share. The papers."

"When it opens again," Antonia said, "we will talk about the papers."

"That is what you said in October."

"In October I was lying. Now I am not." Antonia looked at her. "If the house does not open again, go to Daphnus at Ostia and tell him I sent you. He will find you a place on a ship, and a house that will take you in Puteoli, and he will not ask you for anything, which will confuse you."

Kallisto's mouth worked. Then she got into the litter, and the bearers took her away down the Clivus, and the lane was empty, and the gilt on the door looked cheap in the afternoon light.

Cela and the two youngest went to the country house of a patron's wife at Ficulea, with Rufina to keep them, and were glad to go, and did not understand what had happened. Hilarus stayed, and Cerdon stayed, and Meroe stayed, and Tullia stayed, and Dessa stayed in the cellar because there was nowhere else for her to be that was safe.

At the sixth hour Antonia walked through the empty house and listened to it. A house with thirty people in it makes a hundred small noises; a house with seven makes a different hundred, and each of them is a door being closed by someone who is being careful.

In the dining room the painted Danaë held out her hands to a shower of coins. Antonia looked at her for a while.

"You were not a fool," she said. "You were a woman with a father. It is not the same thing."

That night she wrote three letters.

The first was to the house of Lucius Iunius Gallus, and it said that the body would be brought at the second hour, and that the house on the Clivus would pay for the funeral, and that the writer would not attend unless sent for. She sealed it and gave it to Cerdon.

The second was to Daphnus at Ostia, and it said: *The men from Caesarea will look at the manifests. They will find nothing, because there is nothing, and then they will look for something else. Close the warehouse at the end of May and move the Egyptian wheat to the smaller one. Do not write to me until June.*

The third she wrote twice and burned the first one.

The second said: *You were in the lane. The girl saw the ring. Come to me before the funeral or I will come to you, and I will bring the watch with me.*

She sealed it with wax and pressed the seal with the ring that had a leaf on it, the ring she had taken from his hand in the year 93 and had kept for eighteen years and had never once worn.

Then she sat in the small room with the lamp and waited for morning, and the house was silent, and the city was silent, or as silent as it ever was, and somewhere in the dark a man was turning over in his bed with a leaf on his finger and thinking about a fountain.

CHAPTER VIII

A FATHER'S GRIEF

Rome, May, AD 112

The house of the Iunii stood on the Caelian with its back to the aqueduct and its face to a street that had been respectable for four hundred years and was now full of shops. It had a black threshold stone worn into a hollow by four centuries of feet, and a door with a bronze knocker in the shape of a bull's head, and a porter who had been in the family since he was a boy and who had not slept.

Antonia came at the second hour, in a plain mantle and no jewelry, with Tullia and Hilarus and a basket of white roses that had cost more than the man who carried them. She had been told not to come. She came anyway, because a woman who does not attend the funeral of a boy who died in her fountain has already made a public statement, and she preferred to make a different one in person.

The atrium of the Iunii was full of men. They stood in groups with their hands behind their backs, in the awkward silence of men who have come to be seen being sorry. The masks were out.

There were nineteen of them, in their cupboards along the wall, and the cabinet doors were open, and each mask had its own small bronze label with a name and a consulship. They were wax and wood and painted, and they had been painted so often that the faces had a shine to them, and the eyes were not carved but painted on, so that every dead Iunius looked out of the wall with the same fixed,

courteous attention, as though he had just heard something mildly interesting and intended to mention it later.

And in the middle of the floor, on a bier, with lamps at the four corners, was the newest one, and it was not a mask. It was a boy's face, painted, with the mouth closed by a coin and the eyes closed by wax, and it looked nothing at all like Decimus and everything like every Iunius who had ever been born.

Antonia stood at the back with the basket of roses and looked at the nineteen masks and the one face, and thought about a family that keeps its dead in a cupboard and speaks to them through actors once a generation, and found that she understood it better than she wanted to.

Gallus came through the crowd. He was in the black of mourning, and his hair had gone white at one temple, which it had not been on the morning of the fountain. His wife was behind him, supported by two women, and she was making the sound women make at the front of a funeral, and it was a performance, and it was also true, and Antonia knew enough about both to know that the difference did not matter.

"You were told not to come," Gallus said.

"I was told not to come to the house. This is the atrium of the house, which is not the same as the house." Antonia held out the basket. "White roses. He would have thought they were a waste of money."

Something moved in Gallus's face. It might have been a smile.

"He would have said that the money would buy a good pair of boots," he said.

"Then he would have been right."

"He was almost always right about money and almost always wrong about everything else." Gallus took the basket and gave it to a slave without looking. "Come and see the masks. My wife does not want you here, and my wife's brother has told me that a woman

who keeps a house of pleasure should not stand in a room with the death masks of the Iunii, and I have told him that the Iunii have had a great many dealings with a great many women, and that the masks have seen worse."

"That was unkind."

"It was true, which is worse." Gallus took her by the elbow and walked her along the wall. "This is my father. This is my grandfather. This is my great-uncle, who was consul twice and was caught taking money from the corn supply and paid a fine and was never spoken of again by anyone in the family until today. And this —" he stopped at a mask at the end of the row, a woman's face, small and narrow, with a mouth that had been painted and repainted until it was almost nothing — "this is my mother. The Iunii do not usually keep the women, but my father kept her, because she made him laugh."

"She looks kind."

"She was not kind. She was witty, and wit passes for kindness in a house where nobody listens." Gallus looked at the mask. "She used to say that a Roman family is a machine for turning dead men into furniture."

Antonia looked at the nineteen masks and thought of a cedar box with a lead token in it, and a girl in a garden with her head to one side.

"Lucius," she said. "I have to tell you something before the procession, and you will not like it, and you may put me out of the house after, and I will go."

Gallus did not turn. "Say it."

"Your son was in my house on the night of the Floralia, and he was drunk, and he struck a man in front of thirty guests, and he insulted me. None of that is new to you. But there is a thing that is new. He came back. The gate was open from the inside, and someone opened it, and he came back into my garden after he had

been sent home, and he went to the fountain, and there is a cut on his forehead that is not the shape of the rim of that fountain, and his hands had no scrapes on them, which is not what a drowning man's hands look like." She said it quietly. "He was hit. Or he was pushed. Or he was held. I do not know yet which, and I am not going to pretend to you that I do."

Gallus turned and looked at her, and his face was the face of a man who has been holding up a wall and has just been told that there is a door in it.

"You told the aedile's man that he fell."

"I did."

"Why?"

"Because if I had told the aedile's man the truth on the morning after, he would have written down the word accident anyway, and taken my money, and told the Subura that the house on the Clivus had killed a consular's son and bought its way out. And because the man who did it would have known that I knew, and would have had a week before the funeral to do whatever he liked about it." Antonia held his eyes. "I gave you my word in the garden. I keep it now. There is one other person who knows, and she is a slave, and she will be sold to Africa in the register before anyone can question her, and she will not be questioned under the rod. That I will not permit. Not for your son, and not for mine."

"Your son?"

"I misspoke," Antonia said.

Gallus looked at her for a long moment. Then he turned back to the masks.

"The census is in three years," he said. "In the year 115 the emperor will hold a census, and the senate will be revised, and a man's rank can be taken from him at that revision if there is a scandal attached to his name. It has happened to better men than Verus. It has happened for less than a death in a brothel and a slave girl in a great

house." He straightened the mask of his mother with one finger. "If you bring me the truth of what happened to my son, I will bring the Cassii down. Not in a court. In the senate. I have twenty years of friends there who owe me nothing and would enjoy a scandal in September. Verus will not go to Asia. His son will not hold even the decemvirate. The daughter's marriage will be broken, and the money will go elsewhere, and the house will be a name on a list of men who were once something."

"And the girl?"

"What girl?"

"The slave girl in the Cassian house."

Gallus looked at her. "You are asking me to save a slave."

"I am asking you to do what you are going to do anyway, and to do it in a way that does not crush a girl of eighteen who has done nothing."

"I do not care about a slave girl."

"You will," Antonia said. "Before the year is out, you will care about her a great deal, and it will cost you something to say so, and you will say it anyway, because you are a better man than you think and a worse one than your wife believes."

Gallus's mouth twisted. "That is the sort of thing my mother used to say."

"Then your mother was a sensible woman and you should have listened to her."

For a moment, in the middle of a funeral, in a room full of masks, Gallus laughed. It was a terrible laugh, with grief in it, and it stopped as suddenly as it had begun.

A slave came through the crowd with a folded tablet and put it in Antonia's hand, and went away before she could ask who had sent it. It was a woman's hand, small and careful, and it said: *I am not permitted to come. I have the tablet. It is under my mattress. He has moved her to the room next to the steward, and she is not allowed*

out of the house. Do not write to me again. The flower-seller is watched.

Antonia put it in her sleeve.

"Go out to the street," Gallus said. "The procession starts at the third hour. Walk behind the family, with the women, and do not speak to anyone, and if my wife's brother says anything to you, tell him that I invited you and that he may take it up with me."

"I will tell him that you invited me," Antonia said, "and I will not mention you at all."

❦

Before the procession there was the conclamatio.

It had been done the night before, when the body was brought home: the women of the household stood around the bier and called the boy's name three times, and then a fourth, and then they stopped, and the stopping was the point. Antonia had not been there. Gallus told her about it in the atrium, in a flat voice, in the middle of a sentence about the masks.

"My wife called his name," he said. "She called it four times. She has not spoken to me since."

They carried him out at the third hour. The bier was cedar, and there was a purple cloth over it that had been in the family for a hundred years and smelled of cedar and dust, and the designator walked in front with his staff calling out the route, and the flute players played the tune that is played at funerals and at nothing else, and the hired mourners walked with their hair unbound and their faces scratched, and they made the sound that hired mourners make, which is not a cry of grief but the shape of one, and it went down the Caelian like a wind through a chimney.

Behind them came the family, and behind the family the friends, and behind the friends the masks.

The procession went from the Caelian down the Vicus Tuscus into the Forum, and it took two hours, and it was the largest funeral in Rome that spring.

The crowd along the Vicus Tuscus was thick. A funeral was free entertainment, and a consular's funeral was the best kind, because there were masks and speeches and the possibility of a fight between the family's clients. There were women selling bread from baskets, and boys up on the shoulders of other boys, and a man with a monkey on a string who was doing a good trade until the flute players came past and the monkey bit him.

Antonia walked with the women of the household, at the back, with her veil down. The woman beside her was a cousin of Gallus's wife, and she talked for four streets about the price of the funeral and who had paid for it, and it took Antonia a while to understand that the woman was telling her, in the way that Roman women told each other things, that the Iunii were not as rich as they had been and that the funeral was being paid for by the wife's family under protest.

"Gallus paid for it," Antonia said.

"The house paid for it," the woman said. "There is a difference."

"There is always a difference. That is what makes a family interesting."

They came into the Forum at the fifth hour, and the procession stopped at the Rostra, and the crowd filled the square and the steps of the temples and the colonnades of the basilicas, and the masks were ranged behind the bier in their robes of office, and the oldest of them was a man who had been consul in the reign of Tiberius and whose face, painted and repainted, had become a kind of summary of every Roman who had ever held an office and been afraid of the next man.

Antonia looked at the masks and thought about the Cassian house, and the masks in the cupboard there, and the way a family could be a machine for turning people into furniture.

At the front of the crowd, near the Rostra, Verianus Cassius stood with his father. He was very pale, and he had his hand over his mouth, and twice Antonia saw him sway and twice saw his father's hand come out and take his elbow, without looking, without a word, the way a man steadies a table that has a short leg.

And once, in the middle of the eulogy, Verianus looked across the crowd and found Antonia's eyes, and held them, and his face was not the face of a murderer. It was the face of a boy who had done something in the dark and was waiting to be told what it was.

There were the flute players first, and the professional mourners, and the women of the household with their hair unbound, and behind them the bier with the boy's body, and behind the bier the family, and behind the family the masks.

The masks came on actors who had been hired for the day. Each actor wore the mask of a dead Iunius and the robe of the office that man had held, and each walked in order of the consulship, oldest first, and by the time they reached the Forum they were forty men deep, and they walked in silence, and the crowd along the Vicus Tuscus went quiet as they passed, because a procession of dead consuls is the one thing in Rome that can make a crowd go quiet.

Antonia walked with the women, at the back, with her veil down.

She did not watch the masks. She watched the living men who had come to be seen.

Verus was there, in the black of a family friend, with his son beside him and his wife behind. Verianus looked ill. He had not shaved, and there was a stain on his tunic that he had not noticed, and he kept his eyes on the ground in front of him with the concentration of a man who is afraid of what he will see if he looks up.

Marcella stood behind her husband with her hands folded and her chin level, and she looked at Antonia once, across the heads of forty people, and her face was not hostile and was not kind. It was an accounting face. She was counting what this funeral would cost her house.

Publia was not there. A girl of sixteen did not walk in a funeral procession for a man she had never met; she stayed at home with her maid and her wedding clothes.

Nepos was there, of course. He was in the third rank of the family's friends, and he wore the correct expression, and when the bier passed he bowed his head with the air of a man who had known the deceased well, which he had not.

And at the Rostra, when the procession stopped, Gallus climbed the steps and spoke.

He spoke for a quarter of an hour. He spoke about his son's childhood, and his son's bad Latin, and his son's fondness for a particular kind of fig, and the way his son used to leave a lamp burning in his room because he was afraid of the dark. He said that the boy had been a fool and had been loved, and that the two things had not been in the right proportion, and that he was sorry for it. He said that he would have given his own consulship to have the boy back for an hour, and that he did not know what that said about him, except that he was a father before he was a senator, and that the discovery had come too late.

The crowd listened. Some of them wept. Most of them did not, and the ones who did not were the ones who would talk about it afterward.

Then they carried the body out through the Porta Ostiensis to the place where the pyres were, and the family said the words, and Gallus put the torch to it himself, and the smoke went up white and then black, and the nineteen actors who were wearing the masks of the dead Iunii stood in a line with their masks pushed back on their

heads, and their own faces were young and sweating and bored, and that was the worst thing Antonia saw all day.

The fire took a long time. A body on a pyre does not burn the way a log burns; it goes slowly, and the cloth goes first, and then the hair, and then the shape of the thing changes, and there is a smell that Antonia had smelled twice before in her life and had never told anyone about.

Gallus stood at the front with his hands at his sides and watched the whole of it. He did not turn away. His wife had been led back to the litter before the torch was lit, and her women were around her, and the sound she made came out of the litter in small regular waves, like a woman in labor.

When the flames had taken the shape of the body, Gallus turned and walked back through the crowd toward the gate. People made way for him. Nobody spoke to him. He stopped once, by a stone, and put his hand on it, and stood for a moment with his head down, and then went on.

Antonia watched him go and thought about the nineteen masks, and the newest face in the cupboard, and the actor with the mask pushed back on his head, sweating, bored, and the fact that in twenty years a different actor would wear the boy's face at a different funeral and would not know whose face it was.

She stood at the back of the crowd with the smell of the pyre in her hair and thought: I have done this. Not the death; the other thing. I have stood in a garden and let a boy be humiliated in front of thirty people, and I could have stopped it earlier and I did not, because it was useful to let him show what he was. And then I sent him out into the night with a garland and a bleeding mouth and a bill for two thousand sesterces, and someone was waiting in the lane.

"Domina."

She turned. Nepos was at her elbow with his hands folded and his face arranged for a funeral.

"Oppius."

"A sad day. A very sad day. I came to pay my respects to Gallus, who is a good man, and to tell him that if there is anything I can do — anything at all — he has only to send to me."

"That is generous."

"It is what one does." Nepos looked toward the pyre. "I hear the aedile's office has closed the matter. An accident. A boy, a party, a fountain. I hear the house on the Clivus has closed for the month, and that the girls have gone to the country, and that the steward is selling the wine cellar." He turned. "And I hear that a slave girl was sold to a house in Africa on the Ides, and that the registration was made in the morning and stamped in the afternoon, and that the clerk who stamped it says the girl was never brought before him, which is a thing that happens, but not often, and not in the same week as a death."

Antonia looked at the pyre. The smoke was going up in a long black column, and the smell of it was in her mouth.

"You are very well informed for a man paying his respects."

"I am a friend of the house," Nepos said. "I am a friend of several houses. It is my only accomplishment, and I have worked hard at it, and I do not like to see a friend make a mistake." He turned to face her. "The book, domina. I will pay you three hundred thousand for it, and I will pay it today, in gold, in your hand, and I will ask you one question about the household of Cassius Verus, and you will answer it, and then this unhappy business will be over, and your house will open in June, and the wedding in September will be a wedding for other people."

"And if I say no?"

"Then I will be obliged to do what I am obliged to do," Nepos said. "I will tell the aedile's office that a slave girl who witnessed a

death has been concealed by her mistress. I will tell the prefect's office that the house on the Clivus has been selling wine without a licence and harboring men of the senatorial order in a place of ill repute. Neither of those things is a crime that will hang you. Both of them together will close your door for a year, and a year is a long time in the Subura. Houses forget how to open."

Behind them the pyre cracked and settled. A woman began the ululation at the graveside, and the crowd took it up.

"I will think about it," Antonia said.

"That is what you said in March."

"In March I was lying. Now I am not." She turned to face him. "I will think about it until the Kalends of June. On the Kalends, I will send you my answer, and it will be a single word, and you will not need to read it twice."

Nepos inclined his head. "I have waited four months. I can wait a month."

"Then you will have my answer on the Kalends of June, and it will be the word no."

Nepos smiled. "You said you would think about it."

"I have thought about it," Antonia said. "While you were talking."

For the first time that day, Nepos's face did something unguarded. It was not anger and it was not fear. It was the look a man has when he has been counting on a thing and the thing turns out to be different from what he counted, and he discovers that he is no longer the cleverest person in the conversation.

"That is a mistake," he said.

"Probably." Antonia turned away. "But it is my mistake, and I have paid for it in advance, which is more than most men can say."

"You cannot," Antonia said. "You have never waited for anything in your life. That is why you will lose."

She walked away through the crowd, and her hands were shaking, and she did not let anyone see.



That evening, in the empty house, Tullia brought her the accounts and a cup of wine and stood by the table until Antonia looked up.

"Say it," Antonia said.

"You cannot beat him."

"I know."

"He has the prefect's office and the aedile's office and money and a name that is not his and a patron we cannot see. He has the register of the city and the ear of men who will believe him because he is well dressed." Tullia put the accounts down. "You have a book and a token and a girl in a cellar, and a consular who is mad with grief, and a tribune who is in debt to three money-lenders, and a house that is closed."

"I know all of that."

"Then what are you going to do?"

Antonia looked at the lamp. It had a bronze door on the handle, and she had bought it in the year she stopped being poor.

"I am going to do the thing he cannot imagine," she said. "I am going to tell the truth in a room full of men who have something to lose, and I am going to make them choose between the truth and the loss, one at a time, and I am going to start with the man who has the most to lose and the least time."

"Which man?"

"Manius Cassius Verus," Antonia said. "In his own house, in front of his own family, at his own daughter's wedding."

Tullia looked at her for a long moment.

"That is either the bravest thing I have ever heard," she said, "or the stupidest."

"Most days there is no difference." Antonia picked up the cup. "Send to the house of the Cassii in the morning. Not to Verus. To Acilia Marcella. Tell her that the woman from the Clivus asks for an hour of her time, in private, before the wedding, and that she will come to the back gate if she must."

"And the girl in the cellar?"

"The girl in the cellar is a problem I made this morning," Antonia said, "and I am going to have to live inside it."

She went down to the cellar with the cup in her hand. Dessa was awake, sitting on the stool with the cup of water she had not drunk, and she looked up when the door opened the way a dog looks up.

"You are not going to be sold," Antonia said.

The girl's face did not change. This was the worst thing about her, and about all of them: they had learned not to believe a sentence until the second half of it had arrived.

"You told the man from the aedile that I was sold."

"I did."

"Then in the register I am in Africa."

"You are in Africa," Antonia said, "in a house that does not exist, in a province where the man who owns it is a fiction I paid a clerk to invent this morning. Which means that for as long as the register says you are in Africa, no man with a warrant can take you out of this house and put you on a board and ask you questions with a rope. It means that you are, as far as the law of Rome is concerned, gone."

Dessa looked at her. "And if I walk in the street?"

"Then a man who knows you will see you and ask why a girl in Africa is buying bread in the Subura, and the whole thing will come apart." Antonia sat down on the other stool. "You will stay in this house until the wedding. Not in the cellar. In the room next to mine. You will keep the accounts with Tullia, and you will answer the door to nobody, and if the house is searched — and it may be

searched — you will go through the passage to the fuller's, and the fuller will hide you in the vat room, and you will not come out until I send Hilarus with a red cloth."

"Why?"

"Because I need you alive," Antonia said. "Because you are the only person who saw the lane, and you are the only witness to what was done to a boy in my garden, and because I have already told one lie for you and I am not going to make it a waste."

Dessa looked at the floor. "The master in the house where I was before," she said, "he used to say that a slave who is useful is a slave who lives. And then he sold me anyway."

"Then he was a fool as well as a master." Antonia stood. "Eat something. Sleep. In the morning Tullia will bring you the grain accounts, and you will find three errors in them, because I have put three errors in them, and if you find all three I will give you a knife and teach you how to use it."

The girl's head came up. "A knife?"

"A small one. For the passage, and the vat room, and the dark." Antonia stopped at the door. "And Dessa. The mark on your wrist. The crescent. Was it there when you were taken?"

"It has always been there."

"Then it is yours," Antonia said, "and nobody can sell it."

CHAPTER IX

THE CASSIAN HOUSE

Rome, May, AD 112

She had prepared for it the way she prepared for a banquet: by deciding, in advance, what she would not do.

She would not weep. She would not raise her voice before the slaves. She would not sit on the bench by the fountain, or look at the room behind the kitchen, or say the word father. She would not ask him whether he had ever thought of her. She would not, under any circumstances, take his hand.

She put on the dark blue stola and the mantle the color of wine, and the gold earrings she had bought in the year 103 with money she had earned in a single season, and no other ornament at all. She put the half-token in the fold of her sash, because she wanted it on her body. She looked at the ring with the cassia leaf in the cedar box and did not take it, and then at the last moment she took it and put it in the purse at her belt, and told herself it was for evidence.

And she took Rufina aside in the passage and said, "If I am not out of that house by dark, go to the station and find the tribune, and tell him that I am in the house of the Cassii and that he should bring men and a warrant and be very loud at the door."

"Domina," Rufina said, "you are going to a wedding contract."

"I am going to a house where I was a slave," Antonia said. "If you have never been in a house where you were a slave, you will not understand why I am telling you this. If you have, you will not ask me any more questions."

Rufina looked at her for a moment. Then she said, "I was in a house in Pompeii when the mountain went. I was sold four times after. The fourth time I came here."

"And?"

"And if you are not out by dark, I will burn the house down myself," Rufina said, "and the tribune may help."

❦

The house of the Cassii had not changed in eighteen years. That was the first thing, and it was worse than any of the others.

The lane still smelled of the same things: stone dust, and the privy of the house opposite, and the fig tree at the corner that had grown over the wall and dropped its fruit on the paving where the ants found it. The door was the same door, with the same iron boss in the middle of it, and the same worn place at the bottom where the delivery boys kicked it. And the threshold stone was still black, a single block of basalt worn into a hollow by the feet of six generations, and when Antonia stepped over it she felt the hollow with her foot the way she had felt it ten thousand times when she was nineteen, and she stopped.

"Domina?" Marcella's steward was a thin man of forty with the face of a man who has been in service since he was eight. "The lady is in the garden. Will you come?"

"Will you give me a moment?"

The steward's face did nothing. "Of course."

She stood on the black stone in the fauces of the house she had been sold into, and the past came up around her like water in a cellar.

The walls of the fauces had been painted, eighteen years ago, with a garden scene: a trellis, a vine, a bird. The paint was still there, faded, and someone had painted over the bird at some point and

then scraped the paint off again, and the bird was still there under the scraping, one wing showing, a green smear of vine behind it.

To the left was the passage to the kitchen. There was a door in that passage, and behind the door was a room with a pallet and a jug and a nail in the wall, and in that room a girl had slept for nine years, and in that room a man had come to her in the fourth year, and in that room she had learned to be silent.

To the right was the atrium. She could hear it: the small sound of the fountain in the impluvium, the shuffle of feet, a woman's voice giving an order about a chest.

Straight ahead, at the end, the garden, and beyond it the tablinum, and in the tablinum a man who had not spoken to her in eighteen years except across a garden full of roses.

Antonia stood on the threshold and looked at the bird.

Then she lifted her veil and walked in.

❦

The atrium had the masks.

They were in the same cupboard, on the same wall, with the same bronze labels, and there were twenty-three of them now, and Antonia knew every name on every label because she had been made to learn them when she was sixteen, by a steward who had beaten her when she got the order of the consulships wrong.

She stood in front of the cupboard and read them, one by one, and the steward waited, and Marcella came out of the garden with her hands folded.

"You are early," Marcella said.

"I am punctual. It is a different vice."

"You said on the tablet that you would come at the fourth hour. It is the third."

"It is the third hour and a half."

"That is still early." Marcella came and stood beside her. She was in the blue wool she always wore, with her hair braided close, and here, in her own atrium, she looked smaller than she did in public, and harder. "You are looking at the masks."

"I was made to learn them. Caius Cassius Verus, consul in the year of the consulship of... I could recite the whole cupboard. It is the only thing I learned in this house that I have ever used."

"What did you use it for?"

"To know what kind of men I was dealing with," Antonia said. "There is a pattern in the cupboard. Every third generation produces a man who is clever and a man who is cruel, and the clever one always dies first."

Marcella's mouth moved. "That is a terrible thing to say in the presence of the family."

"They are not present. They are wax."

"They are more present than you think." Marcella turned. "Come into the garden. The slaves are cleaning the receiving room and there is dust everywhere, and I do not want to talk in the atrium where the whole household can hear through the passage."

They went out through the garden. It was smaller than Antonia remembered, and the vine was older, and the fountain was the same fountain with the same lion's head spout, and the bench where she had sat with a man who was going to be consul was still there, and she did not look at it.

"Your husband is not here."

"He is at the senate house. He does not know you are coming." Marcella sat on the bench. "You asked for me, and I have not told him, and I am going to have to decide what to tell him and when, and both of those decisions will be mine."

"Why?"

"Because I have been married to him for nine years," Marcella said, "and I have spent nine years being the woman who manages

the money and the household and the wife's family and the daughter's marriage and the slaves, and in nine years I have not once been asked what I think about anything. So I am going to have this conversation, in my own garden, in my own house, and I am going to enjoy it, and then I am going to tell my husband whatever I decide to tell him."

Antonia sat down at the other end of the bench. "What do you want to know?"

"Why the wedding," Marcella said. "Why you, of all the people in Rome, are going to walk into this house in September and stand in the room with the shrine and eat my husband's dinner. You could have sent a man. You could have sent a letter. You could have gone to the praetor with whatever it is you have and never come near this house at all. But you asked for an invitation, and my stepdaughter wanted you there, and my husband forbade it, and I overruled him, which was the first time in nine years." She looked at Antonia. "So. Why?"

"Because I want to see the house again," Antonia said.

Marcella looked at her for a long time.

"Ah," she said.

"Yes."

"Then it is true. I had thought it was a story." Marcella's voice did not change. "I knew it was a story the day I found the page. In the year 104, when my husband's steward died, I went through the tablinum, and I found a bundle of tablets marked with the year of the fire, and I read them, and I found a page about a child, and a note in my husband's hand that said *for the child, from Bassa, and no more to be said.*"

Antonia did not move.

"I asked him about it," Marcella said. "Once. In this garden. And he said that it was a family matter from before our marriage, and that it had been settled, and that I was not to speak of it again.

And I did not speak of it again for eight years." She turned her cup — there was a cup in her hand; Antonia had not seen her take it up. "I have thought about it every week of those eight years."

"What did you think?"

"I thought: a child was bought. And I thought: a child was bought because the mother could not keep her. And I thought: the mother is somewhere in this city, and she has not forgotten, and one day she will come to this door." Marcella looked at Antonia. "I did not think she would be the most successful woman in the Subura."

"She is not the most successful woman in the Subura."

"She is the most successful woman in the Subura. I have seen the household accounts of this city. Half the men on the Viminal owe money to a woman on the Clivus and do not know that they owe it to the same woman."

Antonia almost smiled. "Then you know my business."

"I know your business from the outside. I know what a house costs and what it earns and what a woman in it has to do to survive." Marcella put the cup down. "What I do not know is what you intend."

"I intend to free the girl," Antonia said, "and I intend to do it lawfully, in front of a court, with witnesses, and I intend her father to be the man who must answer for what was done. And I intend to do all of it before your stepdaughter's wedding, because after the wedding your husband will go to Asia with the dowry in his hands and the girl will be sold to a man in Formiae, and there will be nothing left of her to free."

Marcella's face went still.

"You are telling me this," she said slowly. "In my garden. With the door open."

"Yes."

"Because you know that I will not tell my husband."

"Because I know that you will tell your husband exactly what you choose to tell him," Antonia said, "and because I have made a study of you for fourteen years, Acilia Marcella, and I know that a woman who has read a page about a stolen child and has said nothing for eight years is not going to be on the side of the man who bought her."

❦

The girl came into the garden to pour the wine.

Antonia saw her before she saw the token. She saw the way the girl came through the door with a tray and the way she set her feet, the way the slaves in a great house moved, as though the floor were glass and might crack and bring the whole house down; she saw the way the girl kept her eyes at the level of the bench, and the way her hands did not shake.

"Myrtale," Marcella said. "Put the tray here. And bring the white cup for the guest, not the red one; the red one has a chip."

"Yes, domina."

The girl set the tray down. She was close to Antonia, close enough to touch, and the two of them were within an arm's length of each other, and Antonia looked at her hands on the tray.

They were good hands. Long fingers, a narrow wrist, a small crescent mark on the inside of the wrist, and nothing else. No bruise, no brand, no collar. She was wearing a plain grey tunic and a belt of plaited leather, and her hair was bound up and held with a wooden pin, and around her neck, on a leather cord, was a lead token the size of a thumbnail.

The girl turned to fill the cup, and the token swung out from her throat, and the light caught it, and Antonia saw it clearly: a wreath on it, struck by a die that had made ten thousand others, and a break across the middle where the other half had been snapped off.

The world went white at the edges. Antonia heard, very distinctly, the sound of her own heart, and under it the little dry click of the token against the girl's collarbone, and under that, from a long way off, the sound of a room above a fuller's shop, and a woman saying, *the door half is yours, and when you have money, you will look for the wreath half, and you will find her.*

"Thank you," Antonia said.

"Domina." The girl glanced up, once, and her eyes were dark and careful, and she went back through the garden and into the house.

Antonia sat with the cup in her hand and did not drink.

"She does not know," Marcella said.

"No."

"You have not told her."

"No."

"Eighteen years."

"Eighteen years."

Marcella looked at the door the girl had gone through. "I have wanted to tell her," she said. "Four times in eight years I have come close to it. Twice I was prevented by my husband, and twice by myself. The first time I was prevented by the thought that if I told her, she would do something reckless and be sold, and it would be my fault. The second time I was prevented by the thought that she is happy." She turned. "She is not happy. But she has a room, and work, and my stepdaughter loves her, and a girl who is not happy but is safe is a thing a woman can live with. A girl who knows she has been robbed is a girl who will set the house on fire and be sold in the aftermath."

"You should have told her."

"Yes."

"Then why are you telling me this?"

"Because I am ashamed," Marcella said, and the word came out flat, and it was the first true thing she had said all afternoon. "I have been ashamed for eight years and there is nobody in this house I can be ashamed in front of. My husband does not permit it. My stepdaughter is a child. My stepson is drunk. The slaves cannot be told. And now the mother of the girl is sitting on my bench with a cup of my wine, and I find that I would rather confess to her than go on being the woman who said nothing."

Antonia put the cup down.

"What do you want me to do?" she said.

"I want you to take her out of this house," Marcella said, "and I want you not to tell anyone that I helped. Not the girl, not my stepdaughter, not my husband. If it fails, I will say I knew nothing, and I will be believed, because I am the wife and the wife is always the last to know. And if it succeeds, I will be the woman who did nothing, and I will live with that, because it is better than the alternative."

"What is the alternative?"

"Being the woman who did something," Marcella said, "and having my husband know it."

❦

Verus came home at the sixth hour, and he came into the garden with his toga still on and his face grey with the heat of the senate house, and he stopped when he saw her.

"You," he said.

"Me."

Marcella rose. "I invited her."

"You did not."

"I did. She asked, and I invited her, and I am going to leave the two of you alone in this garden for a quarter of an hour, because I am tired, and because I have been the wife of this house for nine years and I am entitled to one afternoon of not being present at the

thing I have arranged." Marcella went past her husband without touching him. "The slaves have been told to stay out of the garden. The steward has been told to keep the household in the kitchen until the seventh hour. And Manius — do not raise your voice. The whole lane can hear a raised voice in this garden, and half the lane works for people who would enjoy it."

She went in. The door closed.

Verus stood in the middle of his own garden with his hands at his sides.

"How did you get in here?" he said.

"Your wife invited me. You heard her. You were standing there."

"You have no right —"

"I have every right," Antonia said. "I was born in this house's service. Literally. In the room behind the kitchen, on a pallet, with a midwife from Ficulea and a woman from the kitchen holding my mother's hand. I was carried through that passage when I was three days old, and I was given to a nurse in the country, and I was brought back when I was six, and I slept in that room until I was twenty. I have more right to be in this garden than you have, because you have only owned it. I lived in it."

Verus took a step back. "How do you know about the midwife?"

"Because she is alive," Antonia said, "and she remembers a birth in the Subura in the year before the child was sold, and she remembers a token tied to a baby's wrist, and she remembers a man in a good cloak who came to her afterward and paid her to forget it, and she has not forgotten, because she is a woman who has delivered four hundred children and remembers every one of them."

"Antonia."

"Say her name."

"Antonia."

"Not mine." Antonia took a step toward him. "Say hers."

He did not move. The fountain ran. The vine moved in the wind.

"I do not know what you mean."

"You know exactly what I mean. I have seen the token, Manius. I have seen it on her throat in this garden, in the sunlight, on a leather cord, and it is the wreath half, and I have the door half in a cedar box in my house, and I have had it for eighteen years. And you have known since the day you arranged her put in that room behind the kitchen that I would come for her, and you have known that when I came I would not be polite."

Verus sat down on the bench. He sat down the way a man sits down when his legs have decided for him, and he put his hands on his knees, and he looked at the fountain.

"Her name is Myrtale," he said.

"Her name is not Myrtale. That is a name a slave is given. Her name is what her mother called her, and her mother called her nothing at all, because she was taken from her at three months and the mother was not allowed to name her." Antonia's voice was shaking, and she let it. "You had a daughter by a slave in your father's house, and you took the daughter and put her in the same house as a maid, and you watched her grow up at a distance of ten feet, and you never told her, and you never freed her, and you never let her go. Do not tell me her name."

Verus's face had gone the color of the wax in the mask cupboard.

"You have made a mistake," he said. "The child was bought from a dealer. The records say so. The dealer is dead. The slave who handled it is dead. There is no proof that the child was yours, and there is no proof that the mother was —"

"She was yours," Antonia said. "She was your father's slave and she was yours, and there is a book in my house that says so, page by page, in your hand and in your steward's hand and in mine. There is

a page that says a child of three months was bought for ninety thousand sesterces, and beside it, in your own hand, *and no more to be said.* And there is a woman at Ficulea who attended the birth, and a piece of lead in a cedar box, and a slave called Chryseros who is dead and whose hand is on the page, and a woman standing in your garden who has spent eighteen years waiting for the day she could say this to you in your own house."

"Antonia."

"Do not say my name."

"What do you want?"

Antonia looked at him.

"I want my daughter," she said.

He was quiet for a long time. The shadows of the vine moved on the paving. Somewhere in the house a door closed and a woman laughed, and it was not Marcella.

"You cannot have her," Verus said.

"Why not?"

"Because she is mine."

"She is not yours. She is mine. She was born of my body in a room in this house, and you took her from me at three months, and the only thing you have ever given her is a lead token and a name."

"I gave her a life," Verus said. "I gave her a room and food and work and a house that is not a brothel. I gave her the run of the kitchen garden when she was eight and she used to sit among the beans and sing to herself, and I used to stand at the window of the tablinum and listen, and I never once let anyone see me do it. I have kept her from every man in Rome who would have bought her, and there have been four. I have paid her nurse's pension for twelve years. I have —" he stopped.

"You have what?"

"I have loved her," Verus said, "in the only way I was permitted."

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

"You have loved her," she said, "in the way a man loves a thing he has put in a box. You have loved her from the window of a tablinum, at a distance of ten feet, without once telling her who she was. And when the box became inconvenient, you found a farmer in Formiae who will pay twelve thousand, and you arranged to have her sent away after the wedding, so that the bride would not have to look at her." She leaned down. "Do not say the word love to me in this garden. I have heard it before. You said it to me in this passage when I was nineteen, and I believed it, and six months later I was on a board with a rope in your hand."

Verus came up off the bench so fast that the cup went over, and for a moment his face was the face of the man in the passage, and Antonia did not step back.

"Hit me," she said. "There is no one in the garden. There is no one in the passage. There is no one in the tablinum to write it down. Hit me, Manius, and I will walk out of this house with a mark on my face, and by tomorrow every man in the Subura will know what kind of man the Cassii keep, and your wedding will be a wedding in a small room with the doors closed."

He stood there, breathing, with his hand half raised, and then he put it down.

"I did not do that," he said. "That was my father's doing. I was not in the room."

"You were in the room."

"I was not —"

"You were in the room," Antonia said. "You held the lamp."

The world stopped. The fountain ran. The vine moved.

"I held the lamp," Verus said.

"Yes."

"I have told myself for eighteen years that I was not there."

"You were there. You held the lamp, and your father asked the questions, and you did not stop him, and when it was over you untied me yourself and carried me to the room behind the kitchen and sat on the floor with your back against the door until morning." Antonia's voice was very quiet. "I remember your hands. I have spent eighteen years hating your hands."

Verus sat down again. He sat down slowly, and put his face in his hands, and his shoulders shook, and the sound he made was not a man's sound. Antonia stood over him with her hands at her sides and did not touch him.

"I have the ring," she said. "The one with the leaf. You gave it to me in the passage when I was nineteen, and you took it back the day the child was taken, and I took it back from your desk in the year 94 when I came for my daughter and the steward would not let me in. I have worn it once. I pressed it into wax on a letter to you and I sent it with the watch, and you did not answer."

Verus did not look up.

"What do you want?" he said again.

"Do you know what I did when they took her from me?" Antonia said. "I walked from this house to the room above the fuller's shop, and I sat down on the floor, and I did not get up for four days. On the fifth day the woman who kept the shop came up and put a bowl of soup on the floor and said that I owed her for the week, and that if I did not work I would be sold, and that I was free and freedom was a thing that could be taken away by a debt as easily as by a rope. And I got up. And I ate the soup. And I went down and washed clothes for eleven hours a day for a year and a half, and every night I walked to this lane and stood at the corner and looked at that door."

Verus's hands were over his face.

"Once I saw her," Antonia said. "She was six years old, and she was in the passage with the steward, and she was crying about something, and the steward took her by the arm and pulled her along. I stood at the corner and I did not move, because if I had moved the steward would have seen me, and he would have told you, and you would have had me taken up for loitering and put in the cells for a month. So I stood at the corner and watched a man pull my daughter along a passage by the arm, and I did nothing. And then I went back to the fuller's and washed clothes."

"Antonia —"

"You took a year and a half of my life with the debt, and eighteen years with the child, and I have had to build everything I have out of what was left. And you are going to sit on that bench and tell me that you loved her."

"I did love her."

"Then free her."

"I want you to free her," Antonia said. "In the praetor's court, in front of witnesses, by the rod, with a written record and a citizen's name. And I want an admission, in writing, that she was born of a slave of this household who was manumitted before the birth, and that she is therefore freeborn and has been held in slavery these eighteen years. And I want your signature and your seal on it, and I want it before the wedding."

"And if I do it?"

"Then you will have done the only decent thing you have ever done," Antonia said, "and I will not bring the rest of it to a court, and your daughter will be married in September, and your son will not be asked where he was on the night of the Floralia, and your house will go to Asia with its name intact."

Verus lifted his head. His eyes were red, and his face was wet, and he was still a man in a garden with an old name and a lot of

debts, and Antonia saw him calculate, and she saw the moment he understood what she had just offered him.

"The night of the Floralia," he said.

"Yes."

"My son."

"Your son."

"What do you know?"

"I know that Decimus Iunius Gallus was in my garden at the sixth hour, and that he was dead before he went into the fountain, and that a man in the lane was wearing a gold ring with a leaf on it." Antonia held his eyes. "Your ring is not on your hand, Manius. I have been looking at your hand for a quarter of an hour. Where is it?"

Verus looked down at his own hand, and then at her, and his face did something that Antonia had never seen on it before.

"On my son's finger," he said. "It has been on my son's finger since the Kalends of May. He asked for it. He said a man should have a seal of his own."

The fountain ran. Somewhere in the house, a woman laughed again.

"Then we have a great deal to talk about," Antonia said, "and very little time."

CHAPTER X

THE INFORMER

Rome, May, AD 112

The house of Oppius Nepos was on the Quirinal, in a street of houses that had been built in the reign of Claudius and had all been bought, in the last twenty years, by men who had made their money in the reign of Domitian. It had a portico of six columns, a garden with a fish pond, a library of four hundred scrolls that had been bought by the yard, and a doorkeeper who had been bought, Antonia suspected, in the same way.

"You are expected," the doorkeeper said.

"Am I."

"The master said to bring you to the garden and not to the tablinum, because the tablinum has a mosaic that cost him a great deal and he does not want it spoiled."

"By what?"

"By whatever it is you are going to say to him," the doorkeeper said, and stood aside.

Nepos was in the garden, feeding the fish. He was in a plain tunic with his sleeves rolled, and he had a bowl of bread in his hand, and he was dropping pieces into the water with the concentration of a man who has found something to do that requires no thought.

"Domina," he said. "Sit. Is the bench comfortable? I bought it in the year 106 from a man who was selling everything he owned to pay a debt, and I have always meant to ask him what the debt was, and now he is dead and I shall never know."

"You are in a good humor."

"I am in an excellent humor. I have had a letter from a friend in the east. The emperor has decided, or is about to decide, or has been persuaded by his architects, and there will be a war, and it will be in the spring, and every man in Rome who owns a ship or a warehouse or a cousin will make money, and every man who does not will pay for it." He threw the last of the bread into the pond. "Which of the two are you, domina?"

"That depends on the day."

"Today?"

"Today I am the second," Antonia said, "and I have come to find out what it will cost me."

Nepos sat down on the bench beside her, at a distance of a foot, and put the empty bowl on the ground. "You have my terms."

"You offered three hundred thousand for the book and a question about Verus. I have come to hear the terms in a room with a door, from a man who is not standing at a funeral with a crowd around him."

"This is a room with a door. It is a garden with a door. In Rome very little is a room." Nepos smiled. "But I take your point. Very well. The terms. I want the book, all of it, the original and every copy, and I want a statement, sworn before a magistrate, in your own words, describing the night of the Floralia as you saw it, and describing the household of Cassius Verus as you know it. In return I will pay you three hundred thousand sesterces, and I will see to it that the aedile's office closes its file, and that the prefect's office takes no further interest in your house, and that the register of the city forgets that a slave girl was ever concealed."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then I will take the book in a different way, and it will cost me more and you will like it less." He looked at the fish. "I have been doing this for twenty years, domina. I know how a house like yours

is held together. It is held together by secrets and by the fact that everyone in it agrees to pretend that the secrets are not there. I do not need to prove anything. I need only to make one of your people believe that another of your people has told me something, and then I need to sit back and wait."

"They will not believe it."

"One of them will. There is always one." Nepos turned. "The cook who is owed wages. The singer who wants her papers. The steward who has been keeping the accounts for nine years and has begun to think that the house would not run without her. I have a list of your household, domina. It is not a long list. I could read it to you."

Antonia looked at the fish pond.

"Show me the file," she said.

"What file?"

"The file. The one you have been keeping since 93. The one with the transcript in it. You did not bring me here to talk about a singer and a cook. You brought me here to show me that you have something that will put me in the dock if you wish it, and to watch my face while I read it."

Nepos looked at her for a long moment. Then he got up and went into the house, and came back with a bundle of tablets tied with cord.

"There are four copies of the transcript," he said. "One in the urban prefect's archive. One in the archive of the aediles. One in the house of Cassius Verus, in his own hand. And this one, which I had copied in the year 98 from the prefect's, when a clerk owed me a favor." He put it on the bench. "Do you want to read it alone?"

"No," Antonia said. "I want you to watch me read it. That is what you brought me here for."

She untied the cord.



The tablets were thin and the wax was old and the writing was small and sloping. The first page was a heading: a date in the year 93, the name of the investigating magistrate, the name of the household, the nature of the charge, which was treason, and the names of the two slaves to be questioned.

The second page was the transcript.

It was in the formal style. *Interrogatus, respondit* — asked, she answered. The clerk had written it down as it happened, and the clerk had not been interested in the pauses, or in the sound of a rope creaking against a beam, or in the smell of the room.

Asked whether she knew the man Didius Probus, she answered that she knew him by sight.

Asked whether the said Probus had been received in the house of the elder Cassius Verus, she answered that he had come four times and had spoken with the master in the tablinum with the door closed.

Asked what was said, she answered that she did not know, that the door was closed, that she was a slave and did not listen at doors.

Asked again, with the question applied, she answered that she had listened at doors and had heard the said Probus speak of a letter to the governor of Germania and of a sum of money.

Asked whether she had told anyone, she answered that she had told the young master.

Asked what the young master did, she answered that the young master had told her to be silent and had gone to his father.

Asked —

The letters on the page had blurred. Antonia looked up at the fish pond and the sky above the roof of the house of Oppius Nepos, and then she looked down again.

Asked whether she had seen the said Probus receive money in the house, she answered that she had seen him receive a folded paper and no money.

Asked to name the persons present, she answered that she was alone with the said Probus on the day in question and that no one else was present.

Asked again, with the question applied twice, she answered that the young master had been present, that the young master had come into the passage behind the kitchen, that the young master had taken the folded paper from the said Probus, and that the young master had struck her and told her that if she spoke of it she would be sold.

Asked whether she had told the elder master of this, she answered that she had.

Asked what the elder master had said, she answered that the elder master had said nothing, and that the next day the said Probus was found dead in his bath, and that the young master came to her in the passage and told her that she was the only witness and that he was sorry.

Asked whether she understood what she had said, she answered that she understood.

Antonia turned the tablet over. On the back, in the same small sloping hand, was a note:

This is the evidence of the slave Prima, aged nineteen, of the household of the elder Cassius Verus, taken on the fourth day before the Kalends of October, in the consulship of —

She stopped. She knew the date. She had known the date for eighteen years.

"You were there," Nepos said, from a great distance. "That is the part that interests me. Not what you said. That you were there. The file has one gap, domina, and it is not the transcript. It is the fact that the clerk who took the transcript was dismissed in the following year and his papers were burned, and that the whole file — the

charge, the witnesses, the transcript — was closed within a fortnight, and that the reason given was that the accused man had died before trial."

"Didius Probus died before trial."

"Didius Probus died in his bath before anyone was charged," Nepos said. "The elder Cassius Verus was never accused. The son was never questioned. The only person who was ever asked a single question about the whole affair was a slave girl of nineteen, and she was questioned for eleven hours, and afterward she was manumitted by the mother of the house, which is a strange thing to do for a slave who has just accused your husband's son."

Antonia put the tablet down.

"What do you want?" she said.

"I want to know who closed the file," Nepos said. "I have wanted to know for twenty years. The file was closed by a man with influence, in a fortnight, in a year when files were not closed. And there is one more thing in this file that I have never been able to explain, and that is the note in the margin on the last page."

Antonia turned over the last tablet. There was a note in the margin, in a different hand, small and cramped.

The woman was not sold. Let her be found a place.

"It is not signed," Nepos said. "But the hand is the hand of the elder Cassius Verus."

The fish came up to the surface of the pond and made a small ring, and were gone.

"He did not sell me," Antonia said.

"He did not sell you," Nepos agreed. "That is the last thing I do not understand. A man who has just had a slave questioned for eleven hours writes in the margin that she is not to be sold, and lets her go. It is not mercy. I have known men all my life and that is not how mercy looks. It is —" he searched for the word — "it is an accounting."

"It is a bribe," Antonia said.

"To whom?"

"To himself. He could not say that he had done a terrible thing, so he did one small decent thing, and wrote it in the margin, and for eighteen years that margin has been his absolution." She set the tablet down. "You have read this file a hundred times and you have never once asked the only question that matters."

Before she left the garden, Nepos said one more thing, and he said it in the mild voice he used for the sentences that mattered.

"There is a girl in your house," he said. "The Dacian. The one the register says is in Africa."

Antonia's hand was on the door.

"I have no interest in her," Nepos said. "She is a slave and she saw something and she is not worth the trouble of taking her. But you should know that a man who is paid to look for something always finds something, and that the man I have paid to look for the book has been looking in your house for two months. He has looked in the warehouse, and the garden, and the cellar. He has not looked in the room next to yours, because the room next to yours is where you sleep, and a man who searches the room where a woman sleeps has to be certain of what he will find, and he is not certain."

"You have a man in my house."

"I have a man in every house," Nepos said. "It is not a boast. It is a business expense."

"Then tell him from me that if he comes into the room where I sleep, I will know it before he has crossed the threshold, because I have been in this city for thirty-nine years and I have never once slept without a knife under the pillow." Antonia opened the door. "And tell him that the room next to mine is not a room. It is a passage, and the passage has two doors, and the second door goes to the fuller's yard, and the fuller has four sons and a vat of piss, and none of them like men who come into houses at night."

She went out. Behind her, Nepos laughed — a real laugh, the second one she had heard from him, and the second one that was worse than a false one.

"Which is?"

"Who held the lamp," Antonia said.

Nepos looked at her. In the afternoon light, with a fish pond behind him and a bowl of bread at his feet, he was an ordinary man of forty-three, and there was nothing in his face to say that he had spent twenty years building a career out of other people's worst afternoons.

"The lamp," he said slowly.

"There were two men in that room. The old man asked the questions. The young man held the lamp." Antonia stood. "You have a copy of a file, Oppius, and you have carried it about for fourteen years like a boy carrying a stone in his pocket, waiting for the day he can throw it at a window. And it never occurred to you to ask who else was in the room, because a file is a thing written down, and what is not written down does not exist for a man like you."

She walked to the door of the garden.

"The book," Nepos said.

"On the Kalends of June," Antonia said, "you will have my answer."

"I have told you what will happen if it is no."

"I have told you that you have never waited for anything in your life," Antonia said. "That remains the most interesting thing about you."

❦

She went first to the station of the seventh cohort, because she had promised, and because a promise to a man in debt was the only kind of promise she could afford to keep.

Crescens was in the yard with the pumps. He had a body on a board again — an old woman this time, from a fire on the Viminal, and she had not drowned, she had burned, and the smell of it was still in the yard.

"Not here," he said. "Come upstairs."

The room upstairs had a bed, a chest, a basin, a helmet on a nail, and a window the size of a hand. He shut the door and stood with his back against it.

"You asked to see a man's hands," he said. "When he has drowned fighting."

"I did."

"There was nothing to see. That was the point." Crescens crossed to the chest and took out a tablet. "I wrote it down, because a tribune who notices is a tribune who writes it down. No abrasions on the knuckles. No scrapes on the palms. A laceration of the forehead, transverse, above the brow, which is not consistent with a fall against a smooth marble rim. Water in the lungs, which the physician says means he was alive when he went in." He handed her the tablet. "I have not filed it. It is in this chest. If the prefect's office asks for my report, I will give them the one that says accident. This one is for you."

Antonia read it twice. It was a plain document, in a plain hand, and it said what she had known for a month and could not prove.

"Thank you," she said.

"Do not thank me. If it is ever read out in a court, I will be dismissed, and the prefect will say that I was bribed by you, and a man in Ostia will say that I owed money to three lenders, and both of those things will be true." Crescens took the tablet back and put it in the chest. "Where is the girl?"

"In my house, in the room next to mine."

"And the register says she is in Africa."

"The register says she is in Africa."

Crescens looked at her for a long moment. "I have been thinking about the register," he said. "It is a very good lie. It is such a good lie that it has made her into a thing that does not exist. And a thing that does not exist cannot be freed, domina. If you go to the praetor and say, this woman is free, the praetor will look at the register and say, this woman is in Africa. You have put her beyond the law to keep her safe, and now the law cannot give her anything."

Antonia sat down on the chest.

"Yes," she said.

"You had not thought of that."

"I had thought of it at the fourth hour of the morning after I did it, and I have been thinking of it ever since." She looked at the small window. "There is a way. It is a bad way. It requires the girl to be produced in court as a slave, claimed by a master, with an adsertor to assert her freedom. If the master produces her, the register is answered. If the adsertor wins, she is free and the register is corrected. If the adsertor loses, she is a slave, and the master takes her away, and the penalty is paid by the adsertor."

"Who is the master in this story?"

"Cassius Verus. Who else? He must be the one who produces her, or the whole thing is a fiction and the praetor will see it in a morning." Antonia looked at him. "He has agreed. He will claim her in court, and the adsertor will assert her freedom, and the case will be heard by the praetor with the decemvirs, and she will be freed by the rod or she will not."

"And who is the adsertor?"

"A free man of good standing who is willing to risk a penalty and his reputation on the outcome."

"Who?"

"I do not know yet," Antonia said. "It cannot be a freedman. It cannot be a client. It must be a man whose word is worth something

in a court and who will not be bought." She looked at Crescens. "I had thought of Gallus."

"You cannot use Gallus. He is grieving and he is angry and he believes his son was murdered, and if you put him in a court as the adsertor for a slave girl in the house of the man he suspects, the whole thing will be a spectacle and the praetor will adjourn it before the second hour."

"Then I will find another."

"You will find another," Crescens said, "or you will find that the whole case turns on the one man in Rome who is willing to stand up in front of a praetor and say that a girl in a great house is free, which is a thing that no man in Rome has said in a hundred years without being paid for it."

He opened the door. In the yard below, the men were rolling the pumps back into the shed, and the old woman on the board had been covered with a sheet, and a boy was waving a branch at the flies.

"Domina," Crescens said. "When it comes to it, and you need a man to stand in a court and be ruined —" he stopped, and looked at his helmet on the nail, and did not look at her — "I am a tribune of the fire-watch, and I have no name, and I owe money to three lenders, and I am the worst adsertor in Rome. But I am better than nothing."

Antonia looked at him.

"Keep your helmet," she said. "You will need it, and I will need you where you are."

She went down the stairs and out into the street, and the sun was on the roofs, and she found that her eyes were stinging, and told herself it was the smoke.

She went from the Quirinal to the Vicus Tuscus, to a shop under the shadow of the temple of Castor where a man named Salvius sold old bronze and stone, and where a freedman called Epaphroditus had kept the records of the auctioneers' guild for thirty years.

Epaphroditus was seventy and had no teeth and a memory like a locked box, and he had known Antonia's — he had known, he said, the woman who used to come to the auctions with Gaius Antonius Felix, in the year when Felix was buying everything in Rome that had a good name attached to it.

"You want the guild's lists," he said.

"I want the list of the coactores for the year 71 and the year 72."

"Which coactores?"

"All of them."

"That is four hundred names."

"Then I want the name that is missing." Antonia put a purse on the counter. "There was a man in this guild, in the reign of Vespasian, who was a slave and worked as an auctioneer's clerk in the Porticus of Livia. He was manumitted in the year 71 or 72 and went into the grain trade at Puteoli, and he died rich, and he had a son who is now an equestrian in Rome and claims that his family has been in Puteoli for five generations."

Epaphroditus's mouth worked over his gums.

"Oppius," he said.

"Oppius."

"Gaius Oppius Philargyrus. He was in the guild. He was a slave of the Oppii, and he was a clever man with a crowd, and he ran the auctions for the wine lots in the Porticus. He was manumitted in the year 72, in the consulship of —" the old man stopped and closed his eyes — "the year of the two consuls who were brothers, whatever their names were. And he went to Puteoli, and he was in the grain trade, and he made a fortune, and he came back to Rome in the reign of Domitian and bought a house on the Quirinal, and he died

in the year 96, in his bed, of a complaint of the liver, and his son sold the house and bought a better one."

"And the son?"

"The son was born in the year 69, in the house of the Oppii, and he was a slave for two years until his father was manumitted and bought him free." Epaphroditus opened his eyes. "It is all in the guild's book. The manumission is recorded, because the guild recorded every manumission of a member, and the fee was paid, and the name of the praetor who manumitted him is in the margin."

Antonia stood very still in the shop of old bronze and stone.

"You are certain," she said.

"I am seventy years old and I have no teeth," Epaphroditus said, "and the only thing I have left is that I am certain about the guild's book. The man was a slave. The son was a slave. There is no five generations in Puteoli. There is a tomb in Puteoli with the father's name on it, and the tomb says *libertus*, and the son has never gone back to see it, and the guild's book says why."

❦

That night, in the small room, Antonia laid it all out on the table: the page from Bassa's ledger, the copy of the transcript that Nepos had allowed her to read and not to keep, the notes she had made from the guild's book, the half-token, and the ring with the cassia leaf.

Tullia stood at her shoulder. Dessa stood at the other end of the table with a lamp, and did not ask a single question, and watched everything.

"He is a freedman," Antonia said. "He has been passing as freeborn for twenty years. He is on the equestrian list, and a freedman cannot be on the equestrian list, and if it is known, he will not be prosecuted — nobody prosecutes a man for that after twenty years — but he will be struck off the list, and he will lose the right to sit in

the first fourteen rows at the theater, and the right to wear the gold ring, and the right to be called anything but what he is. And he will lose the thing that matters to him more than any of it."

"Which is?" Tullia said.

"The prefecture," Antonia said. "He wants to be prefect of the grain, or prefect of the watch, or a procurator of a province. He has wanted it for twenty years. And a man who is discovered to be a freedman passing as an equestrian will never be given a prefecture as long as the emperor lives."

"You are going to tell him that."

"I am going to show him that I know," Antonia said, "and then I am going to give him what he wants, which is the book, and a statement about Verus — written and sealed, and false in every particular that matters. And he will take it, because it is what he has asked for, and because a man who is about to be exposed will believe any bargain that lets him keep his ring."

Tullia looked at the table. "And the book?"

"The book will be a copy," Antonia said. "A copy of the first twenty pages, which are all real, and the rest invented. And the statement will say that I saw nothing on the night of the Floralia, and that the house of Verus is respectable, and that the death was an accident, which is a thing that every man in Rome believes already."

"And what does that buy you?"

"Time," Antonia said. "Nepos will take the book and be satisfied, and he will go to the prefect with it, and the prefect will look at it and find nothing, and in the meantime the real book will be somewhere else, and the guild's book will be in my hand, and the man who thinks he has won will be learning arithmetic."

Dessa spoke for the first time. "And what does it buy me?"

Antonia looked at her.

"Nothing," Dessa said. "It buys you time. It buys me nothing."

"That is true," Antonia said.

"Then say it."

"It is true," Antonia said again. "It buys me time, and the time is for your mistress's daughter, and you are not in it. That is the arithmetic of this house, and I am not going to pretend it is anything else."

Dessa looked at her across the table with the lamp between them.

"You should have told me that in March," she said, "when you gave me a knife."

The lamp guttered. Antonia looked at the girl across the table and did not look away.

"Everything I have," she said, "I built by being useful to people I did not love and keeping my promises to them, and the promises were small ones, and I kept them because a woman in my position cannot afford to be unreliable. I did not promise you anything in March. I told you to stay out of the water and I gave you the accounts and then I gave you a knife, and you took it, and you have kept it, and you have not run, and you have not stolen, and you have not told anyone in this house what you saw in the lane. So I am going to tell you the truth now, and it is a worse truth than the one you had."

Dessa's chin came up. "Say it."

"When I walk into the praetor's court with the girl, you will be in that court, and the court will ask whether a slave saw anything, and I will say no. I will say that you were in the kitchen. I will perjure myself in front of a praetor of Rome, and if I am caught I will lose my house and my fortune and my name, and I will do it anyway, because the case is about the girl and not about the boy, and a witness who is a slave is not a witness, she is a piece of property to be questioned with the rod."

"They will find me."

"They will look for the girl in Africa and they will not find her, and they will look for you in my house and you will be in Ostia, in a warehouse, with a man who owes me and who will not ask questions. And you will stay there until the case is over, and then I will bring you back, and I will free you."

Dessa looked at her.

"You will not free me," she said. "You will say it now, and in the winter you will forget, because a woman who has lost her house does not have anything to give away."

"Then I will put it in writing," Antonia said, "and Tullia will witness it, and if I do not do it you may take the writing to the praetor, and he will look at it, and a written promise from a freedwoman to a slave is worth nothing in law. So it will be worth nothing, and I will give it to you anyway, and you may keep it, and when you are free you may keep it as a thing that was owed to you and paid."

Dessa looked at the paper that Antonia had not yet written, and then at the lamp, and then, briefly, at Antonia's face.

"Write it," she said.

CHAPTER XI

THE TOKEN

Rome, June, AD 112

Myrtale woke before the light, as she had done for as long as she could remember, and lay for a moment in the dark listening to the house.

A great house at night has a voice. The Cassian house talked in its sleep: the beams over the atrium creaked when the wind came off the Viminal; the water in the impluvium dripped into the cistern below with a sound like a small, patient counting; the dog in the porter's lodge dreamed and whined; and somewhere at the back of the house, in the kitchen, the cook's boy turned over on his pallet and said something to nobody.

She knew every sound. She had lived in this house since she was six years old. She could tell the hour by the sounds: the first cart on the Viminal meant the fourth hour, the baker's shutter meant the fifth, and the porter's cough meant that the porter had been drinking again and would be useless until noon.

She got up. The room was not hers; it was the room off the passage that the maids shared, and there were three of them in it, and the other two were still asleep on their pallets with their mouths open. Myrtale folded her blanket and put it on the shelf and washed her face in the basin and put on the grey tunic that she had washed the night before and hung by the window to dry.

Then, before she went out, she took the cord from the nail and put it over her head and tucked the token inside her tunic, against her skin, where it always was.

She had worn it since she was small. She did not remember being given it. She remembered the nurse — a big woman with a heavy arm and a smell of onions, who had kept her in a cottage in the country until she was six, and who had called her *little moon* because of the mark on her wrist. The nurse had died in the winter of the year she came to Rome, and Myrtale had been brought to the house on the Viminal by the steward, and the steward had said, "This is the girl," and the master had looked at her for a long time and had said, "Yes."

She had been six years old. She had thought that she was being brought to a house to work. She had not been wrong.

❦

The morning of a great house was a machine made of small parts.

Myrtale went down the back stairs to the kitchen, where the cook had the fire going and the boy was grinding pepper and the steward was standing in the doorway with his tablet, saying what had to be bought and what had to be cooked and what had to be sent to the house of the lady's sister before noon.

The steward's name was Callistus. He was fifty, and he had been in the house for thirty years, and he had the face of a man who has been given a little power and has decided to become it. He had never beaten her. He had, twice, made her stand in the passage for an hour with her hands on her head, and had watched her while she did it, and had not said anything at all.

"Girl," he said. "The lady's bath at the eighth hour. The lady's hair at the ninth. The lady's dress is to be brought up from the press and aired, and if there is a crease in the veil you will be the one who is blamed for it."

"Yes, Callistus."

"And the master's letters. He wants them copied before the second hour, and he wants the copy in a better hand than the original, and he has said that if the copy is worse than the original he will not pay for the ink." The steward's mouth moved. "He has said that to me three times."

"Then I will make it better than the original."

"You will make it legible. Better than the original is a thing that annoys him." Callistus turned away. "And the girl — the daughter — is not to leave the house today. Her father has said so. She is to stay in her rooms and she is not to send messages, and if I find a tablet in her room it will be my fault and your fault and everyone's fault, and I will begin by blaming you."

"Yes, Callistus."

She went up with the tray.

The house was waking. The porter was coughing in the lodge. The ladies' maid was in the passage with a basin. The garden door was open, and the light in the garden was the color of the inside of a fig, and the old vine was in flower, and the bees were already at it.

Publia was awake, and she was in a mood.

"I will not wear it," she said.

"Domina."

"I will not wear the green. He chose the green. He stood in the room with the goldsmith and he chose the green for the betrothal and he did not ask me, and I will not wear it."

"It is the betrothal," Myrtale said, "and the green is the color of the house, and if you do not wear it he will be angry, and if he is angry he will be angry with Callistus, and Callistus will be angry with me."

Publia looked at her. She was sitting on the edge of her bed with her hair down and her face still soft with sleep, and she was sixteen, and she looked about twelve.

"That is the most horrible thing I have ever heard," she said, "and it is true, and I hate it, and I will wear the green."

"Yes, domina."

"You are the only person in this house who tells me the truth."

"That is not true."

"It is true. The others tell me what I want to hear because I am the daughter, and my father tells me what he wants me to be, and my stepmother tells me what she has decided I am, and you tell me the truth because you have to live here."

Myrtale put the tray down. She had been Publia's maid since the winter she came, and they had grown up in the same house, eight years apart, and there was a thing between them that had no name in any language she knew. It was not friendship. It was closer than friendship and it was wrong in ways that Myrtale could not have explained to anyone, and it had kept her alive.

"I am not brave," she said. "I am careful."

"That is what bravery is, when you are a slave." Publia pulled the comb through her hair. "Myrtale. If you were free, what would you do?"

"Domina?"

"If you were free. Not freed — free from the day you were born. What would you do?"

Myrtale thought about it. It was a game they played sometimes, and it had become harder to play as the years went on, because the answers she had given at twelve were not the answers she had at nineteen, and the new answers frightened her.

"I would have a shop," she said. "A small one. Not in the Subura. On the Viminal, near the gate, where the women come to the market. I would sell ribbons and thread and pins, and I would

keep the accounts, and I would have a dog, and I would not get up before light."

"You would still get up before light. You would be a shopkeeper."

"Then I would get up before light for myself," Myrtale said, "and it would be a different thing."

Publia looked at her in the bronze mirror. Her eyes were bright and unhappy.

"Would you take me with you?" she said.

Myrtale stopped combing.

"I would," she said. "But I would make you get up before light."

"You are not allowed to make me do anything. I am the daughter of the house."

"Then I would ask you very politely to get up before light, domina, and you would complain about it, and then you would get up."

"That," Publia said, "sounds like the best of all the lives I have imagined." Then she turned on the stool. "Myrtale. There is a thing I have never told you, and I am going to tell you now, and then I am going to ask you never to speak of it, because if it is spoken of in this house I will be sold before the week is out."

Myrtale put down the comb. "Domina?"

"There is a reason my father has forbidden the lady on the Clivus to come to this house," Publia said. "And there is a reason he has moved you to the room next to the steward's. And I am not supposed to know either of them, and I do know them, and I am going to tell you, because you are going to be sold in September and I would rather be hanged for telling you than be silent for the rest of my life."

Myrtale said, "There is a thing I have never told you, too."

"Then we shall trade," Publia said, and her hands were shaking, and her voice was steady.

And they traded. Myrtale told her about the tablinum, and the fifty-one times, and the cord. And Publia told her about the tablinum on the Nones, and the strongbox, and the page in her father's own hand that said *for the child, from Bassa, and no more to be said*, and the lady on the Clivus, and the word that had been used, twice, in the portico of Octavia: *her mother*.

"Then the lady on the Clivus is —" Myrtale stopped.

"She can be anything," Publia said. "She mends fans."

Myrtale sat down on the edge of the bed. The room was very quiet, and outside the bees were in the vine, and somewhere below in the kitchen Doris was singing an African song that she had sung in this house for twenty years.

"Domina," Myrtale said, "there was a page you were not supposed to see."

"Yes."

"Did you copy it?"

Publia's eyes came up.

"Yes," she said.

"Then you had better show it to me," Myrtale said, "because if I am going to be sold in September, I would like to know what I am worth."

Publia got up and went to the chest at the foot of the bed, and took out a wax tablet from under a folded cloak, and put it in Myrtale's hands.

"Read it," she said.

Myrtale read it. It was eleven words and a note in the margin, and it was in the hand of the master of the house, and she read it twice, and then she sat down on the edge of the bed with the tablet in her lap.

"She is the most dangerous woman in Rome," Publia said. "That is what my father says. He says it the way a man says a thing he is afraid of."

"Yes, domina."

"And my father has forbidden her the house."

"Yes, domina."

Publia looked at the painted birds on the wall for a long moment.

"Then we shall have to be very careful," she said, "and very quiet, and we shall have to do it all before September."

She turned back to the mirror, and Myrtale took up the comb again, and for a while the room was quiet except for the small noise of the comb in the hair.

"Domina," Myrtale said at last. "You are going to marry a rich man and live in a house with a garden."

"Yes," Publia said. "Would you take me with you?"

Myrtale combed.

"Yes," she said. "But I would make you get up before light."

Publia laughed. It was a small, cracked, unhappy laugh, and it was the first time she had laughed in a month.

"Then it is settled," she said. "We will run away to the Viminal and sell ribbons, and my father will come after us with the whole senate, and you will have to hide us both in a vat."

"I would hide you in a vat," Myrtale said. "But you would ruin your dress."

"I would ruin my dress," Publia agreed, "and it would be the best day of my life."

❦

The news of the death came down to the kitchen before it came to the atrium.

It came with the boy who fetched the water, who had it from the porter of the house opposite, who had it from a client of the Iunii, and by the seventh hour the whole household knew that a young man had drowned in a fountain in a house of women on the Clivus,

and that the young man was the son of a consular, and that the house was the house of Antonia Cassia.

Myrtale was in the kitchen when the cook heard it. The cook's name was Doris, and she was from Africa and had been in the house for twenty years, and she had a way of taking news the way a cat takes a fish: she held it down with one paw and looked at it before she ate it.

"In a fountain," she said. "How does a man drown in a fountain?"

"He was drunk," said the boy.

"Drunk men drown in rivers. A fountain is eighteen inches deep and has a rim around it." Doris turned the spit. "There is more to it."

"There is not more to it," said Callistus from the doorway, and everyone stopped talking. "There is a death, and the family will be in mourning, and there will be no music in this house for a month, and the master will be in a temper for a week, and if any one of you repeats a word of what the street says, I will have the whole kitchen on bread and water until the Kalends." He looked around the room. "The lady of the house is to be told nothing until the master comes home. The daughter is to be told nothing at all."

He went out. The kitchen breathed again.

"Eighteen inches," Doris said, and turned the spit.

Myrtale carried the bread up. In the passage she met the porter, who was coughing, and who said, "Girl. The master wants you in the tablinum."

"Now?"

"Now. And he has been sitting in there since the fourth hour with the door shut, and the steward has been standing outside it like a man waiting for a dog to bite him." The porter wiped his mouth. "Say as little as you can."

She went to the tablinum. The master was at the table with a cup and a lamp, and there was a letter open in front of him, and he was not reading it.

"Shut the door," he said.

She shut it.

"Come here."

She came. He looked at her for a long time, and she stood with her hands folded and looked at the floor, and the silence went on so long that she began to count her own heartbeats.

"You are to move to the room next to the steward's," he said. "Tonight."

"Master."

"You are not to leave the house. You are not to speak to the porter, or the boy, or the cook's girl. You are to serve your mistress and you are to come to this room when you are sent for. Do you understand?"

"Yes, master."

He picked up the letter and looked at it, and then put it down again, and his hand was shaking.

"There was a boy," he said, "who died in a house on the Clivus. Did you hear of it?"

"Yes, master. In the kitchen."

"And what did the kitchen say?"

Myrtale thought, very fast, about the truth and about the price of the truth.

"The kitchen said that he was drunk, master, and that he drowned."

"Yes," the master said. "That is what happened." He looked at the letter. "That is what happened. Now go."

She went. In the passage, outside the door, she stood for a moment with her back against the wall, and the porter's words went through her: *say as little as you can*, and she had said as little as she

could, and the master had said *that is what happened* in the voice of a man who is telling himself something.

She went up to her mistress.

She took them to the tablinum, where he was sitting at the table with the tablets piled in front of him and the window open onto the garden. He did not look up when she came in. He never looked up when she came in. He looked up when she had finished.

"Put them there."

She put them on the corner of the table, and stood with her hands folded, and waited.

"Read me the second one."

She read it. It was a letter to a man in Antioch about a debt, and it was full of numbers, and she read the numbers correctly, because she had been taught to read numbers by a woman in a cottage in the country, and had been taught to read them better by a cook who had found her reading the shopping list at eight years old, and who had said, "The girl can read. Do not tell the master."

"They are correct," he said. "Sit down."

She sat. She had been told to sit in this room perhaps a dozen times in thirteen years, and each time it had lasted about a quarter of an hour, and each time she had left and had gone to wash her hands.

"The wedding is in September," he said. "You will go with your mistress to the house of Caesennius Rufus. You will be her maid there. You will have a room in the household, and you will be under the steward of that house, who is an old man and a good one."

"Yes, master."

"Do you want to go?"

She looked at her hands. There was a right answer. There was always a right answer, and it was never the true one, and she had learned to find it the way a cat learns to find the warm place in a room.

"I will do what is best for my mistress."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he got up and went to the window and stood with his back to her, looking out at the garden.

"You have a look of your mother," he said.

Myrtale's hands went cold.

"Master?"

"She was in this house when I was a young man. She was clever, and she could read, and she used to sit in the garden in the evening and sing to herself. You sing. You have her voice." He was silent for a moment. "She died. You were very small."

"I do not remember her."

"No," he said. "You would not."

He turned around. And then he did what he did, the thing that happened perhaps four times a year, and that she had never once spoken of to anyone, because there was no one to speak of it to and because she did not have words for it that did not make it worse.

He looked at her. He stood in his own tablinum with the light behind him and looked at her for a long time, and it was not a look that a man gives a slave, and it was not a look that a father gives a daughter, and Myrtale sat with her hands folded and looked at the floor and waited for it to end.

It always ended. He would turn back to the window, and say something about the letters or the garden or the weather, and she would stand up and go out. It had happened four times a year for thirteen years. She had counted. Fifty-one times.

This time he said, "Take off the cord."

She did not move.

"The cord. Around your neck. Take it off."

"My mother —"

"I said take it off."

She lifted the cord over her head and put it on the table, and the token lay on the wood between them, and the wreath on it caught the light.

He looked at it for a long time. Then he pushed it back across the table.

"Put it on," he said, "and go."

She put it on. She went out. She got to the passage, and her legs would not hold her, and she sat down on the step by the store-room door with her back against the wall, and put her hands over her mouth, and stayed there for a long time.

The lady in the blue mantle came on the eighteenth day of May, and Myrtale was told to bring wine.

She had heard the household talking about her for a week before she came. The lady on the Clivus. The woman who kept a house of pleasure, and was richer than the master, and had once been — the talk stopped when she came near, and started again when she went away, and what it said was not clear, and what it did not say was very clear indeed.

She came into the garden with the mistress, and she sat down on the bench, and Myrtale brought the tray.

The lady was not what she had expected. She had expected paint and jewels and a voice like a woman selling something. The lady in the blue mantle had grey at her temples and lines at the corners of her eyes and a plain gold earring, and she sat with her back straight like a soldier, and when she looked up at Myrtale her eyes were the eyes of somebody who is doing arithmetic.

"Thank you," she said.

"Domina."

Myrtale went back into the house. In the passage she stopped, because the lady had said thank you, and nobody in the house of the Cassii had said thank you to her in a year.

Later, in the portico of Octavia, the lady mended her mistress's fan.

She did it fast, with a pin from her own hair, and her hands were quick and certain, and Myrtale watched them because she had spent her life watching people's hands. And she said, "You have the hands of a woman who mends," and the lady looked at her with an expression that Myrtale did not understand and could not forget.

And then, at the end, the lady turned her own wrist up, and said, "Show me your mark."

And Myrtale, who had never in her life shown her mark to a stranger, turned her wrist up and showed it.

❦

After the portico, the house changed.

She did not know how she knew. Nobody told her anything. But the house changed: the steward stopped meeting her eyes, and the cook gave her an extra piece of bread at supper and did not say why, and the porter, who had never spoken to her in thirteen years, said "Good evening, girl," in a voice that was almost kind.

And on the second day of June, the mistress sent for her.

Acilia Marcella was in her own room with the shutters half closed and a box of papers on the table, and she was not dressed, which Myrtale had never seen, and her hair was down, which she had never seen either, and it made her look like a different woman: a woman of thirty-three, with a tired face.

"Sit down," Marcella said.

Myrtale sat.

"You are to move," Marcella said. "Tonight. Your things are to be taken to the room next to the steward's, and you are to sleep there until the wedding."

"Domina."

"Do not ask me why. I am not going to tell you why, and if you ask me I will have to lie to you, and I have been lying to too many people this month and I have run out of lies that are any good."

Myrtale looked at her hands. The room was quiet. Outside, the bees were in the vine.

"Domina," she said. "Am I to be sold?"

Marcella's face did not move. She looked at the box of papers on the table for a long time.

"There is a man in Formiae," she said, "with a farm and a wife who is ill. He has offered twelve thousand sesterces for a maid. Your master has accepted."

The room went very far away. Myrtale heard the bees, and the drip in the cistern, and her own breathing, and all of them were very loud and very slow.

"When?"

"After the wedding. When the house is quiet." Marcella's voice was flat. "He is not a cruel man, the man in Formiae. He is dull, and he is old, and his wife will not last the winter, and after she dies he will want a woman to run his kitchen. You will have a room and food and work, and you will not be beaten, and in four or five years he will free you, because men like that always free the woman who runs the kitchen."

"And my mistress?"

"Your mistress will be married and gone, and she will not be able to do anything, and if she tries, her husband will tell her that a bride does not interfere in her father's household, and she will learn the first lesson of a married woman, which is that you cannot save everyone."

Myrtale sat with her hands in her lap. She was not crying. She noticed that she was not crying, and she noticed that she had known, somewhere, for weeks, and that the knowing had been sitting in her chest like a stone.

"Is there anything I can do?" she said.

"Yes," Marcella said.

"What?"

"Nothing that I can tell you," Marcella said, and her voice was strange, and she looked at the box of papers, and then she pushed one of them across the table. It was a page of a letter, in a hand that Myrtale did not know, and it said: *the woman from the Clivus asks for an hour of your time, in private, before the wedding.*

"The lady who mended the fan," Myrtale said.

"The lady who mended the fan."

"Why are you showing me this?"

"Because I am not a good woman," Marcella said, "and I am not a bad one either, and I have been sitting in this room for an hour trying to decide whether to burn that page or to give you a reason to hope, and I have decided to give you a reason to hope, and I do not know whether it is the right decision, and I will never tell anyone I made it."

She took the page back and folded it and put it in the box.

"Go and pack," she said. "And Myrtale — if the lady on the Clivus sends for you, go. If she tells you something, listen to all of it before you say anything. And do not tell your master. Not one word. Do you understand?"

"Yes, domina."

"Then go."

Myrtale went out into the passage. The house was quiet, and the light was the color of the inside of a fig, and the bees were in the vine, and she stood in the passage with her hand on the wall and did not cry, and did not cry, and then went up to pack.

That night she lay in the room next to the steward's, which was small and clean and had a window that looked at a wall, and she took the cord from her neck and held the token in her hand.

She had never looked at it closely. It was a piece of lead the size of her thumbnail, worn smooth by thirteen years against her skin, with a wreath on it and a break across the middle where something had been snapped off. She turned it over. On the back, at the edge of the break, there was a mark that might have been the edge of a leaf or the edge of a door.

The nurse had told her, when she was small, that the token was a charm and that she must never take it off. The nurse had told her that her mother had died. The nurse had told her a great many things, and the nurse had been paid to tell them, and Myrtale had known for years that the things the nurse told her had been paid for.

She held the token in her hand and thought about the lady in the blue mantle, and the way she had mended the fan, and the way she had said *show me your mark*, and the way she had looked at her in the garden with the eyes of somebody doing arithmetic.

Then she thought about the master, and the fifty-one times, and the way he had said *take off the cord*.

She sat up in the dark and put the token back around her neck and tucked it inside her tunic. Then she got up and felt under the mattress for the knife she had stolen from the kitchen in March, which was small and dull and had a wooden handle, and she put it under the pillow.

It was not much. It was a knife, and a token, and a name she did not know, and a lady who mended fans.

But it was hers, and nobody in that house had given her anything that was hers, and she lay in the dark holding all of it, and waited for morning.

CHAPTER XII

WHAT VERUS KEPT

Rome, June, AD 112

There is a kind of man who is not afraid of anything except the opinion of a particular room.

Manius Cassius Verus had been afraid of one room since he was seven years old. It was not the senate house, though he had been afraid of that too, at first. It was the tablinum of the house on the Viminal, and in it his father had sat at a table with a wax tablet and a pen, and the room had smelled of ink and of the oil in his father's hair, and his father had said, without looking up, *the family is the only thing that lasts.*

He was forty-five now and his father had been dead for nineteen years and the room was his, and he still could not sit in it without putting his shoulders back.

The morning after the woman from the Clivus had stood in his garden, his wife came into the tablinum and shut the door.

Acilia Marcella was thirty-three, and she had been in his house for nine years, and in nine years she had never once shut the door of the tablinum. She had been a good wife. She had been better than a good wife: she had brought money when there was none, and she had taken the household in hand when his mother died and the slaves had begun to steal, and she had never, not once, said a word about the room behind the kitchen.

"Manius," she said. "Sit down."

"I am sitting."

"You are standing behind the chair and holding the back of it as though it were a shield. Sit down."

He sat.

"Did you tell her?" he said.

"Did I tell her what?"

"Anything."

"I told her that I had read a page in your tablinum in the year 104," Marcella said. "And that I had asked you about it and that you had told me it was a family matter and that I was not to speak of it again. And I told her that I had not spoken of it again."

"Why?"

"Because she already knew," Marcella said. "That is the thing you have never understood about this, Manius. She has known everything for eighteen years. She has known the child was in this house since the day the steward brought her back from the country. She has been building a case against you since before I met you, and she has been doing it in a house in the Subura with a book and a set of accounts, and you have been sitting in this room telling yourself that a thing not written down does not exist."

"There is nothing to build. The purchase was in Chryseros's name. Chryseros is dead."

"Chryseros is dead, and Bassa is dead, and the nurse is dead, and half the household that knew is dead, and you are alive, and you have a daughter in your house with a lead token on her neck." Marcella came and stood in front of the table. "She has the token, Manius. The mother has the other half. That is what she came to this house to see, and she saw it, and now she has it."

He looked at the table.

"I want you to tell me why," Marcella said.

"Why what?"

"Why you did it. Not why you bought her — I have worked out the buying. I want to know why you kept her. You could have sold her at six, at ten, at thirteen. You could have given her to a house in the country and never seen her again. You could have freed her at sixteen and married her to a freedman of the household and never spoken to her again, and there would have been no scandal and no case and no woman on the Clivus." Her voice was steady. "Why did you keep her?"

He did not answer.

"I have a theory," Marcella said. "I have had it for eight years and I have never said it out loud. My theory is that you cannot bear to be a man who did what you did, and that as long as the girl is in this house, being fed and not beaten and taught to read, what you did is not what it was. It is something else. It is a thing with a room and a name and a coat. And the day she leaves this house, it becomes what it is."

He looked up.

"That is not —"

"Then tell me the true reason and I will believe you," Marcella said. "Tell me in one sentence. Not a speech. One sentence, and I will believe you, and I will never ask again."

Verus sat behind his father's table and looked at his father's wife — no, at his own wife, at the woman who had saved his house with her dowry and had kept her mouth shut for eight years — and he opened it, and nothing came out.

"There," Marcella said. "That is what I thought."

"It is not that simple."

"It is exactly that simple. You are a man who did a shameful thing in his father's house, and instead of confessing it or repenting it or even enjoying it, you built a room around it and put a girl in the room and called the room a household, and now the room is falling down and you are standing in it with your hands behind your

back." She came around the table. "I am going to tell you what is going to happen. She will go to the praetor. She will not go to the praetor with a case she cannot prove; she is too careful, and she has been too careful for eighteen years. She will go to the praetor with a case she can prove, and she will have the midwife, and the page, and the token, and a man of standing to assert the girl's freedom, and she will do it in the autumn, before the wedding, because after the wedding you will be in Asia with the dowry in your hands and there will be nothing left of the girl to free."

"Then she will fail."

"Will she?"

"She cannot prove a birth. There is no record of a birth. Births of slaves are not registered."

"There is the midwife," Marcella said. "There is the dealer's page. There is the token. There is the fact that a child of three months was bought for ninety thousand sesterces, which is the price of ten healthy adults, and there is the note in your hand that says *no more to be said*. And there is a woman in the Subura who has kept a book of names for eleven years and has used it to make herself the richest freedwoman in Rome, and who has not yet spent a single page of it on this." Marcella's voice was very quiet. "You are going to be asked, in a public court, in front of a praetor, why you bought a child for ninety thousand sesterces, and you are going to have to say something, and every word you say will be written down."

Verus put his hands flat on the table.

"What do you want me to do?" he said.

"I want you to do the thing you should have done eighteen years ago," Marcella said. "I want you to free her, in public, with the words said properly, and take whatever comes after."

"And the wedding?"

"The wedding will be in September," Marcella said. "If you are quick, and if she is quick, the case will be heard in November, and

the wedding will be a month past and Caesennius's cousin will have his money, and the proconsulship will be decided in the spring, and there will be a scandal, and it will be a scandal about a girl who was freed, and not about a girl who was sold. Do you understand the difference?"

"I understand the difference."

"Then say it."

"I will free her," Verus said.

Marcella looked at him for a long moment.

"Say it without the sigh," she said.

"I will free her."

"There," Marcella said. "That is the first true thing you have said in this room in nine years. I am going to send for the jeweler about the wedding bracelets. You will receive her — the mother — at the end of the month, in this house, with me present, and you will not raise your voice to her, and you will not call her anything but her name."

"She will not come to this house again."

"She is coming to the wedding," Marcella said. "That was my decision, and it stands, and if you tell me to uninvite her I will tell my father's steward to stop paying your interest on the loan in June, and you will find out what a freedwoman on the Clivus is not the only woman in Rome with a long memory."

She went out and shut the door.

❦

Before he left the house, his son came to him.

Verianus was twenty, and he had not been sober in the daytime since the Floralia, and he stood in the doorway of the tablinum with his hair uncombed and a cup in his hand and the look of a man who has been waiting a month for a conversation and has decided to have it badly.

"You are going to the palace," he said.

"I am."

"To be looked at for Asia."

"Sit down."

"I do not want to sit down." Verianus came into the room and put the cup on the table, hard enough that the wine came over the rim. "I want to know what you are going to say about the night of the Floralia."

Verus looked at his son.

"I am going to say nothing," he said, "because nothing has been asked."

"It will be asked."

"It has been asked and answered. The aedile's office has written it as an accident."

"The aedile's office is a man you have paid." Verianus's voice was shaking. "The aedile's office takes money. You have been buying men since I was a child, and you have been buying them in my name, and now a boy is dead and I am the one who hit him and you are the one who paid for it to go away, and I did not ask you to."

"You did not have to ask."

"I did not want it."

"Then you should not have hit him," Verus said.

Verianus stared at him. Then he laughed, and it was a terrible sound in a room with a door.

"That is what you always do," he said. "You take the thing that happened and you turn it into an accounting. I hit him, and the aedile was paid, and the account balances, and now everybody can go to the palace and be looked at." He picked up the cup and put it down again without drinking. "I have not slept in a month. Do you know that? I have not slept, and I have not told anyone, and I have been walking the streets at night, and last night I walked to the

Clivus and stood at the corner and looked at that door, and I could not go in, and I did not know why, and then I understood."

"Verianus."

"I understood that I was going to be a man who had killed somebody and had been forgiven by his father, and that I would be forgiven every year of my life, and that the forgiveness would be worse than the death." He looked at his father. "I would rather you had beaten me. In front of the family. In the atrium. I would rather have been beaten every day for a year."

Verus stood up.

"Nothing has been forgiven," he said. "Do you understand me? Nothing has been forgiven. I have paid a man and I have closed a file, and those are not the same as forgiveness. Forgiveness is a thing that happens between two people who are still alive, and the boy is dead, and the only way you will ever be forgiven is to say it out loud in a public place and take what comes."

The room was very quiet.

"Say it out loud," Verianus said.

"You heard me."

"Say what you did."

Verus looked at his son. He was twenty, and he had his mother's eyes, and his mother had been dead for eleven years, and he had been raised by a woman who had married his father for money and had been kind to him in public and had not been alone in a room with him in seven years.

"I held the lamp," Verus said.

"What?"

"That is what I did," Verus said. "In the year 93, in this house, in the passage behind the kitchen. Your grandfather questioned a slave about a letter, and there was a rope, and I stood in the passage and held the lamp. And when it was over I untied her." His voice was

flat. “She was nineteen years old, and she could read, and she sang, and six months later your sister’s maid was born.”

Verianus’s face had gone the color of wax.

“Verianus.”

“Which slave?”

“Her name was Prima.”

“And where is she?”

“In a house on the Clivus Suburanus,” Verus said. “She is the most dangerous woman in Rome.”

❦

The council met at the palace on the Ides, in the small hall off the portico where the emperor worked when he was in Rome, and the emperor was not in Rome.

He was at Antium, or at Centumcellae, or on the road; the letter had said Antium. In his absence the council met anyway, because the machinery of the empire did not stop for the emperor’s holidays, and because a hundred questions a week came up from the provinces that required the opinion of men of standing.

There were eleven of them. There was the urban prefect, Petronius Celer, who was tired. There was the prefect of the guard, Acilius Attianus, who was said to know everything and who sat with his hands folded and said nothing. There was Neratius Priscus, the jurist, who was seventy and had the best mind in Rome and no ambition of any kind left. There was a young man from the emperor’s own staff, a Greek freedman called Haterius, who took the notes.

And there was a fourth chair along the table, which was the chair of a consular who was being considered for a province, and Verus had spent a week choosing the clothes he would wear to sit in it.

The first three hours were the provinces. A complaint from Bithynia about a road. A question from Africa about a boundary. A letter from Egypt about the Nile, which had risen generously, which

meant bread and taxes and no trouble, and the eleven men wrote a sentence of thanks to a river and moved on.

At the fourth hour, Attianus said, "There is the question of the Asian proconsulship."

The room changed. It always changed when the word *Asia* was said. Verus kept his hands still.

"The emperor has asked for three names," Attianus said. "The senate will send five, as usual, and the emperor will choose from the five, and he has asked that the five include no man who is currently under any —" he looked at his tablet — "*unresolved obligation to the fiscus.*"

There was a silence of the kind that follows a sentence that has been aimed.

"Meaning what?" said Celer.

"Meaning that the emperor is tired of appointing governors who arrive in a province with debts and leave it with a fortune," Attianus said. "He has said, in his own words, that a man who cannot govern his own household cannot govern a province. He said it in the presence of the empress and three of his staff, and Haterius has it written down."

Verus looked at the table. Six hundred thousand to the fiscus in three installments. The first had been paid in June, with money that had come from Caesennius Rufus as an advance on the dowry.

"Are there other names?" Celer said.

"There is Gallus," said Attianus.

"Gallus is in mourning."

"Gallus is in mourning and Gallus is a consular and Gallus has no debts and no province and no scandals, and a man in mourning is a man who can be presented to the senate as a man of gravity." Attianus turned a page. "There is also Verus."

Verus looked up. Every man at the table looked at him, with the particular courtesy of men who are deciding how much to spend on a funeral.

"Verus has been consul," Attianus said, "and has a name, and has a wife with money, and a son in the decemvirate. He also has a debt to the fiscus of four hundred thousand, and a daughter whose marriage contract is not yet signed, and —" he looked up — "a household that has been mentioned in a recent inquiry by the aediles."

The room did not move. The young Greek went on writing.

"There was a death," Attianus said, "of a young man of the Iunii, in a house in the Subura, on the last night of the Floralia. The aedile's office has written it as an accident. The prefect's office has taken an interest, because the house belongs to a woman of some note, and because a man called Oppius Nepos has made a representation to the prefect about the conduct of the woman's establishment."

"He has made a representation," Verus said. His voice was steady, which he was proud of. "About the woman."

"About the woman, and about the register of the city, and about certain irregularities in the manumission records of the fourteenth region, which nobody has ever looked at and which he seems to know a great deal about." Attianus looked at him. "You know him?"

"I know him as a man in the street knows a man at a window."

"Then you know him better than I do," Attianus said, and closed his tablet. "The list of five goes to the emperor in September. We will meet again before then. I would advise every man at this table to have no unresolved obligations, of any kind, by the Kalends."

He got up. The meeting broke. Men gathered their tablets and their cloaks and began the delicate work of leaving a room without appearing to be the first to leave it.

Verus was the last. He stood at the table with his tablet in his hand, and Attianus came back from the door.

"Cassius," he said.

"Prefect."

"The emperor likes you. He has said so, twice, in my hearing, and he is not a man who says such things often." Attianus's face was old and calm and entirely without comfort. "He likes you because you are a man who keeps his accounts and does not complain. That is the whole of what he asks of a senator. He does not ask that you be a good man; he has been emperor too long for that. He asks that you be a tidy one."

"I am tidy."

"Yes," Attianus said. "That is what I am afraid of."

He went out.

Verus stood alone in the small hall with the portraits of the emperors on the wall, and the light coming through the window, and the noise of the palace going on beyond the door.

He did not go home. He walked.

He walked down from the Palatine through the Forum, past the new basilica with its shops full of merchants, past the temple of Castor, past the place where the Rostra stood and where a boy had been spoken of for a quarter of an hour in May. He walked through the Subura because he did not admit to himself that he was walking there, and he came up the Clivus Suburanus in the late afternoon with the shopkeepers putting up their shutters and the smell of hot bread from the bakeries and the tanners beginning at the bottom of the hill.

The house was at the corner of a lane. The gilt was fresh, and there were no garlands on the door, and the doorkeeper was a big man with a club and a good cloak who looked at him without recognition, which was an insult he had not been prepared for.

"I am here to see the lady."

"Which lady?"

"Antonia Cassia."

"And you are?"

He opened his mouth to say his name, and found that he could not. Not in that lane, with a baker's boy watching and a litter going by and a woman with a basket of leeks stopping to look at a consular in a toga standing at that door.

"Tell her," he said, "that a man has come about a girl."

The doorkeeper looked at him for a moment. Then he turned and went in, and the door closed, and Verus stood in the street for a long time, and the light went off the top of the wall, and the lanterna were lit at the corner.

The door opened.

"He will see you," the doorkeeper said.

She received him in the garden, and she was not alone. There was an old woman with a face like a closed door sitting in the corner with a tablet, and there was a young woman standing by the fountain with her hands folded, who looked at him for a moment and then went out without being told.

"The girl," he said.

"Not that one," Antonia said. "That is Dessa. She was in the garden on the night of the Floralia, and she saw a man in the lane with a ring on his hand, and she is under my protection, and if you have come here to ask about her you may leave now."

"I have not come about her."

"Then sit down."

He sat. The old woman with the tablet did not move. The fountain ran. Antonia sat opposite him in a chair with a footstool, and she had her hair down, and she looked tired, and he found that he was looking at her hands.

"There will be a case," she said. "The praetor's court. In November, before the wedding season ends and after the harvest. I have the midwife, and I have the page, and I have the token, and I have found a man to assert her freedom. What I do not have is the thing without which the whole of it is a story."

"And what is that?"

"You," Antonia said. "In the court. Producing her as the slave you claim, and admitting that you claim her, and giving the court the thing it needs to hear from your own mouth."

He looked at her.

"You want me to stand in a public court and say that I own her."

"I want you to stand in a public court and say that you bought her, and that you have held her, and that you cannot produce the title under which you hold her, because there is no title, and there never was. And then I want you to stand down, and say nothing, and let the adsertor speak."

"And if I do not?"

"Then the case fails, and she stays in your house, and in September you sell her to a man in Formiae for twelve thousand sesterces, and you go to Asia with the dowry and the scandal is a scandal about a freedwoman's claim that she could not prove." Antonia looked at him. "And you will have won. And you will sit in the proconsul's chair in Ephesus, and every night for the rest of your life you will know exactly what you are."

The fountain ran.

"I have held her for eighteen years," Verus said. "I have fed her and clothed her and kept her from the men who would have bought

her, and there have been four. I have never raised a hand to her. I have never said a word to her that —"

"You have looked at her," Antonia said.

He stopped.

"You have looked at her," she said again, "in a room with the door shut, and you have said nothing, and she has stood there with her hands folded and waited for it to end. She has told me how many times. She has counted. Fifty-one times in thirteen years." Antonia's voice was very low. "Do you know what a girl learns, standing in a room while a man looks at her and says nothing? She learns that she is a thing. She learns that the only question is what kind of thing, and how much, and when. And she learns it from the man who is her father, and she does not know he is her father, so she thinks it is the world that does it, and she thinks it is normal, and she thinks that every girl in Rome stands in a room while a man looks at her."

"I never touched her."

"Fifty-one times," Antonia said.

"I never touched her."

"You held the lamp," she said.

The word went into him like a knife going in slowly.

He had been twenty-six.

He had been in the passage that night because his father had sent for him, and because he had come from a dinner with the woman who was going to be his wife, and because he had wanted to tell his father about the dinner. The house had been quiet in the way a house is quiet when everybody in it is awake.

There had been a lamp in his hand. There had been a rope on the beam. There had been a chair, and his father's voice, and the questions, and the clerk in the corner with the tablets, and the wo-

man on the board who was not screaming, which was the thing he could not bear, even now, eighteen years later: that she had not screamed.

She had answered the questions. She had answered them for eleven hours, and her voice had gone strange, and in the middle of it his father had said, *again*, and the man had done it again, and she had answered, and the answers had been what his father wanted, which was that his son had taken a folded paper from a man who was dead.

And at some point in the night, Verus had understood that his father had known, before he began, that the boy had taken the paper. That the whole of it was not a search for the truth; it was a demonstration. His father was showing him what the family cost, and what it was worth paying.

He had stood in the passage with the lamp in his hand and had not said a word.

And in the morning, when it was over, he had untied her himself.

❦

"I have thought about it every day," he said.

"I know."

"How do you know?"

"Because I have thought about it every day," Antonia said, "and men are not so different from women, whatever they tell themselves."

He looked at her. She was sitting with her hands in her lap and her hair down, and she had a scar on the back of her hand from a splash of hot oil, and she was the richest freedwoman in Rome, and she was the mother of the girl in his house.

"I will do it," he said.

She did not move.

"Say it properly," she said.

"I will produce her in the praetor's court. I will claim her as my slave. I will give the court no title. I will stand down." He swallowed. "And when it is over, I will sign the admission, and she will be freeborn from the day of her birth, and it will be recorded."

"Before the wedding."

"Before the wedding," he said, "and the wedding will happen, and the marriage contract will be honored, and Caesennius will have his bride, and my daughter will go to a house on the Caelian and be a rich woman, and no one will take her." He looked up. "That is the price. That is my price. The case, the girl's freedom, the admission, the scandal — all of it, and the wedding goes ahead."

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

"You are selling one daughter to save the other," she said.

"I am saving both."

"No," she said. "You are selling one to save the other, and you are calling it both, because you cannot say the thing you are doing." She stood. "I accept. The wedding will happen. I will be in your house in September, and I will stand in the room with the shrine, and I will eat your dinner, and I will watch your daughter be given to a man of fifty-four for a million sesterces, and I will not raise my voice, and I will not spoil it. And then, in November, I will take you into a court and pull your house down around you."

"You said you would not bring the rest of it."

"I said I would not bring the rest of it to a court if you freed her. I did not say I would not bring it to the senate, or to your wife, or to your son, or to the man who is going to be your son-in-law's cousin." Antonia's voice was steady. "I have spent eighteen years learning that the law is a slow and expensive way of doing what a well-informed woman can do in a week. The court is for the girl. The rest is for me."

Verus stood up. His hands were shaking.

"Then why should I do any of it?" he said. "Why should I stand in a court and ruin myself, if you are going to ruin me anyway?"

"Because the girl is your daughter," Antonia said, "and because there is one thing in you that is not the family and not the name and not the room, and I have seen it, twice, in eighteen years: once in the passage when you untied me, and once in your garden when you said you had loved her in the only way you were permitted." She stepped close to him. "You are a coward, Manius Cassius Verus, and a hypocrite, and a man who held the lamp. And you are the only person in that house who can give that girl her name back. So you will do it, and you will do it properly, and then you will go to Asia, or you will go nowhere, and either way you will have done one thing in your life that was not for the family."

He looked at her.

"And you?" he said. "What will you have?"

"My daughter," Antonia said. "For a start."

❦

He walked home. The lamps were lit along the Viminal and the shops were shut, and a girl was singing somewhere in a courtyard. He went in through the front door and the porter said something to him and he did not hear it.

The passage behind the kitchen was dark. There was a lamp on the wall, and he took it down, and he stood at the bottom of the back stairs with it in his hand.

The room next to the steward's had a door, and the door had a crack of light under it. He stood outside it for a long time with the lamp and did not knock.

He could hear her moving: a stool, a box being opened, the small noise of a person putting things away in the dark.

He thought: I will knock, and she will open it, and I will say, *I am your father.*

He thought: and she will look at me, and she will not say anything, because she has been trained not to say anything, and then she will shut the door.

He stood there for a long time.

Then he turned and went up the stairs with the lamp, and the light under the door went out behind him.

In the morning he sent for the family's advocate, and told him that a question of status was to be prepared for the praetor's court in November, and the advocate asked who the person was, and Verus said: a girl of my household, and no more.

PART THREE

THE WOUND

CHAPTER XIII

PRIMA

Rome, September, AD 93

The house of the Cassii had a garden with an old vine in it, and in the evening, when the sun had gone off the wall and the bees had stopped, the vine made a green shade that smelled of dust and sweetness, and it was the best place in Rome to sit if you were a slave with an hour to yourself.

Prima sat there most evenings. She was nineteen, and she was the ornatrix of the household, which meant that she dressed the hair of the mistress and the daughters and, on the days when the old lady was well enough, the old lady too. She had a good eye and a light hand and a memory for what a woman wanted to look like, and she had, in nine years, made herself necessary.

That was the whole of her position, and she knew it. She had been born in the room behind the kitchen to a woman whose name she was never told, and she had been put out to a nurse in the country at three days old, and brought back at six, and put in the kitchen, and told to keep out of the way. At eight she had been found reading a shopping list by the cook, who had said, *the girl can read, do not tell the master*, and had taught her sums. At twelve she had been taken into the household as a maid to the old lady's attendant, and had learned hair. At fifteen she had been given a room of her own behind the kitchen, which was more than any other slave in the house had, and a lamp, and a stool.

She had been proud of the room. She had been proud of the lamp.

The old lady was Cassia Severa, the mother of the household, and she was sixty-one and had a disease of the joints that had turned her hands into knots. She had been a beauty in the reign of Nero and she still dressed like one, and she had decided, for reasons of her own, that Prima was worth teaching. She taught her to read Latin properly, and to write a good hand, and to keep quiet when the men were talking, and to know the difference between a thing that was said to be heard and a thing that was said to be repeated.

"Women in this house," the old lady said once, "are either furniture or weather. Be weather."

Prima did not know what that meant, and thought about it for years afterward, and understood it at last when she was thirty and rich and had learned to keep every door in a house locked.

❦

The young master came home in the spring of that year from the army.

He had been away three years, on the Danube, as a tribune of a legion, and he came back brown and quiet with his hair cut short and a way of standing that made the room he was in seem smaller. He was twenty-six. His father met him in the atrium and embraced him and said, in front of the household, "You have come back a Roman," and the young master said, "I have come back," and the two of them looked at each other for a moment in a way that Prima, standing at the back with the other slaves, did not understand until much later.

She served him wine that night at dinner. He looked at her once, and she looked away, and that was all.

For a month it was all.

He walked in the garden in the evenings. She sat under the vine in the evenings. For a month they sat at opposite ends of the same garden and did not speak, and then one evening he said, "You are the one who reads."

"Yes, dominus."

"My mother says you read better than my sister."

"The lady is kind."

"The lady is not kind. The lady is accurate." He sat down on the bench, at the other end, with a distance between them that was almost a courtesy. "Do you read the poets?"

"I read what is in the house."

"Then you read the tax rolls and the household accounts."

"And the poets. When the steward throws them out."

The young master laughed. It was a good laugh, and it was surprised out of him, and it was the first time she had heard it.

That was the beginning. It went on for four months, and it was, for most of it, a thing of the garden and the lamp: he would come out in the evening and sit at the other end of the bench, and they would talk about the poets and the army and the family, and he would tell her things he had never told anyone, and she would listen the way she had been trained to listen, with her hands folded and her face attentive, and it was not entirely a lie.

By the fourth month it was not a bench with a distance on it. It was the two of them in the passage outside her room with the lamp on the wall, and his hands on her waist, and her hand flat on his chest, and the words he said into her hair, at night, in a voice that had nothing of the senate house in it.

She was not a fool. She had been in the household nine years and she knew what happened to a slave who was taken by the young master: she knew the three cases in the house's own history, and she knew

where two of the three women had gone. She knew that a man's affection was a room with a door and that the door was on his side.

And she was nineteen, and she was lonely in a way she had no words for, and she had been read to only twice in her life, and he read to her.

It lasted four months.

In the month of September, in the fourth month, a man came to the house at the eleventh hour with a folded paper and asked for the master, and was told that the master was at his villa at Tibur and would not be back till the morning, and said that he would wait, and waited in the tablinum with a cup of wine, and left before dawn, and on his way out through the passage behind the kitchen he met Prima.

He was a fat man with a good cloak and a ring with a horse on it, and he spoke to her pleasantly for a moment about the weather, and then he said, "You are the young master's girl."

"I am the lady's ornatrix."

"You are the young master's girl," he said, "and you should be careful, because the young master's father is a man who does not like to be surprised." He smiled. "I am a friend of the house. Tell the young master that Didius Probus left the paper on the table."

She told him. She told the young master in the garden the next evening, and he went white, and he went into the house, and he came back an hour later and said that it was nothing, that it was a business matter, that she was not to worry, and that she was not to speak of the man to anyone.

Two days later the young master came to her in the passage and took her by the arm, hard, and said, "What did you hear?"

"Nothing, dominus. I heard nothing."

"You were in the passage. You were there. What did you hear?"

"I heard a man say that your father does not like to be surprised, and I heard him laugh, and I heard him go out."

"That is all?"

"That is all."

He let go of her arm. His hands were shaking. He said, "If anyone asks you — anyone at all, my father, the steward, anyone — you say that you were in the kitchen, and you did not see the man, and you did not speak to him."

"Dominus."

"Say it."

"I was in the kitchen," she said. "I did not see the man. I did not speak to him."

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "I am sorry," and went away, and she stood in the passage with her hand on her arm where he had held her, and did not understand what she had just promised.

❦

The man Didius Probus was found dead in his bath nine days later, and the whole city said that he had drowned, and the whole city said it in the way Rome said things, which is to say that nobody believed it and everybody repeated it.

The old master came back from Tibur on the day the body was found. He came into the house at the fourth hour and shut himself in the tablinum with the young master and the steward, and they were in there for two hours, and when they came out the young master's face was grey.

Prima was in the passage. She was always in the passage; it was where the work was. And when the old master came out he stopped and looked at her, and she had been in the house nine years and she had never once been looked at by him in that way — not with desire, which she had learned to expect, but with the appraising look of a man who is deciding what a thing is worth.

"You," he said. "The ornatrix. Come here."

She came.

"You were in the passage," he said, "on the night the man Probus came to the house."

"Yes, dominus."

"Did you speak to him?"

"No, dominus."

"You did not speak to him."

"No, dominus."

The old man looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, "We shall see," and went into the atrium, and Prima stood in the passage and felt the floor go soft under her.

They came for her at the fourth hour of the morning, nine days later, when the house was asleep and the lamps had burned down, and they took her from her room behind the kitchen and along the passage to the small room at the back of the tablinum, where the steward kept the wine and where the walls were stone.

There were four of them. The old master stood by the window. The young master stood by the door with a lamp in his hand. There was a man with a rope, who was not a slave of the household and who did not give his name, and there was a clerk with tablets in the corner, who was old and had ink on his fingers and would not look at her.

"Prima," the old master said. "You are of this household, and you will answer what you are asked."

"Yes, dominus."

"Did you see the man Didius Probus in this house?"

"Yes, dominus."

"Did you speak to him?"

"Yes, dominus."

"What did he say to you?"

"He said that he was a friend of the house, and that the young master's father did not like to be surprised, and that the young master's girl should be careful."

The clerk wrote. The old master did not move his eyes from her face.

"And what did you say to the young master?"

"I told him what the man had said."

"And what did the young master say to you?"

"He said that it was a business matter and that I was not to speak of it."

"And what else did he say?"

"He said that if anyone asked me, I was to say that I was in the kitchen and had not seen the man."

The room was quiet. The young master's lamp shook, and the light moved on the wall.

The old master said, "Again."

"Dominus?"

"From the beginning," he said. "And this time, we will do it properly."

It went on for eleven hours.

They did not do it all at once. That was the thing she had not known, and would spend years trying to explain to people who had not been in the room: that it was not one long act but a series of them, with intervals, and in the intervals they gave her water and the clerk sharpened his pen and the old master sat down and read what had been written and said, "Again."

The man with the rope was not cruel. That was the other thing. He was a professional, and he worked carefully, and twice he stopped and said to the old master, "She will not last if we go on at that rate," and the old master said, "Then go slower."

And the young master stood by the door with the lamp in his hand.

He did not speak. Not once, in eleven hours. She looked at him the first time, and he looked away, and after that she did not look at him again, because there was a thing in his face that was worse than the rope, and she was nineteen years old and she understood, in the first hour, exactly what it meant: that he would not stop this, and that he would remember not stopping it, and that he would not be able to look at her again without remembering, and that this would be his reason, afterward, for everything he did.

Somewhere in the fifth hour she began to answer before they asked, which is a thing the body does, and the clerk wrote it down, and the old master said, "Good."

Somewhere in the eighth hour she heard herself say the young master's name, and heard the clerk write it, and heard the old master say, "Again," and she understood that he had known all of it before he began.

And in the eleventh hour, the old master said, "Enough," and the man with the rope untied her, and she fell off the board onto the floor, and lay there on the stone with her cheek against the cold, and the old master came and stood over her.

"You are a clever girl," he said. "You have been clever all night. That is why you are alive."

She looked up at him.

"If you had lied," he said, "I would have had you killed. Do you understand? A slave who lies in this house is a slave who will be sold to a man who will make her tell the truth, and then she will tell it in a market, and then it will be a story. But a slave who tells the truth is a slave who can be trusted with a silence." He knelt down beside her, and his voice was almost gentle. "You are going to be freed. Not because you have earned it. Because a freedwoman cannot be put to the question, and a freedwoman's word in a court is worth nothing,

and because a man who frees the witness has bought a silence that no one can accuse him of buying."

He stood up.

"Take her to the room behind the kitchen," he said, "and have the physician attend her, and tell my wife that the girl is to be manumitted before the Kalends of December, and that the reason is her long and faithful service."

The young master took a step forward, and the old master turned on him.

"You will not go to her," he said. "You will not speak to her. You will not look at her. You have done enough for this family in one month to last a lifetime, and if I hear that you have been in the passage behind the kitchen, I will send you to your uncle's estate in Africa and you will not come back."

The young master put the lamp down on the table. His hand was shaking so badly that the flame guttered.

Then he came and knelt on the stone floor beside her, and put his arms around her, and lifted her, and carried her along the passage to the room behind the kitchen, and set her down on the pallet, and sat with his back against the door until morning.

She remembered his hands. She remembered them for eighteen years.

The physician came at noon and put a salve on her back and told her that she would heal, and that the arm would not lift above the shoulder, and that she should not be surprised if the skin never sweated in that place again.

The old lady came in the afternoon, with her knots of hands folded, and stood in the door of the room and looked at her for a long time.

"You are going to be freed," she said.

"Yes, domina."

"My husband is a coward," the old lady said, "and my son is a coward, and I have lived in this house for forty years and I have been a coward too, and this is the one thing I can do." She looked at the room, at the pallet, at the jug, at the nail in the wall. "When you are free, you will have a name and a trade and nothing else. You will find that freedom is a room you have to pay for. Do not come back to this house."

"I have nowhere to go."

"Then find somewhere." The old lady put a small purse on the stool. "That is my own money. It is not from him. There are two hundred sesterces in it and it will keep you for a month if you are careful and a week if you are not. And Prima —" she stopped.

"Yes, domina?"

"Whatever he gives you, afterward, take it," the old lady said. "Take it and do not thank him. A man like my son will give you things for the rest of his life, and every one of them will be a payment, and if you refuse one he will think you are asking for something better."

She went out.

The manumission was done on the eleventh day before the Kalends of December, before the praetor, with the rod, in the company of the steward and two witnesses. The old lady paid the tax. The record was made, and Prima's name was written in it, and the name was the only thing that was given to her that day that she kept.

She found a room above a fuller's shop on the Aventine, for eleven sesterces a month, and she found work: hair, in three houses, for women who paid her by the visit and never asked her to stay for dinner. She was good at it. She had always been good at it.

The young master came in January.

He came at night, with a cloak and no slave, and stood in the lane below her window and would not go away, and she went down because a man standing in a lane looking at a window is a scandal and a scandal is a thing that closes doors.

"Antonia," he said.

"My name is Prima."

"Prima." He stood in the mud of the lane with his cloak pulled round him. "I have brought you money."

"I do not want your money."

"Take it."

"No."

"Then I will leave it on the step."

"And I will give it to the fuller's wife, and she will tell the whole street that the young master of the Cassii leaves money on the steps of houses at night."

He was silent for a moment. Then he laughed, and it was the laugh she remembered from the garden, and it was a terrible thing to hear in that lane.

"What do you want?" he said.

"I want to be left alone."

"That is a lie."

"It is not a lie."

"You sat in the garden with me for four months," he said. "You talked to me. You let me —"

"I was a slave," Prima said. "You were the young master. If I had told you to go away, what would you have done?"

He did not answer.

"Now I am free," she said, "and I am telling you to go away, and you are still standing in the lane."

He looked at her.

"I love you," he said.

"Do not," she said, and shut the door.

He came back in March. He came back in April and in May, and in June he came with a fever and she took him in because a man with a fever in a lane at night is a dead man, and because she had been nineteen in a garden and had not forgotten it, and because the room was small and the lamp was hers and the door was on her side of the room.

In July she knew.

She knew in the way that women know, and she sat on the bed in the room above the fuller's shop with her hand flat on her belly and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was a house on the Viminal and a man with a name and a girl with no name at all.

She did not tell him for a month. When she told him, in August, in the garden of a tavern on the Aventine where nobody knew either of them, he put down his cup and looked at her and said, "Are you certain?"

"Yes."

He was quiet for a long time.

"I will provide for it," he said.

"It."

"The child. I will find a house, and a nurse, and —"

"You will find a house," Prima said. "And a nurse. And the child will be a thing you provide for, and I will be a thing you provided for, and in ten years there will be a girl in a house somewhere who does not know her mother."

"That is not —"

"That is exactly what will happen. I have watched it happen in your father's house three times."

He looked at her. He was twenty-seven years old and he was going to be consul, and he had been raised in a room that smelled of

ink, and he had held a lamp for eleven hours, and his hands were shaking on the table.

"Then tell me what to do," he said.

She looked at him for a long moment.

"Marry me," she said.

He did not answer. He did not laugh, or look away, or make a speech. He sat in the garden of a tavern on the Aventine with his hands on the table and looked at her, and the silence went on, and in the silence she saw the whole of the rest of her life.

"A senator cannot marry a freedwoman," he said at last.

"No."

"Not even —"

"Not even," Prima said. "Not even if she is rich. Not even if she is respectable. Not even if she has borne him a child. It is not a rule, it is a law, and the law is not a wall, it is a floor. You can stand on it. You cannot go under it."

"Prima."

"Do not say my name like that."

"Then what?" he said. "What am I to do?"

She looked at him across the table.

"Nothing," she said. "You are to do nothing. You are to go to the senate house and be a Roman, and I am to go home and have this child, and you are to think about her every day for the rest of your life, and you are to be a man who thinks about her and does nothing, and that is what you are, and I have known it since the fourth month and I have been pretending otherwise because it was pleasant in the garden."

She got up and went out, and he did not follow her, and it was September, and the light on the Aventine was the color of old honey, and she walked home alone.

The birth was in the middle of the month, in the room above the fuller's, with a midwife from Ficulea called Iusta who had been recommended by the fuller's wife, and it took nine hours, and at the end of it there was a girl.

The midwife put her in Prima's arms and went to wash her hands, and Prima lay on the bed with the child against her chest and looked at her for a long time. She had a great deal of dark hair and a nose that was not anybody's yet, and a small crescent mark on the inside of her wrist, and her hand closed on Prima's finger and would not let go.

"You are not a thing," Prima said to her. "You are not a thing that a man provides for. You are a person, and your name is —"

She stopped. She had no name to give. A slave's child takes the mother's condition, and a freedwoman's child is free, and free people have three names and a family and a shrine and a record, and she had none of it; she had a room above a fuller's shop and a purse with two hundred sesterces and a name that had been written in a record in December.

"Your name is Cassia," she said, "because I have nothing else to give you, and a name is a thing that nobody can take away if you write it down."

She wrote it down. She wrote it on the back of a tablet, and she drew a door on the front of the tablet, and a wreath, and she took it to a man in the Subura who struck lead tokens for the dealers, and she paid him four sesterces to strike two halves of one token and break them across the middle.

The father came in November, and stood in the room with his hands at his sides and looked at the child in the cradle, and did not touch her.

"She is small," he said.

"She is three months old."

"She looks like my mother."

"She looks like a baby."

He sat down on the stool by the bed. He had brought a purse, and he put it on the table, and she did not look at it.

"I have found a house," he said.

"For what?"

"For the child. A nurse in the country, near Ficulea. A good woman. She will be well fed, and she will be taught, and when she is six she will be brought into the household."

Prima sat up.

"No."

"Prima —"

"She is not going into that house."

"She will be with me. She will be in the household, where I can see her, where I can —"

"Where you can see her," Prima said. "Where you can look at her across the garden and not say a word to her, and where she will grow up as a maid in her father's house and never know it, and where your wife will look at her every day and know what she is and never say it, and where she will be sold the moment you are dead or bored or need money for a consulship." She was shaking. "I have been in that house since I was six years old. I know exactly what happens to the girl in the passage. I was the girl in the passage."

"It will not be like that."

"It will be exactly like that."

He sat on the stool with his hands on his knees.

"Then what?" he said. "You cannot keep her. You have eleven sesterces a month for the room and no work while you are nursing and a child who will be four before you can leave her to go to a house and do a woman's hair. You will be on the street by the spring, and then you will be in a house worse than mine, and she

will be sold to whoever will take her, and I will not be able to stop it. You know that I am right."

She looked at him.

She knew that he was right. She had known it for three months, in the way that a woman knows the ice is thin, and she had been walking on it with the child in her arms and telling herself that the water was warm.

"What is the arrangement?" she said.

Her voice was flat. She had heard that voice in other women, in the house, and had never thought she would use it.

"The nurse in the country until she is six," he said. "Then the household. She will be a maid to my sister's daughter, when my sister has a daughter, and she will be brought up with her, and she will be taught to read and to keep accounts, and she will have a room and food and a trade. And when she is sixteen I will free her, and give her a dowry, and marry her to a freedman of the household, and she will be a free woman in Rome with a name and a trade, and nobody will ever know."

"And me?"

"You will have money," he said. "Every month. For the rest of your life. And you will be able to see her —"

"No."

"Prima —"

"No. If I see her, I will want her, and if I want her I will do something, and if I do something you will take her away where I cannot find her." She looked at the child in the cradle. "I would rather know where she is and not go. That is the arrangement. Those are my terms. I will not come to the house, I will not write, I will not stand at the corner, and you will bring me word once a year that she is alive and well, and you will give me your word on the thing you hold most sacred that you will free her at sixteen and give her a name."

Verus looked at her for a long time.

"I swear it," he said, "by the household gods of the Cassii."

"Then take her," Prima said.

He came for the child three days later, with the nurse, in a litter, at the sixth hour, when the lane was empty because the whole street was at dinner.

Prima wrapped her in the good blanket and put the token round her neck, and the door half in the cedar box, and she held her for a long time, and the child slept through all of it, and that was the worst thing: that the child slept.

"Her name is Cassia," she said. "Write it down. Not the name of the house. Her name."

"I will write it down."

"Say it."

"Cassia," he said.

He carried her down the stairs. Prima stood at the window and watched the litter go up the lane, and the fuller's wife came out into the yard and looked up at the window and then went back in, and the lane was empty, and it was November, and the light was going.

She stood at the window until it was dark.

Then she sat down on the floor with her back against the bed and her hand flat on the place where the child had been, and she did not get up for four days.

On the fifth day the fuller's wife came up and put a bowl of soup on the floor.

"You owe me for the week," she said. "Eleven for the room and four for the wood. If you cannot work you cannot stay, and if you

cannot stay you will be on the street, and a woman on the street in this city lasts about a year."

Prima looked at the bowl of soup.

"I can work," she said.

"Then eat, and come down, and wash."

She ate. She went down. She washed clothes for eleven hours a day for a year and a half, and her hands went red and then white and then hard, and she learned to keep accounts in her head while her arms were in the tub, and every month a slave from the house on the Viminal came with a purse and a single sentence: *she is well.*

Then in the year of the fire the fuller's wife died, and her son took the shop, and the son was a gambler, and by the spring Prima owed him eleven months' rent, and he sold the debt — and her with it — to a man in the Subura called Cominius Asiaticus, who kept a house on the Aventine and did not care that she was free, because a freedwoman with a debt and no patron was, in practice, a thing that could be sold.

She was in that house for two years.

She was twenty-two when Gaius Antonius Felix came into it, and twenty-three when he paid her debt, and twenty-six when he died and left her everything, and thirty-nine when she stood in the Hall of the Decemvirs and told a praetor of Rome what had been done to her in the passage behind the kitchen of the house of the Cassii.

But that is another chapter, and this one ends where it began: with a girl of nineteen sitting under a vine in a garden in the evening, with a lamp in her hand and a book in her lap and her whole life in front of her, thinking that she was necessary, and that necessity was the same thing as safety, and that a man who reads to you in a garden is a man who will not destroy you.

She was wrong about all of it, and it took her eighteen years and a fortune to be wrong in comfort.

CHAPTER XIV

THE GIRL WHO RAN

The road to Ostia, July, AD 112

The cart left the Porta Ostiensis at the fourth hour with a load of wool and two passengers, and Dessa sat at the back with her knees drawn up and watched the city go away from her one wall at a time.

She had not been outside the walls in six years. She had forgotten that the country made a sound. In the city there was always a noise, but it was a noise made of people, and the country made a noise out of things: wind in poplars, a dog barking three farms away, water going over stones, the creak of the cart, the wool shifting.

Tullia had put her in the cart with a purse and a letter and a cloak, and had said, "You are to be at the warehouse of Gaius Calpurnius Daphnus before dark, and you are to give him the letter, and you are not to speak to anyone on the road."

"And if the cart is stopped?"

"Then you are the niece of the fuller's wife, going to Ostia to nurse a sick aunt, and you have never heard of any house on the Clivus." Tullia had looked at her for a moment. "And Dessa. Do not run."

"I am not going to run."

"I know you are not. I am telling you so that you will remember that I told you." Tullia had adjusted the cloak, and her hands had been gentle, and her face had not. "The mistress has done a great many hard things in her life and she has done them in a particular order, and the order has always been the house first, and the women

second, and herself last. It is not the same as kindness. But it is not nothing."

"I know what it is," Dessa had said.

"Then you know more than most of the people who work for her."



She had come from a village in the mountains, and she could not remember its name.

She had tried, in the first year. She had lain on a pallet in a stranger's house and said the name over and over to herself, and it had been there, and then it had been a shape, and then it had been a sound, and then one morning she had reached for it and it was gone, the way a road is gone when the snow comes.

She remembered the road to the village. She remembered that it went up, and that there was a stream on the left, and that in the spring the stream was full of snowmelt and the noise of it was the first thing you heard in the morning. She remembered the house: one room and a byre, with the animals in the byre in the winter and the door open in the summer. She remembered her mother's hands, which were large, and her brother, who was older, and who was called something that began with a D, or a V, or a B.

She remembered the soldiers.

They had come in the last year of the war, in the autumn, in the morning, and there had been eleven of them on horses and forty on foot, and the village had not fought, because the village had no men in it; the men had gone to the fortress in the spring and had not come back.

She had been fourteen. She had been in the byre with the goat, and she had heard the noise, and she had stayed in the byre because she was fourteen and frightened of men on horses. And then a man had come into the byre and taken her by the arm, and she had bitten

him, and he had hit her, and the rest of it she remembered in pieces: the rope on her wrists, the line of people, the smell of the horses, a woman screaming in a language she knew, the fort, the fort, the fort, and then the sea.

She had been sold three times since. The first man had taught her to carry water, the second to be quiet, the third to count. She had learned that last thing well, and it had made her worth twelve thousand sesterces, and it had brought her to a house in the Subura where a woman with grey at her temples had given her a cloak and a knife.

The warehouse of Gaius Calpurnius Daphnus smelled of wheat and rats.

Daphnus read the letter twice, and then he looked at her for a long time, and then he said, "You are the one who can count."

"Yes."

"Show me." He pushed a tablet across the table. "That is the last four days of the Egyptian wheat. There are eighty-one entries. Tell me whether the third column totals."

She did it in her head while he watched, and it took her a little less than the time it takes to boil an egg.

"It totals," she said, "but the fourth entry on the second day is wrong. It says forty modii and the price is for sixty."

Daphnus picked up the tablet and looked at it and put it down.

"The clerk will be sorry to hear it," he said. "He has been with me nine years and he has been stealing from me for two, and I have known it, and I have not been able to prove it, because I cannot add a column faster than he can." He looked at her. "What is your name?"

"Dessa."

"Dessa. You are going to stay in the room over the office, and you are going to keep the books for me until the autumn, and in return I will teach you the shipping trade, which is the only trade in the world that is honest, because a ship either arrives or it does not." He stood up. "There are rules. You do not go out of the yard. You do not go down to the harbor. If a man comes to the gate asking after a woman from Rome, I am the only person you speak to. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Say it back to me."

"I do not go out of the yard, I do not go to the harbor, and if a man comes asking, I say nothing and I fetch you."

"Good." Daphnus went to the door and stopped. "There is one more thing. You are not the first person who has been hidden in this warehouse by that woman, and I have never lost one yet, and I intend to keep the record."

❦

The room over the office had a window with a shutter and a view of a wall and a bed with a straw mattress, and it was, by a considerable distance, the best room Dessa had ever slept in alone.

She kept the books. She was good at it. She found the clerk's two years of theft in four days, and Daphnus dismissed him with a written statement and a threat and no prosecution, and the man went away with his box and his cloak and a face like a closed door.

She ate with the porters. She learned the names of the ships and the names of the shippers, and the difference between a manifest and a bill of lading, and why a ship that was listed as carrying wine and had a shallow draught was a ship that was carrying something else. She learned the tides. She learned that the grain fleet came in twice a year and that the whole town lived from it and that in the

months between, half of Ostia was in debt and the other half was in the courts.

And every evening, when the work was done, she went up to the room and stood at the window and looked at the wall, and beyond the wall there was a lane, and beyond the lane the harbor, and beyond the harbor the sea, and beyond the sea, three weeks' walk and two provinces away, there was a road that went up, with a stream on the left, and a village whose name she could not remember.

On the eleventh day she went out of the yard.

She told herself that she was going to the baker, and she did go to the baker, and she bought bread, and she came back, and nobody said anything. On the twelfth day she went to the baker and then to the corner of the lane, and looked at the harbor. On the thirteenth day she walked to the corner and stood for a moment where she could see the water.

That was where the man saw her.

He was a small man with a stick and a dog, and the dog was a big one, brindled, with a scarred muzzle, and it sat at the end of its rope and looked at her with the flat attention of a thing that has been trained to look at people that way. The man looked at her too, and then at the yard, and then at the water, and then he came over.

"You are new," he said.

"I am nobody's."

"Everybody is somebody's." He smiled. He had four teeth. "What house?"

"I am a free woman."

"A free woman with the mark of a collar on her neck." He nodded at her throat, where the lead token hung on its cord, and where the skin under it had a band of pale, unweathered flesh. "That is a collar mark, that is. Six years, I should say. Maybe more."

Her heart was going. She had been trained, in three houses, in what to say to such a man, and the training had gone out of her head entirely.

"I am a freedwoman," she said, "of the house of Gaius Calpurnius Daphnus, and he is at the warehouse, and if you come to the gate he will show you the papers."

"Papers," the man said. "Papers are a wonderful thing." He looked at the yard, at the gate, at the porters unloading a cart. "And what is your name, lady?"

"Dessa."

"Dessa," he said, and wrote something on the inside of his hand with his thumbnail, which is a thing men do who cannot write. "Dessa. And where were you before the house of Gaius Calpurnius Daphnus?"

She did not answer.

"That is what I thought," he said. "You have a good evening, lady."

He went away up the lane with the dog, and she stood at the corner with the bread in her arms and her hands shaking so badly that she dropped it.

She did not tell Daphnus. That was the first mistake, and she knew it was a mistake while she was making it, and she made it anyway, because Daphnus would have written to Rome and the woman on the Clivus would have come, or sent, or ordered her moved again, and Dessa had been moved six times in six years and she had begun to understand that being moved was a thing that happened to property.

She told herself that the man with the dog was nothing. Men with dogs stood at corners in every port in the world. She told herself that she was a freedwoman of the house of Daphnus, and that

Daphnus would speak for her, and that a man who came to the gate would be sent away.

On the third night after that, she woke at the second hour because the yard was quiet in a way it should not have been, and she got up and went to the window, and there were three men in the yard and the gate was open.

She had the knife. She had had it since March, and she had kept it under the mattress, and she took it now and put it in the waistband of her tunic, and she went down the back stairs into the yard, and the yard had a wall on three sides and a gate on the fourth, and the gate had three men in it.

"There she is," said the small man with the dog.

The big one came across the yard. He was not fast and he was not slow; he came the way a man comes when he has done this a great many times and has never yet been stopped by anything a woman could do. She got the knife out and held it, and he stopped, and laughed, and then he took a stick from his belt.

"Put it down," he said, "and you will not be marked."

She did not put it down. She had been fourteen in a byre and she had bitten a man's hand, and she had been fourteen for a long time since.

He hit her across the wrist with the stick, and the knife went out of her hand and skittered across the yard, and then he had her by the hair and her feet were off the ground, and the dog was barking, and the small man was saying, "Careful, careful, she is worth twelve if she is worth a sesterce."

And then there was a light in the doorway, and Daphnus was standing there with a lamp in one hand and an iron bar in the other, and behind him the two porters with their hooks.

"Put her down," Daphnus said.

The big man put her down. She fell on the cobbles and rolled and got to her feet, and her wrist was already swelling, and the port-

ers were on either side of Daphnus with their hooks, and it was four men against three and the three were not paid enough to die in a yard in Ostia.

"This is a fugitive," said the small man. "There is a reward."

"Whose slave?"

"That is my business."

"Then go and do your business at the office of the duumvir in the morning," Daphnus said, "with papers, and a claim, and the name of the owner, and I will bring the woman and the ledger and my own freedman's papers, and we will see what the duumvir says about three men who broke a gate in the night."

The small man looked at him for a long moment.

"There is a man in Rome who wants this girl," he said.

"Then the man in Rome may come himself," Daphnus said, "and he may bring a warrant, and he may explain to the duumvir of Ostia why a freedwoman of my household is worth twelve thousand sesterces to a man who is not her owner." He raised the bar. "Get out of my yard."

They got out. The big man went last, and he looked at Dessa as he went, and it was not a look of anger. It was a look of calculation, and it was worse.

Daphnus shut the gate and barred it, and put the bar down, and stood in the yard in his night-shirt with the lamp, and he was shaking.

"Inside," he said. "Now."

He was not angry. That was the worst of it. He sat her down at the table in the office and put the lamp between them and looked at her, and he said, "Tell me."

She told him. She told him about the man with the dog at the corner, and about the three nights, and about how she had not told

him because she had been moved six times and had learned not to be a thing that caused trouble.

Daphnus listened. When she had finished, he got up and went to the strongbox and took out a purse, and put it on the table.

"There is a ship," he said. "The Isis, out of Alexandria. She sails for Massilia in three days with a cargo of grain and hides. The master is a man called Serapion, and he owes me eleven thousand sesterces, and he will take a passenger to Massilia and from there to Narbo and from there, if you are clever and you keep your mouth shut, up the Rhone and across to the Danube road. It is eight hundred miles. It will take you four months, and it will cost everything in that purse and everything I can put in it besides, and you will be in a country where nobody speaks Latin and the men are not Romans and the roads are worse."

Dessa looked at the purse.

"Why?" she said.

"Because you are worth twelve thousand sesterces to someone," Daphnus said, "and I have been in this town thirty years and I know what happens to a thing that is worth twelve thousand sesterces to a man who has decided he wants it. The law is a slow horse in Ostia, and a fast one in Rome. So you will go, and I will write to the woman, and she will be angry with me, and I will tell her that I made a judgment, and she will tell me that I had no right to make a judgment, and we will have an argument, and it will be a fine argument and I shall enjoy it."

"He will come back."

"He will come back, and he will find an empty room and a man who is very sorry and a duumvir who has been paid to be sorry in the right direction." Daphnus pushed the purse across the table. "Take it."

She took it. She was not crying. She had not cried in six years, and she did not intend to start in an office in Ostia with a man in a night-shirt looking at her.

"There is one thing," she said. "The knife. It is in the yard."

"I will find it in the morning."

"No." She stood up. "I am going to find it now."

She went out into the yard. The moon was behind the wall and the cobbles were wet, and she got down on her hands and knees and felt along the ground by the gate for a long time, and at last her fingers found the wooden handle, and she picked it up and put it in her waistband and stood in the yard with her hand on it.

Then she went up to the room and packed the cloak and the bread and the letter, and lay down on the bed with the knife under the pillow, and did not sleep.

❦

The ship sailed on the third day at the second hour, and Dessa was not on it.

She had gone down to the harbor at dawn with the purse in her belt and the cloak over her arm, and she had walked along the quay to the berth where the Isis lay, and she had stood at the foot of the gangplank and looked at the ship.

It was a merchantman, broad and dirty, with a cargo of grain in sacks and hides in bales and a crew of nine men who were, at that hour, sitting on the deck eating and spitting into the harbor. The master was a fat Greek with a beard, and he looked at her the way a man looks at a passenger he has been paid to carry and has not been paid enough for.

"Massilia," he said. "Twenty days if the wind holds, forty if it does not. You will sleep on the deck and eat what the crew eats and you will not complain, and if a pirate comes you will go below with the others and you will not scream."

"I will not scream."

"Good." He looked at her for a moment. "You are the girl from the warehouse."

"Yes."

"He said you could count."

"Yes."

"Can you count the sacks in a hold?"

"Yes."

"Then you can count them on the deck," the Greek said, "and I will pay you four sesterces a day and you will earn your passage like everybody else."

She stood at the foot of the gangplank for a long time.

Then she said, "I have to go back."

The Greek shrugged. It was not his business. He had a cargo and a passenger and a wind, and one of them had changed her mind, and there would be another one.

❦

She went back along the quay and up the lane to the warehouse, and Daphnus was in the yard with the porters and he stopped when he saw her.

"The ship," he said.

"I am not going."

"Why?"

She stood in the yard with the purse in her belt and the cloak over her arm, and the sun was coming up over the roofs of Ostia, and she was twenty years old, and she had been a slave for six years, and she had spent three days deciding, and she had decided in the middle of the night, in the dark, with the knife under the pillow.

"Because if I get on that ship," she said, "I am a thing that is being moved in the night. And I have been moved in the night six times. And the woman in Rome is a hard woman and she has done

hard things, and she has lied for me and she has lost her house for a girl who is not her daughter, and she gave me a knife and a room and told me the truth about the arithmetic. And if I run, they will say that a slave ran, and they will say that everything she said about the girl was a lie told by a woman who could not keep her own household, and the case will fail, and the girl will be sold, and it will be my fault."

Daphnus looked at her for a long moment.

"You would be alive," he said.

"I would be alive," Dessa said, "and I would be the girl who ran."

The men came in the afternoon, with the duumvir's clerk and four of the town watch, and they had papers.

The papers said that a slave woman named Dessa, of the household of Cominius Asiaticus, deceased, had been sold to a buyer in Rome and had absconded from that buyer's service, and that a reward of five hundred sesterces was offered for her recovery by the procurator of the estate. The duumvir's clerk read them out in the yard with the porters standing in a line and Daphnus beside him, and the papers had a seal on them, and the seal was the seal of the office of the urban prefect.

"This is a forgery," Daphnus said.

"The seal is genuine," the clerk said.

"The seal is genuine and the paper is a forgery. There is no estate of Cominius Asiaticus. He has been dead eighteen years."

"Then it is a matter for the courts," the clerk said, "and the woman will be held at the town's expense until the courts have decided, and you may bring your own papers, and your freedman's papers, and your witnesses, and it will be heard at the next assizes, which is in October."

"October."

"October," the clerk said. "Unless the buyer's procurator withdraws the claim."

Daphnus looked at the papers and then at Dessa, and his face was the face of a man who has been in business thirty years and has just discovered that he has been playing a game whose rules he did not know.

"I will write to Rome today," he said.

"By all means," the clerk said, and took Dessa by the arm.

❦

The cell was under the town's forum, in a row of three, and the other two were empty, and it had a stone bench and a drain and a window at the level of the street, so that she could hear the feet of the people going past.

She was there for four days. The clerk's man brought bread and water twice a day. Nobody asked her anything. On the second day she heard Daphnus in the passage outside, arguing with the clerk, and then he was gone.

On the fourth day the door opened and a man came in with a lamp and set it on the bench, and sat down on the other end of the bench, and said, "You are Dessa."

He was a well-dressed man of about forty with an old burn on the back of his right hand, between the thumb and the first finger.

"Yes."

"You were in the house on the Clivus on the night of the Floralia."

She did not answer.

"You were in the garden," the man said, "and you found the body, and you put your hands in the water. And then the woman told the aedile's office that you had been sold to Africa in the Ides of March." He smiled. "I have been looking for you for three months."

"Who are you?"

"My name is Felix," he said. "I work for the prefect's office. Not for the prefect — for the office. There is a difference, and it is the difference between a man who is paid to keep order and a man who is paid to know things."

"What do you want?"

"Nothing at all," Felix said. "I am here to tell you something, and then I am going to leave you alone, and you will think about it for a night, and in the morning you will tell me which you prefer."

He leaned forward.

"The woman on the Clivus has sold you," he said. "Not to Africa — that was a fiction, and a good one. To a man in Rome, for four thousand sesterces, the day before she sent you to Ostia, because a witness is a liability and a liability is a thing that can be turned into money. I have the bill of sale. It is in the papers I showed the duumvir: a slave named Dessa, sold by the house on the Clivus to a procurator, five hundred reward. You were sold twice, girl. Once to Africa in the register, and once in fact, in a bill of sale with a seal on it, and you walked onto the cart that took you to Ostia thinking you were being hidden."

Dessa sat on the stone bench with her hands in her lap. She had known it in the yard. She had known it when Daphnus's face had changed. She had known it, and she had gone back anyway, and she had thought that she was choosing to be brave, and she had been choosing to do exactly what the woman on the Clivus had told her to do.

"The bill of sale is a forgery," she said.

"Of course it is." Felix smiled. "That is not the question. The question is what a court will believe, and a court will believe a sealed paper from the prefect's office before it believes a freedwoman on the Clivus and a shipper from Ostia with a grudge and a slave who cannot testify without the rod." He stood up. "There are two ways out of this cell. In one of them, you are a runaway slave with a

forged bill of sale against you and a woman in Rome who has already sold you once, and you will be questioned under the rod about what you saw in that garden, and the questioning will last as long as the magistrate wants it to last, and when it is over you will be sold to whoever will take a girl with a ruined hand."

"And the other way?"

"The other way," Felix said, "is that you tell me what you saw, in your own words, in front of a clerk, and I take you out of this cell myself, tonight, and put you on a ship, and give you papers that say you are a freedwoman of the household of Gaius Oppius Nepos, and four thousand sesterces, and a letter to a man in Massilia who will find you work." He picked up the lamp. "The woman on the Clivus will be closed, and her book will be taken, and there will be a scandal, and the scandal will be about her and not about you. That is what my master wants. He does not want you. He has never wanted you. He wants the book, and he wants her closed, and you are the key to the door."

Dessa looked at the lamp in his hand.

"Think about it," Felix said. "I will come in the morning."

He went out. The door shut. The lamplight went out of the crack under the door, and the cell was dark, and somewhere above her the feet of Ostia went past on the pavement, and beyond the wall the sea made its noise.

She sat on the stone bench with her hands in her lap and thought about a woman with grey at her temples who had said, *I am going to have to live inside it*, and about a knife with a wooden handle under a pillow in a room over an office, and about the two ways out of the cell.

Then she lay down on the stone bench and put her arm over her eyes and did the arithmetic, because she was good at arithmetic, and arithmetic was the only thing that had ever been hers.

In one way she was free and the woman was closed and the girl in the great house was sold in September and the case never happened.

In the other way she was a runaway slave in a cell in Ostia, and the woman on the Clivus was looking for her, and there was a knife with a wooden handle in a room over an office, and a knife is a small thing, but it is not nothing.

She made her choice before the light came, and it was the same choice she had made in the yard, and she was going to have to make it again and again, every day, for the rest of her life, and she did not know that yet.

CHAPTER XV

A QUESTION OF STATUS

Rome, August, AD 112

The house of Neratius Priscus stood on the Quirinal in a street so quiet that the loudest thing in it was the fountain in the courtyard, and the fountain had been turned off because the old man said the noise made him lose his thread.

He was seventy and he had been consul twice and he had refused a third consulship and a province and, it was said, a marriage into the imperial family, on the grounds that he was happier with his books. He had written nine volumes on the law and was at work on a tenth, and he had a face like a tortoise and the manners of a man who has decided, at some point in his sixties, that he no longer had to be polite to anybody.

"Sit down," he said. "Not there. There. That chair has the light behind it and I want to see your face."

Antonia sat in the chair.

"You want a causa liberalis," he said.

"Yes."

"For a girl of eighteen in the house of Cassius Verus."

"Yes."

"And you are the mother."

"Yes."

"Then you are either a very brave woman or a very foolish one, and I have been in this profession for fifty years and I have never been able to tell the difference until the verdict." He poured wine

with a steady hand, and did not offer her any. "Tell me what you have."

She told him. She told him about the manumission and the birth, the token, Bassa's page, the note in Verus's hand, the midwife at Ficulea, and the register that said Dessa was in Africa and Myrtale did not exist.

The old man listened with his eyes closed. When she had finished he did not open them.

"The law," he said, "is simple, and it is not simple. The simple part is this: a child born to a free mother is free. It does not matter that the mother was a slave when the child was conceived. It does not matter that the mother had been freed for one day. It does not matter that the father is a senator and the mother a freedwoman and the child was sold at three months like a lamb. If the mother was free at the birth, the child is freeborn, and any man who holds her is holding a free person, and that is not a private matter between him and his household; it is a public crime under the lex Fabia." He opened his eyes. "That is the simple part. Do you want the rest?"

"Yes."

"The rest is that the law does not come and find you. The law sits in a room and waits for someone to bring it a case. And to bring it, you need a man."

"The adsertor."

"The adsertor libertatis. A free man, of good standing, who stands up in court and says: this person is free, and I claim it, and I will answer for the claim. He is not her advocate. He is not her friend. He is a man who stakes himself. If the court finds against him, he pays a penalty to the master, and it is not a small penalty, and worse than the penalty is the fact that he has been publicly wrong about a question of status, which in this city is worse than being wrong about money."

"How much is the penalty?"

"The old law says fifty asses. The praetor's edict says the value of the person claimed, which in this case would be twelve thousand sesterces, and the value of the trouble, which would be whatever the praetor decides it is worth." Priscus turned his cup. "And there is a second risk, which nobody will tell you and which I will, because I am old and I have no career left to lose. The adsertor must be a man whose own status is beyond question. A freedman cannot do it. A man with a stain cannot do it. And a man who does it for a woman he is known to be connected with will be asked, in open court, why he is doing it, and the answer will be that he is doing it for her, and then the case is not about the girl anymore. It is about you."

"I have understood that."

"Have you? Let me be plainer." The old man set his cup down. "You are a freedwoman. You have been free for nineteen years and you have a fortune and a house and a name that the city uses, and none of it matters, because the one question a Roman court asks about a freedwoman is not whether she is rich. It is whether she is respectable. And respectability in a woman is not a thing she owns. It is a thing that other people lend her, and they can call in the loan at any time, for any reason, and once it is called in, it is not a matter of money. It is a matter of the street, and the street does not forget."

"You are telling me not to do it."

"I am telling you what it will cost. Whether it is worth the cost is not a question for a jurist." Priscus smiled, and his smile was surprisingly kind. "I will tell you what I would do, if I were you, and then I will tell you what you will do, and you may compare them."

"Very well."

"If I were you, I would do nothing. I would send the girl money, if I could send it without being seen. I would wait until Verus is in Asia, and then I would buy her from his steward, quietly, through three men, for fifteen thousand, and free her in my own house with two witnesses and no court. It would take two years and it would

cost a little more and it would work, and nobody would ever know, and the girl would have her freedom and you would have your daughter and the world would be exactly as unjust as it was the day before."

"That is what you would do."

"That is what I would do." Priscus looked at her. "And you will not do it, because you are not a jurist, and because the girl has a token around her neck and a man has been looking at her across a tablinum fifty-one times, and because a thing that is done quietly is a thing that was never done at all."

Antonia looked at him.

"Will you be my adsertor?" she said.

The old man laughed. It was a dry, delighted, entirely unkind laugh.

"No," he said. "I am seventy years old and I have a book to finish and I have not stood in a court in eleven years. But I will tell you who will. There is a man called Lucius Iunius Gallus, who is a consular, and who has no debts, and no stains, and no fear of Verus, and who is in mourning for a son and has recently discovered that grief makes him reckless." He picked up his cup again. "I have known him since he was a boy. He is a good man with a shallow river in him, and he will say yes before you have finished the sentence, and you will spend the rest of the case wishing he had said no."

❦

Gallus said yes before she had finished the sentence.

They were in the garden of the house on the Caelian, in the heat of the afternoon, with the bees in the roses and the aqueduct going over the wall like a row of arches built by giants. He had put on weight since the funeral, and his eyes had a flat look, and he drank more than he had.

"Say it again," he said.

"I need a free man of good standing to assert the freedom of a girl in the house of Cassius Verus. The case will be heard in November, before the praetor, with the decemvirs. If we win, she is free and the record is corrected. If we lose, you pay the value of the girl and you are wrong in public."

"I will do it."

"Lucius."

"I will do it," Gallus said, "and I will tell you why, and you will not like it." He turned and walked to the end of the garden and came back. "Because it is the house of Cassius Verus. Because a boy died in your garden and his son was there and his father came to my son's funeral in the correct clothes and said the correct words. Because a man came to me in June and told me that my son was killed by a push in a garden and that the man who did it was the son of a consular, and that the whole city knew it and nobody would say it."

Antonia stood very still.

"Who came to you?"

"Oppius Nepos."

"Nepos is a liar."

"Nepos is a liar and Nepos is a man who sells information, and a man who sells information sometimes sells true information, because a merchant who only sells false goods does not stay in business." Gallus stopped in front of her. "I have thought about it for two months. I have gone over it every night. I have written it out. And I have come to this: I do not know whether Manius Verus's son killed my son. But I know that the man who held the lamp in a room in the year 93 is the same man, and I know that a man who can stand in a passage for eleven hours and say nothing can stand in a garden and say nothing, and I have decided that I will spend the rest of my life making his life as difficult as it can be made, in every lawful way, in every court in Rome."

"That is not justice."

"No," Gallus said. "It is grief, wearing justice's coat. I am aware of the difference. I am a consular; I have been aware of the difference all my life." He took her hand. "I will be your adsertor. I will stand up in the praetor's court and say that a girl is free because her mother was free when she was born, and I will do it because her father is the man I intend to ruin. And I will do it honestly, because the law is the law and the girl is free, and I have read the papers."

Antonia looked at his hand on hers.

"There is a thing I have not told you," she said.

"There always is."

"The night of the Floralia. I have not told you all of it."

Gallus's face did not change.

"Then tell me now," he said, "before I stand up in a court and swear an oath on your behalf."

"Your son was in my garden at the sixth hour. He was not alone." Antonia's voice was steady. "There was a man in the lane with a ring on his hand. My slave saw him. He was tall, and he stood with his hands behind his back, and he went away down the hill when she screamed. And in the morning I found that Verianus had left the house at the fourth hour and had not come back, and that his father had given him a ring in May."

Gallus let go of her hand.

"You are telling me," he said slowly, "that the son of Manius Verus was in the lane outside your house on the night my son died."

"I am telling you that a tall man with a gold ring was in the lane. I do not know that it was Verianus. I know that Verianus had the ring, because his father told me, in his own garden, in May."

"His father told you."

"Yes."

"Why would he tell you that?"

Antonia looked at him.

"Because I asked him where his ring was," she said, "and because he is a man who has spent eighteen years discovering that the truth is easier to say to a woman who already knows it."

❦

Acilia Marcella came to the house on the Clivus on the Ides of August, at the ninth hour, in a plain litter with one slave and no escort, and stood in the atrium looking at the mosaic with an expression Antonia had never seen on her before.

"It is a door within a door," she said.

"It is."

"Who chose it?"

"Nobody chose it. The mosaic was here when I bought the house, under three layers of dirt and a bad repair. I had it cleaned because a customer had slipped on the repair and threatened to sue me." Antonia came and stood beside her. "My man took off the top layer with a chisel, and there it was. I have never changed it. I have thought about changing it a hundred times and I have never done it."

"Why not?"

"Because a door within a door is a very good description of my life," Antonia said, "and because the man who laid it was probably a freedman himself, and it is the only thing in this house that I did not buy."

Marcella looked at the mosaic for a moment longer.

"I have brought you something," she said, and took from her sleeve a small purse and put it on the table. "There is twenty thousand sesterces in that. It is my own money; it is not my husband's, and it is not from the dowry. I have been saving it for eleven years against the day my husband's house fell down, and I find that I would rather spend it on this than on a house in Puteoli."

Antonia looked at the purse.

"Why?"

"Because a case costs money. There is the adsertor's fee, and the praetor's clerk, and the copies, and the witnesses' time, and the man at Ficulea who will want his roof repaired before he will come to Rome and stand up in a court. I have been the wife of a great house for nine years. I know what a case costs." Marcella pushed the purse across the table. "Take it. Do not thank me. If you thank me I shall cry, and I have not cried in nine years and I do not intend to begin in your atrium."

Antonia took the purse.

"There is a condition," Marcella said.

"There always is."

"When it is over, and the girl is free, I want her out of that house within a week. Not because I do not want her there. Because a freedwoman in the house of the man who kept her is a thing that the whole city will talk about for a year, and she will hear every word of it, and she will be a scandal before she is a person." Marcella's voice was steady. "She will need a place. Not this house. A respectable house, with a respectable woman in it, where she can learn a trade and be somebody's freedwoman and not a story."

"Kallisto wants a house on the Aventine."

"Kallisto is a singer with a temper and a patron in Puteoli."

"Kallisto is a singer with a temper, a patron in Puteoli, and four hundred thousand sesterces that I am going to give her in the spring, and she will need a respectable woman in her house to keep her respectable, and she will hate it, and it will work." Antonia put the purse in her own sleeve. "I will arrange it."

Marcella nodded. Then she said, "The wedding is on the fourth day before the Kalends of September."

"I know."

"You will come."

"I said I would."

"My husband has told the household that you are not to be spoken to. He has told my stepdaughter that you are a woman of no consequence. He has told his son that if you are seen at the wedding, there will be trouble." Marcella's mouth was thin. "He is afraid of you, and a frightened man makes rules, and the rules are the only power he has left. Do not break them. Come in at the side gate with the women, sit where I put you, and do not speak to him, and if he speaks to you, answer him in one sentence and then look away."

"That is not my way."

"I know it is not your way. It is my house, and it is my stepdaughter's wedding, and I am asking." Marcella looked at her. "Do you know what the slaves are calling you?"

"No."

"The mother of the house." Marcella's voice was strange. "They are calling you that. Not to your face. In the kitchen. The cook started it and the steward has not stopped it, and by September the whole household will be saying it, and my husband does not know."

Antonia stood in her own atrium with the purse of another woman's savings in her sleeve and found that she could not speak.

❦

The old woman at the gate of the empress's garden was a freedwoman of sixty with a face like a nut and a stool and a stick, and she had been at that gate for nineteen years.

"A quarter of an hour," Antonia said. "That is all. Tell her that the woman who sent the petition in March is standing at the gate."

The old woman looked at her.

"The empress is at Antium," she said. "She will be back in October. There is a place made for petitions to her household at the beginning of November, in the garden, on the third day before the Nones, and it is not a quarter of an hour, it is the time it takes to

walk from the gate to the fountain and back, and you must be brought by someone the household knows."

"I do not know anyone the household knows."

The old woman looked at her for a long moment.

"You are the woman from the Clivus," she said. "The one with the gilt door."

"Yes."

"My sister was in a house on the Aventine for six years." The old woman shifted on her stool. "She came out with a bad chest and four hundred sesterces, and she died in the year of the fire, and she used to say that the only person in that whole trade who ever gave her a thing without taking something was a woman with grey eyes who kept the accounts and never once pretended to be her friend."

Antonia did not move.

"Come back on the third day before the Nones," the old woman said. "Come to this gate at the second hour and ask for me. My name is Callirhoe. I will walk you to the fountain myself, and on the way you will say whatever it is into the air, and the empress will hear it if she is disposed to hear it, and if she is not, you will have had a walk in a garden and nobody will have lost anything."

"Thank you."

"Do not thank me. I have been at this gate nineteen years and I have never once let anyone in." Callirhoe settled back on her stool. "It is a small thing to be kind once."

❦

The tablet came on the fifteenth day before the Kalends, by the hand of the fuller's boy, wrapped in a piece of sacking and addressed to nobody.

It was a wax tablet, and the wax had been smoothed and written on and smoothed again and written on again, so that the earlier writ-

ing showed through the new like bones through skin. The new writing was in a girl's careful hand, and it was a copy, and it said:

In the tablinum of the house of M. Cassius Verus, in the third pigeonhole, a bundle tied with string and marked with the year. On the fourth tablet of the bundle: a note of a debt owed by Chryseros, slave, to his master, in the sum of ninety thousand sesterces, paid on his behalf to Bassa, dealer, for a child of three months. In the margin, in my father's hand: For the child, from Bassa, and no more to be said.

And underneath, in the same hand: *I could not take the tablet. He has moved the bundle. He has moved me, too — I am to go to my aunt's at Tibur on the Kalends of September and stay until the wedding, and Myrtale is to stay in the house. I do not know why he has separated us. I am frightened. Do not write. P.*

Antonia read it three times, and then sat with it in her lap in the small room with the lamp and the strongbox and the smell of oil.

Ninety thousand sesterces. A debt owed by a slave to his master, paid on the slave's behalf; a fiction that turned a purchase into an accounting, because a Roman gentleman does not write down that he bought a baby. And then eleven words in the margin, in his own hand, in his own tablinum, in the house where he had held a lamp for eleven hours: *and no more to be said.*

She had waited eighteen years for this piece of wax.

She felt nothing at all, and then she felt everything at once, and she put her hand over her mouth and sat very still for a long time.

❦

The petition was refused on the last day of August.

She had gone up to the office of petitions with the sealed endorsement of a consular in her hand and the fee paid and the witness's statement taken, and she had waited three hours on the bench in the corridor, and at the end of it she was shown into the

room of the secretary who had told her in March that the office had no objection.

Haterius had aged in five months. He sat behind his table with the tablets in front of him, and he did not look at her, and that was how she knew.

"The petition is refused," he said.

"On what grounds?"

"The office has received a representation from the urban prefect's office, in the matter of certain irregularities in the manumission records of the fourteenth region, and in the matter of the character of the petitioner." He read from the tablet in front of him, in a flat voice, like a man reading a list of goods. "The petitioner is a woman of the freed class who keeps an establishment of entertainment in the fourteenth region, who has been the subject of a public inquiry by the aediles, and whose household has been named in a matter of concealment of a slave. The office does not say that the petition is false. The office says that the petition cannot be advanced while the matter of the house is unresolved."

Antonia stood in front of the table.

"There is no matter of the house," she said. "There is an inquiry by the aediles which has been closed, and a death which has been written as an accident, and a slave who was registered as sold. There is nothing unresolved."

"The prefect's office has written that there is."

"The prefect's office has been persuaded to write it by a man called Oppius Nepos, who wishes to buy my book."

Haterius's pen stopped moving.

"Domina," he said, and his voice was almost kind, "do not tell me that."

"Why not?"

"Because I am a clerk, and a clerk who is told a thing must write it down, and if I write it down it becomes a document, and a docu-

ment is a thing that can be used." He put the pen down. "The petition is refused. It may be presented again in a year, with a fresh endorsement and a clean record and a statement from the prefect's office that the matter of the house is resolved. In a year. Not before."

"A year."

"A year." He looked at her, and then away. "The emperor is going east. The office goes with him in part. A petition that is presented again in a year may be presented to a man who is not the emperor, and a man who is not the emperor cannot grant a rescript of this kind." He picked up his pen. "I am sorry, domina. I have been in this office twenty years and I have refused four hundred petitions and I have never once been sorry, and I am sorry now."

She stood in the corridor for a moment with her hand against the wall.

The room behind her had a table and a pen and a man who had been sorry. In front of her the corridor went down to the stair, and the stair went down to the forum, and the forum was full of men going about the business of an empire that had been built on exactly this: on a table, and a pen, and a man who was sorry, and a woman who was told to come back in a year.

"Domina." The clerk who had called her name in March was standing at the door of the room with a tablet in his hand. "The secretary's clerk asked me to give you this."

It was a copy of the refusal. He had written it out himself, in his own hand, in the corridor, in the last quarter of an hour, and at the bottom, where the seal would go, there was nothing at all.

"It is not sealed," Antonia said.

"No, domina."

"An unsealed copy is not a refusal."

"No, domina." The clerk looked at the floor. "An unsealed copy is a piece of paper that a woman might have taken away by mistake, and there is no record of it in the office, and if a praetor's clerk were

to come to this office in November and ask whether the petition had been refused, I would have to look in the book, and the book has not been written up yet." He cleared his throat. "The book is written up at the end of the quarter. There are four hundred petitions in it. It takes me three weeks."

Antonia looked at the young man.

"What is your name?" she said.

"Faustus, domina."

"Faustus. Do you know what you are doing?"

"I am giving a woman a piece of paper that has not been sealed," the clerk said, "and I am going back to my table, and I am going to write up the quarter, and if the refusal is in the book by the Kalends of October it will be because somebody in this office wrote it there, and I am not going to be that somebody, and I am not going to be able to explain why." He went back into the room and shut the door.

Antonia stood in the corridor with the unsealed copy in her hand and understood, for the first time in eleven years, that the city was not one thing. It was a hundred thousand people, and every one of them had a reason, and the reasons were not all the same, and a woman who had spent her life assuming that every door was locked because the men behind it were against her had been wrong about at least one clerk in an office on the Palatine.

She went out through the corridor where the woman in black had sat with the boy in March, and there was a different woman there now, with a different boy, and the letter in the boy's hand was addressed to a different dead man.

Tullia was waiting in the street with the litter.

"Well?" she said.

"Refused."

Tullia's face did not change. "On what grounds?"

"The company I keep." Antonia got into the litter. "Take me to the palace."

"The palace?"

"The house of the empress. Not the palace. The garden of the house of Pompeia Plotina, on the Palatine, at the fifth hour, and send a message ahead of me that the woman who sent the petition in March asks for a quarter of an hour."

Tullia stared at her. "You cannot simply go to the empress's house."

"I am not going to the empress's house. I am going to the garden of the empress's house, which is a different thing, and I am going to stand at the gate until someone comes out, and I am going to say one sentence, and then I am going to go home." Antonia pulled the curtain. "It is the only door in Rome I have never knocked on. I have been saving it."

"Why now?"

"Because my petition is refused for a year and the case is in November and the wedding is in September and a man in the prefect's office has my book, and because the only person in this city who can move an emperor's office with a word is a woman who has never been in an emperor's office."

She went home and put on the dark blue stola and the gold earrings and no other ornament at all, and then she sat in the small room with the two halves of a lead token in her hand and waited for the fifth hour.

CHAPTER XVI

THE WEDDING

Rome, the fourth day before the Kalends of September, AD 112

She dressed in the dark, before the household was up, because she had learned a long time ago that the days that frighten you are best met before anyone else is awake to see your face.

The dark blue stola. The mantle the color of wine. The gold earrings. The shoes with the small pearl on the strap, which she had bought in the year 104 and had worn four times. She put up her own hair, and it took her longer than it used to, and she did not call Rufina to help, because Rufina would have seen her hands.

At the fifth hour Tullia came with bread and olives and stood in the doorway and looked at her.

"You are not eating."

"I will eat at the wedding."

"You will not eat at the wedding. You will stand in a corner with a cup in your hand and watch the room, and at the end of it you will be hungry and tired and you will have drunk nothing." Tullia put the plate on the table. "Eat the bread. For me. I have been up since the third hour making sure the girls are dressed and the litter is clean and the gift is wrapped, and I am not going to be told at the ninth hour that you have fainted in a great house."

Antonia ate the bread.

The gift was in a box on the table: a mirror of polished silver, on a stand of ivory, with a handle in the shape of a girl's arm. It had cost four thousand sesterces and it was the sort of thing that a woman

gave a bride, and it had no history in it, and no message, and nobody would be able to say anything about it at all.

"Is it too much?" Tullia said.

"It is exactly too much. If it were less they would say I was stingy and if it were more they would say I was insolent. Four thousand is the exact amount of money that says *I am richer than you and I am not going to apologize for it, but I am also not going to make a scene.*"

"You have a mind like an account book."

"Thank you."

"It was not entirely a compliment." Tullia came and straightened the mantle at the shoulder, and her hands were kind and quick, and Antonia stood still for it as she had stood still for it for nine years. "The flower-seller came at dawn. She says the girl is well. She says the mistress of the house has been in her room every evening this week, and that the master has not spoken to the girl since the Kalends, and that the steward has been told to have a litter ready on the fifth day before the Kalends of October."

"Where for?"

"She does not know. The litter is to be ready and the destination is not written down. That is how a man sends a girl away quietly: he tells the steward the day and the hour and not the place, and the bearers are hired from a man who does not ask."

Antonia put on her mantle.

"Then we have a month," she said.

"We have a month," Tullia said, "and a wedding today, and a case in November, and a book that a man in the prefect's office is still looking for, and a girl in a cellar in Ostia who is going to be brought up to Rome to be questioned in front of a magistrate, and a mistress who has not slept properly since March."

"You forgot the petition."

"I did not forget the petition. I left it out on purpose." Tullia handed her the box. "You cannot carry all of it at once. Nobody can. Today you carry the wedding."

They came to the house on the Viminal at the fourth hour, and the street was full.

There were litters along the whole lane, and the bearers squatting in the shade of the wall, and a crowd of the poor at the corner being kept back by two of the household slaves with sticks, and the torches already stacked by the door, and the flute players warming up in the porch with the particular insolence of men who know they will be paid whether or not they are good.

The side gate was open. Antonia went in through the garden with the women, and the garden was full of them: the aunts, the cousins, the wives of the bridegroom's friends, the wife of the praetor, the widow of the twice-consul, and Marcella in dark red with her hair in the old fashion and a face like a city wall.

"You came," Marcella said.

"I said I would."

"You came in through the side gate."

"You told me to."

"I did not think you would." Marcella took her arm and walked her into the house. "Come. I will put you where the whole room can see you, and where my husband cannot reach you without walking past eleven women, and where the bride can see you when she comes down."

The atrium had been transformed the way a great house is transformed for a wedding: the masks were still in their cupboard, but the cupboard doors were shut, which Antonia had never seen, and there were garlands on the columns and a couch for the bride and

cushions on the floor and a table with the marriage contract on it and the two families' seals.

And the household was there, all of it, in its best clothes: the steward, the cook, the porters, the kitchen boys, the maids, standing at the back along the wall in a line, with their hands folded.

Myrtale was among them.

She was in a pale dress, and her hair was up, and she had the bride's veil over her arm because she was the bride's maid and would put it on her at the door. She stood with her eyes down and her hands steady and the token at her throat, and she did not look at Antonia at all.

Antonia stood where Marcella put her, in the second rank of women, under the garland, in full view of the room.

She had not been in this atrium since May.

The cupboard of masks was shut, and the doors were polished, and the bronze labels had been cleaned, and there was a bowl of roses on the table where the marriage contract lay. And behind her, to her left, the passage went to the kitchen. She could feel it behind her the way a person feels a door in a dark room: not by seeing it, but by knowing exactly where it is.

She had walked along that passage ten thousand times. She had carried a jug along it, and a lamp, and a basin, and a tray, and her own body. At the end of it, on the right, there was a door, and behind the door a room with a pallet and a jug and a nail in the wall, and she had slept in that room for fourteen years, and had been taken out of it on a September morning and put on a board in a stone room at the back of the tablinum.

She stood in the atrium in the dark blue stola with the gold earrings and let the memories come, one at a time, and did not turn around, and did not look at the passage, and answered when she was spoken to.

At the far end of the room, by the door to the garden, the steward Callistus was standing with his tablet. He was fifty and grey and he had the face of a man who has been given a little power and has decided to become it, and he had been a young under-steward in the year 93, and he had been in the passage on the morning after, and he had been the one who was told to carry her to the room behind the kitchen when the young master could not do it.

He looked at her across the atrium. She looked back.

He inclined his head, very slightly, and then looked down at his tablet, and Antonia understood — with a clarity that was almost physical — that in nineteen years this was the first time the man had ever acknowledged that he remembered her, and that the acknowledgment was not an apology and was not meant to be one. It was an accounting. He was telling her that he knew what she had come for, and that he had been in the house long enough to know how these things ended, and that he intended to be on the side that was still standing when it was over.

❦

Before the ceremony, in the garden, one of the aunts came and stood beside her.

She was a small woman of seventy with a face like a dried apple, and she was dressed in a great deal of purple, and she held a fan and used it against the heat with the air of a woman who had been using a fan against the heat since the reign of Nero.

"You are the woman from the Clivus," she said.

"I am."

"My daughter's husband has been to your house."

"Many men have been to my house."

"His name is Pomponius. He is a praetor this year. He told my daughter that he went to your house for a dinner and that the dinner was better than anything he had had in a year, and my daughter

has not spoken to him since." The old woman fanned herself. "I told her that a man who is going to be a praetor must be seen in the right places and that a house of entertainment is a place where a man may be seen, and that a wife who makes a scene about a dinner is a wife who will spend her life making scenes. I did not tell her what I actually think."

"What do you actually think?"

"I think that a woman who sells nothing but dinner is a woman who has understood something about this city that the rest of us have not, and that the rest of us are too proud to ask her what it is." The old woman looked up at her. "Is it true that you keep a book of every man who has been in your house?"

Antonia looked at her.

"I keep accounts," she said.

"Ah," said the old woman, and smiled, and it was a smile with thirty years of a bad marriage in it. "Then you are cleverer than my daughter, and I shall tell her so."

The bride came down at the fifth hour.

She was in white, with the tunica recta that she had woven herself, and her hair was dressed in the six locks with the woollen band, and she carried the spindle and distaff that her mother had carried, and she came down the stairs with her aunt on one side and her stepmother on the other, and she was white as the dress and she did not stumble.

The room made the sound a room makes at a wedding.

Publia came through the atrium and stood by the couch, and Myrtale came forward and put the veil over her, and the two of them were close together for a moment, and Antonia saw Myrtale say something, and saw Publia's mouth move, and saw the veil go down.

The bridegroom was waiting with the priest and the ten witnesses. Titus Caesennius Rufus was fifty-four, and he was not fat and he was not ugly, and that was somehow worse: he was a solid, grey, well-kept man with the hands of a man who had never done a day's work that did not involve a ledger. He looked at his bride the way a man looks at a contract he has been assured is sound.

The words were said. The *ubi tu Gaius, ego Gaia* was said by the bride in a clear, flat voice, and the room sighed with pleasure, and the contract was read, and the dowry was named.

One million two hundred thousand sesterces.

There was a small movement in the room. The dowry was a great deal of money, and everyone in the room knew exactly what it meant, and the bridegroom's cousin from the council smiled at the bride's father and the bride's father smiled back, and for a moment the two of them looked like what they were: two men shaking hands over a field.

Then the joining of hands. The bride and the bridegroom took each other's right hand, and the priest said the words, and the bride's hand was small and white in the man's big one, and Antonia watched it and thought about a girl in a byre and a girl in a passage and a girl on the floor of a stone room, and she did not look away.

The dinner was in the garden, at three tables, and it went on for four hours.

Antonia ate very little and drank less and stood where she could see the door. She was, she discovered, a spectacle: the women came past her in a stream, and some of them spoke, and some of them did not, and one of them, the wife of the praetor, went so far as to say, "You are the woman with the house," and then to say, "I have heard it is very fine," and then to go away in the certainty that she had been gracious.

At the second table, a man was talking about the east.

He was a senator of about fifty, and he had the loud, cheerful voice of a man who has decided that the world is a place where a man of good will can always make himself understood, and he was telling the woman beside him that the emperor would go to Parthia in the spring, and that the whole thing would be over in a year, and that there would be a new province and a great deal of money to be made in the carrying of it.

"And who will go with him?" the woman said.

"Every man who can get a commission," the senator said. "There are already four hundred applications for the staff, and the emperor has not yet announced the route. There is a man from the prefecture who is said to have made a list of the men who are to be taken and the men who are to be left, and a man on that list can name his price for the next three years."

"And who is the man from the prefecture?"

"Attianus," the senator said. "Or one of his freedmen. They say the list is kept in a book."

Antonia stood with her cup in her hand and thought: in a book; everything in this city is kept in a book; and understood, with a coldness that went down her arms, exactly what it was that Oppius Nepos wanted, and why he wanted it in the autumn, and what he intended to do with it when he had it.

Verus did not come near her.

He was at the head of the first table with his wife and the bridegroom and the bride, and he made a speech at the end of the second hour that was exactly the right length, and in the speech he said that a daughter is a door, and that the whole art of a father's life is to know when to open it.

The room applauded. Antonia watched his face while he said it, and his face was the face of a man who has said a thing that everybody will remember and nobody will understand.

Verianus was not at the table. He came in at the third hour and stood by the wall with a cup, and he was very drunk, and his eyes kept going to the corner where the household stood with their hands folded.

At the fourth hour, the bride and groom were taken through the ceremony of the nuts. The boys threw walnuts on the floor and the guests scrambled for them, and the bridegroom went through the room scattering coins, and the flute players followed him, and the whole wedding went out into the street.

The torch procession went from the Viminal to the Caelian, and it took an hour and a half, and it was the largest one Antonia had ever seen.

There were the flute players, and the boys with the nuts, and the guests with torches, and the bride with her two attendants, and the bridegroom with his friends, and the whole thing wound down the Clivus and along the Vicus Tuscus singing the wedding songs, the rude ones first and then the tender ones, and the crowd came out of the houses to see and the crowd threw flowers that had been bought for the purpose.

Antonia went with the second rank of women, at the back, with a torch in her hand.

At the corner of the Caelian the procession stopped, and the bridegroom took the bride by the hand and pulled her, gently, so that she stumbled, because a bride who does not stumble is a bride who has not been properly carried, and the room laughed. Then he took her over the threshold of his house and the guests followed and the door was shut in the faces of the crowd, and the songs went on in the street for a while and then stopped, and people went home.

Antonia stood in the street with the torch in her hand and the smell of it in her hair.

"Domina." Hilarus was at her elbow. "The litter."

"Not yet."

"It is the fourth hour of the morning."

"I know what hour it is." She watched the closed door. "I am waiting for something and I do not know what it is, and if I get into the litter I shall go home and lie down and it will be morning and I will not have waited."

They waited an hour. The crowd thinned. The last of the flute players went away down the hill with their instruments under their arms, and the torches burned down in the holders, and the street was empty, and the door of the house of Caesennius Rufus was shut.

"I was married once," Antonia said.

Hilarus did not move.

"Not truly. There was a man in the year 98, a freedman — no, a freedman's son; a citizen, but poor. He wanted the name and the respectability and the money, and I wanted to be a woman with a husband, and it lasted a year. He was not cruel. He was simply not there. He was a man who wanted to be a gentleman and could not afford it, and he drank, and when he drank he told me that I was a woman with a shop and that a shop was not a marriage." She looked at the closed door. "I have not thought about him in eleven years."

"Domina."

"What?"

"There is a woman at the corner."

Antonia turned.

Publia was standing at the corner of the street, in her wedding clothes, alone. Her veil was off and her hair was down and there was a mark on her wrist as though somebody had held it too hard, and she was carrying her shoes in her hand.

The house on the Clivus had never seemed as quiet as it did at the fifth hour of that morning.

Tullia had sent everyone to bed. There was a lamp on the table in the small room, and Antonia sat in the chair, and Publia sat on the stool with her wedding dress in folds around her and her hair loose and her face the color of a candle.

"I walked out of the house," she said.

"I know."

"I walked out of the house, and nobody stopped me, because they were all drunk, and because the porter thought I was one of the guests' daughters, and because a bride is not supposed to walk out of the door on the first night." Her hands were in her lap and she was turning her wedding ring around and around. "He put me in the bedroom and he put his hand here, on my arm, and he said that he could see I was frightened and that I should not be, and then he —"

She stopped.

"You do not have to tell me," Antonia said.

"I do have to tell you. If I do not tell someone, then nothing happened, and that is the thing they all want, that is the thing my stepmother wants, and my father, and the priest, and the whole room at the wedding. They want it to be nothing that happened." Publia's voice was very quiet. "He could not. He tried for a long time, and he was very — he was embarrassed, and he apologized, and then he said that it was because he had drunk too much and that I should not say anything to anyone, and then he put his face in his hands and he cried, and then he called me by a name. And the name was not my name."

Antonia sat very still.

"Whose name?"

"His first wife's. He called me Sabina, and he called me it twice, and then he got up and went out of the room and I heard him in the atrium, and he was talking to someone and I could not hear what he

said." Publia looked up. "And do you know what I felt? I felt relief. I felt relief that he had left the room, and then I felt ashamed of the relief, and then I thought: I am sixteen years old, I have just been married in front of four hundred people, and I am sitting on a bed in a strange house, and the thing I am feeling is relief."

Antonia got up and came and sat on the floor beside the stool, and took the girl's hands.

"You are not going to cry," she said.

"I am not going to cry."

"Good. Because it is four hours before dawn and we have a great deal to do before the household wakes up, and I am going to tell you what is going to happen now, and you are going to listen." Antonia held her hands. "You are going back to that house before the sixth hour. You are going in through the garden, and you are going up to your room, and you are going to be in bed when your maid comes in, and when your husband asks you in the morning how you slept, you are going to say that you slept well."

"Why?"

"Because you are a married woman and the whole of Rome is watching a house where a man has been called by his first wife's name, and if you leave him on the first night, in the first year of the marriage, your father will be ruined and your stepmother will be able to do nothing and the money will be a scandal, and there will be a suit, and the case in November will be drowned in it. And because you will be able to leave him in a year, with your own money, in a way you choose, and you will be able to take his money with you." She looked at the girl. "And because a man who calls his second wife by his first wife's name on the first night is a man with a grief in him, and I have known men like that, and I have found that they can be reasoned with, in time."

"He cried."

"He cried," Antonia said. "Remember that. He cried, and he apologized, and he did not put his hand on you a second time. He is not a monster, and a man who is not a monster can be managed."

Publia looked at her hands.

"Did your husband cry?" she said.

"I was never married in a house with a shrine," Antonia said. "I was never given a dowry and a priest and a room full of women. I have been a wife in my own way, and I have had a husband in my own way, and none of it was ever said in front of a priest." She let go of the girl's hands. "Now. There is a thing I have to tell you, and I was going to wait until November, and I cannot wait any longer, because you walked out of that house and came here and you did it without telling anyone, and there is not going to be a better evening for it."

Publia looked up.

"Myrtale," Antonia said. "The girl you call Myrtale. She is my daughter."

The room was very quiet.

"I know," Publia said.

"You know."

"I have been sitting in that house for six months, and I have read the tablet, and I have spent every evening with her, and I have looked at her hands." Publia's voice was steady, which was, in its way, the worst thing Antonia had ever heard. "You both do the same thing with a cuff. You turn it twice and then you pull it straight. I noticed it at the portico in April. I said nothing. Do you know why?"

"Tell me."

"Because I wanted to see how long it would take you to tell me," Publia said, "and because I wanted to be trusted with it, and because I was so angry with you in that portico that I could not speak." She looked at Antonia. "She knows I have been copying a page. She

knows my father looks at her. She does not know what I think she is. And I have not told her, and every day I have not told her has been a stone in my chest."

Antonia sat on the floor of her own small room, with her daughter's mother — with the slave girl she had been, and the woman she had made, and the girl of sixteen she had been when she first learned what a great house was — and she found that she was shaking.

"There is a place for her," she said. "In the spring. A house on the Aventine, with a woman who will be respectable because she is happy, and a trade, and a name. If we win in November, she will not go back to that house. Not for a single night."

"And if you lose?"

"Then I will lose with her standing next to me," Antonia said, "and she will have heard her mother's name said out loud in a court, in front of the praetor, in front of the whole city, and there is not a man in Rome who can take that back from her even if the law says she is a slave."

Publia looked at her for a long moment. Then she got up, and went to the table, and poured a cup of water, and drank it, and put it down.

"I have a confession," she said. "It is not a great one. It is the sort of thing that a woman remembers when she is married to a man who calls her by another name."

"Tell me."

"In the tablinum, on the Nones, I found the bundle and the page, and I read it, and I copied it." She turned. "And then I went to the kitchen and I told Myrtale everything I had read. I told her in the kitchen, in front of the cook. I could not help it. I was so frightened and so angry that I could not hold it in, and the woman on the Clivus had said not to tell her, and I told her, in the kitchen, with the door open."

The lamp guttered. Antonia looked at her.

"Who else was in the kitchen?"

"The cook. The cook's girl. The porter came in at the end of it to fetch his supper." Publia's voice was shaking now. "And Callistus was in the passage. I did not see him, but I heard the door of the storeroom, and when I came out there was nobody there."

She stopped. The house was very quiet.

"Then your father knows that she knows," Antonia said.

"Yes."

Antonia stood up. Her legs were steady. Her hands were cold, and she had got used to that, and she did not permit it to mean anything.

"Then the litter on the fifth day before the Kalends of October is not taking her to Formiae," she said. "It is taking her somewhere that a woman with a case in November cannot follow her."

She went to the door and opened it and called for Tullia.

"Get Hilarus," she said. "Get him up, and get Cerdon, and tell them to put on dark clothes and take the small lamp. And the fuller's boy — send to the fuller's yard and tell him that I want the man with the boat at the Transtiberim and I want him at the top of the Clivus within the hour."

Publia stood in her wedding dress with her hands at her sides.

"What are you going to do?" she said.

"I am going to move a girl out of a house," Antonia said, "and I am going to do it badly and in the dark, because we have come to the end of doing things well."

CHAPTER XVII

FIRE IN THE SUBURA

Rome, September, AD 112

They went on the third night after the wedding, at the second hour, when the moon was down and the whole Subura was asleep except the bakers and the watch and the women who could not sleep.

There were four of them: Antonia, Hilarus, Cerdon, and the fuller's man with the boat, whose name was Vindex and who had a bad leg and a good memory for lanes. They went up the Viminal by the back ways, through the yard of a dyer's and over a wall that Vindex knew, and came into the lane behind the house of the Cassii from the east, where the wall was lower and where the fig tree had grown over it.

The plan was not a good plan. Antonia knew it was not a good plan, and had known it from the moment she had said it out loud, and had gone on with it because a bad plan that moves is worth more than a good plan that waits.

The plan was this: Hilarus and Cerdon would go over the wall into the garden and open the side door. Antonia would go in and up the back stairs to the room next to the steward's, and she would wake the girl, and she would say four sentences, and the girl would come or she would not. If she came, they would go out through the garden and down the lane to the boat and across the river to the fuller's cousin's house in the Transtiberim, and in the morning Antonia would send word to the praetor's office that the girl had been produced by her mother and was under the protection of a consu-

lar, and the case would begin in November with the girl alive and out of the house.

Four sentences. She had written them out on a tablet and burned the tablet.

My name is Antonia Cassia and I was born in this house.

You are my daughter and you were born free.

There is a case in November and a man called Gallus who will stand for you.

Come with me now and you will not go back.

She had said them to the wall of her own room a hundred times in the last three days. She had heard them in her own voice and in the voice of a stranger. She had thought about what the girl would do, and had made herself consider every answer, including the one she could not bear: that the girl would look at her and say, *you are the woman who keeps the house on the Clivus, and my master has told me what you are.*

The wall was cold and the fig tree was easy and the garden was dark.

They got over. They crossed the garden by the vine, where Antonia had sat in the evenings when she was nineteen, and where the bees had been in the spring and were not now, and where the bench was still the bench.

The side door was bolted from the inside. Hilarus had it open in a quarter of an hour with a knife and a piece of wire, and they went into the passage, and the passage smelled of the same things: stone dust and lamp oil and, faintly, the vinegar they used on the floors.

Antonia stood in the passage behind the kitchen of the house of the Cassii, nineteen years after she had been carried out of it, and listened.

The house was asleep. The kitchen at the end had a banked fire and a smell of bread. The door to her old room was shut, and behind it someone was snoring, and it was not the girl; it was a man's

snore, deep and regular, and she stood outside the door of the room she had slept in for fourteen years and listened to a man she did not know snoring in it.

She went up the back stairs.

The room next to the steward's had a door with a crack of light under it.

She stood outside it for a moment, and her heart was going, and her hands were steady, and she thought: I have waited eighteen years for this door, and now I am going to knock on it, and the person on the other side is going to be my daughter, and she is going to look at me the way she looks at a stranger.

She knocked.

The door opened at once, as though someone had been standing behind it, waiting.

Myrtale was in her shift with a lamp in her hand, and her face was the face of a person who has not slept. Behind her, on the bed, there was a bundle tied with cord, and a cloak, and a pair of shoes.

"You are the lady," she said.

"Yes."

"You are the lady with the fan."

"I am." Antonia's voice was steady. "May I come in?"

The girl stepped back. Antonia went in and shut the door, and they stood in the small room with the lamp between them, and Antonia saw, on the table, a wax tablet with writing on it, and a knife with a wooden handle.

"You are leaving," Antonia said.

"Tonight." Myrtale's chin came up. "The cook is going to leave the gate unbarred at the third hour, and there is a man with a cart who takes the vegetables out at the Porta Esquilina at dawn, and he has been paid, and I have eleven sesterces and a cloak and the name of a woman in Tibur who knew my nurse."

"Who paid the man with the cart?"

"The cook." Myrtale looked at her. "She has been in this house thirty years and she has never once done anything that was not ordered, and she is doing this, and she is doing it because the master has told the steward to have the litter ready, and because a girl who is sent away in a litter does not come back."

Antonia stood in the small room and looked at her daughter.

"I have four sentences," she said.

"Domina?"

"I have four sentences that I wrote out and burned, and I have said them to a wall a hundred times, and now I am going to say them to you, and you are going to listen to all four before you say anything at all." She put her hands behind her back, because her hands were not steady anymore. "My name is Antonia Cassia, and I was born in this house. You are my daughter, and you were born free. There is a case in November, before the praetor, and a consular of Rome called Gallus has sworn to assert your freedom and to answer for it. Come with me now, tonight, and you will not go back to this house."

The lamp burned. The girl did not move.

"Say it again," she said.

"Which part?"

"The first part."

"My name is Antonia Cassia, and I was born in this house."

"Where?"

Antonia looked at the floor, and then at the wall, and then at the girl.

"At the end of the passage," she said, "behind the kitchen, on the right. There is a door, and behind the door a room with a pallet and a jug and a nail in the wall. I slept in it for fourteen years. There is a crack in the plaster above the nail in the shape of a leaf, and the third brick from the floor on the left of the door is loose, and I used to

keep things behind it." She paused. "There was a lamp with a bronze door on the handle. I stole it when I left. I still have it."

Myrtale's face had gone strange.

"The crack is in the shape of a leaf," she said. "I have looked at it. I have looked at it for thirteen years."

The lamp burned.

"You are my mother," Myrtale said.

"Yes."

"The master said she was dead."

"The master lied."

"The master said she was a slave who died when I was small, and that he had bought me from a dealer because he was a kind man and my mother had been his servant and he had promised her." Myrtale's voice was very quiet. "He has said it twice. Once when I was nine and I asked him, and once in the tablinum in the spring, when he told me to take off the cord."

Antonia's hands were shaking.

"What did you say?"

"I said, yes, master. What else would I say?" Myrtale looked at the lamp. "And then I went out and sat on the step by the storeroom door and I put my hands over my mouth, and I did not cry, because a slave who cries in a passage is a slave who has to be asked why."

Antonia took a step forward, and the girl took a step back, and Antonia stopped.

"I am not going to touch you," she said. "Not until you say I may. Do you understand? You may say no to everything I say tonight, and I will go out of this house and I will find another way. But I am going to tell you the rest of it, and it is not a nice story, and you are going to be angry with me, and that is your right."

"Tell me."

So she told her. She told it standing in a small room with a lamp between them, in the house where it had happened, and she did not spare herself, because she had spent eighteen years learning that the truth told badly is a kind of lie.

She told her about the garden and the bench and the poets, and about the man who read to her. She told her about the man with the folded paper and the passage and the promise she had made without understanding it. She told her about the stone room at the back of the tablinum and the clerk and the man with the rope, and about the young master standing by the door with the lamp in his hand. She told her about the eleven hours and the physician and the salve and the arm that would not lift above the shoulder. She told her about the manumission and the record and the old lady's purse. She told her about the room above the fuller's and the birth, and about the midwife from Ficulea and the crescent mark on a baby's wrist, and about the token that had been struck and snapped in two, and about the four days on the floor after the litter had gone up the lane.

She told her about the year and a half of washing, and the debt, and the house on the Aventine, and the two years. She did not spare herself there either, and she watched her daughter's face while she said it, and her daughter's face did not change, and that was worse than anything.

At the end she said, "That is all of it. There is nothing else."

Myrtale stood with her hands at her sides.

"You left me," she said.

"I did not leave you. He took you."

"You gave me to him."

"I let him take you, because I had eleven sesterces a month and a room above a fuller's shop and no work while I was nursing, and he had a house and a name and a promise." Antonia's voice was steady. "I have told myself for eighteen years that I had no choice. That is not true. I had a choice. I had a bad one and a worse one, and I chose

the worse one, because I could not bear the thought of watching you grow up in a house where I could not touch you, and I told myself it was for you, and it was not for you. It was for me. I could not do it, so I let him do it, and I have been paying for it ever since."

Myrtale looked at the floor.

"The lady Marcella," she said. "She knows."

"Yes."

"The young mistress knows."

"Yes."

"Everybody knows," Myrtale said, "except the girl in the passage."

"Yes."

The lamp guttered, and Antonia reached out and turned the wick up, and her hand was shaking so badly that she could not do it, and Myrtale took the lamp from her and turned the wick and set it down.

"Come with me," Antonia said. "Not because I am your mother. Because there is a litter ready on the fifth day before the Kalends of October and a destination that is not written down, and because your cook has a cart at the third hour and a man who has been paid, and because a man who has been paid by a cook in a great house is a man who can be paid again by a steward."

Myrtale said, "What is the case?"

"It is a freedom suit. In November, before the praetor, with the decemvirs. A consular asserts that you are free. I testify to the birth. Your father produces you as his slave and gives no title. Bassa's page is produced, and the note in his hand, and the midwife, and the token. If we win, you are freeborn from the day of your birth, and it is written in the record, and no man in Rome can say otherwise."

"And if we lose?"

"Then you are a slave, and your father takes you, and Gallus pays the value." Antonia looked at her. "And I will be ruined in the

street, and my house will close, and I will have nothing, and you will still be his."

Myrtale looked at the bundle on the bed.

"And if I get on the cart at dawn," she said, "there is no case, and you are not ruined, and I am in Tibur, and then I am somewhere else, and in a year I am a maid in a house in the country and nobody knows my name."

"Yes."

"Or I am caught," Myrtale said, "and I am sold, and the man in Formiae has his twelve thousand and I never see any of you again."

"Yes."

The girl stood in the small room for a long time. Then she went to the table and picked up the tablet with the writing on it and looked at it, and put it down.

"I do not know how to be a daughter," she said.

Antonia felt something go through her that she had not felt since the room above the fuller's, and she held it, and did not let it out.

"Neither do I know how to be a mother," she said. "I have had eighteen years to practice and I have not done it once. We shall have to be bad at it together."

Myrtale looked at her.

Then she picked up the cloak from the bed, and put it around her shoulders, and picked up the shoes, and the knife, and the tablet, and stood by the door.

"Domina," she said.

"Yes."

"You will have to tell me your name again. Every day, for a while. Because I shall forget it, and it will be a strange thing in my mouth, and I shall call you domina in front of people, and you will have to be patient with me."

Antonia's eyes were stinging.

"Yes," she said.

They went out through the passage, and down the back stairs, and the house was asleep, and the snoring man snored behind the door of the room she had slept in, and the garden was dark, and the vine was still the vine.

They were at the side door when the lamp came out of the tablinum.

"Stop," Verus said.

He was in his night tunic with a lamp in his hand, and he was barefoot, and he looked older than he had in the garden in May. Behind him, in the doorway of the tablinum, Callistus the steward was standing with a second lamp and a face like a closed door.

"You have come into my house," Verus said.

"I have come for my daughter."

"You have come into my house at night with four men and a boat."

"Yes."

"Do you know what I could do? I could have you taken up for housebreaking. I could have the men flogged and sold. I could have you in the cells by morning and the whole of Rome would say that the woman on the Clivus was a thief." His voice was shaking. "My son is in the house. My wife is in the house. My daughter's wedding was four days ago."

"Then do not wake them," Antonia said. "Do not wake your son, Manius. Do not wake him and ask him to help you with this, because he has been sleeping with a cup in his hand for four months and he is the last person in Rome you want standing in a passage tonight."

The lamp shook in Verus's hand.

"Let her go," he said.

"No."

"She is mine."

"She is not yours. You have known she is not yours since the day you signed the note that said *no more to be said*. You have known it every night you sat in your tablinum and sent for her and looked at her. You have known it every time you told her that her mother was dead." Antonia took a step forward. "There are two ways for this to end, and you are going to choose one of them tonight, in this passage, with a lamp in your hand, exactly as you chose in the year 93."

Verus stood in the passage of his own house.

"Which ways?" he said.

"The first way is that I take her out through that door and down the lane, and in the morning the whole city knows that the daughter of Manius Cassius Verus was carried out of his house at night by her mother, and the case in November is a public scandal, and you are finished in a week."

"And the second?"

"The second is that you open the door yourself," Antonia said, "and you say, in front of your steward, that the girl Myrtale is to go with the lady Antonia Cassia, and that she is to be produced before the praetor in November, and that you will answer the summons. And then you go back into your tablinum and you sit down and you do not sleep, and in the morning you are still a man who did one thing properly."

The lamp burned.

Callistus said, from the doorway, "Domine."

Verus did not turn.

"Go back to bed, Callistus," he said.

"Domine, the steward's duty —"

"I said go back to bed."

The steward went. His lamp went away down the passage and the light of it went out behind the corner, and the passage was dark, and there were three people in it and one lamp.

Verus looked at Myrtale.

"Girl," he said.

"Master."

He stood there for a long moment with the lamp in his hand, and Antonia saw him do it — saw him open his mouth to say the thing, and saw the thing go back down, and saw him put his shoulders back the way he did in the tablinum, and saw the man in the garden in May and the man in the passage in 93 and the man in the senate house all standing in the one body, and none of them able to say it.

Then he turned and went into the tablinum and shut the door.

The lock did not turn. He had not locked it. He stood on the other side of it, and Antonia could see the light under the door, and she could hear him breathing.

"Come," she said.

They went out through the side door, and across the garden, and over the wall by the fig tree, and down the lane, and the boat was at the foot of the steps with Vindex in it, and the river was black and moving, and the whole city was asleep above them.

Myrtale sat in the stern with her bundle on her knees and did not look back at the wall. Antonia sat in the bow with her hand on the gunwale, and the water went past, and neither of them spoke until the boat came out into the middle of the river and the current took it.

❦

The boat came in at the landing below the Aventine and they went up the steps into the Emporium, where the warehouses stood in the dark and the smell of grain and rope and river water was so strong

that it was almost a solid thing, and Hilarus went ahead with the lamp.

At the top of the steps there was a wineshop with its shutters down, and a baker's cart, and a group of men loading amphorae by torchlight, and a woman selling hot chickpeas from a brazier. It was the fourth hour of the morning, and the whole riverfront was awake, and the ordinary business of the largest port in the world was going on exactly as it went on every night, and Antonia stood in the middle of it with her daughter beside her and thought: this is the city, this is what it is, it is this and it is not the senate house.

"Domina." Myrtale had stopped at the corner. "What happens now?"

"Now we go up through the Emporium and across the Aventine, and I put you in a house where nobody will look for you, and in the morning Tullia brings you clothes and a comb and something to eat, and I go and find a man about a door."

"Your door."

"My door. It has a hole in the roof of the dining room the size of a cartwheel, and the mosaic in the atrium is full of ash, and there is a man in the passage who was with me for eleven years and is dead, and I am going to have to bury him." She started walking. "That is the whole of what happens now. It is not a story. It is a list."

They walked up the hill. The Aventine was quiet on the river side, and the lamps were few, and the streets were narrow and steep, and Myrtale kept her hand on Antonia's sleeve the way a blind person holds a guide. At the top, at the corner of a lane where a fig tree grew out of a wall, Antonia stopped.

"Turn around," she said.

"Why?"

"Because you have never seen the city from the top," Antonia said, "and because in a month I may not have a house to show you from, and because there is no better hour for it than this."

Myrtale turned around.

Below them Rome lay in the half-dark, and the fires of the bakers were pricked out in every quarter, and the great mass of the Palatine was black against a sky that had begun, at the edge, to be grey. There was the Circus, and the temples on the Capitoline with a light in one of them, and the masts of the river, and beyond all of it the dark that was the Campagna.

"It is not the end of the world," Myrtale said.

"No," Antonia said. "It is the world."

They were three streets from the house when they saw the light.

It was in the Subura, high up, in the block behind the fuller's yard, and it was not a lamp and it was not a cook fire. It was the color of the inside of a furnace, and it was moving, and there was a sound coming from it that Antonia had heard twice in her life and had never forgotten: the sound of a great many people all shouting the same word at once.

"Fire," Hilarus said.

They ran.

The lane to the house was full of people. The whole Subura was out in the street in their night clothes, with buckets and wet cloths and children on their shoulders, and the vigiles were there, the seventh cohort, with their pumps and their hooks and their axes, and the fire was in the insula at the end of the lane and it had already jumped the alley to the roof of the fuller's shed.

"The house," Antonia said. "The house!"

Cerdon was at the door before her. The house was dark and shut, and Cerdon had his club, and he was shouting at the crowd to get back, and the crowd was not getting back, and the sparks were coming down like a hot yellow snow.

"Where is the book?" Antonia said.

"In the room," Cerdon said. "It is in the room. I will get it."

"No."

"I will get it." He pushed her toward the far side of the lane. "Take the women to the fuller's yard. Take the girl and go. The house is stone at the front and the roof is tile and it will hold until the cohort gets the pump up, and if it does not hold it is a house and not a person."

"Cerdon."

"Domina," he said, and he was already going in through the door, and he turned for a moment in the doorway with the light behind him and said, "It is a good door. It will hold."

Then he was gone into the dark of the house.

Antonia got Myrtale to the fuller's yard, and Rufina was there with the girls and Beryllos and the two porters, and the pumps came up the lane and the vigiles got the water going, and the fire was in the insula and then it was in the roof of the house and then it was not a fire anymore, it was a fact.

Crescens found her at the corner of the lane at the fourth hour, with her mantle over her face against the smoke.

"The house," he said. "The roof is gone and the upper floor is gone. The stone is standing. The dining room is standing. The book room is —" he stopped.

"Where is Cerdon?"

Crescens did not answer.

"Where is Cerdon?"

"He went up to the book room," Crescens said. "He got the strongbox. He was coming down and the stair went. The box is in the yard. The book is in the box. He is in the passage."

Antonia stood in the lane with the smoke in her hair and looked at the front of her house, at the gilt on the door, at the iron studs, at the good door which had held.

"Take me to him," she said.

He was in the passage by the back stairs, under the beam.

They had got the beam off him and he was alive, and he was not going to be alive for long, and the physician was a vigiles surgeon with a bag and no illusions.

"Domina," Cerdon said.

"I am here."

"You did not sell me," he said.

"What?"

"In the first year. When I ran. You said you would give me a week's wages and a letter to a man in Ostia." His voice was a whisper and his eyes were going. "I have been thinking about it tonight. I never told you. I have been thinking about it for three years."

"I did not sell you," Antonia said.

"I know," Cerdon said. "That is what I have been thinking about."

He died a little after the fifth hour with his hand in hers, and the whole Subura smelled of smoke, and the gilt on the door had run in the heat and set in a puddle on the step like a spilled coin.

They took her out of the city four days later, at dawn, in a cart of wool, with a cloak and a purse and a letter.

The letter was to Iusta the midwife at Ficulea, on the road to Nomentum, and it said that the bearer was the girl, and that she was to be lodged in the midwife's house and taught whatever the midwife was willing to teach her, and that she was not to be seen in the town and not to be sent to Rome until a man came from the house of Antonia Cassia with a red cloth and a sealed tablet.

The house at Ficulea was small and had a pear tree and a goat and a room with a bed in it, and it was fifteen miles from Rome, and it was, as Myrtale said, the end of the world.

"I have never been outside the walls," she said, on the step, with the cart waiting.

"Then you will have something to tell me when I come," Antonia said. "In November. I will come for you myself, with the litter, and I will bring the record of the case if I win it, and if I lose it I will bring myself and nothing else."

"And what will we do if you lose?"

"We will find out what a freedwoman with no house can do," Antonia said, "and it will not be nothing."

Myrtale stood at the cart with her bundle.

"There is a thing I have not asked you," she said.

"Ask."

"That night. In the stone room. When the man with the rope had finished." She was looking at Antonia's shoulder, not her face. "Did he say anything to you afterward?"

Antonia was silent for a moment.

"He said that I was alive because I had been clever," she said. "And then he said that I would be freed because a freedwoman cannot be put to the question, and because a man who frees the witness has bought a silence that no one can accuse him of buying."

Myrtale looked at her.

"Then he told the truth," she said, "and he is still the man who did it."

"Yes."

"And that is what we are going to do to him," Myrtale said. "In November. We are going to tell the truth, and he will not be able to accuse us of anything, because the truth is the one thing that cannot be bought."

"It can be bought," Antonia said. "It can always be bought. But it is expensive, and there is not enough money in Rome to buy it twice."

Myrtale got up into the cart and sat on the wool with her bundle on her knees. The driver clicked his tongue, and the mule leaned into the harness, and the cart went down the lane and turned at the corner by the burned shed, and Myrtale did not look back.

Antonia stood in the ash of her own doorway with her hands at her sides and watched until the cart was out of sight.

Then she went to find the man with the pump and asked him how long it would take to make the house stand up again.

CHAPTER XVIII

THE PRICE OF A SILENCE

Rome, October, AD 112

The house on the Caelian had a covered walk that ran along the garden wall, and Gallus had taken to walking it in the evenings, up and down, forty paces one way and forty back, for an hour at a time. The household had got used to it. The slaves kept out of the walk, and the steward put a lamp at each end, and the grandson had been told that his grandfather was thinking and was not to be disturbed.

Antonia came at the eighth hour and found him at the far end of the walk with a letter in his hand.

"You had better sit down," he said.

"I have been standing in burnt houses for a month. I will stand."

"Sit down," Gallus said, "because I am going to read you something, and I would rather you were sitting when I read it."

She sat.

He read it. It was a letter, and it was in a good hand, and it was written by a man who had been paid to write it, and it said:

To Lucius Iunius Gallus, from a friend. You have been deceived by the woman who calls herself Antonia Cassia. On the night your son died, she knew that Manius Cassius Verus the Younger had left her house at the fourth hour and had not returned, and she knew, by her own slave's account, that a tall man with a gold ring had been standing in the lane outside her garden. She did not tell you. She told the aedile's office that the death was an accident and paid two hundred

thousand sesterces to have the word written down. She concealed the slave who found the body, and registered her as sold to Africa, and the slave is now in the custody of the prefect's office and will be produced before the magistrate in December. The woman has done all of this to protect a case she means to bring in November, and she has used your grief to find herself an adsertor of consular rank. Ask her. She will not deny it.

Gallus folded the letter.

"Well?" he said.

Antonia looked at him. The lamps at the ends of the walk made two small yellow points, and beyond them the garden was dark, and the aqueduct went over the wall.

"It is true," she said.

"All of it?"

"Almost all of it. I did not pay two hundred thousand. The aedile's office asked for a hundred thousand, and I offered two, because the price of a thing in Rome is usually twice what a man first asks, and I wanted him to remember it." She folded her hands. "And the slave is not in the custody of the prefect's office with my consent. She was taken from Ostia in July by men with a forged bill of sale and a genuine seal, and I have been looking for her for three months."

"You told me in August that there was a man in the lane."

"I told you there was a man in the lane with a ring on his hand, and that Verianus had the ring, and that his father had told me so."

"You did not tell me that you had known it in April."

"No."

"You let me stand in a court and swear to be your adsertor," Gallus said, "and you let me do it in the belief that I was doing it for a girl and against a man, and all the time you knew that the man's son was in the lane outside your house on the night my son died, and you did not tell me."

"I told you in August."

"Four months," Gallus said. "Four months, and my son was in the ground in May, and you sat in my garden and drank my wine and let me talk about the masks."

Antonia did not answer.

"Why?" he said. "That is the only question. Why did you keep it?"

"Because on the morning after your son died I did not know what had happened, and because by the time I knew, I had already lied to the aedile's office, and a woman who has lied once about a death cannot go to the father of the dead boy and say, I lied, but here is a part of the truth." She looked at him. "And because I wanted the case, and I knew that if I told you in April you would have gone to the prefect and there would have been a scandal and an inquiry and the girl would have been sold to Formiae before the summer was out. I made a choice between your grief and my daughter, and I chose my daughter, and I have been paying for it every day since."

Gallus walked to the end of the walk and came back.

"You are the most honest woman I have ever known," he said, "and I find that I would rather you had lied to me now."

"I know."

"You are going to tell me the rest of it," Gallus said. "Not the part that is convenient. The whole of it. And then I am going to decide whether I stand up in the praetor's court in November and assert the freedom of a girl on behalf of a woman who has used me."

Antonia told him. She told him about the fountain and the palms and the cut on the forehead. She told him about the girl in the passage with wet hands, and about the register and the lie of Africa, and about Dessa in the cell in Ostia. She told him about Verianus's face at the funeral, and about Verus in the garden in May with his hands over his face. She told him about the fifty-one times in the

tablinum, and about the note that said *no more to be said*, and about the eleven hours in the stone room.

When she had finished, Gallus stood at the end of the walk with his back to her for a long time.

"There is a thing I want," he said at last.

"Name it."

"I want you to say it in the senate house."

Antonia sat very still.

"Not in the praetor's court," Gallus said. "In the senate. In front of the whole house, on the day of the case, before the praetor sits. I want you to stand in the curia and say what was done to you in that house in the year 93, and what was done to the girl, and what you did in April when my son died. I want it said by you, in your own voice, in the room where the men who are going to decide the province of Asia are sitting." He turned. "And I will stand beside you and I will say that I have read the papers and that the girl is free, and that the man who held the lamp is not fit to govern a province or to sit in that house."

"They will not let a woman speak in the senate house."

"They will let a woman speak in the senate house when a consular of Rome stands up and asks the house to hear her," Gallus said. "It has been done. Not often. Four times in my lifetime. Once for a woman of the family of the Gracchi, once for a British queen, once for a woman who had been wronged by a governor, and once for a woman I have never been able to find out anything about, in the reign of Vespasian, who spoke for a quarter of an hour and was not written down." He came and stood in front of her. "I will ask. And they will let you speak because they will be curious, and because the whole house knows about Verus and the province and the wedding, and because a scandal is the only thing that makes a senator forget his dinner."

"And then?"

"And then you will say what you have told me tonight, all of it, and they will do nothing — the senate does nothing, the senate is a room full of men who agree to be careful — but they will have heard it, and a thing that has been heard in that room is a thing that cannot be unanswered. Verus will not go to Asia. His son will not sit in the decemvirate. The girl will be freed by the praetor in the afternoon, because no praetor in Rome will rule against a woman who has just told that story in front of the consuls."

"And I will be finished," Antonia said.

Gallus looked at her.

"Yes," he said. "You will be finished. You will be a freedwoman who was put to the question and kept a house of pleasure and lied to the aediles, and it will all be said in one afternoon in the hearing of the whole city, and there is not a door in Rome that will open for you afterward."

"And Dessa?"

"Dessa will be in a cell in December, and the prefect's office will question her, and if I am standing in the senate house on the day of the case I will not be able to stop it."

Antonia looked at the lamps at the end of the walk.

"That is the price," she said.

"That is the price."

❦

Verus came to the burned house in October, on a grey afternoon, with one slave and a litter and a face like a man who has not slept since the wedding.

The house was a shell. The roof was gone from the dining room and the upper floor was a fall of black beams, and the mosaic in the atrium was under a layer of ash and broken tile, and the painted Danaë had lost her face to the smoke. The workmen had propped the front wall and were taking the rubble out in baskets, and the

lane was full of dust, and Antonia was standing in the middle of it with a tablet, arguing with a builder about the price of a beam.

She saw Verus at the corner and came out to him with the tablet in her hand.

"You look like a woman who has been in a fire," he said.

"I have been in a fire." She wiped her face with the back of her wrist and left a smear of ash. "Say what you have come to say. I have thirty men and a beam to argue about."

"Send them away."

"No."

"Then walk with me."

They walked to the end of the lane and stood by the wall of the fuller's yard, which was black at the top where the fire had come over.

"I have been to the prefect's office," Verus said. "I have seen the papers on the girl Dessa. They are forgeries — the bill of sale is a forgery, the seal is genuine, and the procurator who is named on the bill does not exist. I have had my advocate look at it. It would not survive an hour in front of a praetor."

"Then why have you come to tell me?"

"Because the prefect's office does not care whether it would survive an hour in front of a praetor. It cares whether it survives until December. And it will." Verus looked at the burned wall. "I can get her out."

Antonia turned her head.

"How?"

"Petronius Celer is the urban prefect. He is a lazy man and an honest one, and he does not know what his office is doing, and if a consular comes to him with a forged bill of sale and a witness who will swear to the forgery, he will be extremely angry, because a prefect who is made to look a fool by his own freedmen is a prefect who will not be made a fool of twice." Verus's voice was flat. "I can be

that consular. I can go to him tomorrow with my advocate and the papers and the man who sold the girl to the dealer in Rome, and the girl can be out of the cell in a week."

"Why would you do that?"

Verus was silent for a moment.

"Because I have been sitting in my tablinum since the night you took her out of my house," he said, "and I have discovered something about myself that I would rather not have discovered. I have spent my whole life being a man who does not do a thing. And now I find that I cannot stop doing things. It is a very tiring condition, and I do not recommend it."

"That is not an answer."

"No." He looked at her. "I want the case to be in November. I want it heard, and the girl freed, and the record made, and the whole thing done properly, and then I want to go to Asia and not come back. And I want the other thing not to happen. That is the answer."

"What other thing?"

"The senate," Verus said. "Gallus has been to see me. He came four days ago and he stood in my atrium and he told me what he intends to do, in front of my wife and my steward and my son, and he did it in the voice of a man who has decided to be reasonable, which is the most frightening voice there is." He looked at Antonia. "He will ask the house to hear you. And you will tell them about the stone room, and about the lamp, and about the fifty-one times, and about my son in the lane, and about the aedile's two hundred thousand, and I will be finished, and I will deserve it, and my wife will be finished too, and my daughter will be a woman whose father was destroyed in the senate house a month after her wedding, and she will spend the rest of her life being that."

"And what do you offer?"

"I offer the other bargain," Verus said. "You drop the senate. You keep the case, and the girl is freed in November by the praetor, and the record is made, and I sign the admission and pay whatever penalty the court names and then go to Asia. And I get the girl Dessa out of the cell, and I find out who forged the bill of sale and I put him in front of the prefect, and I do not stop until the prefect's office has been turned inside out."

"And Gallus?"

"Gallus will be very angry," Verus said. "He will be angry with you, and he will be angry with me, and he will go on being angry for the rest of his life, and his anger will be the only thing that is left of his son, and I do not know how to give him anything better."

Antonia stood by the burned wall of the fuller's yard.

"You are asking me to choose," she said, "between a girl in a cell in December and a man's name in the senate house."

"I am asking you to choose between two bad things," Verus said. "I have been doing it all my life. You get used to it. That is the worst thing I can tell you about it."

❦

Crescens came at the tenth hour, off a watch, and found her in the shed behind the fuller's yard, which had a table made of a door and a lamp and a bed and a chest and a cat that had adopted the place and would not be evicted.

He had brought bread and a jar of wine and a face that she had learned to read in the way that a woman learns to read a man's face when she has decided not to ask him anything.

"The bill of sale," he said. "I have found the clerk who stamped it."

Antonia put down the tablet.

"In the prefect's office?"

"In the prefect's office. His name is Anicetus, he is a freedman of the household, and he has been in that office for eleven years. He did not stamp it himself. He told a clerk to stamp it and then took the clerk's tablet away and had a clean one made." Crescens put the bread on the table. "The clerk is frightened. He is nineteen and he has a wife and a baby, and he came to me because he knew that a tribune of the watch is not the prefect's office and because he has been carrying it about for four months and cannot eat."

"Will he swear to it?"

"He will swear to it in front of the prefect, in front of a praetor, in front of anybody, so long as his name is not written down." Crescens sat down on the chest. "And there is more. Anicetus answers to a man called Felix, and Felix answers to nobody in the office, and Felix has been paying the rent on a house in the Via Nova that is not in his name and never has been. The landlord is a client of Oppius Nepos. That is three steps, domina. I have two of them and the third one is a landlord who is frightened of his patron and will talk if he is pressed."

Antonia looked at him.

"You have been busy," she said.

"I have been a tribune of the watch for seven years," Crescens said, "and in seven years I have learned exactly two things: how to get a pump up a flight of stairs, and how to ask a question in a way that a frightened man can answer without losing his courage. It turns out the second one is useful in other trades."

"Give it to Gallus. He is the adsertor, and he has the standing to take it to the prefect."

"I am not giving it to Gallus."

"Why not?"

"Because Gallus is a grieving consular and he will take it to the prefect in a rage and it will become a public quarrel between two

great men, and the clerk will be found dead in a ditch before the Kalends." Crescens looked at her. "Give it to Verus."

Antonia sat back.

"I never thought I would hear you say that."

"I never thought I would say it. But Verus has something no one else in this has: he wants to be clean. He has spent thirty years being a man who does not do a thing, and now he is doing things, and a man who is doing things for the first time in his life is the most useful instrument in the world, because he will not stop and he does not know how to be careful."

"You are asking me to trust him."

"I am asking you to use him," Crescens said. "It is not the same thing, and you know it, and you have been using men all your life."

Antonia looked at the lamp.

"Yes," she said.

Crescens was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "I have a thing to ask you, and it is not about the case."

"Ask."

"I have eleven thousand sesterces of debt to three lenders. I have a tribune's pay and a room at the station and a helmet on a nail. I am thirty-four years old and I have never owned a house or a field or a horse that was mine." He was looking at the lamp and not at her. "And I have been offered a post in the eleventh cohort at Ravenna, which is a promotion, and it is four days' journey from Rome, and it is a place where a man can save money and be somebody, and I have been sitting with the offer in my chest for a month and I have not answered it."

"Why not?"

"Because I do not want to go to Ravenna," Crescens said. "I want to stay in Rome and put out fires and be shouted at by people whose houses are burning, and I want to come to this shed at the tenth hour and find a woman with a tablet and a cat and a ruined

house, and I want to be the man who is here." He looked up. "I am not asking you to marry me. I know what you would say to that, and I know that a woman in your position cannot afford a husband any more than a senator can marry a freedwoman. I am telling you what I want, because you are the only person in Rome I have ever told the truth to, and because if you are going to be finished in the senate house in November, I want it said before then."

Antonia sat in the shed with the cat on the chest and the lamp between them.

"You are a fool," she said.

"I know."

"You are thirty-four years old and you are in debt and you have a helmet on a nail, and you have just refused a promotion in Ravenna to sit in a shed in the Subura with a woman who is going to be destroyed in a senate house in a month."

"Yes."

"Say it again."

"I want to be the man who is here," Crescens said.

Antonia got up and came around the table, and took his face in her hands, and kissed him, and the cat got off the chest and went out through the door with the dignity of a thing that had been inconvenienced.

"Then be here," she said. "In November, and in December, and in the spring when there is no house and no money and no book, and I have nothing to give you but a ruin and a great deal of trouble."

"I like trouble," Crescens said. "I am a fireman."

❦

Marcella came the next morning, in a litter, with a slave and a basket and a face like a city wall that had been rained on.

"I have come to be unpleasant," she said.

"Come in. There is a chair. It is the only one."

Marcella sat in the chair and put the basket on the floor and looked around the shed at the door on trestles and the lamp and the bed and the cat.

"You are living in a shed."

"I am living in a shed."

"You are the richest freedwoman in Rome."

"I am the richest freedwoman in Rome and my house has no roof and my strongbox is in the fuller's cellar and my book is in a jar under a floor in Ostia, and I am living in a shed because a shed is what I have." Antonia sat on the chest. "Say what you have come to say."

"My husband has told me everything," Marcella said. "The senate. Gallus. The girl in the cell. The bargain he offered you in the lane and the bargain he did not offer, which is the one where he goes to the prefect and makes a fool of himself and does a decent thing for a slave he has never met." She looked at Antonia. "He has not slept since the wedding. He sits in the tablinum at night with a lamp and he does not read. He has begun to talk to me — actually talk to me, in sentences, about his father and the year 93 and the stone room — and I have discovered in the last month that I have been married for nine years to a man I did not know at all, and that the man I did not know is worse than the one I married, and that I prefer him."

"That is a strange thing to say."

"It is a strange thing to discover." Marcella's hands were folded in her lap. "I came to ask you not to do it."

"The senate."

"The senate. Take the bargain. Let the girl be freed by the praetor in the afternoon with the doors closed and the record made and no speeches. Let him go to Asia with his name and his debts and his bad nights. Let my stepdaughter be a woman whose father went

to a province and came back and was dull at dinner." Marcella looked at her. "You have a daughter. You have spent eighteen years wanting one thing. You are about to get it, and you are about to spend it on a speech."

Antonia was silent for a moment.

"Yes," she said.

"Then do not."

"I am going to do it," Antonia said, "and I am going to tell you why, and you are not going to like it, and you are going to go home and be angry with me for a year." She leaned forward. "If I take the bargain, the girl is freed and the record is made and your husband goes to Asia, and in ten years there is not a man in Rome who remembers that anything happened. My daughter will be a freedwoman who was freed by a praetor, quietly, for reasons that nobody wrote down. And every time she meets a man who knows, she will see him decide not to mention it. That is what a quiet freeing is. It is a thing that is done and not said, and a thing that is not said belongs to the man who did it, not to the woman it was done to."

Marcella looked at her.

"And if it is said?"

"Then it is said in the room where the men who govern this city sit, in front of the men who are going to decide whether your husband governs Asia, and it will be written down by a clerk, and it will be in the record of the senate of Rome for as long as there is a senate of Rome, and no man will be able to decide not to mention it." Antonia's voice was steady. "She will be the girl whose mother stood up in the senate house. That is not a small thing. In this city, that is the only kind of thing that lasts."

Marcella sat in the chair with her hands in her lap.

"You are going to destroy my husband," she said.

"Yes."

"And my stepdaughter."

"Probably."

"And yourself."

"Yes."

Marcella looked at the basket on the floor and then at the cat, which had come back in and was sitting on the chest, and then at Antonia.

"I brought you food," she said. "It is in the basket. It is a chicken and some bread and a jar of the wine my father sends from Puteoli, and I brought it because I have been told that you are living on bread and olives in a shed, and because I am unable to have a conversation with a woman I admire without feeding her." She stood up. "Do not thank me. And do not expect me to come to the senate house."

"I do not expect it."

"I will be in the portico outside, in a litter, with the curtains drawn, and I will hear all of it, and I will not come in, and afterward I will go home and I will not speak to my husband for a week." Marcella went to the door. "That is the best I can do, and it is more than you deserve, and it is less than I would like."

She went out to the litter. At the door of the shed she stopped.

"The girl in the cell," she said. "The Dacian."

"Yes."

"My husband will get her out. He has already begun. He went to the prefect on the fourth day before the Ides and he made a fool of himself in the prefect's own tablinum, and he came home and told me about it in sentences, and I have never seen him so pleased with himself in nine years." She looked back. "He is a poor creature, my husband. But he is doing a decent thing, and I find that I am glad of it, and I am telling you because there is no one else I can tell."

She got into the litter, and the bearers took her away down the Clivus, and Antonia stood in the doorway of the shed with the basket of chicken and wine in her hands and the cat winding around

her ankles, and the whole Subura going about its business in the October sun.

She went back to the house and worked until dark, and then she walked up the Clivus to the corner where the lanes met and stood looking down at the ruin of her own front door.

The gilt was gone. The studs were black. The door itself was standing, because it was oak and iron and it had been made by a man who knew his trade, but it had a hole in it the size of a man's head where the vigiles had put an axe through it, and through the hole she could see the passage and the black stairs.

Tullia came up the lane with a lamp and a basket.

"You have not eaten," she said. "Again. The builder says the beam will be eleven hundred and he will not come down, and the mosaic man says he can save the atrium floor if he starts in the spring, and the fuller's wife says she will keep the girls in the yard until the roof is on, and the fuller's wife is a good woman and she is charging you four hundred a month for a shed."

"Pay her six."

"Domina."

"Pay her six hundred a month and tell her it is for the shed," Antonia said, "and that I know it is not for the shed."

Tullia put the basket down.

"What has happened?" she said.

"Verus came."

"I saw him."

"He offered me the other bargain." Antonia told her, standing in the ash of the lane with the lamp between them. "The case, the girl freed, the record, and Dessa out of the cell, and the man who forged the bill in front of the prefect. And nothing in the senate. And Gallus goes on being angry for the rest of his life."

"And if you take it?"

"Then in ten years Verus will be a proconsul who was once a man who bought a child, and the girl will be a freedwoman in a house on the Aventine, and nobody in Rome will remember that it cost anything, and it will have cost everything, and there will be no record of it except in my book, and the book will be a book of names." Antonia looked at the hole in the door. "And Dessa will be out of the cell, and that is not nothing. That is a great deal. She is twenty years old and she has been in a cell for three months and she is going to be questioned in December about what she saw in the garden, and if she is questioned she will not come out of it with a whole hand."

Tullia was silent for a while.

"And if you do not take it?" she said.

"Then I go into the senate house in November and I tell the whole of it, and the whole city hears it, and the girl is freed in the afternoon and Dessa goes on being in the cell, and I do not know what happens to her." Antonia's voice was steady. "And Verus is finished and Verianus is finished and Marcella is a woman whose husband was destroyed in the senate house, and Publia will be a woman whose father was destroyed a month after her wedding, and I will have done to her exactly what he did to me."

Tullia looked at her.

"You are not asking me which is right," she said.

"No."

"You are asking me which one you can live with."

"Yes."

Tullia bent and picked up the basket.

"I have been with you nine years," she said. "In nine years I have watched you do a great many hard things in a particular order, and the order has always been the house first, and the women second, and yourself last. And I have never once seen you choose the thing

that was good for you, and I have sometimes thought that it was because you did not think you deserved it, and I have sometimes thought that it was the only thing about you that was not for sale."

"And now?"

"Now I think that you are standing in a lane with a hole in your door and a dead man in the ground and a girl in a cell, and you are asking a freedwoman with a basket which of two bad things she can live with, and the truth is that you will not be able to live with either of them." Tullia put the lamp in her hand. "So you will have to choose the one that will do the most good for the people who are left, and I am telling you, as the woman who keeps your accounts, that the people who are left are not the ones in the senate house."

She wrote to Gallus that night, and she wrote it three times, and the third one said:

I will do it. I will stand in the senate house and say all of it. But not on the day of the case. On the day before, so that the praetor hears the case knowing what was said, and the whole city has a night to think about it before the girl is produced.

And I will not say a word about your son. Not one word. You will say it, or no one will. I have done enough to you.

If you want to withdraw as adsertor, withdraw now. I will not think less of you. I would think less of a man who stayed.

The answer came back within the hour, on a scrap of tablet, in the old man's hand.

I will not withdraw. I have been a consular for sixteen years and have never once done a thing that mattered. I do not intend to begin now.

One correction. You will say one word about my son, and the word is his name.

Bring the girl to the court on the Ides of November. I will be there at the second hour with the papers and the witnesses and a very bad cold, which I intend to use to make the house listen to me.

L. Iunius Gallus.

Antonia sat in the back room of the fuller's shed with the letter in her hand, and outside the shed the Subura was being the Subura, and she laughed until she had to put her hand over her mouth.

PART FOUR

THE CAUSA

CHAPTER XIX

THE DECEMVIRI

Rome, the Ides of November, AD 112

The court sat in the Basilica Julia, in the great hall on the south side, where the light came in from the square and the noise of the Forum came in with it, and where the praetor urbanus heard cases of status on the Ides and the Kalends and, if the weather was bad and the calendar was full, on any day he chose.

By the second hour the hall was full.

Antonia had expected a crowd. She had not expected this. There were the parties, and the advocates, and the clerks, and the eight men of the jury bench if the praetor called one, and then there were the others: the clients and the hangers-on and the men who came to the basilica every morning because the basilica was where the news was; and behind them, at the back, in the shadows of the great columns, the women.

The women were not supposed to be there. A woman could appear in a status case as a party, or as a witness if the praetor allowed it, but the rest of it — the audience, the watching, the being seen to watch — was not a woman's business, and the women who had come had come early and had taken the dark corners behind the columns, and they were there in their dozens.

Antonia came in at the second hour with Tullia and Hilarus and Myrtale.

Myrtale had come from Ficulea the night before, in a hired carriage, with Iusta the midwife and a bundle and a face that had gone

very still. She was in a plain white dress and a grey mantle, and her hair was up, and she had the token on its cord around her neck, outside her dress, in the sight of everyone.

"Are you frightened?" Antonia said, in the carriage.

"Yes."

"Good. So am I." She had taken the girl's hand. "There is a thing you must understand about this room before you go into it. The men in there are going to talk about you as though you were a piece of furniture. They will say *the person claimed*, and *the value*, and *the title*, and they will not look at you. Do not be angry. Be still. And when the praetor asks you your name, say it in a voice that the whole hall can hear, and say the name I gave you."

"Cassia," Myrtale said.

"Cassia," Antonia said. "Say it again."

"Cassia."

"Again."

"Cassia."

Before the court sat, Verianus came out of the shadows of the colonnade.

He was sober. That was the first thing Antonia noticed, and it was more frightening than the drinking had been. He was in the broad stripe and his hair was cut and he had the look of a man who has been up all night with a cold cloth on his forehead.

"Domina," he said.

"Decemvir."

"I am to sit on the bench today."

"I know."

"I have applied to be excused and the application has been refused, and my father has told me that if I sit on that bench and do my duty by the law, he will not speak to me again, and if I do not sit

on it, the praetor will have me removed and the whole city will know why." He stood in front of her with his hands at his sides. "I am twenty years old and I have been drunk for six months and I have not slept for a week, and I am asking you to tell me what to do."

Antonia looked at him.

"I am the last person in Rome you should ask," she said.

"I know. That is why I am asking." Verianus's voice was very quiet. "You are the only person in this who has never once lied to me about what I am."

Antonia looked at the colonnade and the morning crowd and the light on the marble, and she thought about the boy in the fountain with his palms turned up, and the boy's father in a garden with a boy on his knee, and the nineteen masks in a cupboard and the actor with the mask pushed back on his head.

"Go and sit on your bench," she said, "and do your duty by the law, and do not look at your father, and do not look at me. And afterward, when it is over and the girl is free or not free, you will come and find me, and you will tell me what happened in that lane in April, and I will listen to all of it, and then you will have to decide what to do about it, and I will not help you with that."

Verianus's face did something.

"You know," he said.

"I know there was a ring in the lane and a man who went away down the hill. I do not know what happened in the garden. I have never known, and I have never asked, and there is a part of me that does not want to know." Antonia looked at him. "But I have a girl in a cell in the prefect's office who saw a man in the lane, and she is going to be questioned in December about what she saw, and if she is questioned, she will not come out of it with a whole hand. So you may sit on your bench today and do your duty by the law, and then

you may come and find me and tell me the truth, and if the truth is what I think it is, we will have a great deal to say to each other."

Verianus looked at her for a long moment.

"I will sit on the bench," he said, "and I will do my duty by the law."

He went in.

❦

Gallus was at the second hour with a cold, a roll of papers, and three witnesses.

He had a fever, and his nose was red, and his voice was a wreck, and he had been up half the night with the papers, and he was the most magnificent thing Antonia had ever seen in a public place. He came across the hall to her with the roll under his arm and stood in front of her and blew his nose into a cloth.

"You are late," he said.

"I am punctual."

"You are late, and you are pale, and you are wearing the blue stola, which is a good choice, because it makes you look like a respectable widow instead of the most dangerous woman in Rome." He looked over her shoulder at Myrtale and his face did something complicated. "This is she."

"This is she."

Gallus looked at the girl for a long moment. Then he said, "Domina, I am Lucius Iunius Gallus, and I am going to stand up in that court and say that you are free, and I want you to know before I do it that I have lost a son this year, and that I am not doing this for you, and that I intend to do it properly anyway."

Myrtale looked at him.

"I am sorry for your son," she said.

Gallus's face twisted. He turned away and blew his nose again, and when he turned back he was a consular.

"Right," he said. "Now. The praetor is Marcus Acilius Strabo, and he is a decent man and a lazy one, and he does not like a spectacle, and he does not like to be hurried. The decemvirs will sit with him, and one of them is Verus's son, and I have applied to have him excused on the ground of interest, and the application will be refused, because a decemvir is not excused for interest, he is excused for a defect of status, and Verianus has no defect of status, he has a father." He blew his nose. "So we will have him on the bench, and he will sit there for six hours, and he will either be a man or he will not."

The praetor came in at the third hour and the court rose.

Marcus Acilius Strabo was sixty and had the look of a man who had been sitting in this hall for thirty years and had heard every story that could be told in it. He took his seat, and the decemvirs took theirs on the bench to his right, and Verianus Cassius was the third from the end, in a white tunic with the broad stripe, and he was sober, and he was grey, and he did not look at his father, who was sitting on the bench to the left with his advocate.

The clerk read the matter.

A question of status, in the matter of a person claimed, a woman of about eighteen years, held in the household of Manius Cassius Verus, consular. The freedom of the said person is asserted by Lucius Iunius Gallus, consular, as adsertor libertatis. The said person is claimed as a slave by Manius Cassius Verus, consular, who holds her in his household and who has produced her before this court.

The praetor looked up.

"The person is produced?"

"She is produced, domine," said the clerk.

"Let her stand before the bench."

Myrtale came forward through the crowd. She walked the way a girl walks who has been taught to walk in a great house, and she came to the middle of the floor and stood in front of the praetor's bench with her hands at her sides and her chin up and the token on its cord around her neck, and the whole hall looked at her.

Antonia stood in the fourth rank of the crowd with her hands folded and her heart going like a hammer and her eyes on her daughter's back.

"The adsertor," the praetor said. "You may state your claim."

Gallus stood up.

He had a cold, and his voice was a ruin, and he began badly: he began with the law, and the law is a thing that makes men's eyes glaze. He spoke for a quarter of an hour about the principle that a child born to a free mother is free, and about the burden that lies on the man who holds a person to show his title, and about the lex Fabia.

The hall shifted. A man near the back said something to his neighbour. The praetor looked at the water-clock.

And then Gallus stopped in the middle of a sentence about the *causa liberalis*, and blew his nose, and said, "Domine, I am making a botch of this, and the reason is that I have a fever and I have not slept, and I am going to do the thing that every advocate has told me not to do, which is to tell the court what actually happened."

The hall went quiet.

"There was a slave in the household of the elder Cassius Verus," Gallus said, "in the year 93, and her name was Prima. She was nineteen. She was the ornatrix of the house, and she could read, and she was manumitted by Cassia Severa on the eleventh day before the Kalends of December of that year, and the manumission is in the record and the record is in the archive of the fourteenth region and the clerk has brought a copy. She was free from that day. In the following September she bore a daughter in a room above a fuller's shop

on the Aventine, and the midwife who attended the birth is in this court today, and will tell you what she saw. She saw a lead token tied to the baby's wrist, and she saw the child taken three months later by a litter, and she was paid by a slave called Chryseros to forget it and she did not forget it."

The praetor leaned forward.

"In the same year," Gallus said, "a dealer in the Subura named Bassa sold a child of three months to the household of Cassius Verus, and her book says so, and her book is in this court as an exhibit. The price was ninety thousand sesterces, which is ten times the price of a healthy adult, and it was not paid in money: it was written as a debt owed by the slave Chryseros to his master, and beside it, in the hand of Manius Cassius Verus, there is a note which reads, *for the child, from Bassa, and no more to be said.*" He paused. "That child is standing in front of you."

The hall made a sound.

"The defendant," Gallus said, "holds her and produces her and has produced no title, because there is no title. He cannot produce a bill of sale, because the purchase was written as a debt. He cannot produce the dealer, because she is dead. He cannot produce the slave, because he is dead. What he can produce is a household in which a freeborn woman has been held for eighteen years as a maid, and a note in his own hand, and a woman who has waited nineteen years to stand in this hall and say her daughter's name."

He sat down.

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The praetor looked at the papers in front of him for a long moment.

"The defendant," he said. "You may answer."

Verus stood up.

He was in a plain toga, and he had come alone, without clients, without his wife, without his son, and he stood in the middle of the hall of the Basilica Julia with the whole of Rome looking at him.

"I have no answer," he said.

The silence in the hall was a physical thing.

"I claim the person," Verus said. "I have held her. I have no title to produce. The note in my hand is mine, and the debt is mine, and the purchase was mine, and the household is mine, and the girl has been in it for eighteen years and I have not freed her and I have not told her what she is." His voice was steady. "There is no answer. The adsertor has stated the matter correctly."

The praetor sat back.

"The court will hear the witnesses," he said.

❦

Iusta the midwife was sixty-eight and had delivered four hundred children and had never in her life spoken in a public place. She came forward with her hands folded and her chin trembling and she told it in the flat, detailed way that a midwife tells a birth: the room, the hour, the nine hours of it, the girl's name, the mark on the wrist, the token. She told it twice, because the praetor asked her to tell it again, and the second time she told it better, because she had found the rhythm of it.

Then the exhibits. Bassa's page, sealed and copied and read out. The manumission record, read out. The garden, the vine, the room behind the kitchen, the fifty-one times — no, the fifty-one times were not in court, because the fifty-one times were not law, and Gallus had been right not to put them in.

Then the mother.

"The court will hear the witness Antonia Cassia," the praetor said. "The witness is a freedwoman of the household of Cassia Severa, manumitted in the consulship of Pompeius Collega and

Priscinus, and she appears as a witness in a question of status, and the court has been informed that she is the person who asserts herself to be the mother of the person claimed." He looked up. "Domina, you will speak to the court, and you will remember that everything you say will be written down."

Antonia came out of the fourth rank and stood in the middle of the floor.

She had stood in this hall before. Not in the middle of it, and not in the blue stola: she had stood at the back of it eleven times in eleven years, with a tablet, in a corner, waiting for a clerk, in the way that a woman with money and no standing waits for a clerk. She had never once been in the middle of it.

"I was born in the house of the Cassii," she said. "I was a slave of that household until the eleventh day before the Kalends of December in the year 93, when I was manumitted before the praetor by Cassia Severa, and the record is in the archive and the clerk has read it to this court. In the September of the following year I bore a daughter in a room above a fuller's shop on the Aventine, and the midwife Iusta attended the birth, and she has told this court what she saw: a girl, with a mark like a crescent on her left wrist, and a lead token tied to the wrist, and the token struck with a wreath on one side and a door on the other and snapped across the middle."

She held up her hand. In it was the other half.

"The door half was mine," she said. "The wreath half went with the child. The girl in front of this bench is wearing it."

The praetor leaned forward. Antonia put the half-token on the table in front of him, and the clerk brought the girl forward, and the girl lifted the cord over her head and put the token down beside it, and the two halves lay on the table with the break between them.

The praetor put them together himself.

There was no sound in the hall at all.

"It is one token," he said.

"It is one token," Antonia said. "I had it struck at a shop in the Subura for four sesterces, because I had nothing else to give her, and because I knew that a man who took her would take her name, and I wanted her to have one thing that had not been given to her by the man who kept her."

"Who took the child?"

"The man in this court who has just told the court that he has no answer." Antonia's voice was steady. "He came for her three days after I had agreed to give her up, in a litter, with the nurse, at the sixth hour, when the lane was empty. He put her in the litter and he carried her down the stairs of a house above a fuller's shop, and he promised me that he would free her at sixteen and give her a name, and he swore it by the household gods of the Cassii, and he did not do it."

Verus sat on the bench with his hands on his knees and did not look up.

"Why did you give her up?" the praetor said.

Antonia looked at him.

"Because I had eleven sesterces a month for the room," she said, "and there was no work for a woman with a child, and the man who kept the house was a gambler who had begun to talk about the price of a woman in the Subura, and because I was twenty years old and I believed him." She paused. "And because I have told myself for eighteen years that I had no choice, and that is not true. I had a choice. It was a bad one, and I chose it, and I have been paying for it ever since, and I would like the court to write that down as well as the rest, because I am not here to be a good woman. I am here to be a true one."

The praetor looked at her for a long moment.

"The court will write it down," he said.

Then Myrtale.

"The person claimed," the praetor said. "What is your name?"

Myrtale stood in front of the bench.

"Cassia," she said, in a voice that the whole hall could hear.

"Cassia," the praetor said. "Who gave you that name?"

"My mother," Myrtale said.

The hall made a sound again, a different one this time, and Antonia stood in the fourth rank of the crowd and did not move.

"Do you know your mother?"

"I met her in September," Myrtale said. "In the house where I was a slave. She came at night with four men and a boat, and she told me who I was, and I did not believe her at first, and then I did."

"And what did she tell you?"

"That I was born free, and that a man had held me for eighteen years, and that there was a case, and that I would have to stand in a court and say my name in front of a room full of men." Myrtale's voice did not shake. "And that if I did not, no one in Rome would ever be able to say that I had been free."

The praetor looked at her for a long moment.

"Domina," he said, "I am going to ask you a question and you will answer it truthfully, and it does not matter what the answer is, and nobody in this hall will be permitted to make a noise about it. Do you wish to be free?"

The hall was so quiet that Antonia could hear the water-clock.

"I am free," Myrtale said. "The question is whether Rome will say so."

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That should have been the end of it.

The praetor had the papers, the admissions, the record, the midwife, the girl's own voice. He had a defendant who had declined to answer and an adsertor who had stated the case. Antonia, standing in the fourth rank with her hands folded, had begun — for the first time in eight months — to let herself think about the afternoon.

And then the man stood up at the back of the hall.

"Domine," he said. "I appear."

The praetor looked up. "In what matter?"

"In the matter of the person claimed. I am Caesennius Rufus, equestrian, of the house of Caesennius, and I have an interest in this person, and I have a document which the court has not seen." He came forward through the crowd. He was fifty-four and grey and solid, and he was holding a scroll, and he was not a man who had come to make a scene: he was a man who had come to do a piece of business. "The person claimed was conveyed to my household on the fourth day before the Kalends of September as part of the dowry of my wife, Publia Cassia, and the conveyance is written in the marriage instrument, which was signed by her father and witnessed and sealed, and which I produce."

The hall exploded.

The praetor struck the arm of his chair three times with his staff.

"Silence," he said. "Silence, or I will clear the hall and hear the case in an empty room." He took the scroll from Caesennius and looked at it for a long time. Then he looked up. "The instrument is regular. It is signed by Manius Cassius Verus and witnessed by four men, and it conveys to the household of Caesennius Rufus, among other property, a female slave named Myrtale, valued at twelve thousand sesterces."

The clerk wrote. The decemvirs looked at each other.

"The court is obliged to observe," the praetor said, slowly, "that the defendant in this matter has produced the person claimed, and has no title to her, and has now admitted as much. The court is also obliged to observe that the marriage instrument produced by Caesennius Rufus is a conveyance executed before the fact of this hearing, that it purports to convey the person claimed to a third party, and that the third party is now before the court claiming an interest." He set the scroll down. "The question the court must de-

termine is whether the person claimed was free at the time of the conveyance. If she was not free, the instrument conveys her. If she was free, the instrument conveys nothing at all, because a man cannot convey a free person, and the instrument is evidence of a crime."

He looked at Gallus.

"The adsertor has made his case. The claimant has produced an instrument. The court will hear argument on the instrument on the Nones of December, in this hall, at the second hour, and in the meantime the person claimed will remain in the custody of the court and not in the household of either party."

The hall broke. The clerks began to gather the tablets. Caesennius Rufus was standing with his scroll in his hand, looking at nothing, and at the back of the hall a woman in a drawn litter had opened the curtains.

Gallus got up.

"Domine," he said, "the person claimed is a girl of eighteen who has spent her life in a household where —"

"On the Nones of December," the praetor said, and rose, and the court rose, and the hearing was over.

They came out of the basilica into the Forum, and the sun was on the marble and the whole square was going about its business as though a girl had not just said her name in front of the whole of Rome.

Antonia stood on the steps with her hand on the stone.

"December," Gallus said. "Three weeks. Three weeks, and he produces a marriage instrument, and the question becomes whether the conveyance conveyed a free person." He blew his nose. "It is a bad three weeks and a good case. The instrument is the best thing that could have happened."

"How can it be the best thing?"

"Because it puts the crime in writing," Gallus said, "and because it is signed by four witnesses, and because it makes Caesennius Rufus a party, and a party with a cousin on the council does not want to be a party to a crime under the lex Fabia. He will settle. His advocate will come to me within the week and offer to give her up and pay the costs and say nothing, and we will refuse, and he will offer more, and we will refuse again, and he will begin to be frightened."

"And the senate?"

"The senate is the day before the case," Gallus said. "The day before the Nones. I have asked the consuls for the house to hear you, and the consul has said that the house will hear a statement of fact from a woman of the city if a consular vouches for her and if the statement concerns a matter before a court. He is a careful man and he has covered himself in three directions." He looked at her. "You have three weeks to find a reason for the senate to do more than listen."

"What reason?"

"Plotina," Gallus said. "The empress is in Rome until the Kalends. She is the only person in this city who can make an office move in a week, and she has a garden, and you have been standing at the gate of it since August." He put on his hat. "Go and see her. And domina — when you go, do not go as a petitioner. Go as a woman who knows something she does not."

Publia was waiting at the foot of the steps.

She was in a dark mantle with her hair covered and her veil down, and she had come alone, on foot, from the house on the Caelian, and she was out of breath and her eyes were enormous.

"I heard," she said. "The whole street heard. A girl stood up in the Basilica Julia and gave her name, and they say the praetor put the two halves of a token together on the table and the hall went silent." She caught Antonia's hands. "Is she free?"

"Not yet. December. There is a document and a third party and three weeks." Antonia looked at her. "Your husband is the third party."

Publia's face changed.

"He came to the court," Antonia said. "He produced the marriage instrument, and he read it out, and the instrument conveys Myrtale to his household as part of your dowry, and he is now a party to the case."

"He said nothing to me." Publia's voice was flat. "He said nothing to me at all. He went out at the second hour and he came back for dinner and he talked about the brickfields, and I sat at the table and listened to a man talk about brickfields for an hour, and all the time he had been in a court claiming my maid as property."

"Would you have stopped him?"

"Yes."

"Then he was right not to tell you." Antonia took her by the arm and walked her out of the crowd. "Listen to me. In three weeks there is a second hearing, and the question is whether he can hold her. His advocate will come to Gallus and offer to give her up, and Gallus will refuse, and he will offer more, and Gallus will refuse again, and then he will begin to be frightened. And when he is frightened, Publia, he will come to you, because you are his wife and you are the daughter of the man who signed the instrument, and he will ask you what to do."

"What should I say?"

"Say nothing. Not one word. Let him talk, and look at him, and when he has finished, say: *I do not know, Titus. I am only a woman.*" Antonia's eyes were hard. "A man who is used to being clever will talk himself into a corner with a woman who will not help him. It is the oldest trick in Rome, and it works because men cannot bear a silence."

Publia looked at her.

"I hate this," she said. "I hate all of it. I hate the brickfields and the dinner and the calling me by another name and the fact that my father is going to be destroyed and my husband is a third party and I am sixteen years old and I am standing on the steps of a basilica being told to be a wall."

"Then hate it," Antonia said. "Hate it and do it. There is a whole class of women in this city who have done nothing but hate it and do it, and they are the reason anything is ever done at all."

❦

Myrtale was in the carriage with the curtain drawn, and Antonia got in beside her, and they sat for a moment in the noise of the Forum.

"Cassia," Myrtale said.

"Cassia," Antonia said.

"I said it in front of all of them."

"You did."

"They looked at me as though I were a chair that had spoken." Myrtale's hands were shaking, and she looked at them with interest. "I have never been looked at like that. In the house, nobody looked at me at all, and that was worse, and now the whole hall has looked at me, and I find that I do not mind it. I mind it less than being a chair."

Antonia took her hand.

"Three weeks," she said. "And then December, and Caesennius Rufus, and a scroll with a seal on it. And before that, a senate house, and an empress, and a man in a shed in the Subura who is going to have to find a respectable dress."

"Whose dress?"

"Mine," Antonia said. "I have been in a burnt house for two months and I have nothing to wear to the senate house, and I am going to have to buy a dress and a pair of shoes and a chair to be carried

in, and I have exactly one friend in Rome who will pay for all of it and complain about the price."

"Marcella," Myrtale said.

"Marcella," Antonia said, and the carriage went out of the Forum and up the Clivus, and the whole of the afternoon was in front of them.

CHAPTER XX

THE EMPRESS'S GARDEN

Rome, the fourth day before the Nones of December, AD 112

The garden of the house of Pompeia Plotina was not a large garden and it was not a rich one. There was a gravel walk between two beds of box, a fig tree, a bench with a broken arm that had been mended with wire, and at the end of the walk, where the wall turned, a small fountain with a lion's head and a basin full of green water.

Antonia had expected something else. She had expected marble and peacocks; she had expected a garden that said what a garden says when an emperor's wife owns it. What she found was a garden that said nothing at all, and she understood, standing at the gate with Callirhoe's hand on her arm, that this was the garden of a woman who had spent thirty years being looked at and had decided to have one place in the world where nothing was arranged.

While she waited at the gate, a girl came out of the house with a basket of figs and a jug and set them down on the step and said, "The empress says you are to have something while you wait, and that the figs are from the tree at the back and are not very good, and that you are not to say they are good."

"Tell her they are bad," Antonia said, "and that I have eaten four."

The girl went away delighted. Antonia sat on the step of the empress's house with a basket of figs in her lap and the whole Palat-

ine going on above her, and found that her hands had stopped shaking for the first time in three days.

"Walk with me," the empress said.

She was fifty-four and small, and she wore a plain grey dress with no ornament at all but a pair of pearl earrings, and she walked slowly, and she had a way of looking at the ground in front of her feet that was not shyness.

"You are the woman who sent the petition in March," she said.

"I am."

"And in August you stood at my gate for an hour and would not go away."

"Yes."

"Callirhoe has been at that gate for nineteen years and she has never once let a stranger in. She let you in because of a story about her sister." Plotina looked up. "Was it true?"

"The sister was in a house on the Aventine for six years and died in the year of the fire," Antonia said. "Whether the rest of it is true, I do not know. I did not know her."

"No," Plotina said. "You did not. Callirhoe knows that, and she let you in anyway, and she has been in a state about it for a week." She walked a little way in silence. "I have read your petition. I have read it three times. The office has refused it, and the office has written nothing in the book, and there is a young clerk in the office who is going to be dismissed in the spring for a thing he did in August, and he does not know it yet."

Antonia's hands were cold.

"He gave me a copy," she said. "An unsealed copy."

"He gave you a piece of paper that had not been sealed, which is not a copy of anything, and he told you that the book is written up at the end of the quarter, which was true in the reign of Vespasian and has not been true since." Plotina stopped by the fig tree. "He is nineteen. He has a wife and a baby. He will be dismissed and he will

not find another place in the palace, and he will go to the prefect's office, and the prefect's office will take him, because the prefect's office takes everybody."

"Domina."

"Do not." Plotina held up her hand. "I am not telling you this to make you feel guilty. I am telling you because you are about to walk into the senate house and say a great many true things, and I want you to know what a true thing costs in this city before you do it. It costs a nineteen-year-old clerk his place. It costs a tribune of the watch his cohort. It costs a midwife from Ficulea the goodwill of the men she delivers children for." She turned. "It will cost you your house, which is already burnt, and your name, which is the only thing you have that nobody gave you."

Antonia stood by the fig tree.

"You know about the senate house," she said.

"Gallus asked the consuls for the house to hear you, and the consul asked me whether the empress would be embarrassed by it, and I said that the empress would be interested by it." Plotina began to walk again. "The consul was relieved. He had expected me to say something else."

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because I am going to make you an offer," Plotina said, "and I have been thinking about it for three days, and I am going to make it badly, because I have not made an offer to anyone in thirty years without an advocate in the room."

They came to the end of the walk, to the bench with the broken arm and the fountain with the green water, and the empress sat down on the bench and gestured to the other end of it, and Antonia sat.

"Your petition," Plotina said. "The office will not advance it. The office will not advance anything that has Nepos's seal on it, and Nepos has made a representation, and the prefect's office has writ-

ten a letter, and the letter will sit in the file for a year, and in a year the emperor will be in the east and the file will be in a trunk." She looked at the fountain. "But the emperor can grant a rescript by his own hand, without the office, in a case that has been brought to his attention by a member of his household. It has been done. It is done more often than the office likes. And if a rescript of that kind is sealed before the emperor leaves Rome, it cannot be unsealed afterward, because a rescript is not a favor, it is a law."

Antonia looked at her.

"You are offering me the rescript," she said.

"I am offering you the rescript," Plotina said. "Sealed by the emperor's own hand, in the week before he leaves. Restitutio natalium. You would be freeborn, in law, from the day of your birth, and no man in Rome could say otherwise, and the register of the fourteenth region would be corrected, and the whole of the rest of your life would be a different thing."

Antonia sat on the bench with her hands in her lap.

"And in return?" she said.

"In return," Plotina said, "you will do what you were going to do anyway, and do it a great deal better. You will go into the senate house and you will tell them everything: the year 93, the stone room, the girl, the note, the household. And then you will tell them about the seals."

"The seals."

"The prefect's office is a machine for the selling of seals. It has been a machine for the selling of seals since the reign of Domitian, and every emperor since has known it and has done nothing, because the machine is useful and because the men who run it are freedmen and a freedman can be dismissed. But the emperor is going east, and the east is a war, and a war is won with grain and money and roads, and the grain and the money and the roads all pass through the prefect's office, and every seal that is sold in that office

is a hole in the hull." Plotina's voice was quiet and entirely without emotion. "There is a freedman called Anicetus. There is a freedman called Felix, who carries messages and has a burn on his hand. There is a man called Oppius Nepos, who is not in the office and who has been paying for seals for twenty years, and who is not an equestrian."

Antonia did not move.

"You know about Nepos," she said.

"I have known about Nepos for four years," Plotina said. "His father was an auctioneer's clerk and a slave, and the manumission is in the guild's book, and the guild's book is in a strongroom that three men must open, and one of the three is a senator who has been bought by Nepos and one of the three is a freedman who is frightened of him and one of the three is an old man in a shop in the Vicus Tuscus who has no teeth and remembers everything." She looked at Antonia. "You have been to see him. In May, and again in June. He has written to me twice about it. He is a very conscientious old man and he does not approve of you."

Antonia laughed. It came out of her unexpectedly, and it was not a happy sound.

"Domina," she said. "Why have you not done it yourself?"

"Because a woman of my household cannot appear in the senate house, and because a prefect cannot be accused by the emperor's wife, and because the moment this is said by someone with an interest, it becomes a faction. If I move against the prefect's office, it is the empress against the prefect, and the prefect will say that the empress is meddling in the grain supply, and the emperor will have to choose between his wife and his prefect, and he will choose the prefect, because the prefect has the watch and the grain and the Guard." Plotina turned her head. "But if a freedwoman stands up in the senate house on the day before a case and says, in her own voice, that she was questioned for eleven hours in the year 93 and that the

men who bought her silence are the men who sell the emperor's seals — then it is not the empress against the prefect. It is a wronged woman against a corrupt office, and no emperor in the world can afford to be seen to defend a corrupt office against a wronged woman."

The fountain ran in the green basin.

"Domina," Antonia said, "may I ask you a question that is not about the senate?"

"You may ask. I may not answer."

"Your family is from Nemausus."

"Your family is from Nemausus," Plotina said, "and my father was a magistrate there and a citizen of Rome and an equestrian, and there is not a drop of patrician blood in me, and the first time I walked into the palace the wife of the consul looked at my shoes." She smiled. "I have never forgotten the shoes. I was thirty-one years old, and I had been married to a soldier for eleven years, and I had bought the best shoes I could afford, and they were not the right shoes."

"And now?"

"Now I have a hundred pairs of the right shoes," the empress said, "and I have discovered that a woman in the right shoes is listened to with exactly the same attention as a woman in the wrong ones, and that the difference is entirely in the head of the man who is listening." She stopped by the fig tree. "Your petition has been refused for a reason that is not written in the file. The reason is that a freedwoman who is made freeborn by a rescript becomes a woman who can marry a senator. There is not a family in Rome that wants that door opened. The office did not refuse you because of the house of pleasure or the aediles or the forged papers. The office refused you because a door that opens once can be opened again."

"Then why are you opening it?"

"Because the door has been shut for a hundred years and it is not the only door," Plotina said. "And because I have spent thirty years being told that a woman cannot do a thing, and I have found that what they mean is that a woman cannot do it without a man, and I have found that a man can be found for almost anything if the price is right, and that the price of a man is always the same: he wants to be seen to have done it himself."

"You have been planning this for four years," Antonia said.

"I have been waiting four years for a woman with a grievance and evidence and nothing to lose," Plotina said. "I did not expect her to be a freedwoman with a burnt house and a book of names. I expected a senator's widow."

"Domina, I am a woman who keeps a house of pleasure."

"You are a woman who kept a house of pleasure, and it burnt down in September, and you have been living in a shed behind a fuller's yard for two months, and you have not asked anyone for anything except a dress and a chair to be carried in." Plotina looked at her. "I have been in this city for thirty years. I can tell the difference between a woman who has a house of pleasure and a woman who has a house of business. The difference is in the accounts."

Antonia sat on the bench with her hands in her lap and the fountain running.

"There is a girl," she said. "In the prefect's office. Her name is Dessa and she is a slave of my household, and she was taken from Ostia in July with a forged bill of sale and a genuine seal, and she is going to be questioned in December about what she saw in my garden in April."

Plotina was silent for a moment.

"The questioning has been ordered?"

"Yes."

"By whom?"

"By the prefect's office, at the request of a magistrate."

"Which magistrate?"

"I do not know the name. I know that the order exists, and that it was made in October, and that the girl has been in a cell since July."

Plotina looked at the fountain for a long time.

"If I move against the prefect's office," she said, "the office will know that I have moved, and the order will be executed before I can stop it. If I do nothing, the order will be executed in December anyway." She turned. "There is one thing I can do, and it is not a favor to the girl. It is a favor to the record. I can have the order transferred from the prefect's office to the office of the urban prefect, and the urban prefect is Petronius Celer, who is lazy and honest and will not order a slave questioned about a death that has already been written as an accident unless someone makes him. That will buy a month. Perhaps two."

"A month is not enough. The case is on the Nones."

"Then you will have to be quick," Plotina said, "and I will have to be quicker, and neither of us will be able to say afterward that we were not warned."

She walked Antonia to the gate herself.

At the gate, with Callirhoe standing at her stool with her hands folded, the empress stopped.

"There is a question I ask everyone who comes to this garden," she said. "Most of them lie. I would like you to try not to."

"Ask it."

"What do you want?"

Antonia stood at the gate of a garden on the Palatine in the fourth day before the Nones of December.

"Ten years ago I would have said the rescript," she said. "Five years ago I would have said my house. In March I would have said

my daughter." She looked at the empress. "Now I want to be in a room where the truth is worth something. That is all. I want to say a thing in a room full of men and have it be worth more than the money they were paid to forget it."

Plotina looked at her for a long moment.

"That is a very dangerous thing to want," she said, "and it is the only thing worth wanting, and I have wanted it myself for thirty years and I have never once been in a room where I could say it." She held out her hand. "Come to the palace on the day after the senate. The emperor leaves for the east in the spring, and there is a great deal to do before then, and a rescript is a small thing in a large list, but it will be on the list. Bring the man from the guild. Bring the page from the dealer. Bring the record of the manumission and the decree of the praetor when you have it."

"Domina."

"And Antonia Cassia." The empress's hand was small and dry and surprisingly strong. "When you are in that room tomorrow, do not be modest. Modesty is a virtue for women who have something to lose. You have a shed and a cat."

❦

Gallus came to the shed that night with a cold that had gone into his chest and a list of the rules of the senate house written out on three tablets.

"You will be brought in at the second hour," he said. "You will be brought in by me, and you will stand at the doors, not in the middle of the floor. You will not approach the consuls' bench. You will not raise your voice. You will not weep; if you weep they will decide that you are a woman and they will stop listening; if you feel it coming, stop speaking and count to ten and start again." He wiped his nose. "You will speak for no more than a quarter of an hour. The consul has agreed to a quarter of an hour, and a quarter

of an hour in that room is a very long time; most men cannot fill five minutes without saying something they regret."

"Who will be there?"

"Three hundred men, more or less. The consuls. The consulars. The praetors. The tribunes of the plebs, who will be insulted that they were not consulted. The decemvirs, if they are sitting. The emperor's freedmen, in the gallery, taking notes, which is the only part of it that matters; whatever is written down by the ab epistulis is what the emperor will read, and everything else is noise." Gallus sat down heavily on the chest. "And Verus will be there, because he is a consular and he has the right. And Nepos will be there, because he has been buying himself a seat in that gallery for twenty years. And Attianus will be there, because Attianus is always there."

"What do I call them?"

"You call the consuls *consul*, and you call the rest of them *patres conscripti* if you must address the house, and you do not call any man by his own name unless you are accusing him, and then you call him by his full name, three names, slowly, and you look at him while you do it." Gallus's eyes were bright with fever. "And domina — there will be a moment, about halfway through, when a man at the back will say something, and another man will laugh, and the room will begin to move. They do it to everyone. They did it to me in the year 96. You will have about six seconds to decide whether you are a woman who is speaking to the senate of Rome or a woman who is being laughed at by a room full of men, and whatever you decide in those six seconds is what you will be for the rest of your life."

"What did you do?"

"I stopped," Gallus said, "and I looked at the man who had laughed, and I said, *I am speaking*, and I waited. It took eleven seconds. Nobody has ever laughed at me in that room again."

Antonia looked at the old man.

"You are very good at this," she said.

"I am a great deal better at this than I was at being consul," Gallus said. "In the consulship I sat in a chair and signed things and was told by a clerk what the things were. It was the most useless year of my life, and I have thought about it every day since, and I have come to believe that the whole of the Roman state is designed so that a man may hold the highest office in the world and never once be required to do anything." He blew his nose. "It is a very clever design, and it is why the empire works, and it is why nothing ever changes, and it is why a woman with a shed and a book is the most dangerous thing in the city."

"I am a consular of Rome with a fever and a shed to sit in," Gallus said, "and it has taken me fifty-nine years to find the one thing I am actually good at, and it is telling a woman how to be listened to by men who do not want to listen."

❦

Myrtale came up from the fuller's yard at the tenth hour with a bowl of soup and a face that Antonia had learned to read.

"You have been crying," Antonia said.

"I have not."

"You have. Your eyes are red and you have been at the fuller's shed with the cat, and you have been thinking about tomorrow, and you have decided something and you are afraid to tell me."

Myrtale put the soup down.

"I am coming to the senate house," she said.

"No."

"I am coming to the senate house, and I am going to sit in the gallery with the women, and when you have finished speaking I am going to stand up and say my name, and let them look at me."

"Cassia."

"You have spent eight months telling me that the whole point of this is that a thing which is not said is a thing that belongs to the

man who did it," Myrtale said. "And tomorrow you are going to say it, in front of three hundred men, and if I am not there, then it is a woman saying what was done to a girl who is somewhere else. And they will say, where is the girl? And the answer will be, in a shed behind a fuller's yard, being kept safe. And that is exactly what he did. He kept me safe for eighteen years."

Antonia stood in the middle of the shed with the soup going cold on the table.

"You are right," she said.

"I know I am right."

"You are right, and I hate it, and I am going to allow it, and there will be a condition." Antonia took her by the shoulders. "You will sit with Tullia. You will not stand until I have finished and the consul has thanked me. And when you stand up, you will say your name and nothing else, and you will not answer a single question that any man in that room asks you, because a girl who answers questions in the senate house is a girl who has agreed to be examined, and you are not there to be examined. You are there to be seen."

"Cassia," Myrtale said.

"Cassia," Antonia said. "Now eat the soup. You have not eaten, and tomorrow is a long day, and I am not going to have my daughter faint in the senate house before she has said her name."

❦

The dress came from Marcella's own wardrobe, and it was dark green, and it fitted at the shoulder and was too long, and Rufina sat up half the night with a lamp and a needle taking up the hem.

The chair came from a man in the Vicus Tuscus who hired litters by the day, and it was not a litter, it was a chair with a leather roof and two poles, and the bearers were two brothers from the

Transtiberim who had been recommended by Vindex and who did not ask questions.

The book came from Ostia, in a jar, in a sack of grain, on a boat, and Tullia carried it up the Clivus herself at the fourth hour of the morning and put it on the table in the shed.

It was damp at the edges and the oiled cloth had kept out most of the water, and Antonia opened it on the table with the lamp beside it and turned the pages.

Eleven years. Four hundred and six names. Loans and gifts and favors and dates and, beside some of them, in Tullia's small hand or her own, a word or two about what the man had been afraid of.

She turned to the page with the praetor's name. She turned to the page with the name of the man who had bought her silence in the year 95. She turned to the page where a knight had written, in his own hand, that he would be grateful for the rest of his life, and where she had written, in hers, *he will not be*.

"You cannot take all of it into the senate house," Tullia said.

"No."

"You will be asked to name names."

"I will name four."

"Which four?"

"Anicetus, who sells the seals. Felix, who carries them. Nepos, who buys them." Antonia turned another page. "And the man who bought my silence in the year 95, because he is on the emperor's council and he is going to be sitting in that room, and because a man who is sitting in the room when his own name is said is a man who will not be able to look at the floor."

Tullia was quiet for a moment.

"And Verus?"

"Verus will name himself," Antonia said. "He has been doing it for two months. I do not need to do it for him."

She closed the book.

"Now," she said. "Tell me about the girl."

Tullia's face changed.

"The order was moved," she said. "It was moved to the urban prefect's office on the day before the Kalends, and the prefect's clerk wrote to the prefect's office for the papers, and the papers have not come. The girl is still in the cells under the prefect's office, and the men there say that the order of the ides of October is still in force and that they have had no instruction."

"Then Plotina's month is not a month."

"Plotina's month is a piece of paper, domina, and a piece of paper is only as good as the man who carries it." Tullia sat down on the chest. "There is one more thing. The agent from the prefect's office came to the fuller's yard this morning and asked for you. He did not ask at the door; he asked at the yard, of the fuller's wife, and he said that he was instructed to say that the girl would be available to be seen, by you and by no one else, at the fourth hour of the afternoon of the day after tomorrow, at the office, and that she would be available to be seen in a condition that would make the visit short."

Antonia sat with her hand on the book.

"A condition that would make the visit short," she said.

"That is what he said."

"Then he is telling me that they are going to question her, and that they are going to begin before the senate, and that they want me to know it." Antonia stood up. "Which means they want me to come to the office and bargain, and the bargain will be the book, and the bargain will be offered by a man who believes that a woman will trade a book for a girl."

"Will you go?"

"Yes."

"Domina."

"I will go," Antonia said, "and I will not take the book, and I will not bargain, and I will look at her and I will tell her that the senate is

the day after and that there is nothing in the world that they can do to her in one day that will make me stop." She was putting on her mantle. "And then I will go to the senate house and I will say her name in the first sentence, before the year 93, before Verus, before Nepos, before anything. Her name and what was done to her and the name of the office that did it."

"Domina, if you say her name they will know that she matters to you."

"They already know," Antonia said. "That is what they are counting on. So I will show them what it looks like when a woman tells the truth about a thing they thought was a lever."

She went out into the lane, and the Subura was dark, and the cat came out of the shed and wound itself around her ankles, and she stood there for a moment with her hand on the door.

"Tullia," she said.

"Domina."

"Tomorrow, when I am in that room, I want you to be in the gallery with the other women, and I want you to listen to every word, and I want you to write down what the men say when they are saying it to each other and not to me. Not the speeches. The other thing. The thing they say when they think no one is listening."

"I will need a tablet."

"You will need three."

Tullia looked at her.

"Domina," she said, "there is a thing I have never said to you in nine years, and I am going to say it now in case there is no good time after tomorrow."

"Say it."

"You are the most frightening woman I have ever met," Tullia said, "and I have been proud to keep your accounts, and if they destroy you tomorrow I will still be keeping them, and if they put you in the cells I will bring you bread, and if they sell you I will follow

you to the ends of the earth and steal every one of your masters' account books until they let you go."

Antonia stood in the lane with the cat around her ankles.

"Thank you," she said.

CHAPTER XXI

THE RAID

Rome, the third day before the Nones of December, AD 112

They came at the fourth hour of the morning, which was the hour the vigiles came and the hour the prefect's men came and the hour any man came who wanted to find a house asleep.

Antonia was awake. She had been awake most of the night with the speech in her head, and she was sitting at the table with the lamp and the book and a cup of cold water, and she heard the boots in the lane before she heard the knock.

There were eleven of them, and they had a magistrate's clerk, and the clerk had a warrant with the seal of the urban prefect, and the warrant said that the premises of the fuller's yard in the fourteenth region were to be searched for a book of accounts belonging to one Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, and for any person concealed therein contrary to the register of the city.

"Crescens," Antonia said.

"He is at the station," the clerk said. "The warrant is from the urban prefect's office and does not require the watch. Stand aside, domina."

She stood aside. There was nothing else to do; there were eleven of them and one of her, and Hilarus was at his sister's in the Aventine, and the fuller had gone to his mother's at Fidenae, and the yard had four women in it and a cat.

They found the book in three minutes. It was on the table, under her hand, in the lamplight, because she had been reading it.

The clerk took it and put it in a bag and wrote on the bag with a pen.

"That is a private account book," Antonia said.

"It is a book of accounts," the clerk said. "Whether it is private is a question for the prefect."

"It contains the names of four hundred men and women of this city, and the amounts they have paid, and the reasons, and if it is read by men in an office and copied, then every one of those people will know that I have been raided, and they will not blame the men who raided me. They will blame me."

"Yes," the clerk said. "That is generally how it works."

They took the women next. Rufina, and Cela, and the two youngest, and Meroe, and Beryllos, who had come back from his sister's in October and had been sleeping in the kitchen. They were taken out into the lane in their night clothes and put in a cart, and Cela was crying, and the youngest one, who was fifteen, was asking everyone whether she was going to be sold.

"Where are you taking them?" Antonia said.

"To the office, until the prefect has looked at the register."

"They are not registered to this yard, they are registered to my house on the Clivus, and the house on the Clivus is burnt and the register was corrected in October by a clerk in the fourteenth region whose name is in the record."

The clerk looked at her for a moment.

"You are very well informed," he said.

"I have been in this city for thirty-nine years and I have paid for every piece of information I have."

"Then you will understand," the clerk said, "that a warrant from the urban prefect's office does not have to be right. It has to be signed."

They took Tullia last. She came out of the shed with her cloak over her arm and her tablets in her hand, and she stopped in front of Antonia.

"The book," she said.

"Gone."

"Then they have won."

"They have the book," Antonia said. "They have not won. There is a difference, and it is the only thing I have ever been good at."

Tullia looked at her.

"Tomorrow," she said.

"Tomorrow," Antonia said.

"Domina, if they keep us at that office for a week, you will have no one to write anything down."

"Then I will have to remember it," Antonia said. "I have a good memory. It is the only part of me that has never been for sale."

They put Tullia in the cart, and the cart went down the lane, and the lane was full of people by then, standing in their doorways with their arms folded, watching.

The clerk was the last to go. He stopped at the door of the shed with the bag under his arm.

"There is a message," he said. "I was told to give it to you if you were civil."

"I have been extremely civil."

"You have." The clerk cleared his throat. "The message is: the woman may have the girl out of the cells on the morning of the senate, if she will come herself and sign a statement that the girl was never in the house on the night of the Floralia, and that the death of Decimus Iunius Gallus was an accident."

Antonia stood in the doorway of the shed.

"And if I do not?"

"Then the girl is questioned this afternoon," the clerk said, "and the man who questions her has been at it for thirty years, and he does not stop for the evening."

"Tell them no."

The clerk looked at her.

"Domina," he said, "I am a clerk. I have been a clerk for twenty-six years. I have carried a great many messages and I have seen a great many people say no, and I have noticed that the ones who say no in the doorway are always the ones who have not thought about the afternoon."

"I have thought about the afternoon," Antonia said. "I have thought about nothing else since July. Tell them no."

❦

She went to the office at the ninth hour and they would not let her in.

She stood at the door with her hands at her sides while the porter told her that the office was closed to visitors, and that the girl was under an order, and that the order was being executed, and that the prefect's office was not in the habit of receiving women at the door.

"Then I will stand here," she said.

"You cannot stand here."

"I can stand anywhere in Rome. It is a public street."

She stood there for four hours. Men came and went past her, and some of them looked at her and some of them did not, and at the second hour a young man in a good cloak came out and said that the prefect's office would be grateful if she would go home, and at the third hour an older man came out and said that the prefect's office would be obliged if she would go home, and at the fourth hour a man in the uniform of the watch came out and stood beside her.

"You are relieved," he said. "The tribune has sent me. He says he cannot come himself, and he says you are to go to the house of the

lady Marcella, and he says the lady Marcella has been expecting you since the fourth hour and has been making a great deal of noise about it."

Antonia turned her head.

"Tell him," she said, "that I will come when it is dark."

"Domina."

"Tell him that."

The watchman went away. Antonia stood in the street until the light went off the top of the wall. At the sixth hour the door of the office opened and two men came out carrying a stretcher with a cloth over it, and they put it in a cart, and the cart went down the hill.

She followed it.

The house of the prefect's physician was in the Via Nova, and it had a lamp over the door and a boy on the step, and the physician was a Greek of sixty called Sostratus who had been in Rome for thirty years and had never once refused a patient who was brought to him at night.

They would not let her in. She waited in the street, and after an hour Sostratus came out himself, with his hands washed, and stood in the doorway.

"You are the woman from the Clivus."

"I am the owner of the girl."

"The girl is not owned," Sostratus said. "The girl is a slave of the prefect's office, and I have treated her under an order, and I have been paid for it, and I have nothing to say to you."

"Her hand."

Sostratus was silent.

"Her right hand," Antonia said. "They put the cords on her wrists and her ankles, and they lift, and the shoulders come out, and

the wrists swell, and if they leave the cords on too long in the same place, the hand does not come back. You have been in this city thirty years. You know the injury. You know it takes four hours to happen and four months to heal and that sometimes it does not heal at all."

The physician looked at her.

"It is her right hand," he said.

"And?"

"And it is not healing," Sostratus said. "The tendons are damaged at the wrist. She will have the use of the thumb and the first two fingers, and the little finger and the ring finger will not close, and she will not be able to grip anything heavier than a cup. In a year it will be a hand that looks like a hand and does not work like one." He wiped his own hands on his apron. "I have splinted it and I have given her something for the pain and I have told the office that she is not to be questioned again for a month. They will question her again in a month. They always do."

"Can I see her?"

"No."

"I am asking you to let me see her."

"You are asking me to break an order of the prefect's office for a woman I have never met, in a city where a physician who breaks an order of the prefect's office does not practice medicine again." Sostratus looked at her for a long moment. "Come back at the tenth hour. The boy goes home at the tenth hour and the man who sits with her is a fool who sleeps. Do not come to the front. There is a door in the alley at the back, and it is the door they use for the bodies, and if anyone asks, I will say that I know nothing and that you are a thief."

Antonia looked at him.

"Why?" she said.

"Because I am sixty years old and I have been in this city for thirty years," Sostratus said, "and every year I have said that I would not do this again, and every year there is one girl, and this year it is this one." He went inside and shut the door.

❦

The room was small and had a bed and a stool and a lamp and a window with bars.

Dessa was lying on the bed with her right arm strapped to a board and her eyes open. She had lost weight; her cheekbones were sharp, and there was a bruise on her jaw that had gone yellow at the edges, and her hair was matted on one side.

"Domina," she said.

Antonia sat down on the stool.

"I am here," she said.

"You did not come."

"I did not know where you were until the end of August, and by then you were in the cells and no one would tell me which cells, and I have been to the prefect's office four times and to the station twice and to the house of a man in the Via Nova who would not open the door."

"The man with the burn."

"Felix. Yes."

Dessa looked at the ceiling.

"He told me you had sold me," she said. "In the cell in Ostia. He told me there was a bill of sale with a seal on it, and that you had sold me to a procurator for four thousand sesterces, and that I had been put on a cart to Ostia thinking I was being hidden."

Antonia sat very still.

"And did you believe him?"

"For three days," Dessa said. "And then I remembered that you had told me the truth about the arithmetic in the small room in

May, and that a woman who tells the truth about the arithmetic does not sell a girl in the night. And I told him no." She turned her head. "I told him no four times, and the fourth time he laughed and said that I was a clever girl and that clever girls were the worst kind of witness, and then he went away and two men came and put me in a wagon and brought me to Rome."

Antonia's hands were shaking.

"What did they ask you?"

"About the garden. About the man in the lane. About the ring. About what you said to me afterward, and whether you told me to say that I had been sold to Africa, and whether you paid the aedile's clerk." Dessa's voice was flat. "I said that I was in the kitchen all night and saw nothing. I said it for two days. And then a man came with a rope and they put the cords on my wrists and my ankles and they lifted me off the floor by my wrists, and I said it again, and they lifted me higher, and after a while I said that I had seen the man in the lane and that he had a ring, and then they put me down and gave me water and asked me again, and I said it all again, and then they asked me about you."

"And what did you say?"

"I said that you were a hard woman and a liar and that you had sold me." Dessa looked at her. "I said it because it was what they wanted and because I was on the floor and because my arms had come out of the sockets, and I have thought about it every day since, and I am not sorry, and I am telling you so that you will know before you go into that senate house that they already have a statement from me, in my voice, signed with my mark, that says you are worse than they are."

The lamp burned.

"Good," Antonia said.

Dessa stared at her.

"Good?"

"Good. Because tomorrow I am going to stand up in the senate house and say that a slave of my household was taken from Ostia with a forged bill of sale and a genuine seal, and questioned for four days without a magistrate's order, and that she has a hand that will not close for the rest of her life. And the men who are going to want to know why I am saying it will produce your statement, and I will say: she said it on the floor, after four days, with her arms out of their sockets, and a statement taken that way is not a statement, it is a thing that was taken from her, the way the hand was taken." Antonia leaned forward. "You have given me the best thing in the case, and you did not know it, and you did it by telling me the truth about what you said. That is what I have been trying to tell you since May. The truth is not the thing that is convenient. It is the thing that is left when everything else has been taken and you are still alive and can say what happened."

Dessa looked at her for a long time.

"I want to say my name," she said.

"In the senate?"

"In the senate. Like the girl did in the basilica. I heard about it in the cell; the man who sits with me told me. He said a slave girl stood up in the basilica and gave her name and the whole hall went quiet." Dessa's chin came up. "I want to do that. I am a slave of your household. If I stand up in that room and say my name, they cannot say afterward that I was a thing in a cell. They will have to write it down."

Antonia looked at her.

"Then I will bring you," she said, "and I will bring your splint, and I will bring the physician, and I will stand beside you while you say it."

"They will not let a slave into the senate house."

"They will let a slave into the senate house if a consular of Rome stands up and says that the slave is a witness in a matter before the

court and the court has asked for her, and if the clerk of the house writes it in the book, and if the empress has spoken to the consul." Antonia smiled. "I have been busy for a month. You have been in a cell. We have both been doing our work."

Crescens was waiting for her in the lane outside the fuller's yard when she got back, sitting on the step with his helmet beside him.

"I am suspended," he said.

"I know."

"You do not know. You know that a warrant came from the urban prefect's office and that I was not in it. What you do not know is that the prefect's office wrote to my prefect this morning and asked why a tribune of the seventh cohort had been seen four times at the house of a woman under inquiry, and my prefect — who is a decent man and a lazy one — has suspended me pending an explanation." Crescens picked up his helmet and looked at it. "I have until the Kalends to write the explanation. I have written four. They are all the same. They all say that I did what I did because it was the right thing to do, and none of them say anything that a prefect can act on."

"What will you do?"

"I am going to write the fifth one," Crescens said, "and in the fifth one I am going to say that I have kept a written record of the condition of a body found in a fountain in April, and that I did not file it, and that I am prepared to produce it before a magistrate. And I am going to send it to the prefect, and to the prefect's clerk, and to the man who signs for the aediles. And then I am going to sit in this lane and wait to be dismissed."

Antonia sat down on the step beside him.

"Give me the report," she said.

"It is a report of a tribune of the watch. It cannot be used in a senate house."

"Give me the report," Antonia said, "and I will read it out, and a tribune's report read out in the senate house is not evidence, it is a fact that three hundred men have heard, and a fact that three hundred men have heard is a fact that cannot be put back in a chest."

Crescens looked at her.

"If I give it to you," he said, "I am finished. There is no explanation I can write after that. The prefect will dismiss me and the cohort will be told that I was dismissed for a woman, and I will be thirty-four years old with a helmet and a debt and no post."

"Yes."

"And if I do not give it to you, you will go into that room with a letter from a dead man and a hand that will not close, and the whole of it will rest on the word of a freedwoman and a slave."

"Yes."

Crescens sat on the step with his helmet in his hands.

"I have been in the watch seven years," he said. "I have pulled forty-one people out of burning buildings. I have watched eleven of them die. I have been thanked twice. And I have spent the whole of this year discovering that the thing I am actually good at is not putting out fires. It is noticing." He held out the helmet. "There is a folded tablet in the lining. Take it."

Antonia took the helmet and turned it over, and there was a slit in the leather lining, and inside it a folded tablet wrapped in oilcloth.

"There is one thing," Crescens said. "When you have read it out, do not say my name. Say *a tribune of the seventh cohort*. There are six tribunes in the seventh cohort and the prefect will not be able to dismiss all of them without explaining why."

Antonia looked at him.

"You would let another man take the blame?"

"No," Crescens said. "I would let the prefect discover that the blame is a thing that cannot be assigned to a name, because the

name is not in the record. It is the only trick I know that works in that office." He stood up and put on his helmet. "And domina. When it is over, and I am a man with a helmet and a debt and no post, I am going to come and sit in that shed again, and you are going to be there, and there will be a cat."

"I will be there," Antonia said.

She came out of the alley at the back of the physician's house at the eleventh hour and there was a man waiting for her at the corner of the Via Nova.

He was young and well dressed and he had been crying, and his hands were shaking, and he was holding a letter.

"Domina," Verianus said.

She stopped.

"My father is dead," he said. "He is dead in his bath, and there is a letter, and I have read it, and I have brought it to you, because there is no one else in Rome who will know what to do with it."

Antonia took the letter.

They stood in the Via Nova under the lamp with the shops shut and the whole city asleep, and she read it twice.

To the magistrates of Rome. I, Manius Cassius Verus, consular, being of sound mind and about to do what my father should have done in the year 93, make this statement. In the April of this year, on the night of the Floralia, my son Manius Cassius Verus the Younger followed Decimus Iunius Gallus from the house on the Clivus Suburanus and struck him once in the garden of that house, and the boy fell and struck his head on the rim of the fountain and did not rise. My son came to me at the fifth hour and told me. I did not send for the watch. I did not tell the father of the dead boy. I paid a man in the aedile's office and I closed the file and I told my son that it was finished. It was not finished. It has never been finished.

The girl in my house, called Myrtale, is the daughter of Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, and of me, and was born free, and I have held her for eighteen years. The note in my hand in the tablinum says no more to be said. I say it now.

I have no other statement to make. I have held a lamp, and I have held my tongue, and I have held a girl in a house, and I have not held anything that was worth holding.

Antonia folded the letter.

Verianus stood in the street with his hands at his sides.

"He has written that I killed him," he said. "He has written it down and he has signed it and he has left it on the table in the tablinum, and my mother found him and she read it before I did, and she is sitting on the floor of the atrium with the tablet in her lap, and she has not spoken."

"Verianus."

"He was going to Asia," Verianus said. "He was going to go to Asia and be a proconsul and be dull at dinner, and I was going to be a man who had killed someone and been forgiven. And now he has written it down and he has stopped, and I do not know whether he did it for the girl or for himself or to punish me, and I will never know, and that is the worst of it. That is the worst of it, domina. Not the death. The not knowing."

The house of Acilia Marcella was lit like a house with a death in it.

There were lamps in every room and the door was open and a slave was standing in the lane to tell people that the master was dead and that the household was in mourning. The atrium was full of women. Marcella was not among them. She was in the tablinum, sitting on the floor with her back against the desk and the letter in her lap, and she had been there for two hours.

"You have read it," Antonia said.

"Four times."

"Give it to me."

Marcella held it out without looking up.

"I have been sitting here," she said, "trying to decide whether he wrote it for the girl or for himself or to punish my stepson. And I have decided that it does not matter, and that it is the only thing he has ever written that was worth reading, and that I am going to have it copied twice before the light comes so that if it is lost there is another one."

Antonia sat down on the floor beside her. The marble was cold.

"Marcella."

"Do not be kind to me. I have been a wall for nine years and a wall does not require kindness." Marcella's voice was steady and her hands were not. "Do you know what I have been thinking, sitting here? I have been thinking that I have spent nine years managing the money and the household and the marriage and the slaves, and I have been proud of it, and I have told myself that I was the one who kept the house standing. And he has been dead for two hours and the house is standing, and the money is in the strongbox, and the slaves are in the kitchen making bread for the morning, and none of it needed me at all. The house was always going to stand. It was only the people in it that were falling down."

Antonia said nothing.

"He called me by my name," Marcella said. "Twice. Once when he came back from the prefect's office in October, and once on the night he wrote this. He said, *Acilia*, and then he said, *I have made a mess of it*, and I said, *yes*, and he laughed." She looked at the letter. "Nine years, and the only two conversations I ever had with my husband were in the last two months, and they were about the mess he had made. I do not know whether to be grateful or furious. I am both. I am going to be both for the rest of my life."

Verianus was standing in the door of the tablinum with his hands at his sides.

"Mother," he said.

Marcella looked up.

"Do not call me that in this room," she said. "You have not called me that in seven years and I have preferred it. Call me Acilia, and come and sit on the floor with us, and bring the lamp, and we will decide what to do with your father's letter before it is light."

He came and sat. Marcella took the lamp from him and set it on the floor between the three of them, and the light came up and made three faces out of the dark.

"There is one thing I want," Marcella said, "and then I will do whatever the two of you decide, and I will not say another word about it."

"Name it," Antonia said.

"When you read that letter tomorrow," Marcella said, "read the part about the girl first. Not the part about the death. Not the part about the aedile. The part where he says she was born free and he has held her for eighteen years and that he says it now. Read that first, in his words, before anybody has said anything else. Because that is the only part of it that was not about him."

Antonia looked at her.

"I will read it first," she said.

"Then take the letter," Marcella said, "and take my stepson, and go and get some sleep, because it is three hours before light and you look like a woman who has been standing in a street since the ninth hour."

Antonia got up.

"Marcella," she said. "The book is gone. The prefect's men took it from the shed this morning, with the women. They will read it, and they will copy it, and they will send word to every man in this city whose name is in it that the woman on the Clivus has been raided and that it was her fault."

Marcella looked up at her.

"Then they will have told four hundred people that the woman on the Clivus is dangerous and that her book was worth taking," she said. "I have been in this city for thirty-three years. There is no better advertisement."

❦

Antonia looked at the young man in the lamplight.

"Come with me," she said.

"Where?"

"To the house of the lady Marcella, where there is a fire and a chair and a woman who has been waiting for me since the fourth hour, and where we are going to sit down, the three of us, and decide what to do with this letter before it is light."

"You are going to use it."

"Yes," Antonia said. "In the senate house, tomorrow, at the second hour. And you are going to stand beside me while I read it, and you are going to say, in front of three hundred men, that it is your father's hand and your father's seal, and that it is true."

Verianus looked at her.

"I will be finished," he said.

"Yes."

"I will be a man who killed somebody and was named in the senate house."

"Yes," Antonia said. "And you will be a man who told the truth about it in a room full of men, which is more than your father ever was, and more than most of the men in that room will ever be." She took his arm. "Come. It is cold, and we have four hours, and I have not slept in two days, and if I am going to destroy a family tomorrow I would like to do it sitting down."

CHAPTER XXII

THE INTERROGATION

Rome, the day before the Nones of December, AD 112

The wagon from Ostia took two days, because the oxen were old and the driver stopped at every inn, and she sat in the back with a sack of beans and a boy of about twelve who was being taken to Rome to be a cupbearer and who had been told that it was a great honor.

He talked the whole way. His name was Felix, which was a name he had been given the week before by a man with a burn on his hand, and he had been washed and oiled and told to be cheerful, and he was cheerful, and he was going to be a cupbearer in the house of a very great man, and if he was good he would be freed at eighteen and given a trade.

Dessa listened to him for two days.

On the second night, at the inn, she said, "Do not go to the house."

The boy looked at her. "Why not?"

"Because a boy who is taken to Rome to be a cupbearer is not taken for his hands." She looked at the fire. "If they free you at eighteen, it will be because they have finished with you, and you will be eighteen and you will have nothing, and the trade will be whatever they give you, and it will not be a trade you chose."

The boy thought about this for a while.

"You are a slave," he said.

"Yes."

"Then why are you telling me what to do?"

"Because I can count," Dessa said, "and I have counted, and it comes out badly, and nobody in six years has told me the arithmetic before it was too late."

The boy looked at the fire and did not answer, and in the morning he was cheerful again, and he talked the whole way into Rome about the house of the very great man.

"Have you been to Rome?" he said, somewhere past the ninth milestone.

"Yes."

"What is it like?"

Dessa thought about it. She had been in three houses in Rome and a cell in Ostia and a yard behind a fuller's shop, and she had carried water up three flights of stairs and stood in a garden at night with her shoes off.

"There is a door," she said, "at the top of a hill, and it is covered in gold, and behind it there is a garden, and behind the garden there is a room with a strongbox in it, and in the strongbox there is a book, and in the book there are four hundred names. If you are brought to a house in Rome, look for the book. Every house that matters has one. The ones that do not keep a book are the ones where they do not intend to remember anything they promise you."

The boy looked at her as though she had told him a story about a dragon.

She never saw him again after the gate.

❦

They came for her at the second hour of the afternoon, and the man who had been sitting with her was asleep, and she had to say his name twice before he woke.

She had been in the cell four days. She had counted them by the light at the top of the wall, which came in through a grate and

moved across the floor and went out, and by the bread, which came twice a day and was the same bread. She had counted four days and she had been wrong by one, and she knew that she had been wrong by one because the man who brought the bread said, on the morning of the questioning, that it was the day before the Nones, and she had thought that it was the third.

The cell had a stone bench and a drain and a bucket and a nail in the wall, and the nail was at the height of her shoulder when she sat on the bench, and she had spent a great deal of time looking at it.

She was not frightened. That was the thing she could not explain afterward, to the physician, or to the woman on the Clivus, or to herself. She had been frightened in the wagon, and frightened in the yard at Ostia, and frightened for six years in three houses. And on the fourth day, in the cell, with the light coming through the grate, she had discovered that she had come to the end of the fear, and that on the other side of it there was a kind of quiet.

She had done the arithmetic. That was what she had been doing in the cell, all four days, with the nail and the light and the bread. She had added up the things that were hers.

The mark on her wrist. The knife with the wooden handle, which they had taken from her in the yard and which was, she supposed, in a box somewhere in the prefect's office with a label on it. Eleven sesterces, which they had taken as well. A name. And the fact — the plain, arithmetic fact — that she could count, and read, and keep a column, and that there was no man in Rome who could take that out of her head with a rope, because a rope works on a body and the counting was somewhere else.

Four things. She had held on to them the way a person holds on to a wall in the dark.

The room was on the ground floor and it had a high window and a board and four men.

She had expected a dungeon. It was not a dungeon. It was a room with a mosaic floor, a bad mosaic, of a fish, and a table with a jug of water on it, and a clerk's stool in the corner. There was a brazier in the corner and it was not lit. The walls were whitewashed and there was a hook in the ceiling with a rope on it, and the rope was coiled and hung neatly, the way a man hangs a rope he uses every week.

The clerk was old and had ink on his fingers and he had set out his tablets on the stool in front of him the way a man sets out his tools, and he did not look at her at all.

The man in charge was about fifty and had the hands of a butcher and the voice of a man selling vegetables. "You are the slave Dessa," he said. "Of the household of Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, of the fourteenth region."

"I am."

"You are claimed under a bill of sale by the procurator of the estate of Cominius Asiaticus, deceased, and you are held under an order of the prefect's office, and you are to be questioned in the matter of a death in the fourteenth region on the last night of the Floralia."

"I know."

"You will answer what you are asked, and when you have answered, you will be asked again." He sat down on a stool. "That is how it works. It is not personal. I have done this for thirty years and I do not enjoy it, and the man who says he enjoys it is a liar, and the man who says it does not hurt the person is a liar too. What I can tell you is that it is shorter if you answer the first time. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Then we will begin."

❦

It began with questions, and the questions were not the ones she had expected.

She had expected questions about the garden, and the man in the lane, and the ring. What she got first was her life.

Her name. Her age. Where she was born, and when she was taken, and by whom, and sold to whom, and for how much, and what the men looked like, and whether she had ever been in the house of Cominius Asiaticus, and whether she had known a woman there called Prima, and whether she had ever heard the name Chryseros.

She answered it all. She answered it truthfully and in order, because she had spent six years learning how to answer a man who asks questions, and because the truth was the one thing she was good at, and no one had ever paid her for it.

At the end of two hours the man in charge put down his stylus and rubbed his eyes.

"You are a very good witness," he said.

"I can count."

"So I am told. The office has a note on you: a girl who can count, worth twelve thousand. There is a clerk in the grain office who would give a year's pay for you and would treat you well." He looked at her. "That is not a threat. That is information. I have been in this office thirty years and I have found that a person answers better when they know what the alternative is."

"What is the alternative?"

"The alternative is the rope," he said, "and the alternative to the rope is a statement that you were in the kitchen all night and saw nothing, which is what you have already said, and which the office does not believe, because a girl who was in the kitchen all night does

not have water on her hands and mud on her feet at the sixth hour of the morning."

She had not thought of that. She had washed her hands in the cellar, and Rufina had washed them again, and nobody had thought about her feet.

"You are a clever girl," the man said. "Clever girls make the worst witnesses, because they think they can keep the story straight. The stupid ones cry and say everything in the first hour. The clever ones hold on, and the holding on is what takes the time." He stood up. "I am going to ask you again. Were you in the garden on the night of the Floralia?"

"Yes," Dessa said.

The clerk's stylus began to move.



They put the cords on her wrists first, and then on her ankles, and then they ran the rope through the hook in the ceiling, and the man in charge said, "Lift," and two men pulled on the rope, and her heels came off the floor.

It was not the pain that she remembered afterward. It was the surprise. She had been lifted by the wrists a thousand times as a child; the surprise was that a body could be lifted by the wrists at all, that the shoulders would take it, that a person could hang there by two hands with their feet off the ground and still be alive.

The first lift lasted as long as it takes to say a prayer.

"Were you in the garden?"

"Yes."

"Did you see the man in the lane?"

"Yes."

"What did he look like?"

"Tall. Dark cloak. A gold ring on his hand with a leaf on it."

"Did you see his face?"

"No."

"Did you see anything else?"

"No."

They put her down. The man in charge wrote nothing; the clerk wrote everything. She stood on the floor with her arms hanging and her shoulders burning, and the man in charge said, "Again," and they lifted her again.

❦

It went on for four days, in the way that the woman in the stone room in the year 93 had said it went on: not all at once, and with water in the intervals, and with the clerk sharpening his pen and the man in charge sitting down and reading what had been written and saying, "Again."

She learned the intervals. The first day was the shoulders. The second day they left the cords on longer and the wrists began to swell, and the man in charge said, "Look at that," with a kind of professional interest, and put her down and told the clerk to write that the swelling had begun at the wrist, as though it were a fact about the weather. The third day the pain went into her elbows and her hands and she could not hold the cup they gave her and the water went down her chin, and the man in charge said, "That is the sign," and wrote it down.

The fourth day was the worst, and the fourth day was the one she did not remember clearly, and afterward she would be glad of that.

What she remembered was the room. The fish in the mosaic. The jug of water on the table. The whitewash on the wall, which had a mark on it, a brown mark near the hook, and she had spent a great deal of time looking at the mark. The clerk's hands. The sound of the rope on the hook, which was a small creaking, like a door in a wind.

And the questions. Always the same questions, in the same order, and the truth going out of her answers one word at a time.

❦

On the second day, in an interval, the man in charge sat down on the stool beside her and gave her water and said, "Do you know what I am doing?"

"Questioning me."

"I am not questioning you. I am writing a document. There was a death in a house in the Subura and the aedile's office has written it as an accident and somebody wants it written differently, and my job is to produce a document in which a slave says, in her own words, what happened. The document will be read by a magistrate and it will be filed and it will be the end of it." He looked at her. "The document will say what I am told to put in it. It does not matter what you say. That is the thing nobody tells the person on the board. Your answers are not evidence; they are material. I am a clerk with a rope, and the man in the office already knows what the document will say, and the only question is how long it takes to make it true."

"Then why do you ask?"

"Because it has to be true in the document," he said. "That is the whole of the law of Rome. A thing is not true until a clerk has written it in the form. If I write that you said it, and you sign it, and I sign it, then it is true, and no magistrate can say otherwise, and the man in the office is satisfied. If I write it without your mark, it is a forgery, and a forgery is worth nothing, and I would be dismissed." He gave her more water. "So I ask, and you answer, and after a while you will sign, and then it will be over."

"And if I do not sign?"

"Then it is not over." The man in charge looked at the jug of water. "There is another way, and I am going to tell you what it is, be-

cause I am fifty years old and I have four daughters and I have discovered that I am not able to do this to a girl of twenty without telling her what the door is. The other way is this. You sign the document, and the document is what the office wants, and the office is satisfied, and I write in the margin that the subject was cooperative and that the injuries are consistent with the questioning and not in excess of it. And then the office will sell you, because a slave who has been questioned is always sold, and the price will be in the record, and a man who buys a girl with a document like that will not treat her well, because a girl with a document like that is a girl with no one."

"And the first way?"

"The first way is that you do not sign, and it goes on for another four days, and then you sign." He got up. "That is the whole of the choice, and it is not much of a choice, and I am sorry for it, and I am going to do it anyway, because if I do not do it there is a man in the office who will do it in a worse way."

She looked at the mark on the wall.

"What do you want me to say?" she said.

He told her.

She listened. It took a quarter of an hour, and he said it in the flat voice of a man reading a list of goods, and when he had finished she asked him to say it again, and he said it again, and then she asked him about the part where she was to say that her mistress had paid the aedile's office, and he said that the amount was two hundred thousand sesterces and that it was to be said in her own words.

"Two hundred thousand," she said.

"That is the figure."

"It is a hundred thousand and the aedile's clerk asked for fifty and she gave two hundred, and the difference is the reason she gave it." Dessa looked at him. "If I am to sign a document, I will sign a true one. She paid two hundred, and she paid it to be remembered,

and she did it in front of me in the station house of the seventh cohort, and if you put a hundred thousand in the document then it is your lie and not mine."

The man in charge looked at her for a long moment.

"Two hundred thousand," he said to the clerk, and the clerk wrote it, and Dessa sat on the stool with her arms hanging and thought: that is the only thing I have done today that was mine.

❦

She signed it on the fourth day with her left hand, because her right hand would not close.

The document said that she had been in the garden on the night of the Floralia and had found the body of Decimus Iunius Gallus; that she had seen a man in the lane with a gold ring, and that she could not identify him; that she had been ordered by her mistress, Antonia Cassia, to say that she had been in the kitchen; and that her mistress had told her that a slave who spoke of the death would be sold, and that her mistress had paid money to the aedile's office and had said in her hearing that the death would be written as an accident.

She signed it, and the clerk signed it, and the man in charge signed it, and they put her back in the cell.

She lay on the bench with her arm strapped to a board and looked at the nail in the wall and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic came out badly.

She had said it. She had said the thing they wanted, not because she was weak, or not only because she was weak, but because on the fourth day, in the interval, the man in charge had said a thing that had gone into her like a nail: *the document will say what I am told to put in it.* And she had understood, lying on the board with her arms out of their sockets, that the questions were not a door she could refuse to open; they were a machine that produced a document, and

the only thing she could withhold was her mark, and the withholding of her mark would cost her the hand and would not stop the document.

So she had signed. And she had thought, at the time, that she was being practical.

She was not practical. She had given them the one thing they needed, which was her mark, and she had given it because she was in pain and because she was twenty years old and because a person whose arms have been out of their sockets for four days will sign anything that will make it stop.

That was the truth. She lay in the cell with it and did not look away from it, because she had learned in six years that the truth was the only thing that stayed.

❦

She was awake when the woman came.

The cell was dark. There was a lamp in the passage and the door was open, and the physician was standing in the doorway with his hands folded and his face averted with the elaborate discretion of a man who has decided not to see anything.

"Domina," Dessa said.

The woman from the Clivus came in and sat down on the stool.

She was in a plain mantle and no jewelry, and she was grey with tiredness, and her hands were shaking, and she sat on the stool and looked at the splint on Dessa's arm for a long time without speaking.

"I am here," she said at last.

"You did not come."

"I did not know where you were until August, and by then you were in the cells and no one would tell me which cells, and I have been to the prefect's office four times and to the station twice and to the house of a man in the Via Nova who would not open the door."

"The man with the burn."

"Felix. Yes."

Dessa looked at the ceiling.

"He told me you had sold me," she said. "In the cell in Ostia. He told me there was a bill of sale with a seal on it, and that you had sold me to a procurator for four thousand, and that I had been put on a cart to Ostia thinking I was being hidden."

The woman was very still.

"And did you believe him?"

"For three days," Dessa said. "And then I remembered that you had told me the truth about the arithmetic, and that a woman who tells the truth about the arithmetic does not sell a girl in the night. And when he came back I told him no. I told him no four times." She turned her head. "And then they brought me to Rome."

"What did they ask you?"

"About the garden. About the man in the lane. About the ring." Dessa's voice was flat. "And then about you. And I told them you were a hard woman and a liar and that you had sold me, because I was on the floor and my arms were out of their sockets, and I have thought about it every day since, and I am telling you now, before you go into that senate house, that they already have a document with my mark on it that says you are worse than they are."

The lamp burned.

"Good," the woman said.

Dessa stared at her.

"Good?"

"Good. Because in an hour I am going to stand up in the senate house and say that a slave of my household was taken from Ostia with a forged bill of sale and a genuine seal and questioned for four days without a magistrate's order, and that she has a hand that will not close for the rest of her life. And the men who want to know why I am saying it will produce your document, and I will say: she

signed it on the fourth day, with her hand strapped to a board, and a document taken that way is not a statement. It is a thing that was taken from her, the way the hand was taken." The woman leaned forward. "You have given me the best thing in the case, and you did it by telling me the truth about what you said. That is what I have been trying to tell you since May. The truth is not the thing that is convenient. It is the thing that is left when everything else has been taken."

Dessa looked at her.

"I want to say my name," she said.

"In the senate?"

"In the senate. Like the girl in the basilica. I heard about it in the cell; the man who sits with me told me. He said a slave girl stood up in the court and gave her name and the whole hall went quiet." Her chin came up. "I want to do that. If I stand up in that room and say my name, they cannot say afterward that I was a thing in a cell. They will have to write it down."

"Then I will bring you," the woman said, "and I will bring your splint, and I will bring the physician, and I will stand beside you while you say it."

"They will not let a slave into the senate house."

"They will let a slave into the senate house if a consular of Rome says that the slave is a witness in a matter before the court, and if the clerk writes it in the book, and if the empress has spoken to the consul." The woman smiled, and it was a terrible smile, and Dessa understood, looking at it, that this was what the woman had been building for eight months, and that Dessa was not a piece of material in it; she was one of the stones.

In the cell, on the last night, the man who sat with her was called Lupus, which was a common name, and he had been in the office for eleven years and had a wife and a bad leg.

He sat on a stool in the passage with the door open and talked, because he had learned that a person in a cell who is talked to does not scream, and because he was a lonely man and a captive audience was better than no audience at all.

He talked about the races. He talked about his wife's sister, who had married a man in the corn office and never let anyone forget it. He talked about the emperor, whom he had seen twice, and about the empress, whom he had seen once, and who had stopped in the street to look at a child's toy in a shop window, and he had thought at the time that it was a very great woman who could look at a toy in a window with a whole street watching.

And once, at about the second hour of the morning, he said, "My name is Lupus, and I have a wife called Marcia, and two boys, and I am telling you that so that you will know that the man sitting in the passage is a man with a name, and that what is happening to you is being done by men with names, and that one day you may be in a room with one of us and you will remember his name."

"Lupus," Dessa said.

"Lupus," he said. "It is a common name. There are a great many of us."

They came for her at dawn.

The physician was there, and a chair with a leather roof, and the woman from the Clivus was standing in the street with her hair up and a dark green dress and a face like a wall.

"You will not be able to walk up the steps," the physician said. "There are eleven steps and you will be carried. The men will carry you. You will not look at the crowd."

"I am not afraid of the crowd."

"You will be. It is a different crowd from the ones you know. It is not a market crowd and it is not a street crowd. It is three hundred men who have never in their lives been looked at by a slave, and they will look at you the way a man looks at a dog that has come into a room." The physician took her left arm. "Say your name and nothing else. Not one word more. They will ask you questions and the woman will answer them. Do you understand?"

"I understand."

They put her in the chair, and the bearers took it up, and the street went by, and the whole city was awake and going about its business, and nobody looked at a chair with a leather roof and a slave in it.

At the door of the senate house there was a crowd. There were the lictors and the clerks and the clients and the men who came to the door of the senate house every morning to see who went in, and the women behind the columns, and the boys on the steps.

The chair stopped. The bearers set it down. The physician opened the curtain, and the woman from the Clivus was standing there with her hand out.

"Cassia," she said.

Dessa looked at her.

"Cassia," she said.

"Not to me," the woman said. "In there. When they ask you. Say it in a voice that the whole room can hear, and do not look at any man in the eye, and if your hand hurts, say so, and if you are going to faint, sit down on the floor before you do it. There is no shame in sitting on the floor of the senate house. I have been told that several consuls have done it."

Dessa got out of the chair, and the physician took her elbow, and they went up the eleven steps.

At the top, at the door, a clerk with a tablet looked at her and then at the woman and then at the consular who was standing in the

doorway with a cold, and the clerk said, "A slave cannot be brought into the house."

"She is a witness in a matter before the praetor," the consular said, "and the praetor has asked for her, and the consul has been informed, and the empress has been informed, and if you write in your book that the door was shut against a witness, you will be asked to explain it before the consul at the second hour."

The clerk looked at the tablet.

"Name?" he said.

"Cassia," Dessa said.

The clerk wrote it down, and stood aside, and they went into the senate house of Rome.

CHAPTER XXIII

THE TESTIMONY

Rome, the day before the Nones of December, AD 112

The senate house of Rome was a room four hundred years old, and it smelled of paper.

That was the thing nobody told you. People said the curia and they thought of marble and purple and the masks of the ancestors, and what it actually smelled of was paper: the dry, dusty, faintly sweet smell of a great many documents kept in a great many cupboards for a great many years, with the shutters closed.

Antonia came up the steps at the second hour with Gallus on her right and Tullia behind her, and at the door the clerk with the tablet looked at her the way a clerk looks at a woman who is not supposed to be there.

"Name."

"Antonia Cassia, freedwoman of the household of Cassia Severa, of the fourteenth region."

"Matter?"

"A statement of fact in a question of status, before the praetor urbanus, on the Nones of December. The house has been asked to hear it by the consul, at the request of Lucius Iunius Gallus, consular."

The clerk wrote it down.

"Wait in the portico," he said. "You will be called."

She waited for an hour in the portico, and it was the longest hour of her life.

The portico was full of men. They came past her in twos and threes, in their white woollen togas with the narrow or the broad stripe, and they looked at her and then away, and some of them looked twice. She heard her own name three times, and each time it was followed by something that was not quite a whisper.

At the third hour Gallus came out.

"The consul will call you after the reading of the letters," he said. "You will come in at the far door and you will stand there, and you will not move until he tells you. There are three hundred and eleven men in the room, and there are forty more in the gallery, and one of them is a freedman of the ab epistulis who writes everything down. Speak to the consul. Look at him. If you look at the room you will lose the thread and you will not get it back."

"Lucius."

"What?"

"I am frightened."

Gallus looked at her.

"So am I," he said. "I have been a senator for twenty-two years and I have never once spoken in that room without being frightened, and the men who are not frightened are the men who have never said anything worth saying." He took her arm. "You are not going in there as a petitioner. You are going in as a witness in a case of status, and the law of Rome has put you in the room, and every man in there knows it. They can shout. They cannot put you out."

Oppius Nepos found her in the portico at the third hour, ten paces from the door of the house, with her hands folded and her heart going.

He was in the broad stripe, which was not his to wear, and he had been in the portico all morning, and he came up to her the way

a man comes up to a woman at a dinner: unhurried, with the confidence of a man who has arranged the seating.

"They will not let you speak," he said.

"They will."

"The consul has agreed to it because Gallus asked him and because the empress spoke to him. The consul has agreed to a statement of fact, of a quarter of an hour, in a matter of status. He has not agreed to an accusation of a man who cannot answer." Nepos looked out at the Forum. "I am not here to threaten you. I have been threatening you since March and it has not worked, and a man who threatens a woman for nine months and is not obeyed has lost the argument and should say so."

"Why are you here?"

"To make you a last offer, and to make it before you go in, because after you go in it will be too late for both of us." He turned. "The office will advance your petition. The rescript will be sealed before the emperor leaves. The house on the Clivus will be rebuilt with money from a fund that has no name on it. The girl will be freed in the praetor's court on the Nones with nobody appearing against her. And the girl Dessa will be out of the cells before the evening and the hand will be looked at by the best physician in Rome." He paused. "In return, you will say your statement and you will not say the word *seal*, and you will not say the name of any freedman in the prefect's office, and you will not say mine."

Antonia looked at him.

"That is a great deal of money and a great deal of convenience," she said, "for a word and three names."

"It is."

"Why are you offering it now, when you could have offered it in March?"

"Because in March you had a house and a book and a case and I did not think you would get as far as the portico," Nepos said. "And

because I find, standing here at the door of a room I have been buying my way into for twenty years, that I do not want to be a man who has spent his life on the outside of it with a gold ring on his finger." He looked at her. "I want to be a prefect of the grain. It is not a great ambition. It is a modest one. My father was a slave and I have a house on the Quirinal and a library of four hundred scrolls and not one friend in this city, and what I want, domina, at the end of it, is for a man in a street to say *that is the prefect* and for it to be true."

Antonia stood in the portico of the senate house of Rome.

"No," she said.

Nepos's face did not change.

"Why not? You have been offered the thing you came here for."

"Because a woman who takes that offer will be a woman who sold a girl's hand for a rescript," Antonia said. "And because I have been in this city for thirty-nine years and I have learned that a bargain made at the door of a room is not a bargain, it is a leash. And because you are not the first man to offer me a house and a name, and the last one held a lamp."

Nepos looked at her for a long moment.

Then he did something she had never seen him do. He laughed, and it was not the good laugh, and it was not the false one either. It was the laugh of a man who has been beaten at a game he invented.

"You are the most expensive woman in Rome," he said, "and I have a great deal of money, and I have never once been able to buy you. It is the only thing in my life that I am proud of and it has cost me everything."

He went away down the portico, and the crowd took him, and Antonia stood with her hands folded and the door in front of her.



The doors opened at the fourth hour.

The room was longer than she had imagined and lower than she had imagined, and the light came from the doors at the far end and from the high windows, and the men were on their benches on both sides in their white and their purple, and the consuls were on the raised bench at the end with the curule chairs and the lictors behind them.

The consul was a thin man of fifty called Cornelius Priscus, and he had a face like a folded document.

"The house will hear," he said, "a statement of fact from the freedwoman Antonia Cassia, in the matter of a question of status to be heard before the praetor urbanus on the Nones of December. The statement is made at the request of a consular of this house, and the house will hear it in silence, and any man who interrupts will be asked to leave."

He looked at Gallus.

"The consular will vouch for the witness."

Gallus stood up.

"I vouch for her," he said. "She is a freedwoman of this city, of good standing in her own order, and she is the mother of the person whose status is in question, and she is the only person living who can tell this house what was done in a house on the Viminal in the year 93, because I cannot, and the man who did it cannot, because he is dead." He sat down.

A stir went through the benches.

"Dead?" someone said.

The consul's staff struck the bench once.

"The witness will speak," the consul said.

❦

Antonia came out of the far door and stood in the middle of the floor of the senate house of Rome.

She had thought, on the way, that she would be unable to speak. She had prepared for it: the quarter of an hour, the ten seconds if it came, the not weeping, the voice. What she had not prepared for was the smell of the paper and the way the light came in and the fact that three hundred men in white wool look, from the middle of a floor, exactly like a wall.

"I am Antonia Cassia," she said, "and I was born a slave in the household of the Cassii, and I was manumitted in the consulship of Pompeius Collega and Priscinus, on the eleventh day before the Kalends of December, in the year 93."

Her voice was steady. She heard it going out into the room and she did not recognize it.

"In the September of the following year I bore a daughter in a room above a fuller's shop on the Aventine. She was born free, because I was free, and the law says that the child of a free mother is free, and there is no exception in the law and there never has been. At three months old she was taken from me by the man who had fathered her, who was a senator of this house, and she was sold into his own household under a false name, and she has been held there as a slave for eighteen years."

She took a breath.

"The house may say: this is a private matter. The house may say: it is a family matter, and a sad one, and the courts will decide it. I am not here to ask the house to decide it. The praetor will decide it on the Nones of December, and I have no doubt that he will decide it correctly, because the evidence is in the record and the man who holds her has admitted that he has no title."

She looked at the consul.

"I am here to tell the house what happened in the year 93, when I was nineteen years old and a slave in that household, and when a man of this house held a lamp while I was questioned for eleven hours about a paper that a friend of his father had left on a table."

The wall of white wool did not move.

"There was a man called Didius Probus," Antonia said, "and he was a friend of the household of Cassius Verus, and in September of the year 93 he came to the house at the eleventh hour with a folded paper. I was in the passage behind the kitchen. I was the ornatrix of the house, and I could read, and I spoke to him for a moment about the weather, and he said to me: *you are the young master's girl, and you should be careful, because the young master's father does not like to be surprised.*"

She paused.

"I told the young master what the man had said. Two days later the young master took me by the arm in the passage and asked me what I had heard, and I told him, and he told me to say that I had been in the kitchen and had seen nothing. I promised. I was nineteen and he was the son of the house and I had been in love with him for four months, and I promised."

A man on the benches said something, and another laughed, and the consul's staff struck the bench.

"The man Probus was found dead in his bath nine days later," Antonia said, "and the household said that he had drowned, and the city said what the city says. On the fourth day before the Kalends of October, at the fourth hour of the morning, I was taken from my room by four men and put on a board in a stone room at the back of the tablinum. The elder Cassius Verus asked the questions. A clerk wrote the answers. A man with a rope, who was not of the household, applied the question. And in the doorway, holding the lamp, stood his son, Manius Cassius Verus, who is a consular of this house and who was twenty-six years old."

Nobody laughed.

"It went on for eleven hours," Antonia said. "I answered the questions. Somewhere in the fifth hour I began to answer before they were asked. Somewhere in the eighth hour I named the young

master, and the clerk wrote it down, and the old man said, *again*. And at the end of it he told me that I was alive because I had been clever, and that I would be freed because a freedwoman cannot be put to the question and a freedwoman's word in a court is worth nothing, and because a man who frees the witness has bought a silence that no one can accuse him of buying."

She lifted her left arm, slowly, to the height of her shoulder and no higher.

"This is what it did," she said. "It has been eighteen years. The arm does not go above the shoulder. I have not been able to raise my left arm above my shoulder since the fourth day before the Kalends of October in the year 93, and every day of my life, when I dress, and when I lift a cup, and when I lie down at night, I am told by my own body what this house did to me."

The room was entirely silent.

"I have not come to this house for sympathy," Antonia said. "I have come because of what was done afterward, and because it is still being done, and because the men who do it are sitting in this room."

She took the letter from her sleeve.

"Manius Cassius Verus is dead," she said. "He died in his bath on the third day before the Nones, and he left a statement, and his son has certified the hand and the seal, and I am going to read it to the house. The house will not wish to hear it. The house will wish very much not to hear it. I am going to read it anyway, because it is the only thing that man ever wrote that was worth reading."

She read it.

She read the part about the girl first, as Marcella had asked: *The girl in my house, called Myrtale, is the daughter of Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, and of me, and was born free, and I have held her for*

eighteen years. The note in my hand in the tablinum says no more to be said. I say it now.

Then she read the part about the death: *In the April of this year, on the night of the Floralia, my son Manius Cassius Verus the Younger followed Decimus Iunius Gallus from the house on the Clivus Suburanus and struck him once in the garden of that house, and the boy fell and struck his head on the rim of the fountain and did not rise. My son came to me at the fifth hour and told me. I did not send for the watch. I did not tell the father of the dead boy. I paid a man in the aedile's office and I closed the file and I told my son that it was finished. It was not finished. It has never been finished.*

The benches were moving now. A man in the second row had put his hands over his face. Another was talking to the man beside him, urgently, and the man beside him was shaking his head.

And in the gallery, at the back, a young man in the broad stripe stood up.

"I am Manius Cassius Verus the Younger," he said, "and the letter is my father's hand and my father's seal, and I have signed it, and what it says is true."

The consul's staff struck the bench three times.

"There will be order," the consul said. "There will be order, or the house will be cleared."

Verianus sat down.

Gallus did not move. He was sitting very still on his bench with his hands on his knees and his face the color of the wall, and he did not look at Antonia and he did not look at Verianus, and Antonia thought: he knew, he has known since the summer, and now it has been said in a room with a clerk in it, and after this there is no version of the world in which his son is not a boy who was killed in a garden and lied about by two generations of a consular family.

She went on.

❦

"There is one more thing," Antonia said, "and it is not about the Cassii."

The consul looked at her.

"The house has been patient," he said. "The house has been patient for a quarter of an hour. Say what you have come to say."

"In July of this year, a slave of my household named Dessa was taken from Ostia by four men with a bill of sale that was a forgery and a seal that was genuine. The seal was the seal of the office of the urban prefect. She was held in the cells of that office for five months, and four days ago she was questioned, and she signed a document with her left hand because her right hand no longer closes."

She turned and looked at the far door, and the physician brought Dessa in.

The girl came down the floor of the senate house of Rome with her arm strapped to a board and her chin up, and she stopped in the middle of the floor beside Antonia, and she turned and faced the benches.

Three hundred men looked at her.

"Dessa," Antonia said. "What is your name?"

"Dessa."

"Say what you have come to say."

Dessa looked at the consul.

"My name is Dessa and I am a slave of the household of Antonia Cassia," she said, in a voice that carried to the far end of the room. "I was in the garden on the night of the Floralia. I found the body and I turned it over by the shoulder and I screamed, and there was a man in the lane with a gold ring on his hand, and he went away down the hill. I was taken to Ostia in July and I was questioned for four days without an order of a magistrate, and I signed a document that I did

not write and could not read, and my hand does not close." She paused. "That is what I have come to say."

The room did not applaud. It was not that kind of room. What it did was worse: it went quiet in a new way, a way that meant that every man in it was now thinking about his own household.

The consul waited until the silence had become uncomfortable, and then he said, "The witness may continue."

❦

"The seal," Antonia said.

"The house knows what a seal is."

"The house does not know what this seal costs. There is a freedman in the prefect's office called Anicetus, who has been in that office eleven years, and who sells the use of the office's seal to men who will pay. There is a freedman called Felix, who carries messages and who has a burn on the back of his right hand, and who has a room in the Via Nova paid for by a landlord who is a client of a man called Oppius Nepos. And there is Oppius Nepos himself, who has been buying seals and men and documents for twenty years, and who would like the house to believe that his family has been in Puteoli for five generations, and whose father was a slave of the Oppii, and an auctioneer's clerk, and was manumitted in the year 72, and is buried in Puteoli with the word *libertus* on his tomb."

The benches erupted.

The consul was on his feet with his staff raised. "Order! The house will come to order!" He struck the bench four times, five, and the lictors moved forward, and the noise went down by degrees, and in the gallery the freedman of the ab epistulis went on writing.

"Those are accusations," the consul said, "of a grave nature, made in this house, by a woman, against men who are not here to answer. The house will hear the evidence."

"The evidence is in the guild's book," Antonia said, "and the guild's book is in a strongroom that three men must open, and one of the three is the keeper of the guild's records, a freedman called Epaphroditus, who is seventy years old, who has no teeth, and who is waiting in the portico of this house at this moment with a sealed copy in his hand and the name of the praetor who manumitted Gaius Oppius Philargyrus in the margin. And the second copy of the bill of sale that was used to take the girl Dessa from Ostia is in the hands of the urban prefect, who has had it since October, and who has been unable to act on it because the office that issued it is the office that would have to investigate it."

The consul looked at her.

"And the emperor's council?" he said.

Antonia looked at the benches. She found the man in the third row, on the right, in the purple stripe, sitting very still with his hands on his knees: a consular of sixty, with a good name and a bad memory, who had come to her house in the year 95 with a purse and a proposal.

"There is a man in this room," she said, "who came to me in the year 95, when I was two years out of a brothel and had nothing but a debt and a room, and who offered me four hundred thousand sesterces to leave Rome and never speak of the year 93 again. I took three hundred thousand of it, because I was twenty-two years old and hungry, and I have regretted it every day since, and I have his name in a book and I have his seal on a receipt and I have the copy of the payment in my strongbox."

She let the silence run.

"I am not going to say his name in this house," she said. "He is old, and he has a wife, and one of his sons is a friend of mine. But he is sitting in this room, and he knows it, and every man on those benches is now looking at his neighbour and wondering. That is the

punishment I have chosen for him. It is a better one than the law would give me, and it will last longer."

The room was a wall of white wool with a hundred faces turning.

"I have said what I came to say," Antonia said. "The house may do with it what it likes. The praetor will hear the case on the Nones of December, and the girl will be freed or she will not, and the men who sold the seals will be prosecuted or they will not, and in ten years this will be a story that old men tell at dinner. But it has been said. It has been said in this room, in front of three hundred men and a clerk, and it has been written down, and no man in Rome can now say that he did not know."

The consul leaned forward.

"The witness has said that she was questioned in the year 93," he said. "The witness has asked this house to believe that she was questioned without cause. There was a charge, was there not? There was a matter of treason in that household, and a man died, and the elder Cassius Verus was never accused. Was the witness questioned in a matter of treason?"

"She was questioned in a matter of treason."

"And was a question of treason a matter for the prefect's court?"

"It was a matter for the emperor's court, and the emperor was Domitian."

"Then the house will observe that the questioning of a slave in a matter of treason was lawful."

Antonia looked at him.

"The questioning of a slave is lawful," she said. "The questioning of a slave is lawful and the torture of a slave is lawful and the sale of a freeborn child is a crime, and the law has never had any difficulty holding those three things at once." She paused. "I have spent eighteen years discovering what the law is. I know exactly what the law is. The law is a floor, and a man may stand on it, and a man may

do a great many things standing on it, and the things he does are not the less wicked for being lawful."

The consul looked at her for a long moment.

"The house will observe," he said, "that the witness is a very unusual woman."

"I am a woman who kept accounts," Antonia said. "It is not a remarkable thing to be. It is remarkable only because the men who kept the accounts did not expect me to read them."

She turned to the consul.

"That is my statement," she said. "I am grateful to the house for hearing it."

❦

The consul looked at her for a long moment.

"The house has heard it," he said. "The house will not debate it today. The matter of the status is before the praetor, and the matter of the seals is a matter for the urban prefect, and the matter of the guild's book is a matter for the guild, and the matter of a consular's death is a matter for his family and for the gods." He straightened his toga. "But the house will record that a statement was made in this room on this day, and the clerk will enter it in the book, and it will be read by the emperor's freedmen, and it will be preserved."

He looked at the benches.

"The house is adjourned until the Nones."

The room rose. Three hundred men began to talk at once, and the noise was like a wave coming up a beach, and Gallus was on his feet and moving toward the consul's bench, and the lictors were clearing a path, and in the gallery the clerk of the ab epistulis closed his tablets and looked down at Antonia with an expression she could not read.

Myrtale was standing in the gallery with Tullia.

She had stood up at some point during the speech, and she was still standing, and she was the only person in the gallery who was not moving.

She said something. Antonia could not hear it across the room. She read it off her daughter's mouth, and it took her a moment, and then she had it.

Cassia.



They came out of the senate house into the afternoon, and the steps were full of men, and the whole Forum was full of the news, which had gone out of the doors before they had.

Gallus was waiting at the bottom of the steps with his hat in his hand.

"Well," he said.

"Well."

"I have been in that room for twenty-two years and I have never heard anything like it, and I am not sure that I approve of it, and I am entirely certain that no one will ever forget it." He put his hat on. "The consul has asked me to tell you that the house will not move against the prefect's office while the emperor is in Rome, because the emperor is leaving and the office has to keep the grain moving, and that any prosecution will be a matter for the spring, and that he is sorry."

"I did not expect a prosecution."

"You did not?"

"I expected the record," Antonia said. "I have been in this city for thirty-nine years, and I have learned that a prosecution is a thing that a great man can survive, and a record is a thing that a great man's son has to live with."

Gallus looked at her.

"There is a thing I have to say to you," he said, "and I am going to say it badly, because I have a cold and because I have been holding it in since the middle of your statement. When you read that letter, and my son's name was in it, and the manner of his death —" He stopped. "I have wanted to know for eight months. I have wanted to know more than I have wanted anything in my life. And now I know, and it is exactly what I feared, and it has not helped at all. It has made it worse. Because now I know that my son was killed by a boy who was frightened, in a garden, over a joke about a girl, and that a family closed a file, and that my son is still dead, and that no amount of knowing will put him back."

"Lucius."

"I am not finished." Gallus took her arm. "I have been angry with you for eight months. I was angry with you in April for lying, and in August for telling me, and in October for making me choose. And today you stood in that room and read out the death of my son in front of three hundred men, and you did not once use it. You did not say *and this is why the house should listen to me*. You did not make it a part of your case. You put it in the middle and you let it stand there."

"It was not mine to use."

"No," Gallus said. "It was not. And that is the thing I have been trying to say." He let go of her arm. "I will stand in the praetor's court on the Nones and I will assert the freedom of your daughter, and I will do it as a consular of Rome and as the father of Decimus Iunius Gallus, and I will not say a word about my son, because there is a girl who needs to be free and a dead boy cannot be helped by it. And after the case is over, I am going to go home and I am going to be a man who has lost a son, and I am going to be that for the rest of my life, and you will come to dinner on the ninth day and we will not talk about it."

"All right," Antonia said.

"All right." Gallus blew his nose. "Now go home. You look like a woman who has been standing up in the senate house for a quarter of an hour, and there is a chair at the bottom of the steps with your name on it, and a physician, and a girl with a splint who is going to need a great deal of soup."



They went down the steps together, and the crowd at the bottom opened for them, and Antonia understood, as she came down into the light, that the whole Forum was looking at her.

Not the way a crowd looks at a woman of business. Not the way it looks at a famous courtesan or a rich freedwoman or a spectacle. It was looking at her the way it looked at a man who had come out of the senate house having done something, and she did not know what to do with her face.

"Domina," Myrtale said, at her elbow.

"Yes."

"Did it work?"

Antonia stopped at the bottom of the steps, in the middle of the Forum, with the whole city going past.

"I do not know," she said. "It is the Nones tomorrow, and there will be Caesennius Rufus and his instrument and a praetor who is a decent man and a lazy one, and a case is a case." She looked at her daughter. "But it is written down. Whatever happens in two days, it is written down, and it will be in the book of the senate of Rome when you are an old woman, and no one will be able to take it out."

Myrtale looked at the senate house.

"It is a very small building," she said.

"It is four hundred years old and it has a leaking roof and it smells of paper," Antonia said. "Most of the things that last are like that."

CHAPTER XXIV

THE VERDICT

Rome, the Nones of December, AD 112

The Nones of December came up grey and cold, with a wind off the river that got into the Subura and stayed there.

Antonia was up before the light. She washed in cold water because the furnace had gone out in the night and there was no one to light it, and she put on the blue stola and the grey mantle and the plain gold pins, and she looked at herself in the bronze for a while and found a woman of thirty-nine with grey in her hair and a mouth that had set in a way she did not entirely like.

Four of the seven women had come back from the prefect's office on the afternoon of the senate, with their names written in the register and their clothes still smelling of the cells. Meroe was still held, because Meroe had been bought in Puteoli and the bill of sale was in Puteoli, and a clerk had decided that this required a letter. Rufina had come back and gone straight to the kitchen and started cooking, and Cela had come back and cried for two hours and then slept for fourteen, and the youngest, who was fifteen and whose name was Sabina, had come back and asked Antonia whether she was going to be sold, and had been told no, and had not believed it, and had asked again in the morning.

And the book was gone.

The book had gone out of the house on the morning of the raid in a bag with a clerk's writing on it, and it was in the prefect's office, and the prefect's office had made no answer to three letters from

Gallus and one from the consul. Tullia had a man in the office who had been feeding her information for six years, and the man said that the book was in a cupboard in the second room and that nobody had been authorized to read it, and that the prefect had said, in front of four clerks, that he would rather be eaten by dogs than be the man who opened that cupboard.

"But he will open it," Tullia said, in the doorway of the bedroom, while Antonia put her pins in. "He will open it because the emperor's freedmen will make him, and then four hundred names will be in the hands of an office, and half of them are men who pay us and the other half are men who would like to see us ruined, and after today nobody will be able to tell which is which."

"I know."

"Then what do we do?"

"We go to court," Antonia said, "and we get the girl free, and then we spend the rest of the winter getting the book back."

"And if we do not get it back?"

"Then we have lost a book," Antonia said, "and I will have to start another one, and I am thirty-nine years old and I have a good memory and I have kept the names in my head for twenty years. A book is a thing that can be lost. That is what makes it a book and not a wall." She turned from the bronze. "Where is the chair?"

"In the lane. Hilarus has been standing beside it since the sixth hour, and he is cold, and he has been telling the bearers about his sister."

❦

The Basilica Julia at the second hour of the Nones was fuller than it had been on the Ides.

The crowd was three deep at the doors and there were men on the steps and men on the roof of the colonnade opposite, and the whole south side of the hall was a press of bodies, and the clerks had

given up trying to keep the aisles and had put a rope across the back instead.

"They have come to see the verdict," Gallus said.

"They have come to see whether a slave can be freed by a woman who keeps a brothel."

"They have come to see whether the law works," Gallus said. "It is the same thing, in this city, and it is the only entertainment that is free."

Caesennius Rufus was already at the front with his advocate and two of his four witnesses. He looked older than he had in November. His advocate came over while the court was settling, a thin man in a good toga with the careful manner of a man who has been sent to do something unpleasant, and he asked to speak with Gallus in the corner by the door of the clerks' room, and Gallus went, and Antonia went with him because she was not going to stand in a hall and be told afterward.

"My client will withdraw the instrument," the advocate said.

Gallus looked at him.

"Withdraw it how?"

"He will declare in open court that the conveyance was made without his knowledge of the facts, and that he has no wish to hold a free woman, and that he releases any claim he may have, and he will pay the costs of the action and a sum to the person claimed for her trouble." The advocate's face did not move. "Ten thousand sesterces."

"And the instrument?"

"He will surrender it to the court to be cancelled."

"No."

The advocate blinked.

"Domine —"

"No," Gallus said. "I will not have it cancelled. The instrument is the crime. It is signed by Manius Cassius Verus and sealed and

witnessed, and it purports to convey a freeborn woman as part of a dowry, and if it is cancelled then there is no evidence that any such document ever existed, and in six months there will be a story in this city that Caesennius Rufus was dragged into a court over a mistake in a marriage contract by a freedwoman with a grudge. I have spent eight months on this case. I do not intend to spend the rest of my life explaining it to men at dinner."

"Then what do you want?"

"I want the instrument read into the record, and I want the court to rule on it, and I want the ruling to say what the law says, which is that a free person cannot be conveyed and that the instrument is evidence of a crime under the lex Fabia." Gallus put his hands behind his back. "And then your client may go home."

The advocate looked at Gallus for a long moment.

"Domine," he said, "my client is fifty-four years old and has a wife who is pregnant and a cousin on the emperor's council, and he did not buy the girl. He married a woman whose father put a line in a contract. If you do this, he is a man who has been publicly attached to a crime of which he is innocent, and he will spend the rest of his life denying it."

"Yes," Gallus said. "He will. And the girl will spend the rest of her life being a woman who was conveyed in a marriage contract, and she will not have the consolation of being innocent, because she was there."

The advocate looked at Antonia.

"Domina," he said. "You are the injured party, in a manner of speaking. Will you not be merciful?"

Antonia looked at the front of the hall, where Caesennius Rufus was standing with his scroll in his hand and his face set in the expression of a man who has been told that the morning will be expensive.

"I have been merciful for eight months," she said. "I have been merciful to the aedile's clerk and to the prefect's office and to a man

who held a lamp, and every time I was merciful a girl was taken further away from me. I have run out of mercy. It is not a moral position. It is an inventory."

The advocate looked at her.

"You are a hard woman," he said.

"I am a woman who has been asked to be soft by every man who has ever wanted something from me," Antonia said. "Tell your client that the court convenes in a quarter of an hour, and that if he wishes to be merciful he may be merciful by telling the truth in a loud voice in front of three hundred people, which is the only mercy that has ever done anybody any good."

❦

The praetor came in at the second hour and the clerks called the hall to order and it took a long time, because the hall was full and the crowd at the back kept pressing forward to see.

"The matter of the person claimed," the praetor said. "The court is in receipt of an instrument produced on the Ides and of the argument of the adsertor. The claimant will speak to the instrument."

Caesennius Rufus came forward with his scroll.

He was not a fool, and he had been advised by a man who was not a fool either, and he had obviously been up most of the night. He said what he had come to say in a flat, clear voice: that when he signed the marriage instrument in August he had been told that the woman Myrtale was a slave of the Cassian household and part of his wife's dowry at a valuation of twelve thousand sesterces; that he had never seen the woman and had no interest in her; that when the case came before the court in November and he heard what was said in the hall, he had gone home and asked his wife's father to explain the transaction; and that he had received no explanation.

"I have been a fool," he said, "and I have been made a fool of, and the instrument is mine because my hand is on it, and I do not

ask the court to believe that I am innocent of a crime. I ask the court to believe that I am guilty of nothing but signing a paper that a consular put in front of me at a wedding, and to allow me to withdraw it, and to release the woman, and to accept from me the sum of ten thousand sesterces for her maintenance, and whatever the court thinks fit to add to it."

The hall stirred.

The praetor looked at him for a moment.

"The court accepts the sum and the release," he said, "and the court does not accept the withdrawal."

Rufus's face went the color of tallow.

"Domine —"

"The instrument is before the court," the praetor said, "and the question the court must determine is whether the person claimed was free at the time of the conveyance. The claimant does not get to determine that question by withdrawing. Sit down."

Rufus sat down.

"Adsertor."

Gallus stood up.

"I will be brief," he said, "because the facts are in the record and the court has heard them twice, and because there is a girl in this hall who has been waiting since the Ides of November to be told what she is." He took a breath. "The instrument conveys *a female slave named Myrtale, valued at twelve thousand sesterces*. She was not a slave. She was born free in September of the year 94, in a room above a fuller's shop on the Aventine, to a woman who had been free for less than a year, manumitted before the praetor of this city, whose manumission is in the archive of the fourteenth region. A free woman bore a free daughter, and a free daughter cannot be conveyed, and a document that purports to convey her is not a contract. It is a false statement made with the intent to hold a free person in slavery, and that is a crime under the lex Fabia de plagio. The court

knows this. The court knew it in November. The court has been waiting three weeks for the claimant to produce a defence, and the claimant has now told the court, in his own words, that he has none."

He looked at the praetor.

"The court should rule," he said. "And the court should rule in a way that a clerk can write down in a sentence that a man in a street can repeat, because for eighteen years the whole of this city has been repeating a sentence that was written in a tablinum by a man who is now dead, and it is time the city had a better one."

The praetor looked at the papers in front of him for a long moment.

Then he looked up.

"The court finds," he said, "that the person claimed, called Myrtale, was born free, being the daughter of a freedwoman manumitted before her birth, and that she has been held in slavery contrary to law for eighteen years, and that the instrument produced by Caesennius Rufus is void, and being void conveys nothing, and being an instrument that purports to convey a free person it is to be retained by the court and a copy sent to the curator of the lex Fabia." He set the paper down. "The person claimed is free. She is free from this hour, and the court directs that the fact be entered in the register of the fourteenth region, and that a copy of this decree be given to her."

The hall broke open.

It was not applause. It was something older and worse and better: three hundred people making the noise that people make when a thing they have been waiting for arrives, and half of them were pleased and half of them were angry and all of them were loud, and the clerks were shouting, and somewhere at the back a woman screamed, and Rufus's advocate put his hand over his eyes.

Antonia did not hear any of it.

She was looking at Myrtale, who was standing in the middle of the floor in the white dress with the token on its cord, and who had not moved, and whose face was doing something that Antonia had never seen on it before and could not name.

❦

"The court will complete the form," the praetor said, when the hall had been brought back to order. "The lictor will attend."

This was the oldest part of it, and the part that nobody in the hall had ever seen performed for a woman of eighteen who had been held in a great house for all of her life. It was the form by which a person in slavery was made free before the praetor: the rod laid on the head, the words, the turning, the hand.

The lictor came forward with the vindicta, which was a thin wand of beech, and he stood beside Myrtale, and the praetor said the words of the old formula, and the lictor laid the rod on her head and said, in a voice that carried to the doors, *hunc ego hominem liberum esse aio, et hunc vindicta libero* — I say that this person is free, and I free her by the rod.

And then Myrtale turned.

Antonia had not known that she would turn. Nobody had told her what the form was, and the praetor had not explained it, and she turned because the rod was on her head and there was a hand on her shoulder turning her, and it was the lictor's hand, and she turned the way a door turns on a hinge.

She turned and she was facing the crowd, and Antonia was in the fourth rank on the left, and for a moment their eyes met and neither of them moved.

Then the praetor said, "The person is free. The court is adjourned."

❦

There was a scene at the door.

There is always a scene at the door. The crowd wanted to see her come out, and the clerks wanted her name for the register, and a man from the office of the ab epistulis wanted to know whether the adsertor would be making a statement, and there was a boy selling hot wine, and two of Caesennius Rufus's witnesses were trying to get out of a side door without being seen.

The clerks took Myrtale into the room behind the court to enter her in the register.

Antonia waited outside with her hands folded and her heart going.

The clerk who came out was a thin, tired man with ink on his fingers, and he came out with his tablet and said, "Domina, there is a difficulty."

"What difficulty?"

"The register requires three names."

"It does."

"She has one. *Myrtale.* She says she has one." The clerk looked at his tablet. "A person freed by the rod takes the name of the man who asserts her freedom, or of her household, or of her father, if she has one. She has no father in law. The adsertor is a consular and has not offered his name, and the court will not assign one, and she has declined the name of the household in which she was held."

"She has declined it?"

"She said, and I wrote it down, that she would not be entered as a freedwoman of that house for any man's convenience." The clerk turned the tablet around. "The clerk's instruction is that we cannot enter a person with one name. It is a matter of the form. The form is four hundred years old and there is no one in this building who can tell me what to do with a woman who has one name and a great deal of self-respect."

Antonia looked at the tablet.

"May I speak to her?"

"You may."

Myrtale was standing in the little room behind the court with the decree in her hand and her chin up and her face still doing the thing Antonia could not name, and she looked at Antonia in the doorway and said, "I am not going to be a Cassia."

"I know."

"They will want to write it. They will want to write Cassia because it is the house and it is respectable and the clerk needs a line to fill. And I will be a Cassia in the register of the fourteenth region for the rest of my life, and every man who reads it will think I was freed by a consular family out of kindness, and no one will ever know what was done."

"Then do not be a Cassia," Antonia said.

Myrtale looked at her.

"What else is there?"

"There is mine," Antonia said. "It is not a family name. I took it from a man who was kind to me and who is dead, and I took the other half of it from the house that owned me, and I have carried it for eighteen years in this city and it has been a door and a shield and a stone around my neck by turns. It is not a great name. No consul has ever had it. It is the name of a freedwoman who kept accounts."

Myrtale's jaw worked.

"And if I take it," she said, "then the register says that I am your daughter."

"Yes."

"Everyone will know."

"Everyone already knows," Antonia said. "There were three hundred men in the senate house yesterday and half of Rome was on the steps this morning. The only question left is whether the register says it, and the register is the thing that lasts."

Myrtale stood in the little room with the decree in her hand and did not answer for a long time.

Then she said, "Antonia."

The clerk wrote it down. *Antonia Myrtale, freed by the rod, daughter of Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, of the fourteenth region.* And then, because the form required a third name and there was no father and no patron, the clerk looked up and said, "The third name?"

"Cassia," Myrtale said.

The clerk's pen stopped.

"You said —"

"I said I would not be called Cassia for that house." Myrtale's voice was steady and her eyes were on Antonia and not on the clerk. "Cassia is my mother's manumittor's name and it is the name of the house that held me, and it is also the name of the woman who died in that house and who freed my mother and who did not know what her son was. I will take it, and I will take it for her, and I will not take her son's."

The clerk wrote it down.

Antonia Cassia Myrtale.

They came out of the basilica into the Forum at the fourth hour, and the whole square was full of the news, which had gone out of the doors before them and was already at the rostra and the steps of the temple and the booths in the Via Julia.

Myrtale walked out between Antonia and Gallus with her decree rolled in her hand, and a man in the front called out, "What is your name?" and Myrtale stopped and said, "Antonia Cassia Myrtale," in a clear voice, and the man said, "That is too many names," and she said, "I have the paper for all of them," and the crowd laughed, and

it was the first time Antonia had heard her daughter make a joke in public.

At the bottom of the steps Iusta the midwife was waiting with her hands folded and tears running down her face, and she took Myrtale's face in both her hands and said something in Greek, and Myrtale bent her head and let her say it, and the two of them stood there for a moment in the middle of the Forum with the crowd going past.

Gallus blew his nose.

"Well," he said. "That is the case. Sixteen years of practice and eight months of the worst year of my life, and it took a quarter of an hour, and I am going to go home and sleep for two days."

"Lucius."

"What?"

"Thank you."

Gallus looked at the crowd.

"I did it for the law," he said. "I did it because a man in this city put a line in a contract and I have spent my life believing that a line in a contract is a thing that can be argued with. I did not do it for you, and I did not do it for the girl, and I certainly did not do it for my son." He put his hat on. "But I am glad it is done, and I am going to come to dinner on the ninth day, and you are going to give me the good wine, and we are not going to talk about any of it."

❦

There was a letter waiting at the house.

It had come at the third hour in the hands of a freedman of the ab epistulis with a seal that had been opened and closed again, and Tullia had put it on the table in the room with the strongbox and stood beside it, because she had read it, having been given leave to read anything that came into the house for twenty years, and because she wanted to see Antonia's face when she read it.

It was from the office of the ab epistulis, and it concerned Manius Cassius Verus the Younger.

Whereas the said Manius Cassius Verus the Younger has confessed in the senate house of Rome, on the day before the Nones of December, to having caused the death of Decimus Iunius Gallus in the month of April of this year; and whereas the father of the said Manius Cassius Verus has by his own hand confessed to the concealment of the said death and to the corruption of a magistrate's clerk; and whereas the family of the said Manius Cassius Verus has petitioned that the matter be heard by the emperor's council and not by the court of the lex Cornelia; the council has determined that the said Manius Cassius Verus shall be relegated to the island of Gyaros for a term of five years, and that his father's name shall be struck from the fasti of the consulship of the year 103, and that the imagines of the house of the Cassii shall be veiled for a year and a day.

The council has further determined that the freedman Anicetus, of the office of the urban prefect, shall be put to the question and, if he confesses, sold beyond the hundredth milestone; and that the freedman called Felix shall be sought; and that the matter of the seals shall be laid before the urban prefect, who will report to the emperor before his departure.

The council has not determined the matter of the house of the Cassii, which is a matter of private law and is before the praetor.

Antonia read it twice.

"Five years," she said.

"Five years," Tullia said, "and the island of Gyaros, which is a rock with a spring on it. And his father's consulship struck from the fasti, which has not been done to a consular in forty years. And the imagines veiled." She folded her hands. "It is more than I expected. It is not what I wanted."

"What did you want?"

"I wanted him tried in the court of the lex Cornelia, in the Forum, with the father's letter read out and the mother in the front rank." Tullia's mouth was a thin line. "And instead the emperor's council has taken it, because a consular family asked them to, and they have given him an island, which is where great men go when they are tired, and in five years he will come back with a beard and a Greek library and a great deal of self-pity, and there will be men in this city who say that he was badly used."

"Yes," Antonia said. "There will."

"And you are not angry."

"I am extremely angry," Antonia said. "I am angry in a way that I intend to be for a long time, and I will not spend it on a letter from an office. I will spend it on the book."

❦

The book came back four days later.

It came back because Petronius Celer, the urban prefect, sent it back, with a covering note in his own hand that said, in its entirety: *Domina, this is not my office's business and I have no wish to make it mine. The cupboard was opened in the presence of three clerks and nothing was copied. I have had the bag burned. — P. Celer.*

The bag had been burned. Antonia, who had been in this city for thirty-nine years, did not believe for a moment that nothing had been copied, and she took the book and put it on the table and opened it at the last page.

There were four hundred and six names, with the amounts and the reasons and the dates, in her own hand and in the hands of two clerks before her, and in the back the pages that were not accounts: the six words about the stone room, the numbers, the name of a consular written once and crossed out.

The book was exactly as it had been.

Antonia sat down at the table with it.

"Tullia," she said. "Bring me the pen and the ink, and a new page, and the girl."

Myrtale came in with her decree in her hand, which she had not put down in four days.

"Sit down," Antonia said. "You are going to write in the book."

Myrtale looked at the book on the table.

"That is the book."

"That is the book. It has four hundred and six names in it and it is the reason the house was raided and the reason I have been eight months in a bad temper and the reason I have a strongbox with a false bottom. It is also the only thing in this house that will still exist in a hundred years, because paper lasts longer than marble if it is kept dry, and because a marble arch says what an emperor did and a book says what people are." She pushed the pen across the table. "Write your name at the top of the page. The full name. The one the clerk wrote."

Myrtale took the pen.

She wrote slowly, with her tongue between her teeth, the way people write who have been taught to read and not to write: *Antonia Cassia Myrtale, freed by the rod before the praetor urbanus on the Nones of December in the consulship of Trajan, consul for the sixth time, and of Titus Sextius Africanus.*

"Now write the sentence underneath," Antonia said. "In your own words. Not mine. The sentence you would want a man in a street to be able to repeat."

Myrtale sat with the pen over the page for a long time.

Then she wrote: *I was born free and I was held for eighteen years and I am not going to be quiet about it.*

Antonia read it.

"That will do," she said. "That will do very well."

Myrtale went out at noon to see about a room.

She had decided, in the way she decided things, quickly and without consulting anyone, that she was not going to live in the house on the Clivus, or in a room that Antonia had paid for, and that she would live with Iusta at Ficulea until the spring and then find work.

"There is work," she said, standing in the doorway with her bundle. "There is work in the gardens and work in the markets and there is a woman in the Via Lata who wants someone to keep her accounts and cannot read. I can read. I have been able to read since I was seven, and I have never been paid a copper for it."

"You can keep accounts here," Antonia said.

"I know."

"I am not asking you to forgive me. There is nothing to forgive. I have spent eighteen years looking for you and eight months putting my house and my name and my body in front of a court to get you out, and I have not done one thing in all of it that I am ashamed of."

"I know," Myrtale said again, and her voice was not hard, which was the worst of it. It was patient. "And I am not punishing you. I am not even angry with you. I am angry with the whole of it, and I have nowhere to put it, and if I stay in this house I will put it on you, and you do not deserve it. So I am going to Ficulea, and I am going to be a free woman in a small room for a while, and I will come to dinner on the ninth day."

"All right."

"And domina —"

"Do not call me domina."

Myrtale stood in the doorway.

"I do not have another word yet," she said. "I have been trying them out. I tried *mother* in the room behind the court and it did not come out of my mouth, and I will not say a word to you that does not come out. When I find one, I will say it."

She went out.

Antonia stood in the doorway of her own house and watched her daughter go down the Clivus with a bundle on her shoulder, and she did not cry until the corner, and then she cried for about the length of time it takes to boil water, and then she went in and washed her face and had the chair brought round, because there was a man in the Via Larga who owed her money.

❦

In the evening, Marcella came.

She came in a closed chair with two of her husband's men and no jewelry, stood in front of the table with her hands folded and said, "I have come to be told what happened, because my husband will not tell me and my daughter will not speak to me, and the only person in this city who will tell me the truth is a woman I have been taught to despise."

Antonia told her.

She told her about the court, and the rod, and the clerk, and the three names, and the sentence in the book. She told her about the letter from the ab epistulis, and the island, and the fasti, and the imagines.

Marcella listened with her hands folded.

"So he is not dead," she said, when Antonia had finished.

"Verianus? No. He is on a ship to Gyaros."

"My husband is dead and my son is on a rock in the Aegean and my daughter is a woman whose father's consulship has been struck from the fasti, and the girl is free and has a name and has gone to live with a midwife." Marcella looked at the wall. "I have been in that house for twenty-six years. I have kept its accounts and its keys and its silences. I found the purchase record in 104 and I said nothing for eight years, and the reason I said nothing was not fear and it was not loyalty. It was that I had done the arithmetic and decided that

the price of speaking was higher than the price of silence, and I was right, and I have been right every day for eight years, and it has made me the kind of woman who is right."

"Marcella."

"I am not asking for comfort. I am telling you what I have been." She opened her purse and took out a small, flat object wrapped in cloth and set it on the table. "This is the seal ring. His father's. The one in the strongbox, the one with the ship on it, the one the household has used for forty years to seal everything it ever said. My son gave it to me before he was taken and told me to give it to the girl, and I have decided that I will not, because it is a thing that belongs to a house that is finished, and because a seal ring in the hand of a freedwoman is a temptation and not a gift."

She unwrapped it. It was gold and heavy, and the ship was worn almost smooth.

"I am giving it to you instead," she said. "You are the only person I know who would use it and not be corrupted by it, and if I am wrong about that, then I have been wrong about one more thing, and I am too tired to mind."

Antonia looked at the ring.

"I do not want it," she said.

"I did not want to be the woman I am," Marcella said. "We do not always get the thing we want. Take the ring and put it in your strongbox with your book and your receipts, and when a man comes to you in twenty years and says that the Cassii were a great house, you will have the ring and the book and the letter, and you will be able to tell him what a great house is."

She went out without waiting for an answer.

Antonia sat at the table with the ring in front of her and the lamp burning and the whole house quiet.

Then she opened the book at the page where her daughter had written, and she took the pen, and underneath the sentence she

wrote, in her own hand, the last entry in the book of the house on the Clivus:

On the Nones of December, in the consulship of Trajan for the sixth time, the praetor urbanus of Rome declared Antonia Cassia Myrtale free, and her mother paid nothing for it, and the law did the work, and it took eighteen years.

She blotted it, and closed the book, and put it in the strongbox with the false bottom, and blew out the lamp.

CHAPTER XXV

THE COLUMN OF TRAJAN

Rome, the week of the dedication, May, AD 113

The dedication was in May, which the priests had chosen and the engineers had not, and the whole city came out to see a hundred and ten feet of marble with a bronze man on top of it.

They had been building the forum for eleven years, with money that had come out of Dacia in ox-carts, and Antonia had walked past the site four hundred times and had never once been inside, because it was not a place for a woman with business. Now she was inside.

The crowd filled the colonnade and the steps of the basilica and the whole of the open square, and the square was paved in white marble from end to end, and the light came off it in a way that made her feel she was standing in a bath. There were two libraries, Greek and Latin, and between them the Column rose, and the Column was the thing everyone had come to see.

"It is smaller than I thought," said Sabina, who was fifteen and had been free for nine months and had developed opinions.

"It is a hundred feet high," Hilarus said.

"I know how high a hundred feet is. I have carried things up three flights of stairs in the Subura." Sabina put her chin up. "I thought it would be bigger."

Myrtale laughed.

Antonia stood between them in the good blue stola with the grey mantle and looked up the shaft of the Column and did not say anything at all.

❦

The frieze went up in a spiral, twenty-three turns, and it had been cut by men who had never been to Dacia and who had worked from drawings and from the accounts of soldiers and, Antonia suspected, from their own invention, and the whole war was on it.

The army crossing the river on the bridge of boats. The baggage train. The siege. The Dacian horsemen with their curved swords and their caps. The village burning. The women in the village. The soldiers presenting heads to the emperor. The emperor on a platform, four times, at four different points of the spiral, receiving the submission, receiving the treasure, receiving the embassy, receiving the news.

Dessa walked around it.

She had come in her plain dress and her shoes on, and she had said almost nothing since they had come through the gate, and she walked around the base of the Column once, slowly, and then again, and then a third time, and then she stopped in front of a panel about a third of the way up and stood there with her hands at her sides.

Antonia went and stood beside her.

"That is a village," Dessa said.

"Yes."

"It is not my village."

"No."

"It is not anyone's village." Dessa's voice was flat and not loud. "There is a river and a bridge and a village on a hill, and the village has eleven houses and a wall with a gate with two towers, and the soldiers are coming up from the south. My village had one tower

and the gate was on the east and there were fourteen houses and a stone by the gate that had been there since before the Romans came, and they came up from the north because the north side was the low side."

She looked at the marble.

"It is a good village," she said. "It is better than mine. Some man in a workshop in Rome made a village out of the word *Dacia*, and now the emperor will stand on the top of it on a bronze horse, and the whole of Rome will look up and say, there is Dacia."

"Dessa."

"I am not going to cry," Dessa said. "I have not cried since the wagon, and I will not begin in the forum of the emperor with three thousand people in it."

"I would mind," she added. "I wanted to find it. That is what I came for, domina. One panel out of twenty-three turns with a thing in it that I knew — a gate, a stone, the shape of a hill — and I have walked around it for a quarter of an hour, and there is nothing. It is not that they got it wrong. They got it right in the way that a man gets a face right when he has never seen the face."

The crowd moved past them, and a child was lifted onto a man's shoulders somewhere behind, and the sound was the sound of a great many people being pleased.

"Then you will have to be the panel," Antonia said.

Dessa looked at her.

"You are the only Dacia that is going to survive," Antonia said. "In a hundred years the marble will be a ruin with grass on it, and men will read the panels and say, that is how it was, and the ones who could tell them otherwise were carried off at fourteen and set to washing cups, and they are the ones who will be listened to least. So you will have to write it down."

"I can barely write."

"You can count," Antonia said, "and you can remember, and I have a book and a strongbox and a boy in the Subura who copies documents for two sesterces a page." She looked at the column. "I am going to start a second book. The villages, from the people who were in them. And when it is done I will give a copy to the Latin library, so that a man who comes in here in fifty years to read a poem will walk past the shelf with your village in it, and if he is the sort of man who looks, he will find that the village on the column has the well in the wrong place."

Dessa looked at the marble for a long moment.

"It had fourteen houses," she said. "The gate was on the east."

"Write it down," Antonia said.

❦

Gallus found them at the base of the Column, where he had been carried in a chair and set down under the colonnade, and where he was in the middle of an argument with a man from the praetor's office about whether the dedication counted as a holiday.

"You came," he said. "Well. What do you think of it?"

"I think it is a book," Antonia said, "and I think it has one author, and I think it has been very carefully written."

Gallus was silent for a moment.

"That is exactly what I think," he said, "and I have not been able to say it to anybody, because everybody wants to talk about the engineering. The war is in stone and the names of the dead are not, and every man in this square this morning believes that he is looking at history. He is looking at a receipt."

"A beautiful receipt."

"The most beautiful ever made," Gallus said. "That is not nothing. If I had made it, I would be pleased with myself." He blew his nose. "And the door?"

"The door is new. Real gilt, not paint. The old one had four hundred men's bootprints in the bottom of it, and I have had the oak made into a bench for the garden."

Gallus laughed, and it turned into a cough that went on for a while.

"You will be the death of me," he said, when he had got his breath, "and I will go into the ground saying that the last thing I did as a consular of Rome was to stand up for a freedwoman's daughter against the whole order, and that the wine at her house is better than the wine at the palace."

"That is not saying much. The wine at the palace is not meant to be drunk. It is meant to be seen."

❦

The rescript came in July.

It came in the afternoon heat, when the whole Subura smells of dust and the cook's fires, and it came in the hands of Callirhoe, who was the empress's woman and who came in a plain chair with two men and a sealed box and would not give the box to anyone but Antonia.

She set it on the table in the room with the strongbox and put her hand on it and said, "Before you open it, I am to tell you three things, and I am to tell them in order, and you are not to interrupt me, because if I am interrupted I will lose my place and she will ask me what you said and I will be ashamed."

"Say them."

"The first is that she is sorry it took until July. The office sat on it since March and she had to go to the emperor twice." Callirhoe folded her hands. "The second is that the rescript is what she said it would be, in every particular, and that you should read the second clause aloud in a room with the door shut, because she wrote it her-

self with a jurist behind her, and she wants to be told whether you cried."

"I do not cry."

"She said you would say that." Callirhoe's mouth twitched. "The third is that the office has attached a condition, and that she did not know until the box was sealed, and that she has been in a temper about it for four days, and that she is not to tell me what it is, and that I am not to wait for an answer."

"Then what am I to do?"

"You are to read it and decide and send me a line with one word in it. Yes or no. And whichever word it is, she will not think less of you, and she has never said that about anybody."

She went out.

Antonia sat with the box for a long time before she opened it.

❦

The rescript was two leaves of good papyrus, sealed and counter--sealed, with the subscription in the emperor's own hand at the bottom and the date.

Imperator Caesar Nerva Trajanus Augustus, Germanicus Dacicus, pontifex maximus, to Antonia Cassia, freedwoman of the household of the Cassii: greeting.

Whereas it has been shown to us that the said Antonia Cassia was manumitted lawfully and has lived nineteen years in this city without reproach before the law, we have resolved, of our own motion, to restore to her the standing of one born of free parents, and to order that she be held and reputed freeborn in all courts and in all places, as though she had been born free and had never borne the stain of servitude.

And we order that the register of the fourteenth region be corrected accordingly, and that the manumission by which she was freed be cancelled of record, as being made in error of her true condition.

Antonia read it twice, and then a third time, and then she sat with it in her lap and looked at the wall.

She had wanted it for eleven years. She had wanted it in the way that a woman wants water in the eighth hour of a summer day, and she had built a house and a book and a name in order to be in a position to want it, and she had been refused, and she had said to a great many people that the refusal did not matter, and she had not believed a word of it. She had imagined this moment perhaps four hundred times, and in every one of the imaginings she had been a good deal more dignified than she was now.

The clause was exact. *Freeborn in all courts and in all places, as though she had been born free and had never borne the stain of servitude.*

She would be, in law, a woman of free parents, born in a house she had never seen, of a father whose name she did not know. There had never been a room behind a tablinum. There had never been eleven hours. There had never been a lamp held by a young man of twenty-six, or an arm that did not go above the shoulder.

And there had never been a manumission on the eleventh day before the Kalends of December in the year 93.

The whole case for her daughter's freedom had rested on that manumission. It was the first thing Gallus had said in the basilica; it had been read out to the court. If the register was corrected and the manumission cancelled as made in error, then the record that a free woman had borne a free daughter in September of 94 would be a record of something that had never happened. The girl's decree would stand, because a decree is a decree. But it would stand on a fiction, and any man who wanted to be unpleasant about it in twenty years could say that the whole case had been a confusion.

She was still standing at the window when Tullia came in.

"The box," Tullia said. "The condition."

"Yes."

"It is on the other leaf."

"I know."

"Are you going to tell me what it is, or am I going to stand here until the lamp is lit?"

Antonia turned.

"The condition," she said, "is that I deposit the book of the house with the imperial treasury. All of it. The four hundred and six names, the amounts, the reasons. It is to be sealed and kept in the archive of the ab epistulis and not opened, the office says, except by the order of the emperor or his successor in a matter of public necessity." She held up the leaf. "The phrase is *in a matter of public necessity*. There is no definition. There has never been a definition of that phrase in the history of the office, and there is not going to be one."

Tullia sat down slowly on the chest.

"Then it is not an archive," she said. "It is a drawer. And the drawer belongs to them."

"Yes."

"And every man in the book —"

"Every man in the book has paid me for something he wanted forgotten," Antonia said, "and most of them have behaved well since, and a dozen of them have done things that would put them in a cell, and one of them is a consular who offered me four hundred thousand sesterces in the year 95 to leave Rome, and one of them is a woman who has since paid for a temple. If the drawer is opened, the men who bought and sold seals will find their names in it, and the men who bought a quiet evening and a good dinner will find their names in it too, and there will be no difference made between them, and I will have handed the machine its list."

"And if you say no?"

"Then the rescript is not sealed," Antonia said. "The condition is on the rescript. It is not a bargain that can be separated; it is one piece of papyrus."

Tullia looked at the floor.

"Say no," she said.

"I have wanted it since the day I was manumitted. I have wanted it more than the house and more than the money, and there was a night in October when I sat in a shed behind a fuller's yard and thought: if I lose the case and the house and the girl, at least let me have the name."

"And now you have it, and it costs the book."

Antonia stood at the window with the rescript in her hand.

"No," she said. "It does not cost the book. It costs a copy of the book."

Tullia looked up.

"The condition says that I deposit the book of the house with the imperial treasury," Antonia said. "It does not say that I deposit the original. I have a boy in the Subura who copies documents for two sesterces a page. I will have the whole of it copied, all three hundred and eleven pages, in a fair hand, with the pages that are not accounts left out — the numbers, the six words about the stone room, the name that is crossed out, all of that stays with me. And the copy goes into the treasury, sealed, with the four hundred and six names of the house's clients in it, and if the office opens the drawer in a matter of public necessity, then what the office gets is the names of a great many men who paid a woman for a good evening, and I will have written in the front of it, in my own hand, what the book is, so that no man who opens it can pretend that he has found a list of criminals."

"You will give four hundred people to the office."

"I will give the office a copy of what four hundred people already knew that I knew," Antonia said. "It is not the same as giving them to the office, and it is not nothing either. They have been paying me for years to keep their secrets in a strongbox, and the strongbox is going to have a second key, and the second key will be

the emperor's. Half of them will stop coming to the house, and the other half will come more often, because a secret kept in a drawer in the palace is a secret that a man can do nothing about, and a secret kept by a woman with a book is a secret that a man can buy."

Tullia looked at her.

"That is a very cold piece of arithmetic," she said.

"It is. I am good at arithmetic. It is the only thing I have ever been good at." Antonia put the rescript down. "In the morning I am going to the Palatine to tell Callirhoe the word, and then I am going to find the boy, and we are going to spend six weeks copying three hundred and eleven pages. And then I will be a woman of free parents, and my mother, who died when I was six, will become a person who was never a slave, and I will have no idea what to do with that."

❦

Plotina received her in the garden, in the third week of August, on a day so hot that the box hedges had gone yellow at the tips.

She was sitting on the bench with the mended arm, in a plain dress, with her shoes off, which Antonia had not expected and never afterward forgot.

"You said yes."

"I said yes. With the copy."

"It is better than I hoped," Plotina said. "I thought you would refuse the whole thing and make a speech at me. I had prepared three answers to it and one of them was quite good." She waved at the bench. "Sit down. Do not stand there being respectful. I have been respected all morning."

Antonia sat down.

"The office will read the copy," she said. "You know that."

"Of course they will read it. They will read it in the first week and make a list and lose the list, and in two years someone will find it in a cupboard and not know what it is." Plotina turned her head. "I

am going east with him in October. Did you know? Every empress since Livia has stayed in Rome, and I am going. He will have a war to fight and a hundred cities to be flattered in, and there will be no one in his tent at night who is not afraid of him."

"You are afraid of him."

"I have been married to him for thirty-five years and have never once been afraid of him, and that is the whole of what I know about marriage." Plotina drew her feet up under her. "I am telling you because in September you will be a woman of free parents, and in a year you will find that it has made very little difference to anything, and that the difference it has made is in a room you did not expect. That is what happens to people who get what they want. They find out what it was for."

"And what was it for? For you."

"When I was thirty-one I walked into this palace in the wrong shoes and the wife of the consul looked at them, and I have spent thirty years in rooms where the only thing that mattered was that a woman should be looked at and not listened to. And then a woman came to my gate with a book of accounts and no patience at all, and I found that I could do a thing that no one had asked me to do, in a way that no one could stop, and that there was no one in the world to thank me for it." She looked at Antonia. "That is what it was for. It was for the doing. There is no other reward and there never was, and every woman in this city who has ever got anything done knows it, and none of them say it, because it sounds like complaining."

Antonia sat in the empress's garden with her shoes on and her hands in her lap.

"I will not see you again," Plotina said. "I will be in Antioch and then in Ctesiphon if the gods are kind, and by the time we come back I will be an old woman with opinions about roads. You will be fifty and you will have a third book and a house with a new door,

and there will be a girl who calls you something you have not heard yet."

"You know about that."

"I know about a great many things that people think I do not know about. It is my only accomplishment." Plotina stood up. "Do not come to the gate. Callirhoe will be unreasonable about it for a week."

"Domina. Thank you. For the rescript. And for the shoes."

Plotina looked at her.

"Get out of my garden," she said, "before I say something that will embarrass us both."



The emperor left for the east in the last week of October, and the whole city went down to the gates to see it.

Antonia did not go. She had seen a triumph and two funerals and a dedication, and she had learned that a great man going away looks very much like a great man arriving, and that the crowd is the same crowd.

She spent the morning going through the autumn accounts. The house had taken eleven thousand in September, down from the year before; four of the regular clients had stopped coming and six had started, and one of the six had asked at the door whether it was true that the book was in the treasury, and had been told that it was, and had come in.

At noon Dessa came in with the second book.

It was a cheap codex of six quires, sewn badly, with a wooden cover, and it had eleven villages in it so far, and the fourth quire was Dessa's own, written down over three months with the gate on the east and the fourteen houses and the stone that had been there before the Romans came. There were five other Dacians in the city

whose villages were in it, and the men had cried when asked and then had told it in more detail than anyone wanted.

"Twelve," Dessa said. "The man from the Via Lata came this morning. His village had a mill."

"Write it down."

"I have written it down." Dessa set the codex on the table. "Domina. I want to say a thing badly, because if I try to say it well I will not say it. I have been your slave for seven years, and you have fed me and taught me to read and got me out of a cell, and I am not grateful." She looked up. "Gratitude is what a slave feels when he is not beaten, and it is a small thing that men like because it costs them nothing. What I feel is bigger than gratitude and it has no name in Latin that I know."

Antonia looked at her.

"Then I will have to give you a name," she said, "and it will not be gratitude, and it will not be a name with my house in it, because you have a country and a language and a mill in your village and you do not need mine."

She opened the drawer and took out the manumission, written in September with the witnesses and the seals, and kept in the drawer for six weeks, waiting for a day when it would not look like a payment.

"Take it," she said. "You are free from the day it is entered in the register, and I have entered it and paid the fee, and you do not owe me anything. You do not have to leave and you do not have to stay, and if you stay you will be paid a wage like a free woman, and it will be a good wage, and you will be able to tell me what you think of it."

Dessa took the tablet with both hands and looked at it for a long moment.

Her right hand did not close. She held it in her left and turned it over and read the words, slowly, the way she read everything, with her lips moving.

"The gate was on the east," she said.

"What?"

"The clerk has written *freedwoman of the household of Antonia Cassia* and he has not written my country, because there is no line for it." Dessa put the tablet down. "In the spring I am going north. There is a man in the Piscina Publica going to Aquincum with a wagon of glass, and he will take a free woman who can keep accounts and pay her passage. I want to see whether the stone is still by the gate."

"The village was burned in the year of the war."

"I know," Dessa said. "I want to see whether the stone is still by the gate."

Antonia looked at the codex of villages on the table.

"Then take a copy of that book with you," she said, "and write down what is in the ground, and what the people who came after have built on it, and whether the well is where it was. And when you come back — if you come back — I will put it in the third book, and there will be a page in the Latin library with your village on it that has the gate where the gate was."

Dessa looked at her.

"I will come back," she said. "There is nothing in Dacia but a stone and a hillside. I have a book and a wage and a room with a window in it. I will not live in a burned village to prove a point."

❦

The door was the last thing.

It had been hung in March, and it was iron and oak with real gilt and a bronze knocker in the shape of a lion's head, and it was, everyone agreed, the finest door in the Subura. Antonia did not like it. The old door had been patched at the bottom, with studs of iron painted to look like bronze, and it had fooled people, which was the point. The new door did not fool anyone.

In the last week of October, on the day the emperor's column went out of the Porta Capena and the whole city was at the gates, someone knocked on the new door at the ninth hour.

Vitalis came into the garden.

"Domina. There is a woman at the door."

"There are a great many women at the door."

"She says her name is Publia Cassia, and that she is —" Vitalis hesitated. "She says that you will know her, and that she has left her husband's house, and that she has nowhere to go, and that she is not asking for money."

Antonia stood in the peristyle with the watering can in her hand.

She thought about a door in April, and a girl in a blue dress with her veil down asking, *will you help me*, and a woman saying, *I will think about it*, and then thinking about it for seven months.

"Show her in," she said.

Publia came into the garden in a plain travelling cloak with the hood back and no jewelry at all, eight months gone with a child, and she stood in the middle of the peristyle with her chin up and looked at Antonia the way her mother looked at people.

"I have left him," she said. "He has never beaten me. He has been perfectly correct for ten months and he will be kind to the child, and I cannot stay in that house another day. It is a house where nothing is ever said, and I have begun to hear the nothing at night."

"And your mother?"

"Gone to her sister's at Tibur. She told me I had made my bed, and then she sat in the dark for two hours and came up and gave me her purse. It is not enough, and I have nowhere to go."

Antonia put the watering can down.

"Do you know what you are asking me? You are asking me to take in the daughter of the man who held my daughter for eighteen years, with a child in you that will be born here in a month and will

have a claim on the name I spent a year in the courts making worth something."

"Yes."

"I have thought about nothing else for three weeks," Publia said, "and I will not pretend that my father was a good man. I am asking for a room. I will pay for it out of my mother's purse, and if you want me gone in the morning I will go in the morning."

Antonia looked at her for a long moment.

"Vitalis," she said, "take the lady's things up to the room at the top of the stairs, the one with the window on the garden. And tell Rufina that there will be one more for dinner and that she is to make the fish, not the pork, because the lady is with child and pork lies heavy."

Vitalis went.

Publia did not move.

"Why?" she said.

"Because I have been the woman at the door," Antonia said, "and no one who has been it should ever do it to anybody else. It is not noble. It is arithmetic."

❦

At the eleventh hour Myrtale came down from Ficulea, where she had been for a year, and where she had a room and a wage and a man who kept bees and who was, everyone agreed, very slow.

She came into the garden where Antonia was sitting with the lamp and the second book and a cup of wine that she had not drunk, and she sat down on the bench at the end of the peristyle without being asked, and she looked at the new door and the lamp on its bracket and the shadows of the vine on the wall.

"There is a woman in the room at the top of the stairs," she said. "Vitalis told me. He tells me everything. It is his only fault."

"Publia."

"Publia." Myrtale was quiet for a moment. "She was the only one in that house who was kind to me, and she was kind in the way a person is kind who does not know what she is being kind to. She gave me her old shoes. Once she cried in front of me because a bird had flown into the window, and I held her hand. She was the daughter of the house and I was her maid, and neither of us knew that we were sisters."

"You are not sisters."

"We are not sisters," Myrtale said. "That is what I have come to say. I have been trying to say it for a year, in the room at Ficulea, at night, to the wall."

Antonia waited.

"I have been angry with you," Myrtale said, "and I have been right to be angry, and I am not going to give it up because it is the only thing I have that is entirely mine. But I have thought about the room behind the court, and the clerk with the tablet, and the three names. You did not give me my name. The law gave me my name. You gave me a choice, and you told me the truth about both of the names, and then you let me choose." She looked at Antonia. "Nobody in that house ever let me choose anything. Not what I wore, not what I ate, not what I was called. And you gave me three names and the truth and a pen."

"Myrtale."

"I am not finished. I have been practising this." Myrtale took a breath. "I am not going to call you mother. I have tried it and it does not come out, and it may never come out, and I will not say a word to you that is not true. But there is a word I have found, and it is the word I chose in the room behind the court, and it is mine now, and I am going to use it, and you will have to put up with it."

She turned on the bench.

"Cassia," she said.

Antonia sat in the garden of her house with the lamp and the book and the cup of wine she had not drunk, and her daughter said her name, and it was not the name her manumittor had given her, or the name a dead man in marble had paid for, or the name the city had made for her out of a brothel and a debt.

It was the name she had made herself, and it was in the register of the fourteenth region, and it was on the page of a book in a room with a strongbox, and it had been said in the senate house of Rome, and there was a girl of nineteen sitting at the end of the bench who had chosen it and would carry it when she was dead.

"All right," Antonia said. "Cassia will do."



They sat in the garden until the second hour of the night.

Rufina brought out the fish and the bread and the good wine, and Hilarus came up from the yard with the news from the gates, which was that the emperor had got as far as the ninth milestone and the carts had blocked the road and a donkey had kicked a praetorian, and that the whole of Rome had laughed. Publia came down for an hour and ate a little and went up again. Tullia came out with the household accounts and read them aloud, because she had been keeping them for twenty years and was not going to stop on a night like this one.

At the third hour the lamp was low, and Myrtale had fallen asleep on the bench with her head against the wall, and Antonia sat with the second book open on her knee and the pen in her hand.

She turned to the first page, which was blank, and she wrote:

The house on the Clivus Suburanus, in the fourteenth region of the city of Rome, in the nineteenth year of the reign of Trajan. A copy of the first book of this house is in the treasury of the emperor, and the first book is in the strongbox, and the second is here and is not finished, and the third is not yet written. The door is new and the gilt on it is

real, and the door within the door is in the threshold where it has always been, and everything that is written in this house is written because a woman in the Subura learned to read and was not content.

She blotted it, and closed the book, and sat for a while listening to the city.

Beyond the door the Subura went on with its noise: the carts and the dogs and the men coming up from the Forum with their boots on the stone, the woman two doors down who sang badly and knew it. The gilt on the door caught the lamp and gave it back, and from the Clivus, at the right angle and not too close, the house of Antonia Cassia looked like the entrance to a magistrate's house.

She got up and put out the lamp, and woke her daughter, and they went in.

A NOTE ON THE HISTORY

The Rome of this novel is the Rome of the years 112 and 113, in the fifteenth and sixteenth years of the emperor Trajan. The great forum beside the Forum of Augustus was then new; the column that carried the story of the Dacian wars was dedicated in the spring of 113 and the emperor left for the east in the autumn of that year, and did not come back. Trajan was consul for the sixth time, with Titus Sextius Africanus, and the city was between two wars.

A few of the people in this book existed. Trajan did; so did his wife Pompeia Plotina, his sister Marciana, his niece Matidia, the jurist Neratius Priscus and the prefect Acilius Attianus. Their public careers are a matter of record. What they said in private, and what they did in the rooms this novel invents, is not.

The rest are invented, but the conditions they live in are not. A senator needed a census of a million sesterces. An equestrian needed four hundred thousand. A freedman could be richer than either and still be barred from the Senate, from certain marriages, and from the easy assumption of respect. A woman could own property, run a business, lend money and go to law, and still require a man to stand for her in a question of status. A slave was a thing in law: a thing that could be sold, pledged, inherited, and, where a court wanted evidence, tortured.

A child born to a free mother was free, even if the mother had been a slave when the child was conceived; the law leaned, where it could, toward liberty. That single rule is the hinge on which this story turns, and it is the one piece of legal machinery here that I have not invented.

The other machinery is as close to the record as I could make it. A question of status was heard before the urban praetor, with a free man — the adsertor — asserting the claim on the person's behalf, and the archaic form of manumission by the rod survived into the second century for exactly this purpose: freedom declared in public, before witnesses, by a touch of wood. Restitutio natalium was an imperial rescript, granted by the emperor's own hand and outside the ordinary petitions office, and it did what the novel says it did: it made a freed person freeborn in law, from birth, and it erased the record of the servitude that had come before. It was a favour, and it could carry conditions.

Relegation to an island was not a sentence of death. It was the emperor's answer to a case that the courts would have handled more harshly and more publicly, and it allowed a great family to survive a crime it could not deny. Men came back from it, and wrote about it, and were believed.

The Latin and the money are left as the Romans left them. A sesterce was a small brass coin, four of them made a denarius, and a legionary's year was twelve hundred of them before deductions. A modius of wheat cost a few sesterces in a good year and a great deal more in a bad one. Where a character says a sum, the sum is meant to be felt, not converted. The glossary at the back explains the words a reader is likely to trip over, and the offices a reader is likely to confuse.

GLOSSARY

aedile — A magistrate responsible for streets, markets, water and public order. The aediles could close a disorderly house and fine its keeper.

adsertor libertatis — The free man who formally asserted, in court, that a person claimed as a slave was in fact free. If he lost, he paid a penalty.

annona — The grain supply of Rome, and the office that managed it. A bad year meant bread riots; a good year meant votes.

basilica — A long roofed hall used for courts and business, usually along a forum.

causa liberalis — A freedom suit: a formal hearing to decide whether a person was free or a slave.

census — The property qualification for a class. A senator needed a million sesterces; an equestrian, four hundred thousand.

centurion — A career soldier commanding a century of about eighty men. The backbone of the army and, often, of a province's administration.

client — A man attached to a patron by favours, obligations and the morning call. The relationship ran both ways, and neither way was free.

cognitio — A hearing conducted by a magistrate or the emperor himself, rather than by a jury court.

consular — A man who had been consul. The rank opened the great provinces and the emperor's council, and closed nothing.

decemviri The board of ten young senators who, among other duties, sat with the praetor in questions of status and inheritance.

delator An informer who brought prosecutions in the hope of a share of the condemned man's property. Necessary to the treasury; loathed by everyone.

denarius A silver coin worth four sesterces, and roughly a day's wage for a skilled workman.

equestrian The second order of Rome, below the Senate. Knights commanded cohorts, ran the great offices, and lent the state its money.

ergastulum The slave prison or workhouse on a country estate. The word was meant to frighten, and did.

familia The household, including slaves, freedmen and dependants. Not a family in the modern sense; a unit of authority.

freedman A slave who had been formally manumitted. Free, and not free: barred from office, marked by the name, and often richer than his betters.

fiscus The emperor's treasury, as distinct from the public treasury of Rome.

hypocaust The under-floor heating of a bath or a rich man's dining room.

imperium The power of command held by consuls, praetors and governors. A man with imperium could order a beating, a levy or a war.

infamia Legal disgrace. It followed certain trades and certain convictions, and it shut courts, marriages and doors.

ius annuli The right of a freedman to wear the gold ring of an equestrian. A small hoop of metal, and a whole rank of difference.

lanista A trainer and dealer in gladiators. A useful man to know, and not a respectable one.

lararium The household shrine, where the family's gods stood in miniature.

legatus A senator serving as the emperor's deputy, usually in command of a legion or a province.

leno A brothel-keeper or pimp. Legally tolerated, socially despised, and taxed.

libertus A freedman, in relation to the master who freed him.

lictors The attendants who carried the fasces before a magistrate. The number of rods told you how much to bow.

litter A covered sedan chair carried by slaves. A public statement about the length of a man's purse.

ludi The games: chariot racing, theatre, gladiators, beast hunts. The Roman calendar's chief entertainment and its chief politics.

manumission The formal freeing of a slave, by will, by the rod before a magistrate, or by census. Informal freedom left a man neither slave nor citizen.

mosaic A floor or wall picture made of small stone or glass cubes. Expensive, durable, and a way of telling guests exactly who you were.

nomen The middle name of a Roman citizen, marking the clan. A freedman took the name of the man who freed him, and never stopped hearing it.

patron A man who protected clients and freedmen and expected service in return. The word covered everything from friendship to ownership.

peculium The savings a slave was allowed to keep and manage. Often the only road to buying one's own freedom.

peristyle A garden or court surrounded by a colonnade.

plagium The crime of knowingly holding a free person as a slave, or of buying and selling one. Punished severely, and committed often.

praetor A senior magistrate with legal jurisdiction. The urban praetor heard cases between citizens; his edict was law for a year.

proconsul A consul's power extended to a province after his year in office. The great provinces were governed by men chosen by lot or by favour.

relegatio A sentence of banishment to a named place, without loss of citizenship or property. The milder cousin of exile, and often the emperor's way of ending a scandal quietly.

restitutio natalium An imperial grant restoring to a freedman the standing of the freeborn. A favour, not a right; it could not be demanded, only bought.

sesterce The common brass coin. Four to the denarius; a month's rent in the Subura for a small room.

stola The long dress of a respectable married woman. Not cloth so much as a claim.

tablinum The room off the atrium where a household kept its records and received its visitors.

toga The citizen's gown. Heavy, awkward, expensive to keep white, and indispensable in public.

tribune An officer of a cohort or a legion, or a plebeian official. In the vigiles, a tribune commanded a cohort of the fire-watch.

vigiles The fire-watch of Rome: seven cohorts of freedmen, with buckets, hooks, pumps and a licence to break down doors.

vindicta The rod used in the formal manumission of a slave before a magistrate. A touch of wood, and a change of life.

COLOPHON

Set in EB Garamond, a digital revival of the types cut by Claude Garamont in the sixteenth century, itself drawn from the hand of a fifteenth-century Venetian. The face is licensed under the SIL Open Font License and is used here without modification beyond subsetting.

Composed and typeset with the *autonovel* pipeline: chapters held as plain text, the page built from a single specification of measure, leading and ornament, and the whole assembled twice, once to learn where each chapter falls and once to print it.

The book was written in the order it is meant to be read.